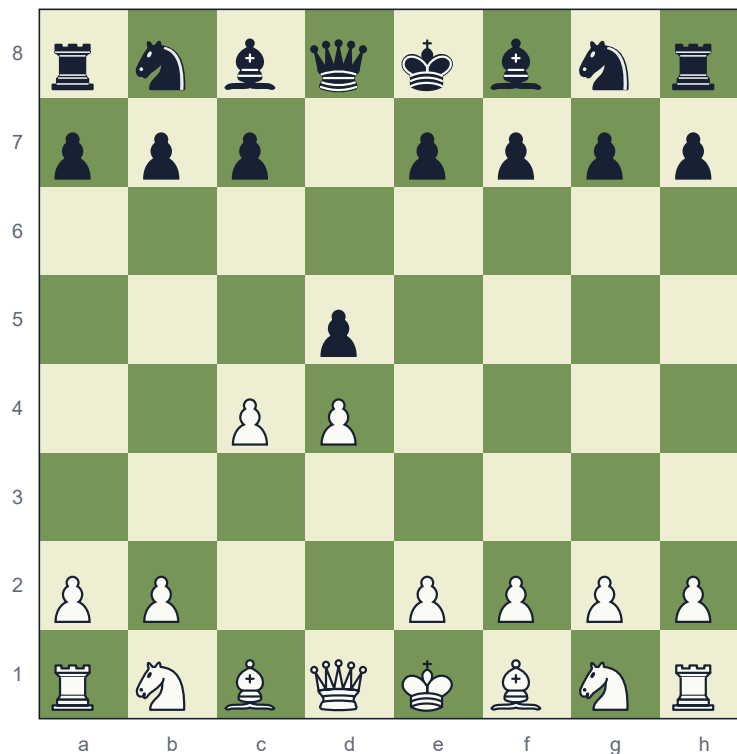


Your 1.d4 repertoire

A complete practical course built around 1.d4 and 2.c4

One coherent White repertoire, with common Black counters, plans after move ten, and exercises. Prepared for a club player who knows the rules and wants to study seriously. Use the foundation pages first if notation or pawn structures are new.



The starting question: how will Black answer the central challenge?

WHAT YOU RECEIVE

27 separate study booklets, a combined volume, 95 selected opening branches, 60 exercises with answers, eight illustrative middlegame continuations, a 12-week plan, and PGN companions for replaying the lines.

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This is a complete practical route against the common defenses, not an encyclopedia of every legal move or every good White system. The main course chooses lines for you; the Nimzo-Indian chapter is optional. No ten-move line predicts all of an opponent's choices.

How to think about the opening

THE PURPOSE OF 1.D4 AND C4

1.d4 controls c5 and e5 and opens the c1 bishop. c4 challenges a black pawn on d5 and makes it harder for Black to keep an uncontested center. Moving the c-pawn before Nc3 also leaves you the option of useful central tension. The point is not to make the same two moves against everything: c4 is a lever that you use when the position calls for it.

A REPERTOIRE IS A DECISION TREE

At each branch, first identify Black's last move and its threat. Then choose your move from that exact position. Do not memorize a list of ten White moves independently of Black's replies. If Black plays ...dxc4, ...Bb4+ or ...e5, your priorities may change immediately.

DEVELOPMENT AND THE CENTER WORK TOGETHER

A center unsupported by pieces can be attacked; developed pieces without central influence can be pushed around. Aim to develop both knights, give each bishop a useful job, and castle when the destination is safe. Use pawn moves that support those aims. A flank pawn move needs a reason.

DO NOT RUSH EVERY EXCHANGE

Before cxd5, dxc5 or dxe5, imagine the opponent's best recapture. Name the resulting pawn structure and open files. An exchange is useful when it wins material, improves a piece, removes a defender, or creates a favorable structure. Releasing tension merely to simplify the calculation can help Black.

How to think about the opening

KNOW WHAT IS FORCED AND WHAT IS CHOSEN

A checked king must answer the check. A hanging queen needs attention. By contrast, a fianchetto, minority attack, or bishop-development preference may have several good alternatives. The course gives you one practical route, while explicitly marking tactical warnings and optional expansions.

WHAT TO DO WHEN THE OPPONENT LEAVES THEORY

Pause and ask: Am I in check? What changed about captures, threats, and loose pieces? Which central break is now available? What is my worst piece? Look for a forcing opportunity, then choose a move that improves development or the center. An unfamiliar move is not automatically an error.

THE MOVE-TEN HANDOFF

At the final diagram of a line, stop reciting moves. State the pawn structure, the two most useful candidate moves, Black's intended break, and your least active piece. If you cannot explain these, replay the line slowly. Knowing a position after ten moves is more valuable than remembering ten moves without a plan.

PRACTICAL ANALYSIS AFTER A GAME

First annotate without an engine: where did you leave the repertoire, what did you fear, and which candidate did you reject? Then consult the matching booklet and a database or engine. Add one correction to your notes. A single position understood deeply is better than copying a long engine variation you cannot explain.

How to study each line

PASS 1: UNDERSTAND

Read the repertoire choice and both players' plans. Play the selected study line on a board. Say why the central exchange or developing move is useful.

PASS 2: RECONSTRUCT

Cover the notation and rebuild the line. Stop at a branch and explain what you would do if Black played differently. Accuracy matters more than speed.

PASS 3: START FROM THE FINAL DIAGRAM

Play a practice game from the move-ten position. Do not consult the PDF during play. Analyze the game afterward and connect mistakes to a plan or tactical oversight.

PASS 4: RETAIN

Review a line after one day, three days, one week and one month. A forgotten tactical detail returns to the front of the queue; a familiar easy line can wait longer.

NOTATION AND DIAGRAM CONVENTIONS

White is always at the bottom, matching your example. Files run a-h from left to right. Board captions identify whose turn it is. N means knight, B bishop, R rook, Q queen and K king. O-O means kingside castling; O-O-O means queenside castling.

KEEP THE ORIGINAL CHOICE COHERENT

Against ...Nf6/...e6 use Nf3 before Nc3 in the main repertoire. Against ...g6 use the fianchetto family. Against the Dutch defer c4 with g3. These are chosen routes, not claims that all alternatives are bad.

Scope, priorities and honest expectations

START WITH THE MOST USEFUL CORE

First study Booklets 01, 02, 04, 05, 08, 14 and 21. Add the rest as your games require, following Booklet 25. You do not need to memorize the entire library before playing 1.d4.

CHOSEN RATHER THAN MANDATORY

The course avoids making the Catalan, London, Colle, Trompowsky, sharp Bg5 Semi-Slav and Exchange Grunfeld additional repertoires. These can all be legitimate choices; they are outside the selected main route.

OPENING KNOWLEDGE CANNOT REPLACE CALCULATION

When the opponent deviates, check forcing moves first. An unfamiliar move can be sound. A familiar pattern can fail because one defender moved, a file opened, or a check changed the tempo.

LIMITS OF VERIFICATION

Every printed move sequence is checked for legality and every diagram is generated from its exact position. Selected White anchor moves were screened with Stockfish 18. Sample continuations are finite engine analysis, not a proof of an advantage and not a substitute for master-level updating.

THIS IS ORIGINAL TEACHING MATERIAL

The commentary, course organization and exercises are written for this course. Opening facts use public references. The middlegame continuations are training examples, not invented historical games. Sources and diagram-art credits appear in Booklet 26.

Course directory

00 START HERE - course map and foundations

01 Move orders and when NOT to play c4

02 Queen's Gambit Declined: the Exchange

03 QGD alternatives: Ragozin, Vienna and early deviations

04 Queen's Gambit Accepted

05 The Slav Defense

06 The Semi-Slav: e3 systems

07 Tarrasch and Semi-Tarrasch

08 Albin Countergambit: a complete practical answer

09 The Chigorin Defense

10 Other Queen's Gambit counters

11 Queen's Indian: the g3 repertoire

12 Bogo-Indian: meet the check with Bd2

13 Optional expansion: the Nimzo-Indian

Use these booklet numbers throughout the course. The combined PDF has outline bookmarks; each separate PDF is also listed in READ_ME_FIRST.txt.

Course directory

- 14 King's Indian: a fianchetto repertoire**
- 15 Grunfeld: keep the fianchetto**
- 16 Modern Benoni: space and the fianchetto**
- 17 Benko Gambit: the 5.b6 practical decline**
- 18 Budapest, Fajarowicz and Blumenfeld**
- 19 Dutch Defense: defer c4 with 2.g3**
- 20 Old Indian and Modern move orders**
- 21 When c4 waits: Englund and unusual first moves**
- 22 Pawn structures and plans after move ten**
- 23 Middlegame laboratory - eight training continuations**
- 24 60 exercises with explained answers**
- 25 12-week study plan and quick reference cards**
- 26 Sources, glossary and verification method**

Use these booklet numbers throughout the course. The combined PDF has outline bookmarks; each separate PDF is also listed in READ_ME_FIRST.txt.

c4 is a decision, not a ritual

THE MAIN RULE

After 1.d4 d5 and 1.d4 Nf6, c4 is the foundation of this repertoire. Against ...e6, ...c6, ...g6 and ...d6 it also remains a sound way to stay within the course.

THE IMPORTANT EXCEPTION

After 1.d4 e5, play 2.dxe5 and develop against the Englund. The central confrontation requires a concrete answer; simply continuing c4 can concede a pawn and the initiative for no repertoire benefit.

PRACTICAL MOVE-ORDER PREFERENCES

Against the Dutch, use 2.g3 and add c4 later. Against 1...c5, use 2.d5. Against 1...Nc6, use 2.d5 followed by development. These are recommendations, not claims that c4 is illegal or necessarily bad.

USE THE SPACE OFFERED

Against ...b6 or ...b5, the course takes e4 and supports the center. Some rare flank moves also justify e4. Your goal is a coherent position, not forcing every opening back into the same pawn skeleton.

The second-move decision table

1.D4 D5 -> 2.C4 | MAIN REPERTOIRE

Attack the d5 pawn and contest the center. The defense Black chooses next determines your setup.

1.D4 NF6 -> 2.C4 | MAIN REPERTOIRE

Claim central space. Follow with Nf3 against ...e6 or ...g6; against ...c5, gain space with d5.

1.D4 E6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

Do not feel forced to transpose to the French with e4. After ...d5 use the QGD; after ...f5 use the Dutch fianchetto.

1.D4 C6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

Prepare for ...d5 and a Slav. Black may transpose to the Semi-Slav with ...e6.

1.D4 G6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

Build the center and use the fianchetto repertoire. Delayed ...d5 must be distinguished from ...d6.

1.D4 D6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

A sound way to stay within Indian structures. e4 is also possible but adds different move orders.

These recommendations form the course route. Other sound moves exist; learn the reason for the choice.

The second-move decision table

1.D4 F5 -> 2.G3 | DEFER BY CHOICE

The course uses Bg2 and kingside castling before c4. 2.c4 is sound; this is not a tactical prohibition.

1.D4 E5 -> 2.DXE5 | CONCRETE EXCEPTION

Black attacks d4 and offers a pawn. Accept and develop against the Englund; do not play c4 automatically.

1.D4 C5 -> 2.D5 | DEFER BY CHOICE

Take space with tempo against the central challenge. 2.c4 is playable but does not follow this selected route.

1.D4 NC6 -> 2.D5 | DEFER BY CHOICE

Gain space against the knight, then use e4 and Nf3. 2.c4 is possible, but allows different Chigorin-like positions.

1.D4 B6 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Build d4-e4, then support e4 against ...Bb7. c4 is playable but is not the course choice.

1.D4 B5 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Occupy the center while Black expands on the wing. Do not chase b5 before developing.

These recommendations form the course route. Other sound moves exist; learn the reason for the choice.

The second-move decision table

1.D4 A6 -> 2.C4 | NORMAL DEVELOPMENT

A useful central move; watch a later ...b5 or ...d5. There is no forced punishment of ...a6.

1.D4 A5 -> 2.E4 | PRACTICAL CHOICE

Take the broad center and develop. c4 remains legal and can be sound; this choice exploits the extra space.

1.D4 H6 -> 2.C4 | NORMAL DEVELOPMENT

Continue the central repertoire. ...h6 may restrict Bg5, but it does not change the purpose of c4.

1.D4 H5 -> 2.E4 | PRACTICAL CHOICE

Use the center and develop calmly. Attack the advanced h-pawn only if it creates a concrete benefit.

1.D4 F6 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Take the center, then develop. Black has weakened the king and obstructed the natural f6 knight square.

1.D4 NA6 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Build a broad center. A knight on the rim is not a reason to neglect your own development.

These recommendations form the course route. Other sound moves exist; learn the reason for the choice.

The next fork after 2.c4

AFTER ...D5 AND ...E6

Use Nf3, then Nc3 against ...Nf6. In the normal ...Be7 QGD, exchange on d5 and develop Bg5. If Black builds the ...e6/...c6 triangle before ...Nf6, choose e3 first to avoid a separate Noteboom route.

AFTER ...D5 AND ...C6

Use Nf3 and Nc3 against ...Nf6. After ...dxc4, a4 fights ...b5. If Black captures before ...Nf6, e3 and a4 are a useful related route. ...e6 leads to the Semi-Slav.

AFTER ...NF6 AND ...E6

Choose 3.Nf3. ...b6 leads to the Queen's Indian, ...Bb4+ to the Bogo, ...d5 to the QGD, and ...c5 usually invites d5 with Benoni or Blumenfeld possibilities.

AFTER ...NF6 AND ...G6

Choose 3.Nf3 and g3. A black d-pawn on d6 points toward the King's Indian; ...d5 immediately means a Grunfeld-type central fight.

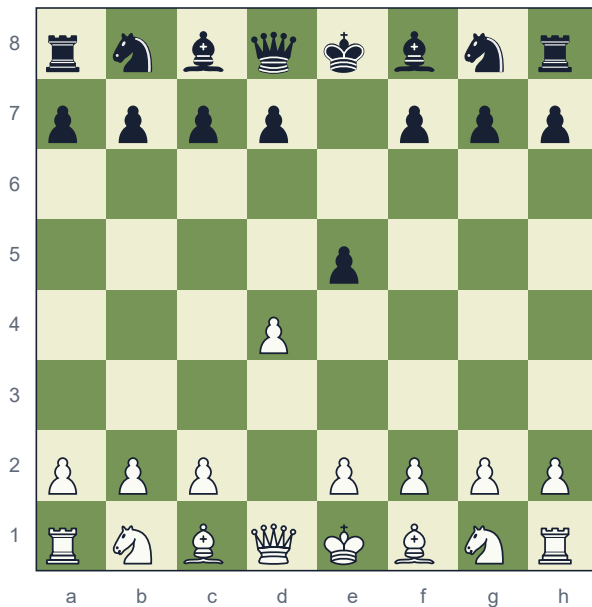
AFTER ...NF6 AND ...C5

Choose d5. ...e6 leads toward the Benoni, ...b5 can be a Benko, and the insertion of ...e6 and Nf3 can create a Blumenfeld.

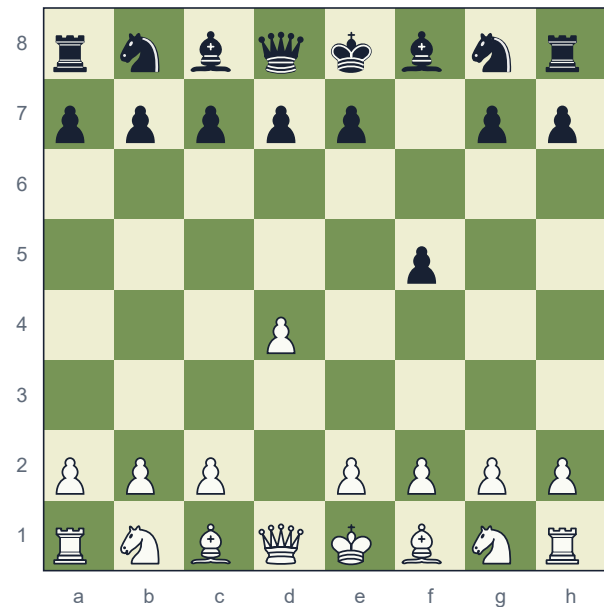
AFTER ...NF6 AND ...E5

Accept with dxe5. ...Ng4 is the Budapest, while ...Ne4 is the Fajarowicz. The exact knight route changes the tactical response.

Two diagrams that prevent two different mistakes



Englund: White to move; play dxe5.



Dutch: White to move; g3 is our choice.

DO NOT CONFUSE THESE REASONS

Against the Englund, Black has directly challenged d4 and offered a pawn; a concrete central response is appropriate. Against the Dutch, g3 is a sound strategic move order that helps your fianchetto development. c4 is also sound there.

YOUR TEST

Without a board, state your second move against ...d5, ...Nf6, ...e5, ...f5, ...c5, ...Nc6 and ...b6. Then explain which choices are tactical responses and which are practical repertoire preferences.

TRANSPOSITION TEST

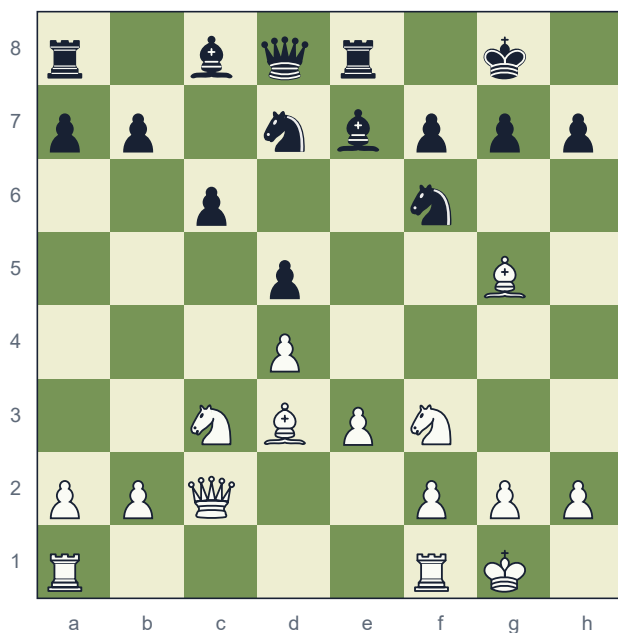
Compare 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Nf6 with 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 d5. The position, side to move and rights agree. Now compare a similar diagram with an extra ...a6: it is not the same position.

Queen's Gambit Declined: the Exchange

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Exchange on d5 once Black has committed to ...e6 and ...Nf6. Develop with Bg5, e3 and Bd3, castle, and only then decide how to use the queenside majority imbalance.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The Carlsbad structure: White's c-pawn and Black's original d-pawn have been exchanged. Black's e-pawn stands on d5, supported by a c-pawn. White often attacks c6 with b4-b5; Black seeks kingside activity or the freeing ...c5.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black wants ...Ne4, piece exchanges that reduce pressure, or ...c5 before you organize a minority attack. Development can matter more than a permanent pawn weakness.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. This repertoire already puts the king knight on f3. Do not copy a Ne2-f3-e4 scheme as though that knight were still on g1.
2. A minority attack is a prepared plan, not an instruction to play b4 before castling.
3. If Black achieves ...c5 safely, recalculate the structure: an isolated d-pawn or a symmetrical position may replace the Carlsbad.

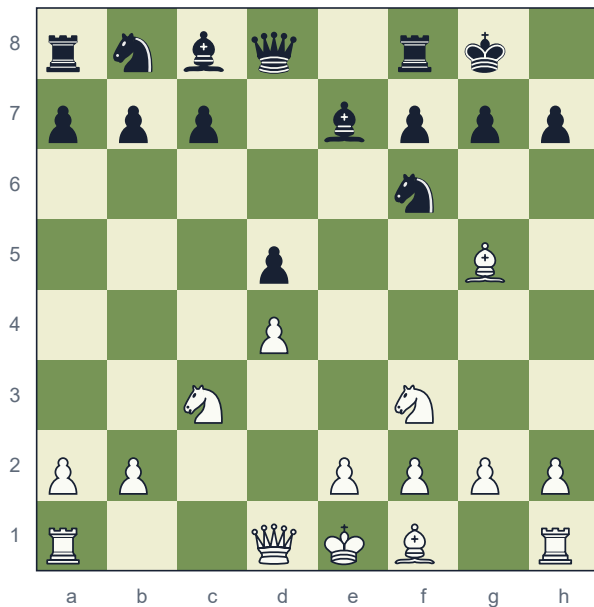
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 The normal Carlsbad setup

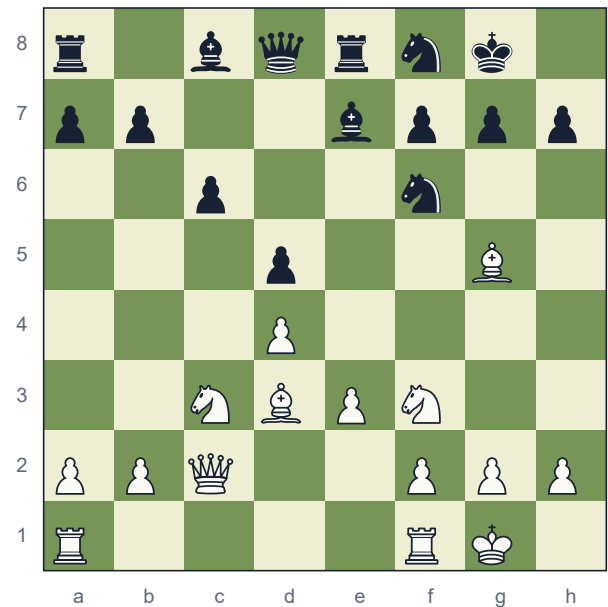
STUDY LINE 02-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 O-O 7. e3 c6 8. Bd3 Nbd7 9. O-O Re8 10. Qc2 Nf8

Selected anchor ends with 10. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

cxd5 fixes a structure you can study repeatedly. Bg5 develops outside the e3 pawn chain; Bd3 points at h7 while supporting later central play.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Complete development with a rook on b1 or c1 according to Black's setup. Prepare b4-b5, and meet a kingside initiative with exchanges or a central break.

WATCH FOR

The bishop sacrifice Bxh7+ is not justified merely because your bishop points at h7. Check the king's escape squares and whether Ng5 is effective.

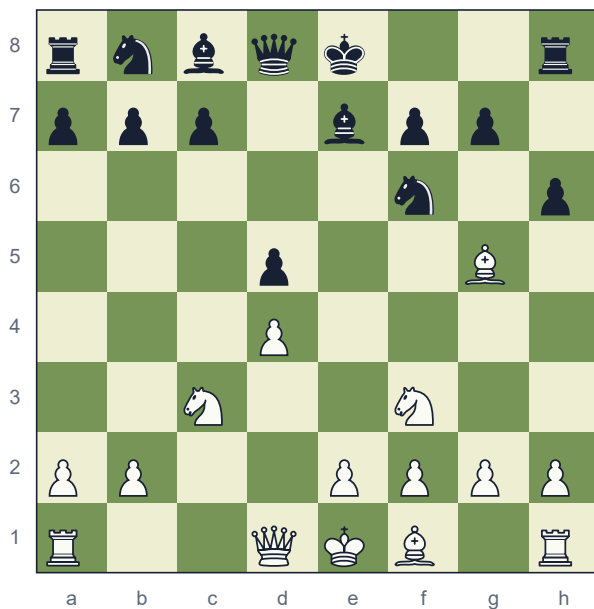
REMEMBER Exchange, develop, castle, then choose the pawn break.

02 Black exchanges the g5 bishop

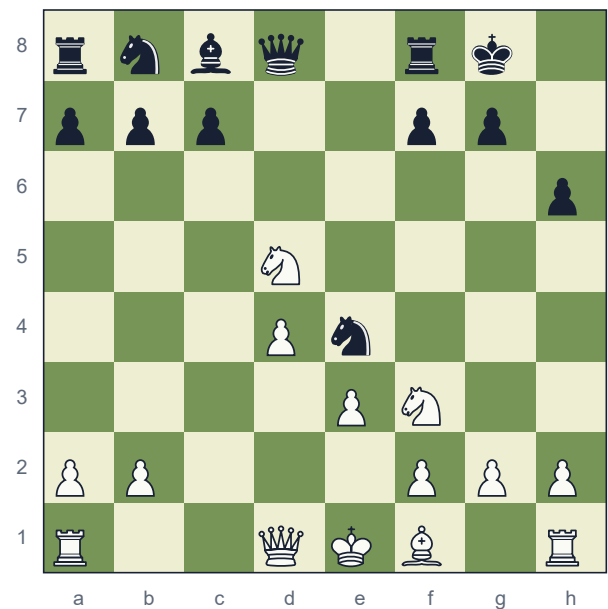
STUDY LINE 02-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 O-O 8. e3 Ne4 9. Bxe7 Qxe7 10. Nxd5 Qd8

Selected anchor ends with 10. Nxd5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bh4 keeps the pin available; when the knight reaches e4, exchanging on e7 simplifies the pressure on your bishop without abandoning development.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

In this exact position, Nxd5 takes a pawn that Black no longer adequately protects. Continue development while meeting any queen or knight activity.

WATCH FOR

Do not copy Nxd5 into a position where Black has already played ...c6. That extra pawn would control d5.

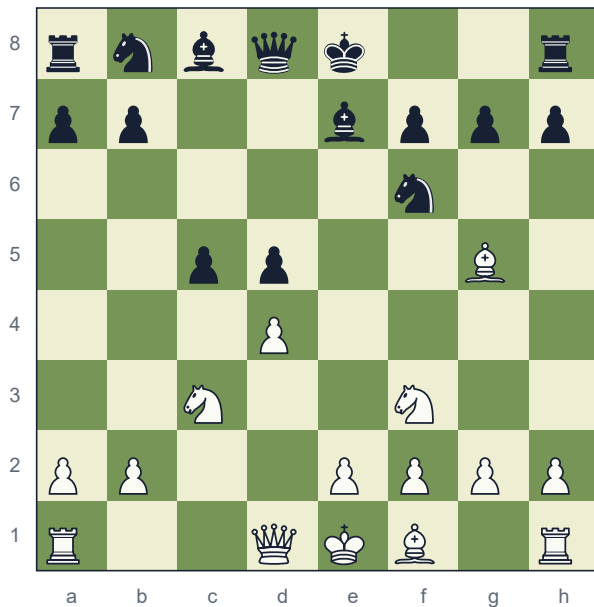
REMEMBER An exact move-order detail can matter more than a familiar plan.

03 Early ...c5 changes the structure

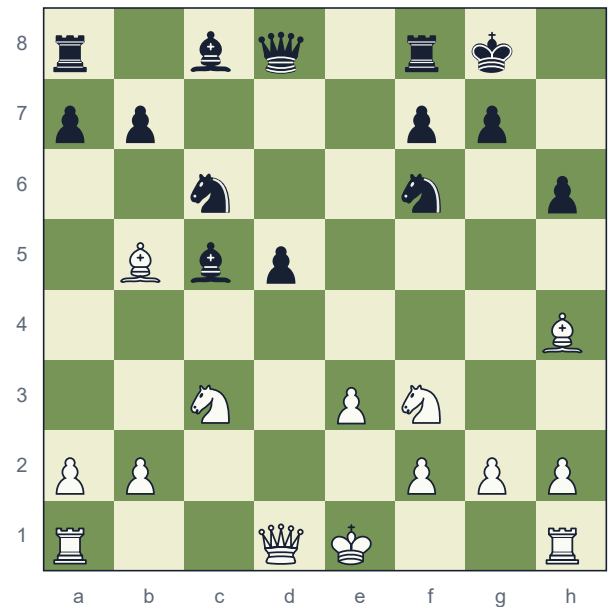
STUDY LINE 02-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 c5 7. e3 Nc6 8. dxc5 O-O 9. Bb5 h6 10. Bh4 Bxc5

Selected anchor ends with 7... Nc6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black challenges d4 immediately. Keep developing while monitoring the tension rather than forcing a minority-attack script onto the position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

After exchanges on c5 or d4, identify whose d-pawn is isolated. Blockade an enemy isolated pawn with pieces; use activity if the isolated pawn is yours.

WATCH FOR

A rook on b1 can be pointless when the main battle has moved to the central files.

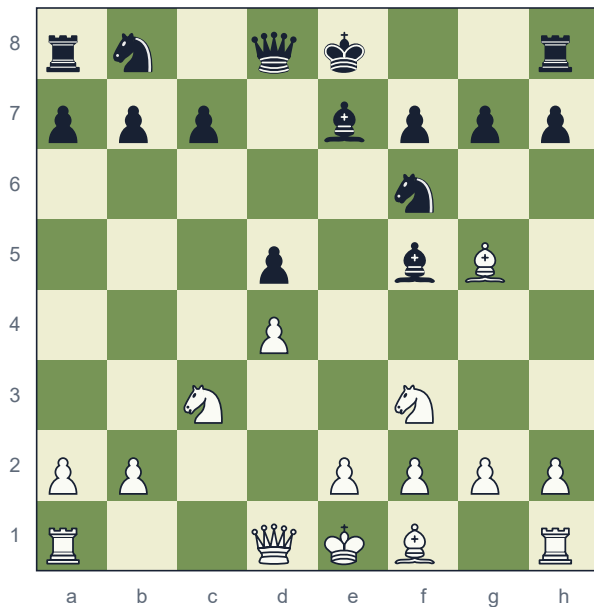
REMEMBER Name the new structure before selecting a plan.

04 The bishop comes to f5 too soon

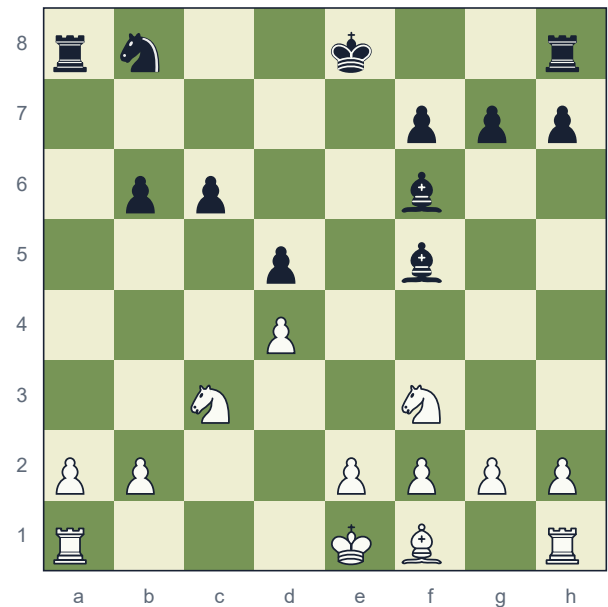
STUDY LINE 02-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 Bf5 7. Bxf6 Bxf6 8. Qb3 c6 9. Qxb7 Qb6 10. Qxb6 axb6

Selected anchor ends with 7. Bxf6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Exchanging the f6 knight removes a defender of d5. This concrete detail makes automatic e3 less ambitious in this exact position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Inspect d5 and b7 after Black recaptures. Queen pressure on the queenside may force concessions before you complete normal development.

WATCH FOR

This tactic depends on Black not yet having played ...c6 or castled. Check the exact position before repeating it.

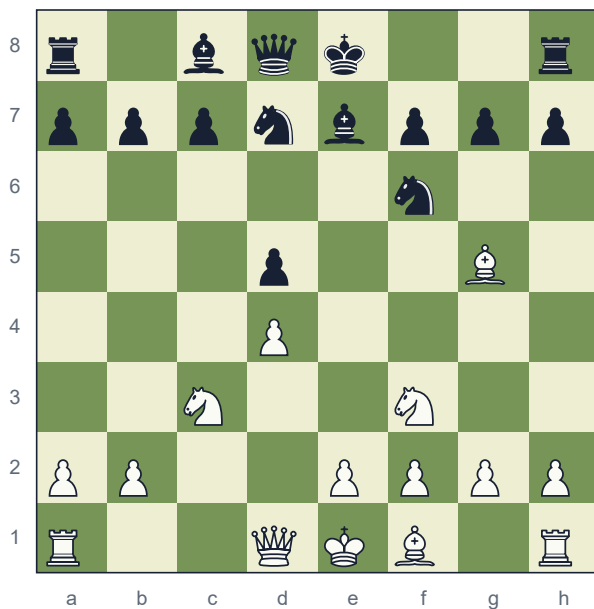
REMEMBER Remove a defender when the central target is real.

05 Black develops ...Nbd7 before ...Be7

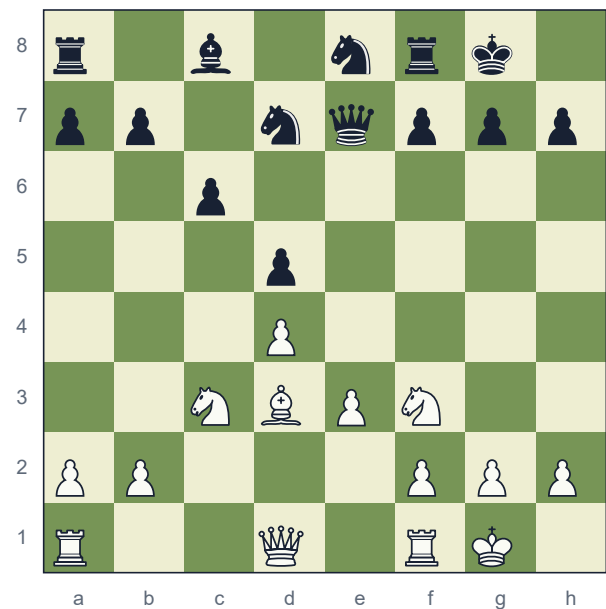
STUDY LINE 02-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Nbd7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 Be7 7. e3 O-O 8. Bd3 c6 9. O-O Ne8 10. Bxe7 Qxe7

Selected anchor ends with 9. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This move order reaches the same familiar structure. Recognizing the transposition saves unnecessary memorization.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

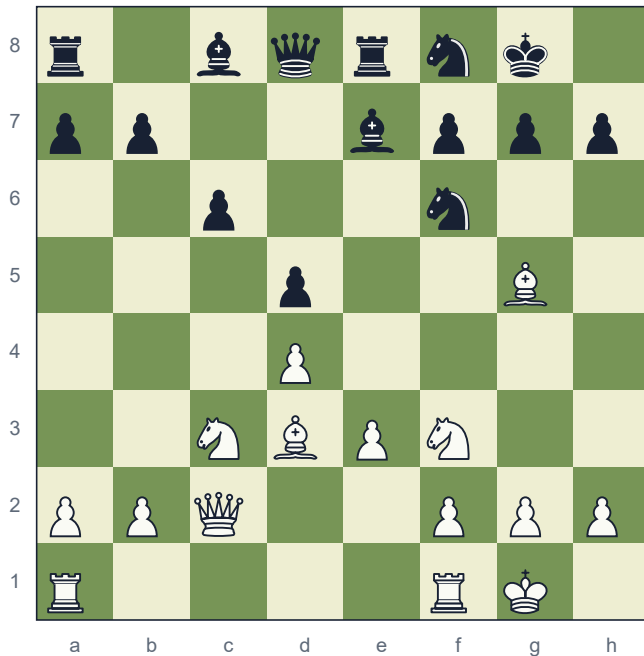
Qc2, Rab1 and b4 are possible preparations. Keep an eye on ...Ne4 and ...Re8 before committing.

WATCH FOR

Transpositions depend on the exact piece placement and whose turn it is. Similar pawn structures alone do not prove two positions are identical.

REMEMBER Recognize the setup, verify the move order.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The Carlsbad structure: White's c-pawn and Black's original d-pawn have been exchanged. Black's e-pawn stands on d5, supported by a c-pawn. White often attacks c6 with b4-b5; Black seeks kingside activity or the freeing ...c5.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black wants ...Ne4, piece exchanges that reduce pressure, or ...c5 before you organize a minority attack. Development can matter more than a permanent pawn weakness.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Complete development with a rook on b1 or c1 according to Black's setup. Prepare b4-b5, and meet a kingside initiative with exchanges or a central break.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

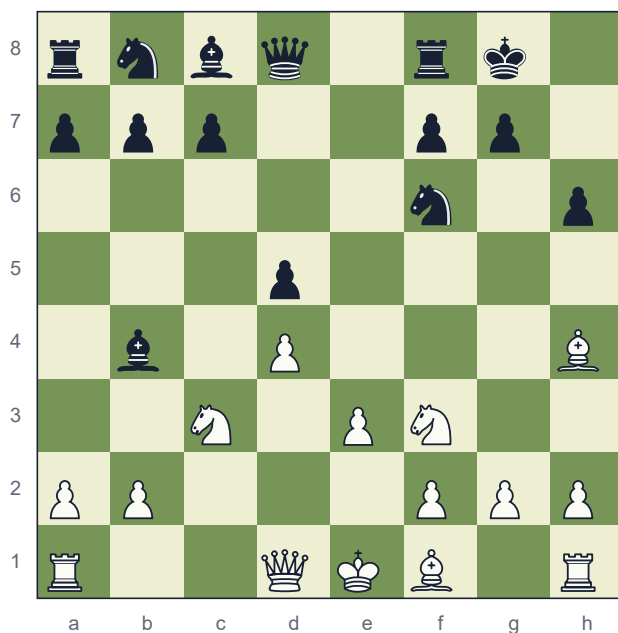
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

QGD alternatives: Ragozin, Vienna and early deviations

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Keep a coherent answer when Black declines to enter your Exchange setup. Resolve the specific pin or central capture before continuing normal development.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

These variations can produce a Carlsbad, an isolated queen pawn, or a broad e4-d4 center. The pawn skeleton must guide your choice, not the opening name.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

...Bb4 pins Nc3; ...dxc4 can invite e4 and attack the new center; ...a6 prepares ...b5 or asks a useful waiting question.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Against a pin, count whether the pinned piece still defends the center.
2. Recapture a gambit pawn when it helps development; do not chase it with the queen unnecessarily.
3. The move e4 is stronger when its central support survives an exchange.

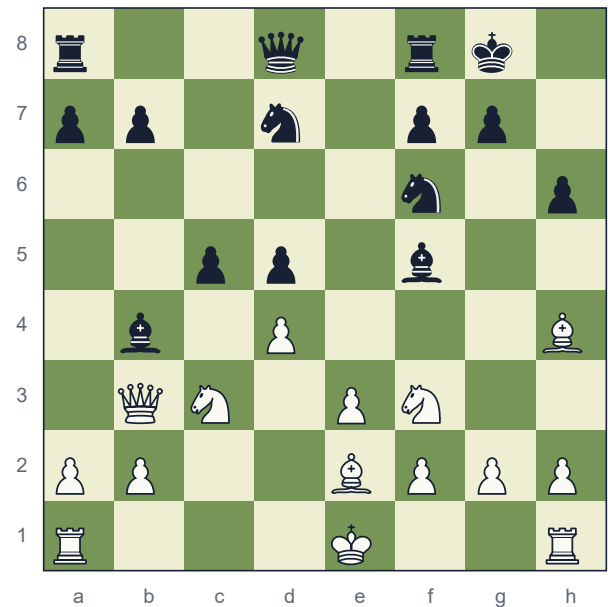
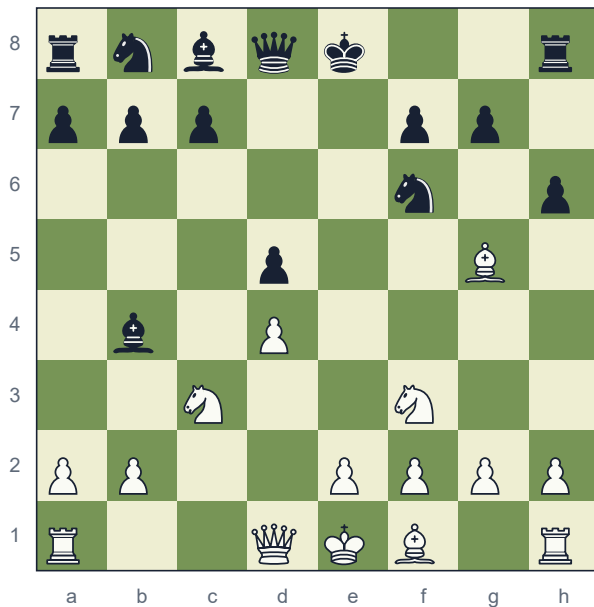
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Ragozin: exchange first

STUDY LINE 03-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 O-O 8. e3 Bf5 9. Be2 Nbd7 10. Qb3 c5

Selected anchor ends with 8. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



WHY THESE MOVES

The exchange removes the tension before the pin generates more complications. Bg5 counter-pins the f6 knight and e3 prepares Bd3.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bd3 and castle. If ...Bxc3 damages your pawns, compare the bishop pair and central control with the structural cost.

WATCH FOR

Do not forget ...g5 can drive the bishop while ...Ne4 creates central pressure.

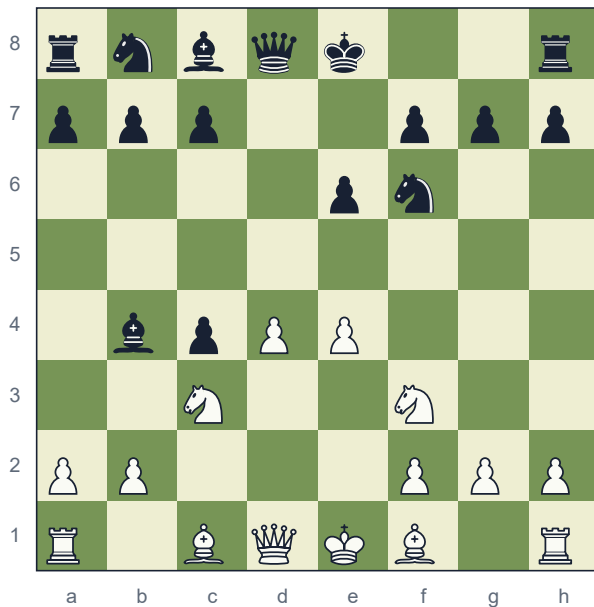
REMEMBER Exchange on d5, then finish development against the pin.

02 Vienna: accept the central invitation

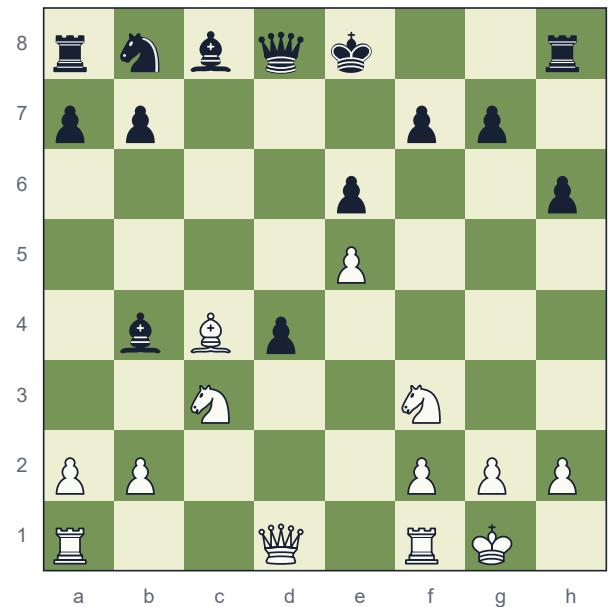
STUDY LINE 03-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bxf6 Qxf6 8. Bxc4 c5 9. O-O cxd4 10. e5 Qd8

Selected anchor ends with 6. Bg5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e4 uses the tempo Black spent capturing c4. The center gives space but becomes the target of ...c5 and ...Nxe4 ideas.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Support the center, develop actively, and calculate before recovering c4. A pawn returned for a lead in development can be a good bargain.

WATCH FOR

The c3 knight may be pinned. Recount e4 defenders after ...Bb4 before treating the pawn as safe.

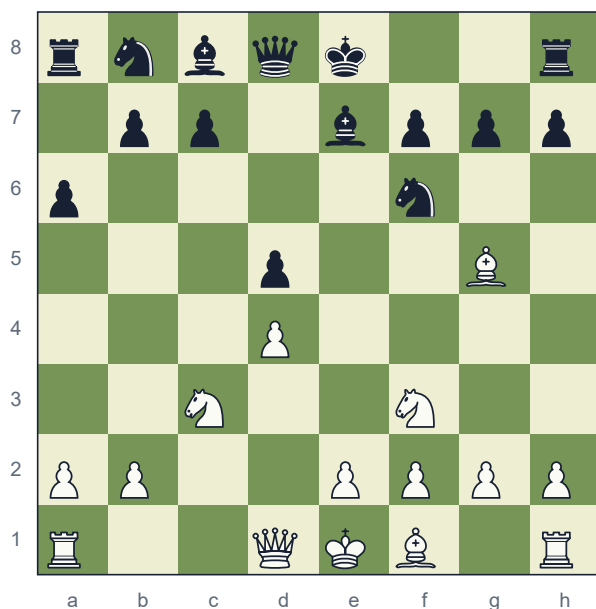
REMEMBER Space creates duties as well as opportunities.

03 Janowski: ...a6

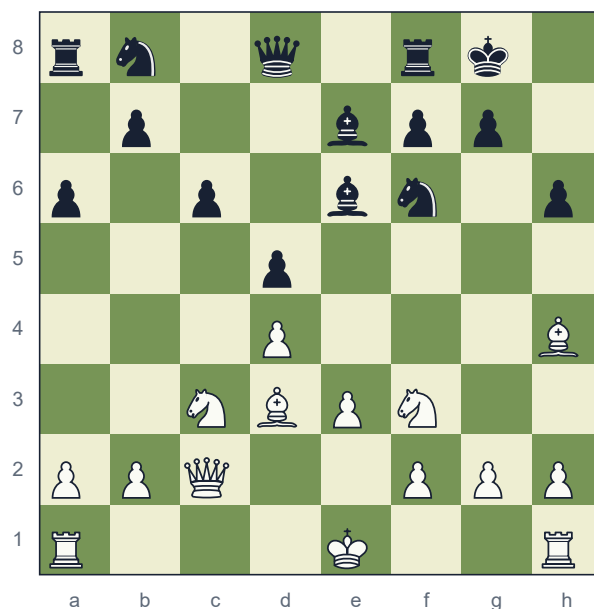
STUDY LINE 03-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 a6 4. Nc3 Nf6 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 Be7 7. e3 h6 8. Bh4 c6 9. Qc2 O-O 10. Bd3 Be6

Selected anchor ends with 7. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black has invested a tempo in ...a6. You can enter an Exchange structure without attempting an immediate punishment.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop and castle. ...a6 may make a later b4-b5 break harder or prepare ...b5, so queenside play needs a fresh calculation.

WATCH FOR

A flank move is not automatically a blunder, and a premature attack can give back your development lead.

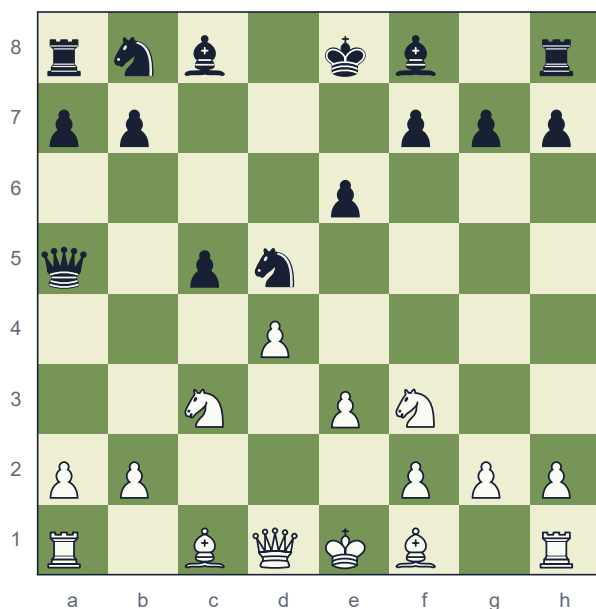
REMEMBER Take the useful center; avoid forcing a refutation.

04 An early queen check on a5

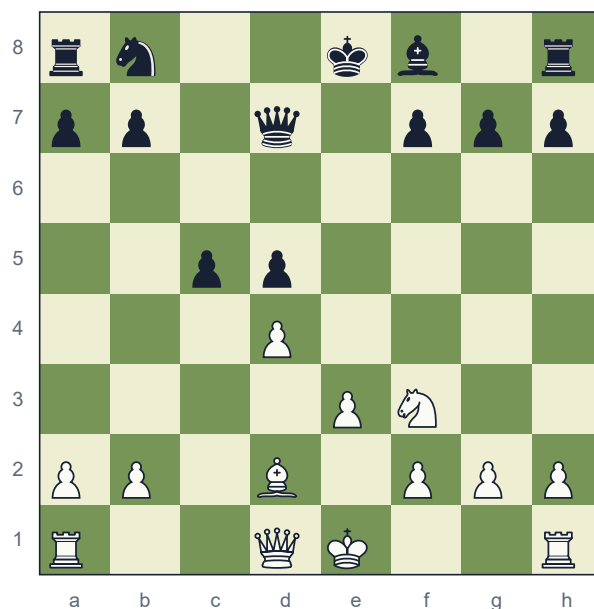
STUDY LINE 03-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e3 Qa5 7. Bd2 Qd8 8. Nxd5 exd5 9. Bb5+ Bd7 10. Bxd7+ Qxd7

Selected anchor ends with 7. Bd2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bd2 unpins the knight and develops a piece. Black's queen sortie gives you a concrete developing response.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bd3 and castling are the priorities. Treat any c-file exchanges as a route into isolated-pawn positions.

WATCH FOR

Do not play a center move that leaves your c3 knight undefended along the a5-e1 diagonal.

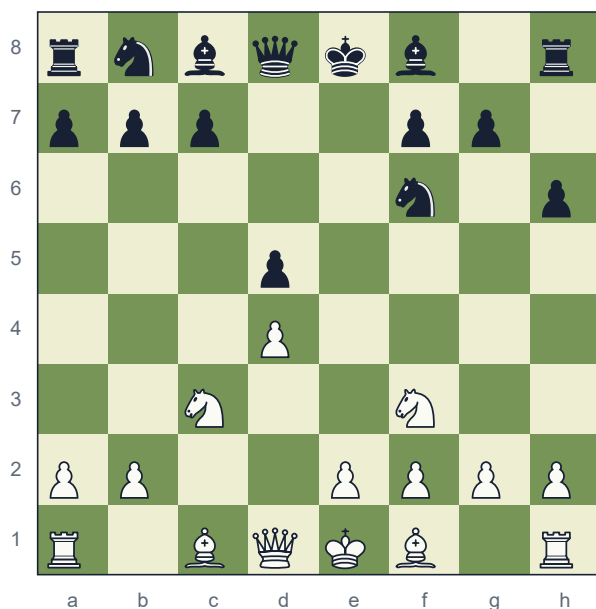
REMEMBER Meet a queen check with useful development.

05 Black plays ...h6 very early

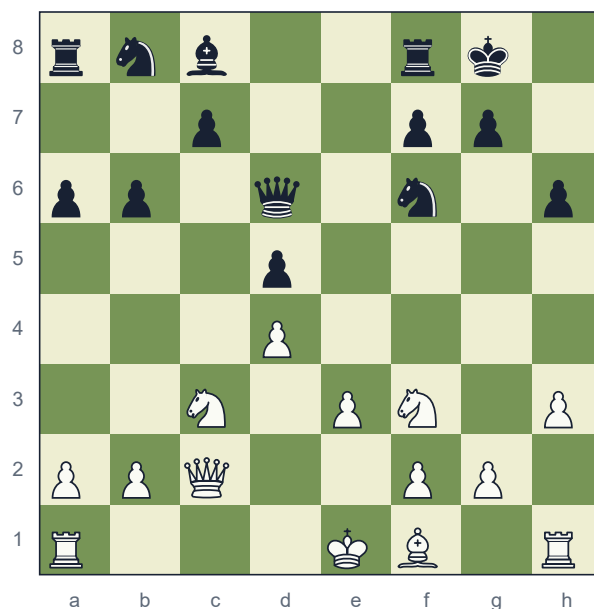
STUDY LINE 03-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 h6 4. Nc3 Nf6 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bf4 Bd6 7. Bxd6 Qxd6 8. Qc2 O-O 9. e3 a6 10. h3 b6

Selected anchor ends with 6. Bf4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bf4 develops to a useful square without arguing with ...h6. The Exchange structure can still be reached.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e3, Bd3 and O-O. Depending on Black's deployment, place the queen on c2 and coordinate the rooks.

WATCH FOR

Do not spend multiple moves trying to prove that ...h6 was a waste. Your own development is the practical gain.

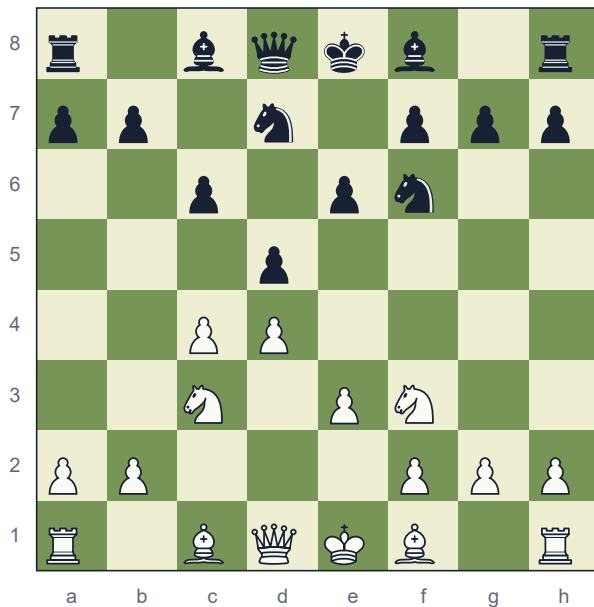
REMEMBER Quiet development can exploit a slow move.

06 Triangle move order: choose e3 before Nc3

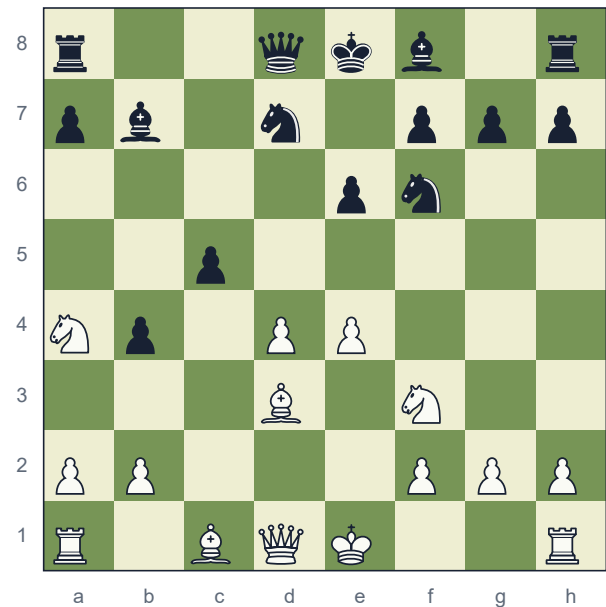
STUDY LINE 03-06

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c6 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 Bb7 9. e4 b4 10. Na4 c5

Selected anchor ends with 6. Bd3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

With ...e6 and ...c6 already played, e3 prepares to recover c4 without entering a Noteboom pawn-grab line with the b1 knight committed too early.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

If Black develops ...Nf6, return to the e3 Semi-Slav. If ...dxc4 comes first, recover with Bxc4 and watch ...b5.

WATCH FOR

Playing Nc3 automatically against the triangle allows ...dxc4 and a different body of theory.

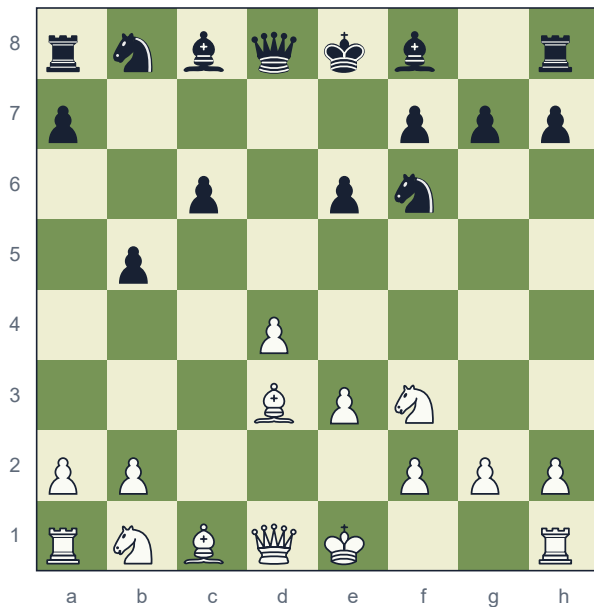
REMEMBER Against the triangle, e3 is the practical bridge.

07 Triangle: Black takes on c4 immediately

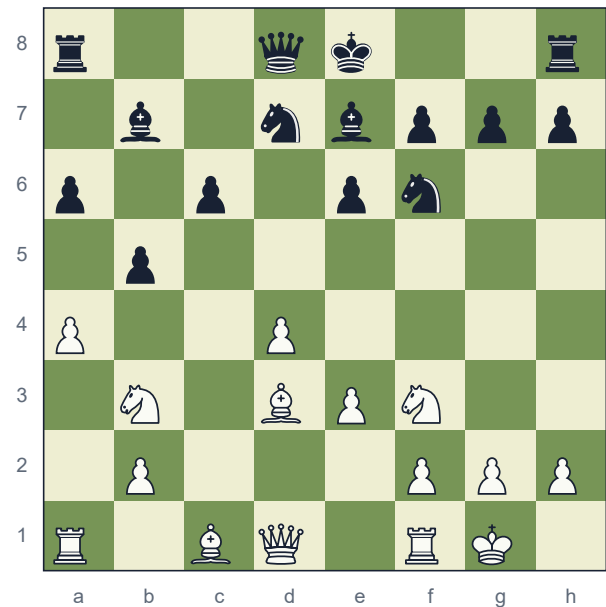
STUDY LINE 03-07

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c6 4. e3 dxc4 5. Bxc4 b5 6. Bd3 Nf6 7. O-O a6 8. a4 Bb7 9. Nbd2 Nbd7 10. Nb3 Be7

Selected anchor ends with 7. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The e3 pawn move allowed a clean bishop recapture. Black can still expand, but White develops toward a central response.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

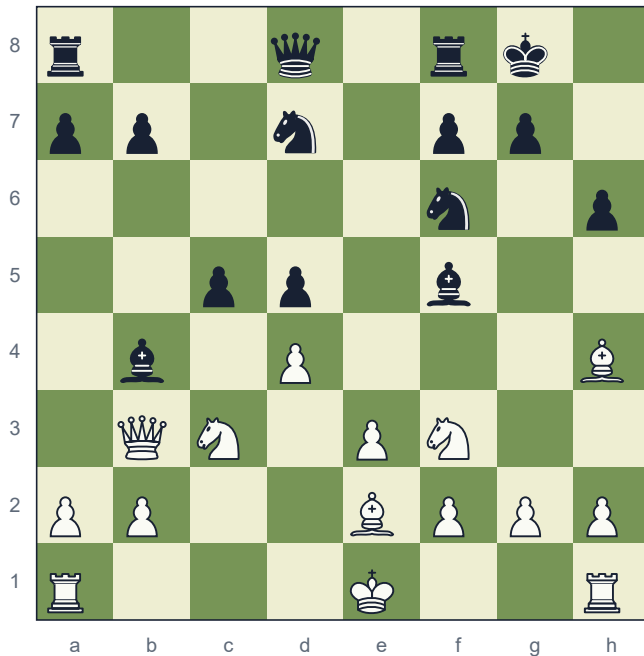
Develop the b1 knight and prepare e4 when ready. This is related to the Semi-Slav structures in Booklet 06.

WATCH FOR

Remember to retreat the bishop when ...b5 attacks it.

REMEMBER Recover c4 with development and keep the center flexible.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

These variations can produce a Carlsbad, an isolated queen pawn, or a broad e4-d4 center. The pawn skeleton must guide your choice, not the opening name.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

...Bb4 pins Nc3; ...dxc4 can invite e4 and attack the new center; ...a6 prepares ...b5 or asks a useful waiting question.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop Bd3 and castle. If ...Bxc3 damages your pawns, compare the bishop pair and central control with the structural cost.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

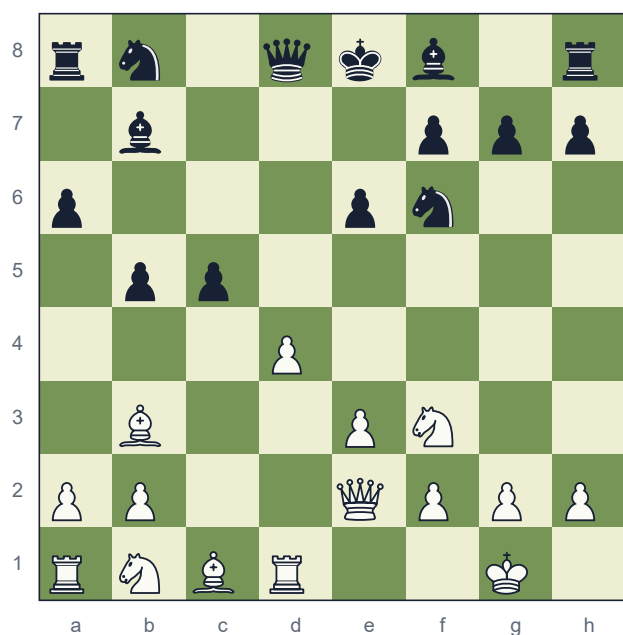
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Queen's Gambit Accepted

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.Nf3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Recover c4 with a developing bishop move when possible. Use Nf3 to restrain ...e5, then e3 and Bxc4. You do not need to win the pawn back immediately.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

After ...c5 and exchanges on d4, White may have an isolated d-pawn. Before that, the open center and quick development are the important features.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black returns the pawn to develop freely, or tries ...b5 to hold it. The latter often gives you targets for a4 and undermining moves.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The Queen's Gambit is not an instruction to sacrifice c4 forever.
2. Against ...b5, attack the supporting pawn chain instead of bringing the queen out repeatedly.
3. An isolated d-pawn is playable with active pieces; avoid drifting into a passive blockade.

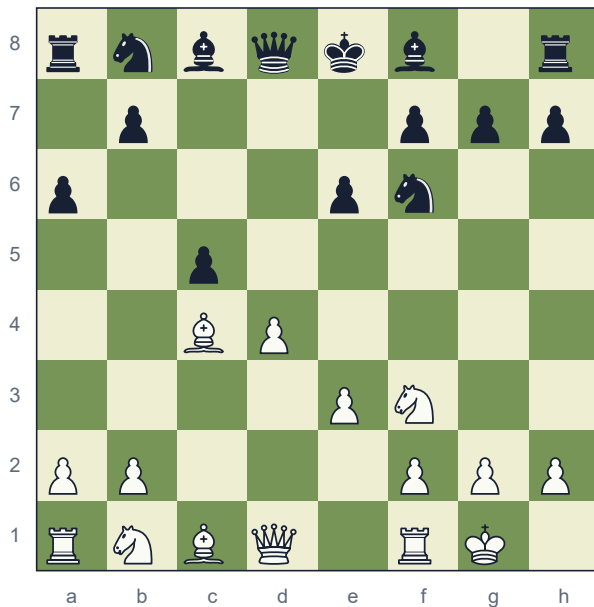
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Classical development

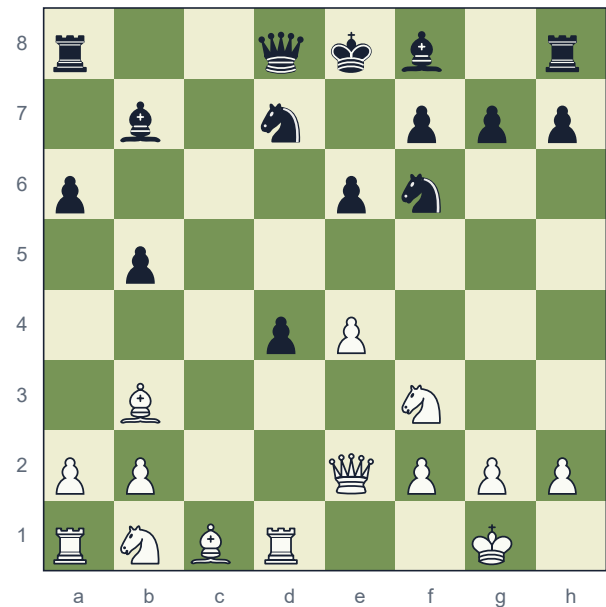
STUDY LINE 04-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4 c5 6. O-O a6 7. Qe2 b5 8. Bb3 Bb7 9. Rd1 Nbd7 10. e4 cxd4

Selected anchor ends with 9. Rd1. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 opens the bishop and Bxc4 recovers the pawn with development. Qe2 and Rd1 build pressure on the central file.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the b1 knight to c3 or d2 according to tactics. Watch ...cxd4 and decide which piece or pawn should recapture.

WATCH FOR

Do not push d5 just because the rook is on d1; make sure the resulting exchanges do not lose the center.

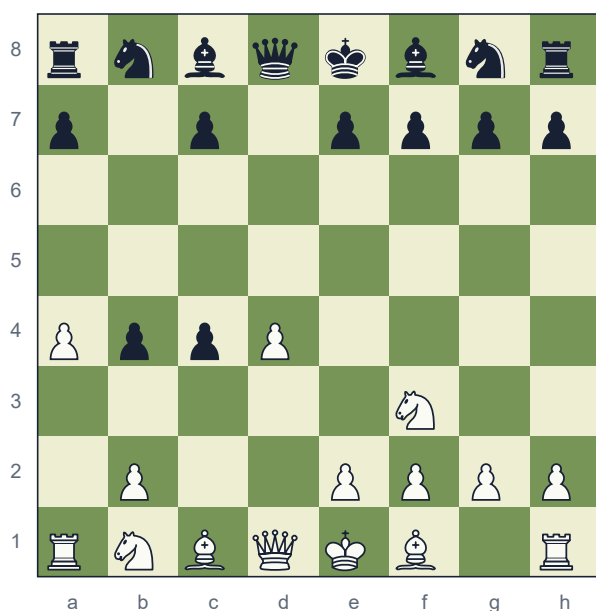
REMEMBER Recover with the bishop and bring a rook to the center.

02 Black tries to hold with ...b5

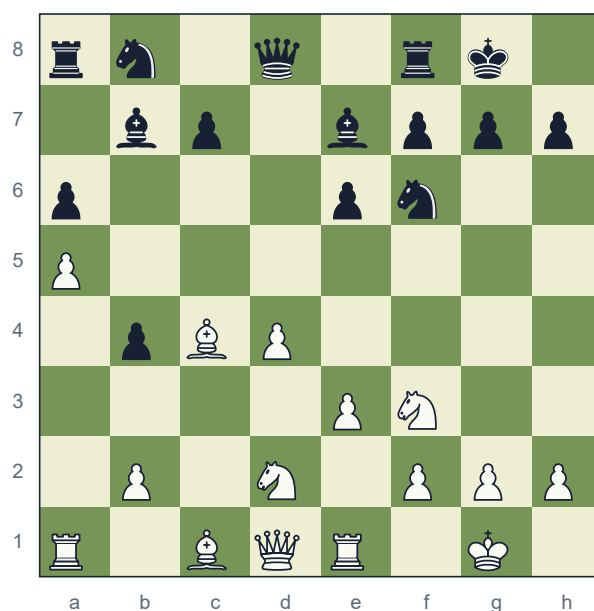
STUDY LINE 04-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 b5 4. a4 b4 5. e3 Nf6 6. Bxc4 e6 7. a5 a6 8. O-O Bb7 9. Nbd2 Be7 10. Re1 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 attacks the base of Black's chain. After ...b4, e3 opens lines and prepares to recover c4.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bxc4 when safe, castle, and exploit the queenside weaknesses. Material is less important than getting your pieces out while Black spends pawn moves.

WATCH FOR

After ...b4, a knight developed automatically to c3 can be attacked with tempo.

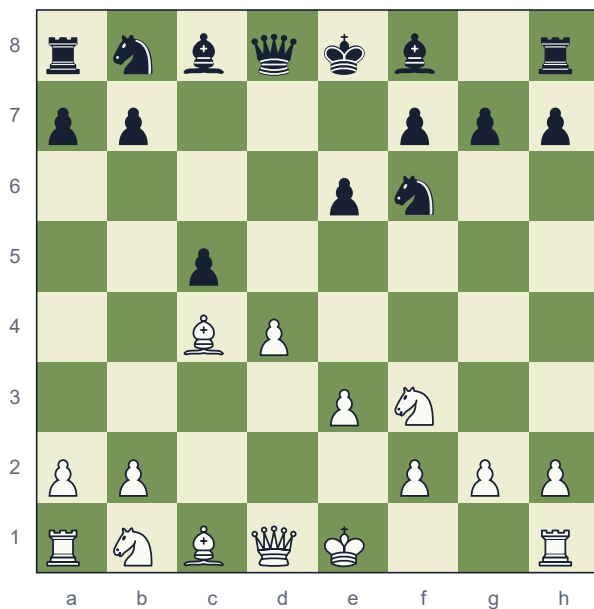
REMEMBER Undermine the support of the captured pawn.

03 An immediate ...c5

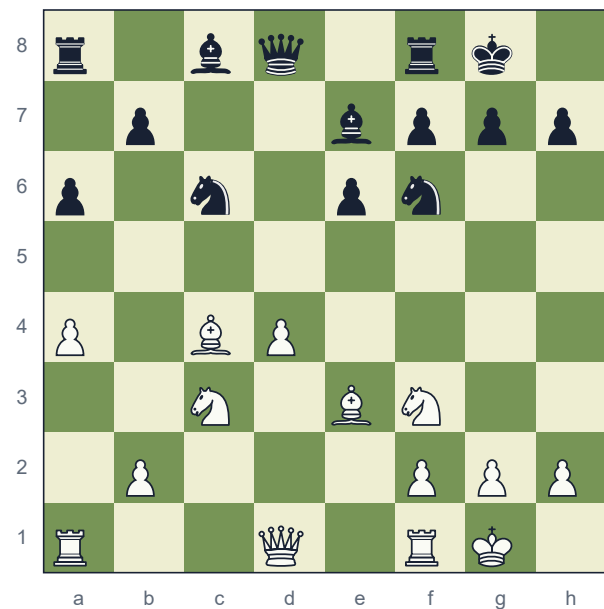
STUDY LINE 04-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Bxc4 e6 6. O-O a6 7. a4 cxd4 8. exd4 Nc6 9. Nc3 Be7 10. Be3 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 6. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The same development scheme works. The key is that your e-pawn is still available to support or recapture in the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Nc3 and Qe2 are useful, with the d-file becoming important after central exchanges.

WATCH FOR

An early dxc5 can leave e4 available to Black and should not be played by habit.

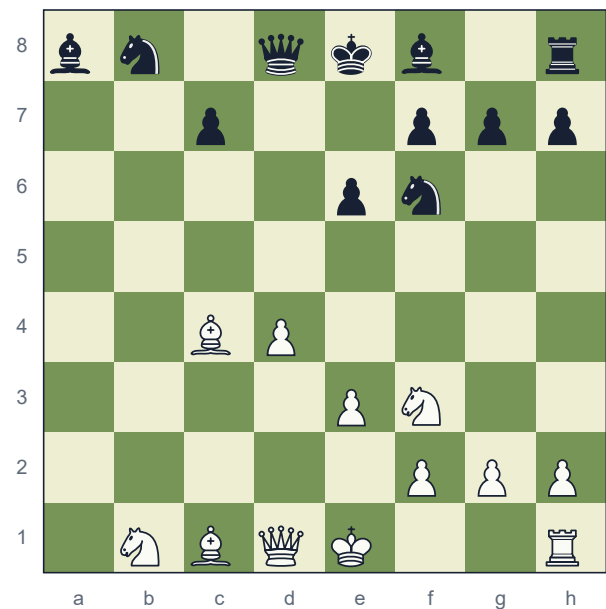
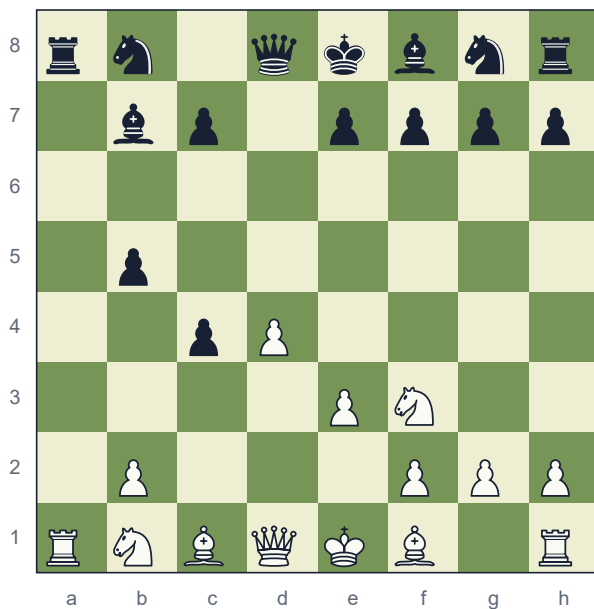
REMEMBER Keep development ahead of pawn collecting.

04 Black prepares ...b5 with ...a6

STUDY LINE 04-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 a6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. axb5 axb5 7. Rxa8 Bxa8 8. b3 e6 9. bxc4 bxc4 10. Bxc4 Nf6

Selected anchor ends with 7... Bxa8. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



WHY THESE MOVES

a4 immediately asks whether Black can hold the extra pawn without concessions. Trading the a-rooks can leave b5 and c4 as targets.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Continue developing and recover c4 at the right moment. The open files favor pieces already in play.

WATCH FOR

Check rook exchanges all the way through: a missing rook is not a free bishop on a8.

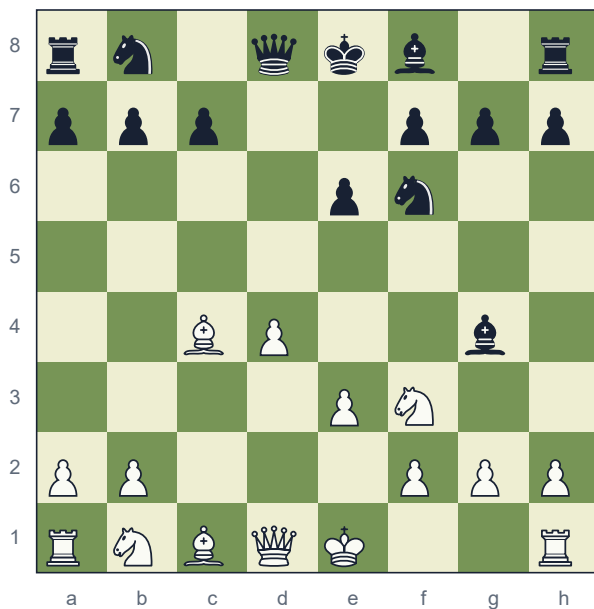
REMEMBER Challenge ...b5 before it becomes comfortable.

05 A pin with ...Bg4

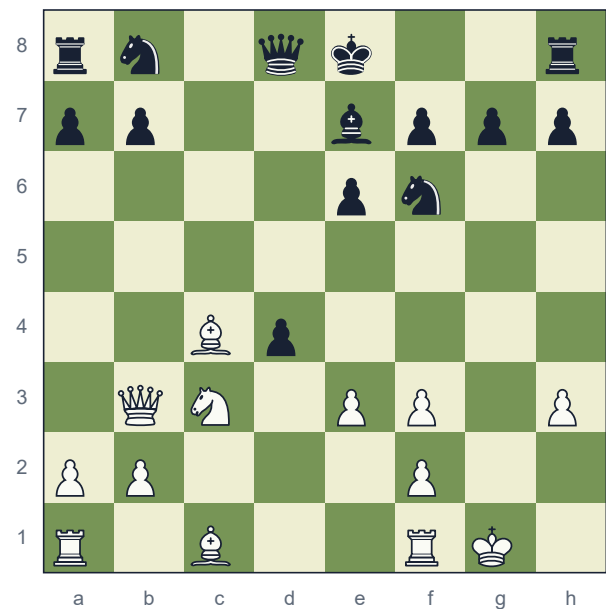
STUDY LINE 04-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. e3 Nf6 5. Bxc4 e6 6. O-O Be7 7. Nc3 c5 8. h3 Bh5 9. Qb3 Bxf3 10. gxf3 cxd4

Selected anchor ends with 6. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 and Bxc4 are enough to maintain a sound position. You can tolerate the pin while the king reaches safety.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

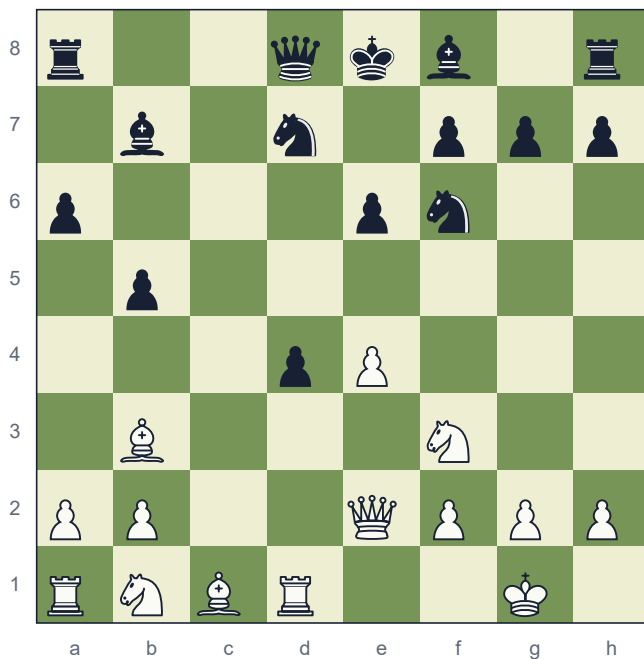
Use Nc3 and h3 only when it helps. If Black exchanges on f3, choose the recapture that suits the center and king safety.

WATCH FOR

h3 is not obligatory if it merely encourages a useful bishop exchange for Black.

REMEMBER Develop through the pin; challenge it on your terms.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

After ...c5 and exchanges on d4, White may have an isolated d-pawn. Before that, the open center and quick development are the important features.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black returns the pawn to develop freely, or tries ...b5 to hold it. The latter often gives you targets for a4 and undermining moves.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the b1 knight to c3 or d2 according to tactics. Watch ...cxd4 and decide which piece or pawn should recapture.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

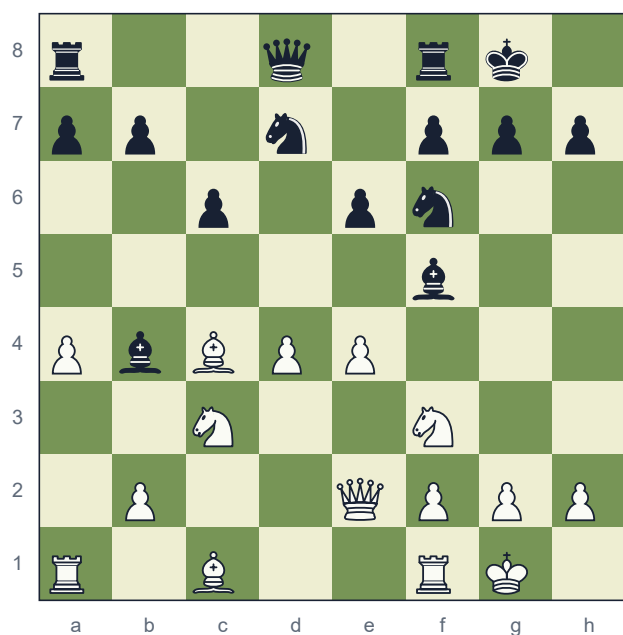
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

The Slav Defense

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Against ...dxc4 use a4 to restrain ...b5, then e3 and Bxc4. Keep a full central position without letting Black hold the extra pawn too cheaply.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The c6 pawn supports d5 while the c8 bishop can develop outside the chain. Unlike the QGD, Black has not necessarily blocked that bishop with ...e6.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black can capture c4, develop ...Bf5 or ...Bg4, play a waiting ...a6, or transpose to the Semi-Slav with ...e6.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. a4 in the main line has a purpose: it fights ...b5.
2. An early ...e6 takes you to the Semi-Slav booklet; do not continue a Slav line mechanically.
3. If the bishop leaves c8 before the center is settled, pressure on b7 or d5 may become possible.

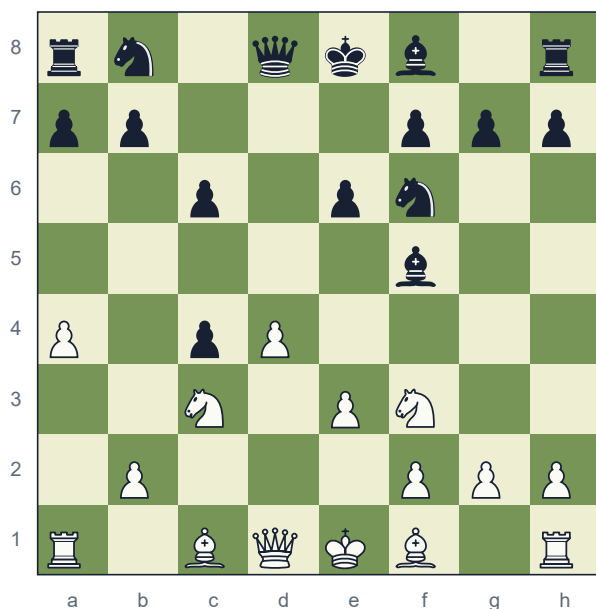
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Main line with ...Bf5

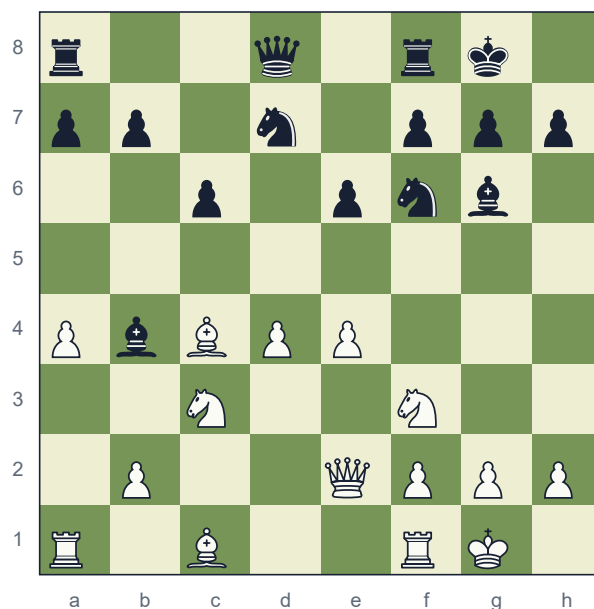
STUDY LINE 05-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O O-O 9. Qe2 Nbd7 10. e4 Bg6

Selected anchor ends with 10. e4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 restrains ...b5, e3 releases the bishop, and e4 later uses your central majority after development.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Support e4, develop the c1 bishop, and watch ...Bg6 or ...Bxc3. The d4-e4 center can advance only if the pieces behind it cooperate.

WATCH FOR

Do not confuse space with stability: ...Nxe4 may work tactically when the c3 knight is pinned.

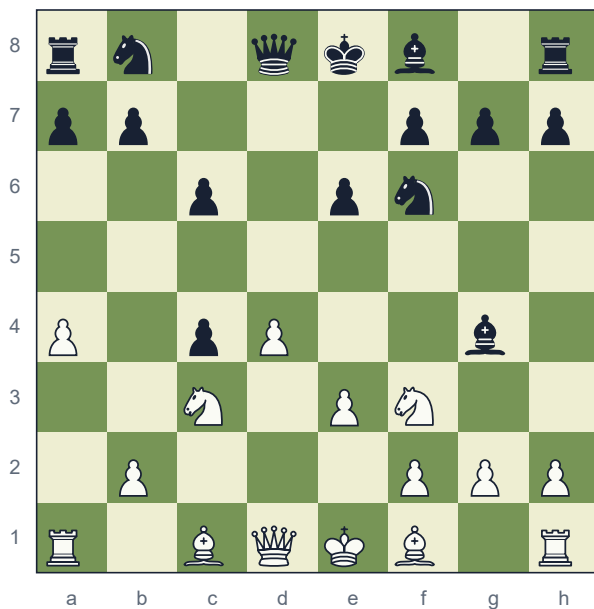
REMEMBER a4, recover c4, develop, then consider e4.

02 The ...Bg4 alternative

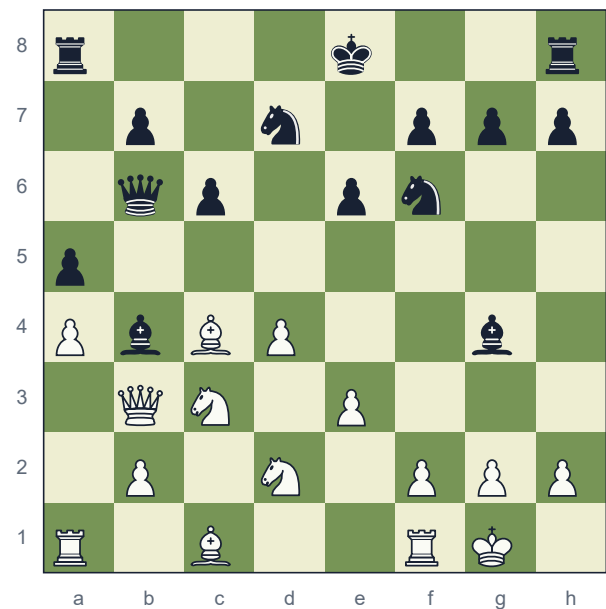
STUDY LINE 05-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bg4 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qb3 Qb6 10. Nd2 a5

Selected anchor ends with 8. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The bishop pins f3 instead of controlling e4 from f5. You can still use the main development scheme.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Meet pressure on d4 with active development. A timely h3 can ask the bishop to decide, but first ensure the central pawns are adequately defended.

WATCH FOR

After ...Bxf3, a queen recapture may abandon a tactical defense elsewhere. Count before recapturing.

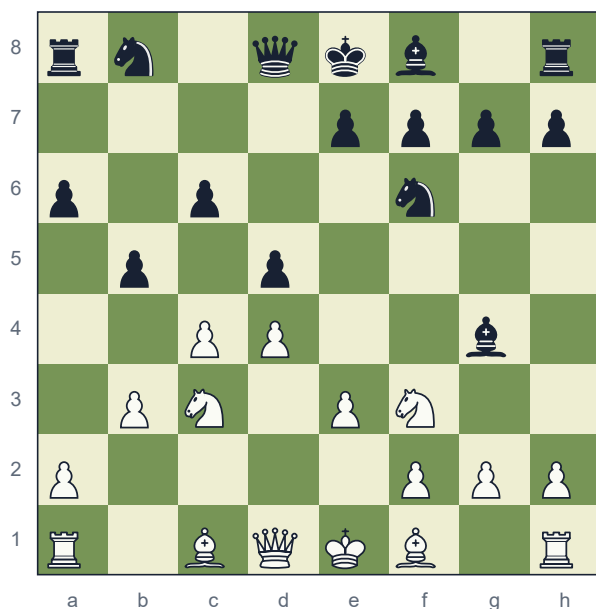
REMEMBER Same development, different pin.

03 Chebanenko: ...a6

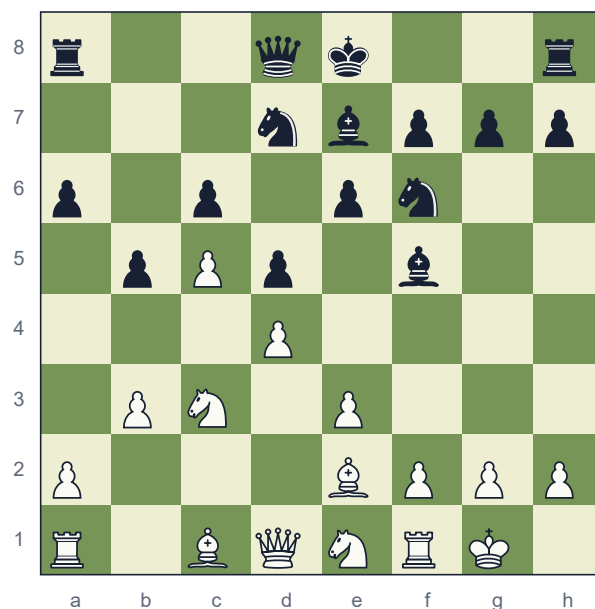
STUDY LINE 05-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 a6 5. e3 b5 6. b3 Bg4 7. Be2 e6 8. c5 Nbd7 9. O-O Be7 10. Ne1 Bf5

Selected anchor ends with 7. Be2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 and b3 build a stable center while preparing to contest the long diagonal. Black's queenside expansion gains space but also creates targets.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Castle, finish development with Bb2, and challenge the center rather than racing the b-pawn without support.

WATCH FOR

cx b5 followed by a recapture can strengthen Black's central or queenside pawn mass. Calculate the structure before exchanging.

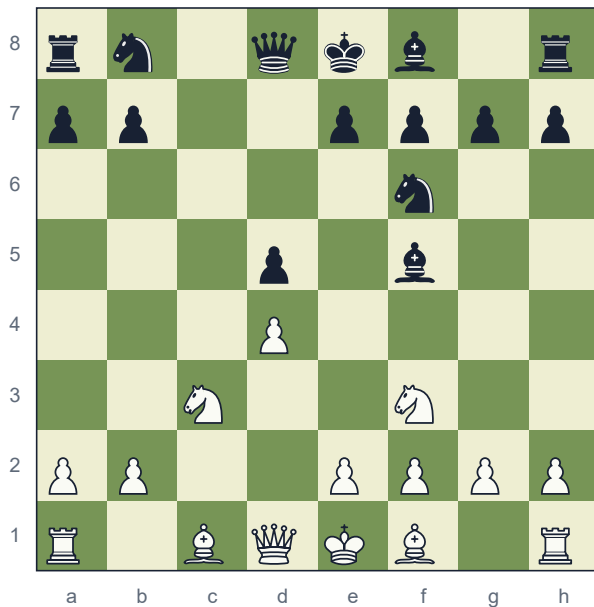
REMEMBER Let development decide when to challenge ...b5.

04 Early ...Bf5 before capturing

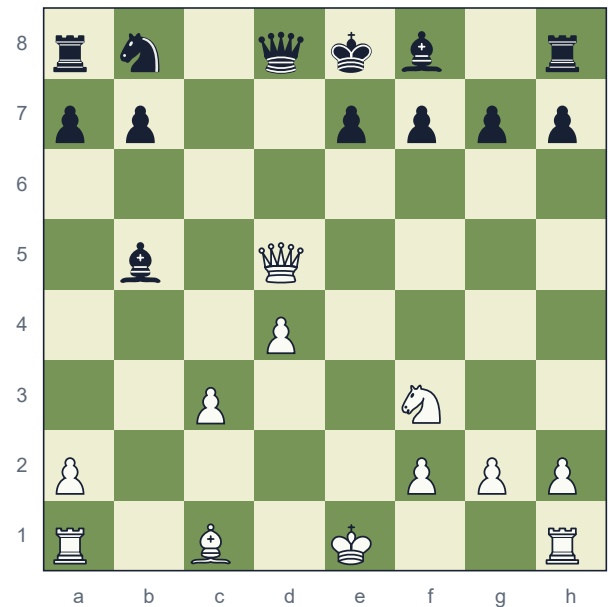
STUDY LINE 05-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. cxd5 cxd5 6. Qb3 Bc8 7. e4 Nxe4 8. Bb5+ Bd7 9. Qxd5 Nxc3 10. bxc3 Bxb5

Selected anchor ends with 6. Qb3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The queen eyes b7 after the bishop has left c8. This makes Black account for the queenside instead of completing a setup for free.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop e3 and Bd3 if the queen raid does not win anything concrete. Pressure is useful even when you do not capture the pawn.

WATCH FOR

Qxb7 can trap your queen or fall behind in development. The threat may be stronger than the capture.

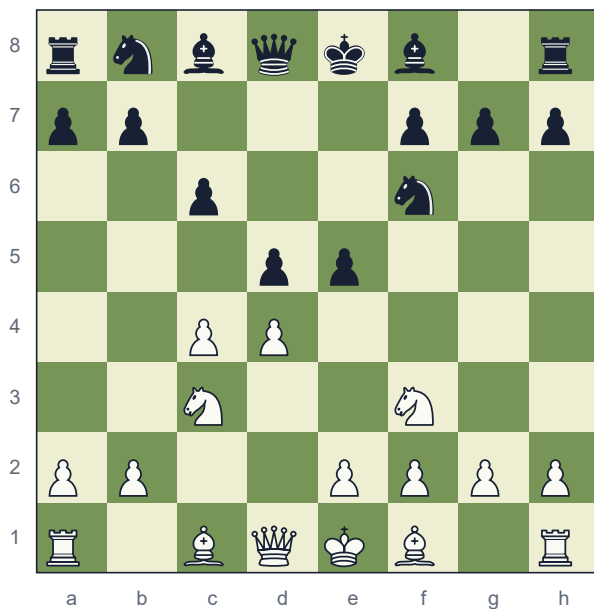
REMEMBER Attack the undefended point, but do not become greedy.

05 An early ...e5 counterstrike

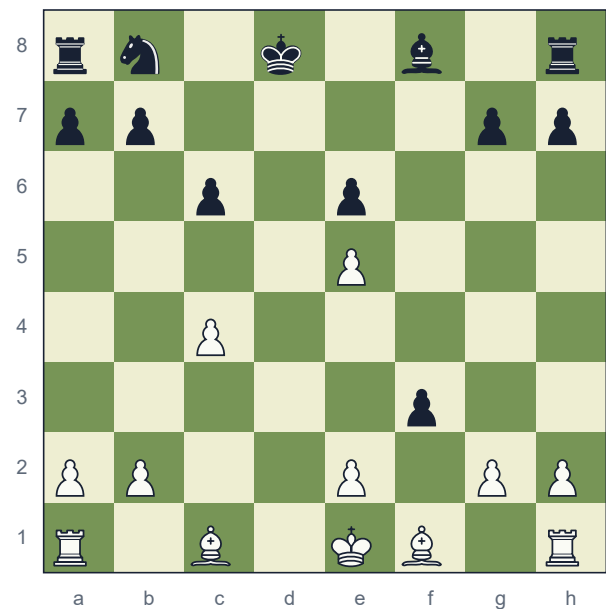
STUDY LINE 05-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e5 5. dxe5 Ne4 6. Nxe4 dxe4 7. Qxd8+ Kxd8 8. Ng5 Be6 9. Nxe6+ fxe6 10. f4 exf3

Selected anchor ends with 5... Ne4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Accept the central pawn and recognize that the knight leap is Black's source of compensation. The center is now tactical, not a standard Slav setup.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop actively and be willing to return a pawn to neutralize threats. Check queen checks and the c3 knight before choosing a capture.

WATCH FOR

Do not mix this ...e5 line with the Albin: the black c-pawn is on c6, and the knight is already on f6 before jumping.

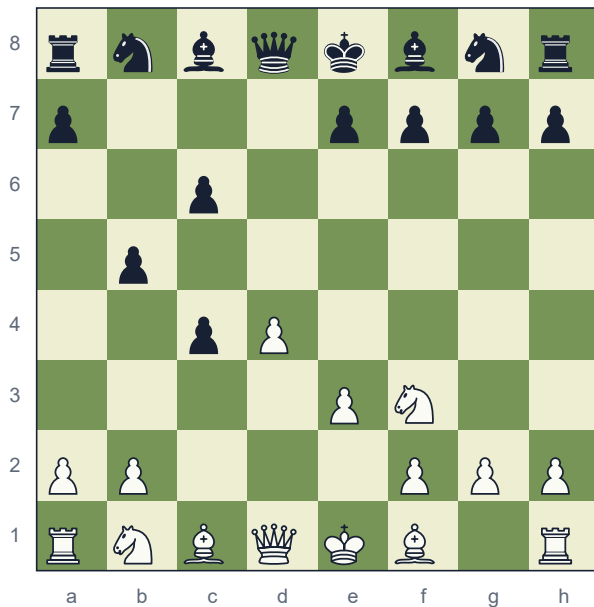
REMEMBER Identify the actual position, not just the word gambit.

06 Black captures before developing ...Nf6

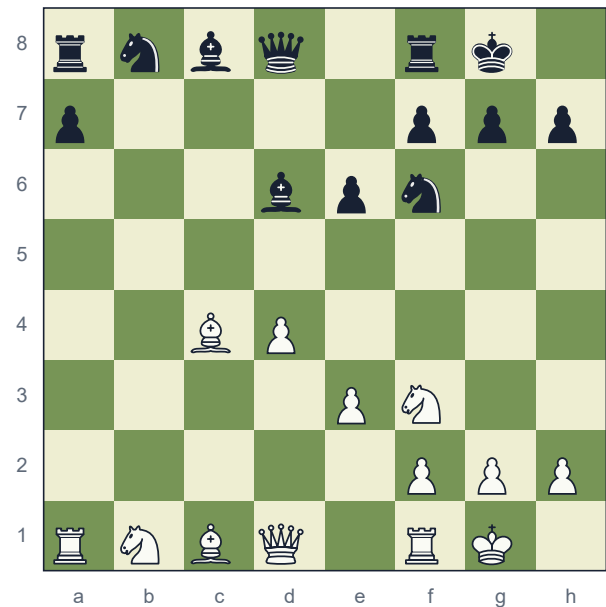
STUDY LINE 05-06

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 b5 5. a4 e6 6. axb5 cxb5 7. b3 Nf6 8. bxc4 bxc4 9. Bxc4 Bd6 10. O-O O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. a4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 prepares Bxc4 while a4 challenges the supporting pawn chain. Black has spent several moves on pawns instead of developing the king side.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

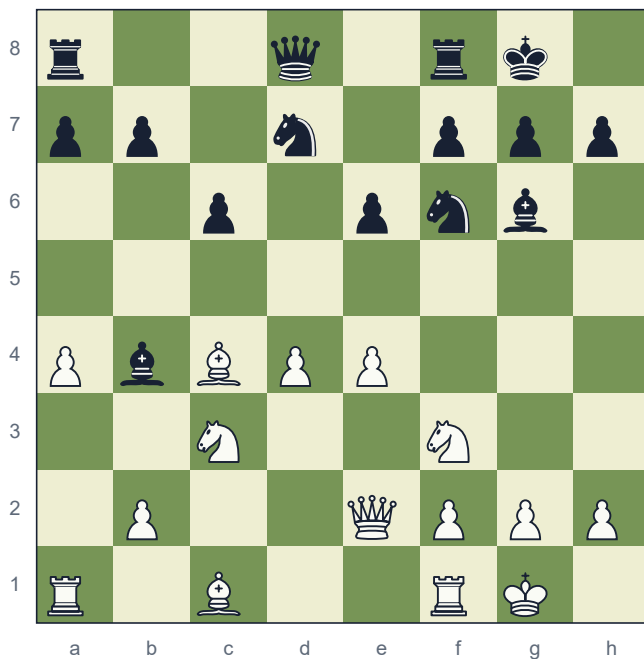
Recover c4 when safe and bring the king to safety. Watch a possible ...b4 before placing the b1 knight on c3.

WATCH FOR

The move order differs from the main Slav, where Nc3 was already played before the capture.

REMEMBER Challenge the support and use the development lead.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The c6 pawn supports d5 while the c8 bishop can develop outside the chain. Unlike the QGD, Black has not necessarily blocked that bishop with ...e6.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black can capture c4, develop ...Bf5 or ...Bg4, play a waiting ...a6, or transpose to the Semi-Slav with ...e6.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Support e4, develop the c1 bishop, and watch ...Bg6 or ...Bxc3. The d4-e4 center can advance only if the pieces behind it cooperate.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

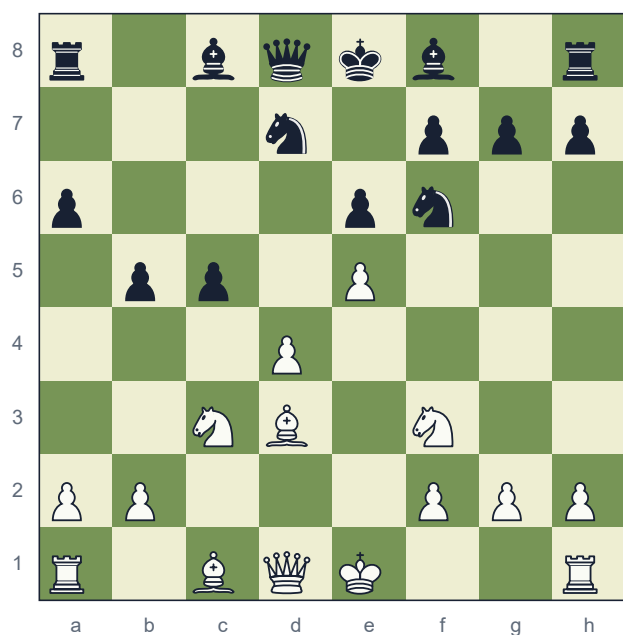
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

The Semi-Slav: e3 systems

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Choose 5.e3 rather than making the sharp Bg5 systems mandatory. Develop Bd3 and decide how to meet Black's queenside expansion.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Black's c6-d5-e6 triangle is solid but restrains the c8 bishop. The ...dxc4 and ...b5 sequence frees the queenside at the cost of time and dark-square concessions.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

The Meran uses ...dxc4, ...b5 and often ...a6 followed by ...c5. Waiting with ...Bd6 can lead to an Anti-Meran structure.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The bishop goes to d3 after ...b5 in the Meran; do not leave it attacked on c4.
2. Central breaks e4 and ...c5 often decide whether a flank expansion was justified.
3. If Black plays ...f5, treat the result as a Stonewall structure rather than a normal Meran.

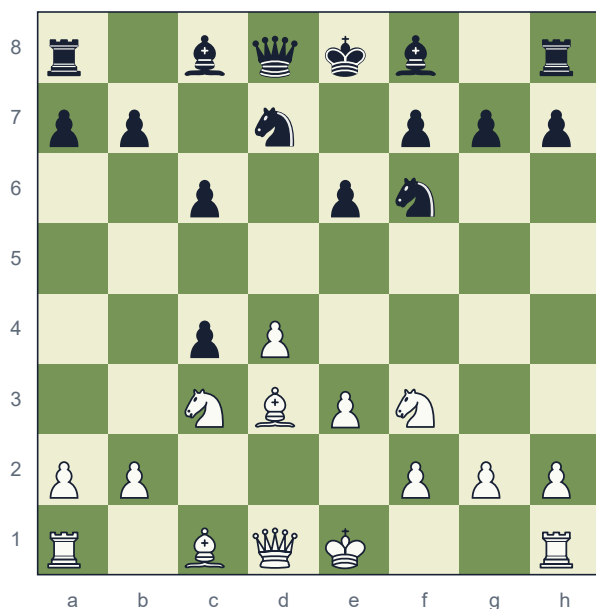
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Meran: the central counterstrike

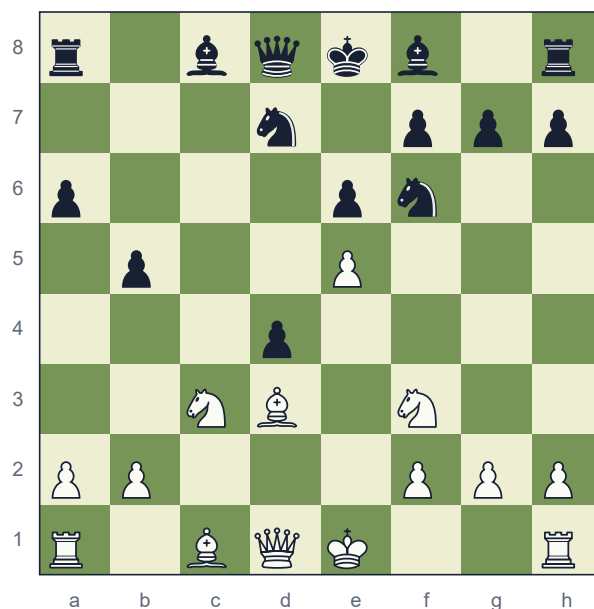
STUDY LINE 06-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4

Selected anchor ends with 10. e5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White gains time against the f6 knight while Black attacks the center. This is a concrete line: e5 is a central reaction to ...c5, not a generic attacking move.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Calculate captures on d4 and b5. Keep pieces active; the position can open before either side has completed the familiar quiet setup.

WATCH FOR

After 10.e5, stop and calculate Black's reply. This is a place to learn a branch rather than blindly finishing a ten-move script.

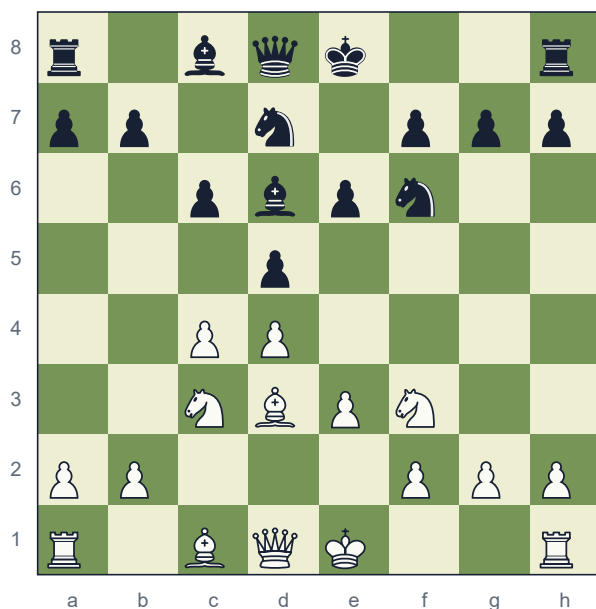
REMEMBER Answer a flank expansion with a prepared central action.

02 Anti-Meran with ...Bd6

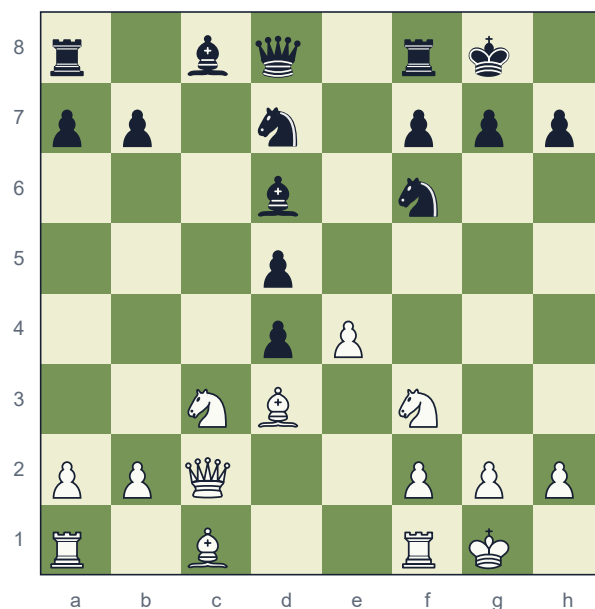
STUDY LINE 06-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 Bd6 7. O-O O-O 8. Qc2 e5 9. cxd5 cxd5 10. e4 exd4

Selected anchor ends with 8. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Qc2 reinforces e4 while castling removes your king from the center. Both players retain choices about the central tension.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Re1, e4 and queenside development are candidates. If Black captures c4 and pushes ...b5, retreat the bishop and strike centrally when ready.

WATCH FOR

e4 can fail if ...dxe4 and a tactical knight capture leave you losing a central pawn. Count the sequence.

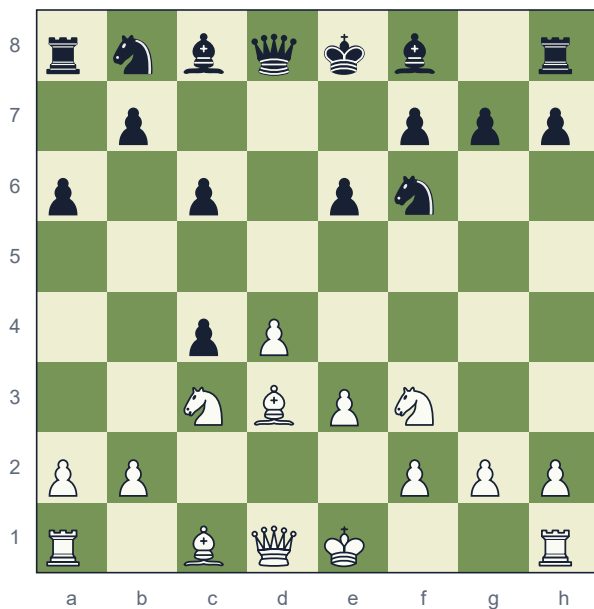
REMEMBER Prepare e4 with pieces, not just enthusiasm.

03 The early ...a6 Meran

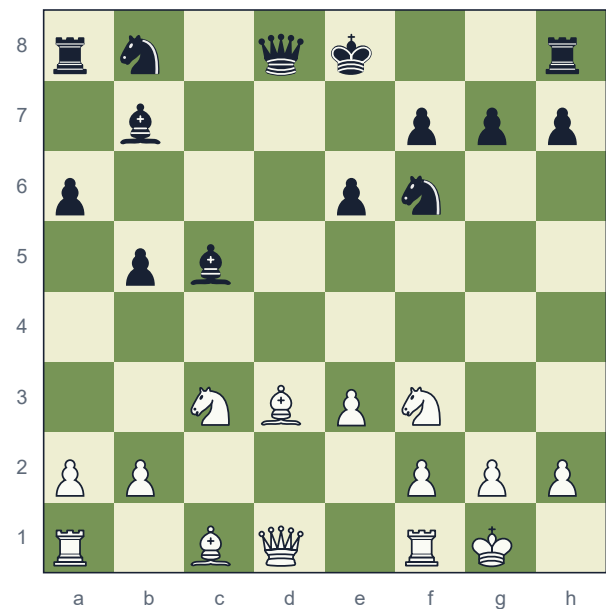
STUDY LINE 06-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 a6 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 c5 9. O-O Bb7 10. dxc5 Bxc5

Selected anchor ends with 9. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black delays the b8 knight and begins expansion. White castles before choosing a direct central confrontation.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

e4 is attractive if properly supported. Compare a quick e4 with keeping the center and improving the queen and rooks.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume every ...a6 line is identical: a knight on d7 changes tactical defenses and available breaks.

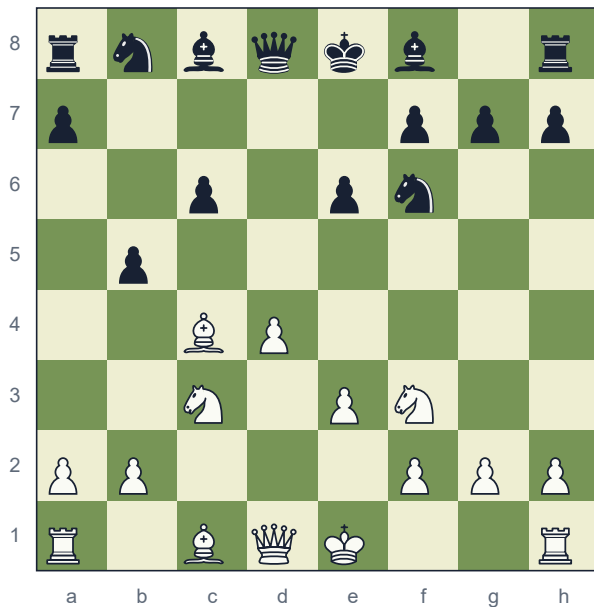
REMEMBER Notice which developing move Black has delayed.

04 Black exchanges on c4 before ...Nbd7

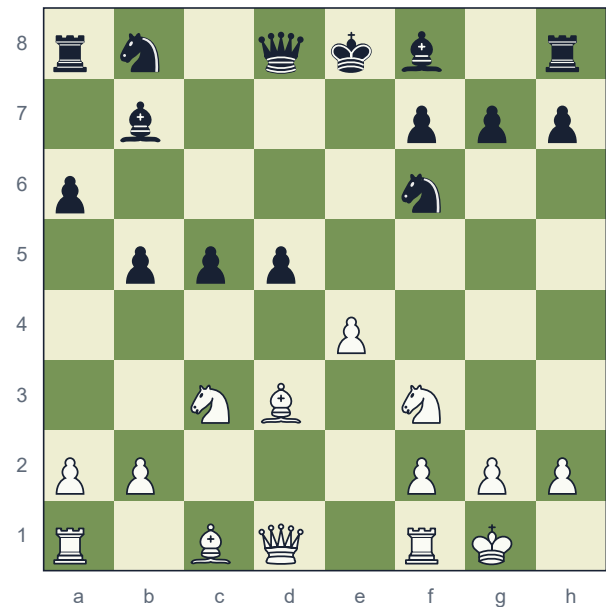
STUDY LINE 06-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 dxc4 6. Bxc4 b5 7. Bd3 Bb7 8. O-O a6 9. e4 c5 10. d5 exd5

Selected anchor ends with 8. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bxc4 and Bd3 accept that a developing bishop may have to move twice. Black also spent time on a capture and a pawn push.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e4 once the central support is sufficient. Watch the b7 bishop's diagonal toward g2 after any central exchange.

WATCH FOR

Opening the long diagonal without checking g2 can turn a routine center push into a tactical error.

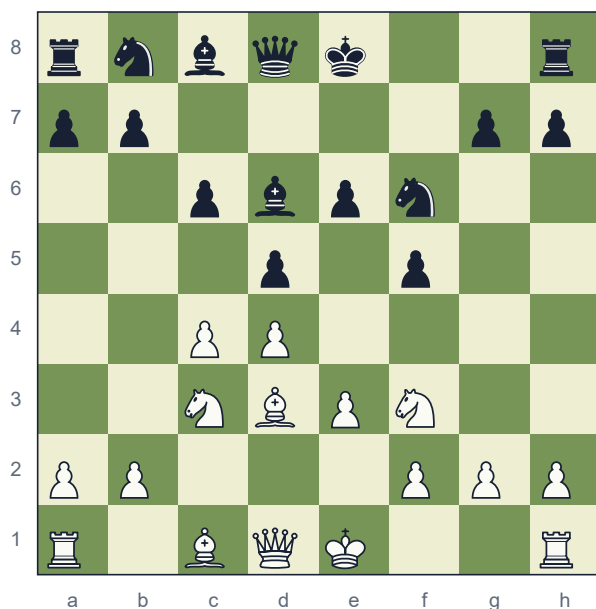
REMEMBER Track the b7-g2 diagonal before opening the center.

05 A Stonewall by ...f5

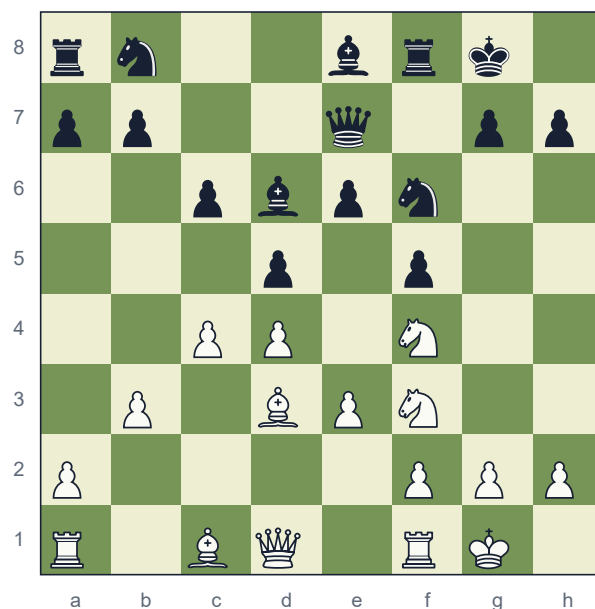
STUDY LINE 06-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 e6 4. Nc3 f5 5. e3 Nf6 6. Bd3 Bd6 7. O-O O-O 8. b3 Bd7 9. Ne2 Be8 10. Nf4 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 8. b3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black fixes a Stonewall and gives up control of e5. b3 prepares a development route for the c1 bishop.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

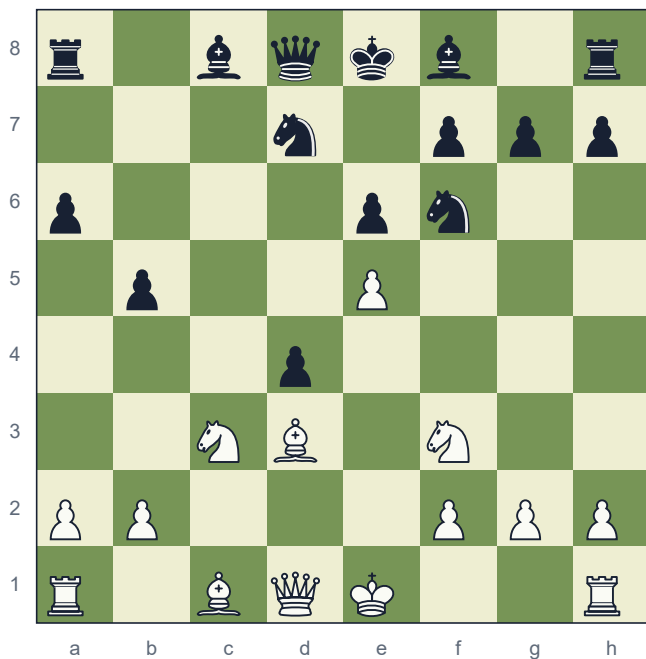
Bb2 or Ba3 may improve the bishop. Aim a knight at e5 and restrain ...g5 or ...Ne4 by controlling key entry squares.

WATCH FOR

If a black knight is already on e4, b3 may remove the only pawn defense of Nc3 and allow ...Nxc3. Verify that detail before using the bishop-development plan.

REMEMBER The e5 square is the strategic prize, but loose pieces come first.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Black's c6-d5-e6 triangle is solid but restrains the c8 bishop. The ...dxc4 and ...b5 sequence frees the queenside at the cost of time and dark-square concessions.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

The Meran uses ...dxc4, ...b5 and often ...a6 followed by ...c5. Waiting with ...Bd6 can lead to an Anti-Meran structure.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Calculate captures on d4 and b5. Keep pieces active; the position can open before either side has completed the familiar quiet setup.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

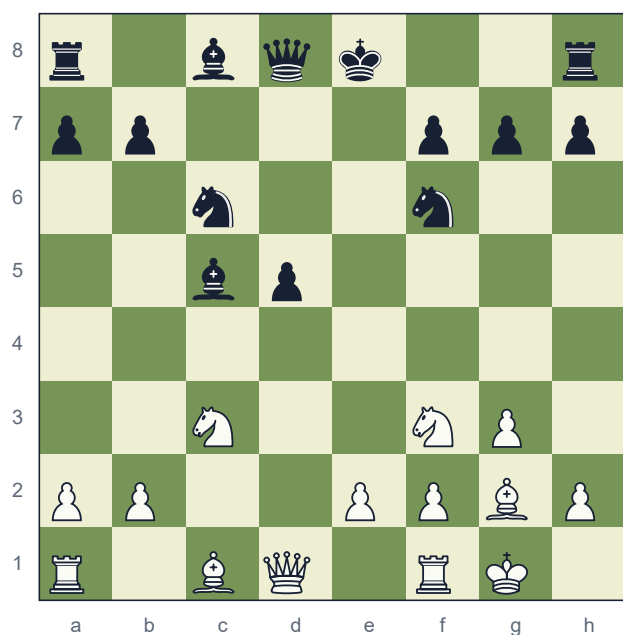
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Tarrasch and Semi-Tarrasch

...e6 and ...c5 against your d4-c4 center

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Use a kingside fianchetto against the Tarrasch and a sound developing setup against the Semi-Tarrasch. Learn to handle the isolated queen pawn from both sides.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

In the Tarrasch, Black often has the isolated d-pawn. In the Semi-Tarrasch, exchanges can leave White with one instead. The identity of the isolated pawn matters.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black seeks rapid development and active central pieces. ...d4 or ...d5 can liquidate a weakness if the timing is right.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. An isolated pawn is a target only when you can blockade it.
2. The side with the isolated pawn usually wants activity and piece play, not indiscriminate simplification.
3. Trade attacking pieces before pawn-grabbing if the opponent has a lead in development.

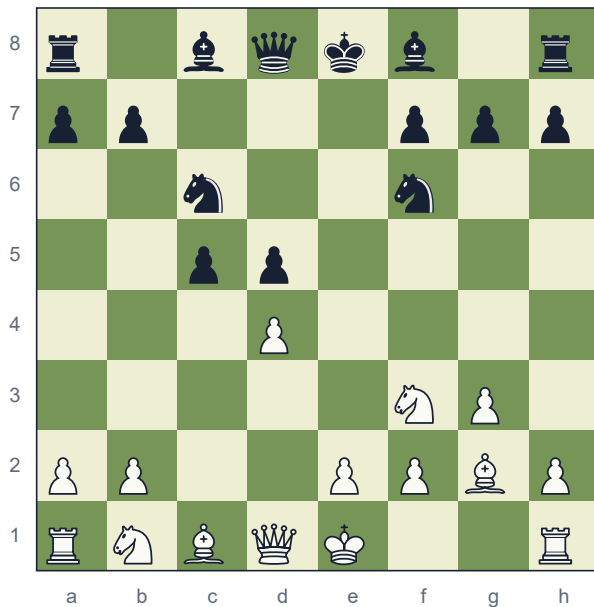
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Tarrasch: the fianchetto setup

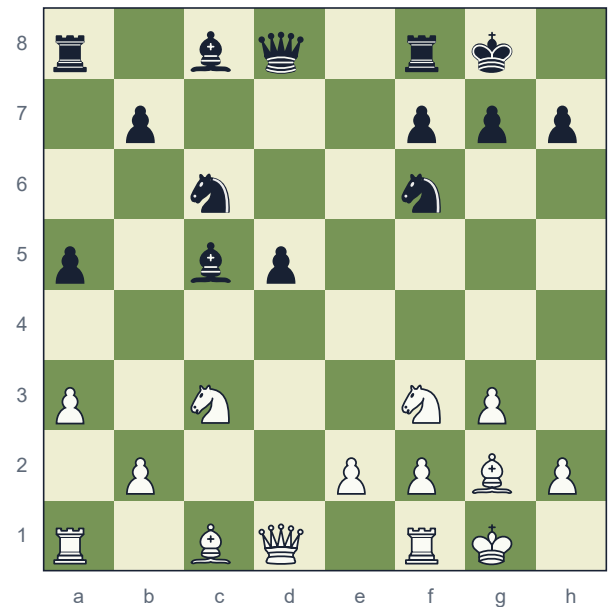
STUDY LINE 07-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. g3 Nc6 6. Bg2 Nf6 7. O-O Be7 8. dxc5 Bxc5 9. Nc3 O-O 10. a3 a5

Selected anchor ends with 9. Nc3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The bishop on g2 attacks central dark squares. Exchanging d4xc5 can leave Black with an isolated d5 pawn.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use a knight to restrain d4 and place rooks on the central files. Do not hurry to win the pawn at the expense of piece coordination.

WATCH FOR

...d4 can gain time on Nc3. Calculate the advance before parking pieces on squares it attacks.

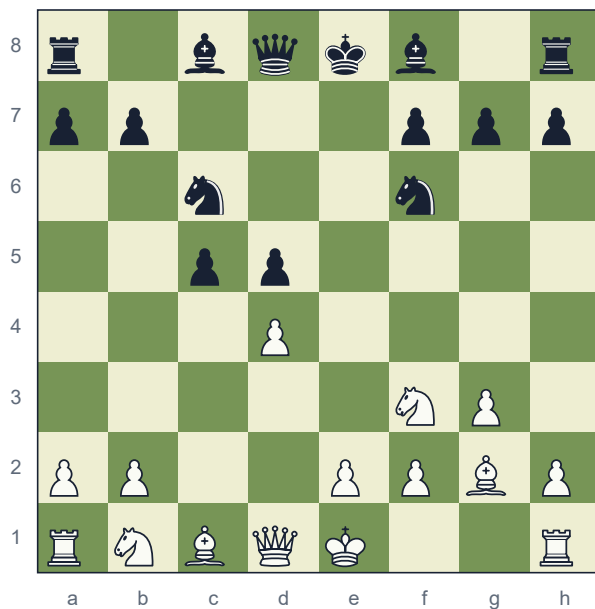
REMEMBER Blockade first; win the pawn later.

02 The ...c4 space-gaining alternative

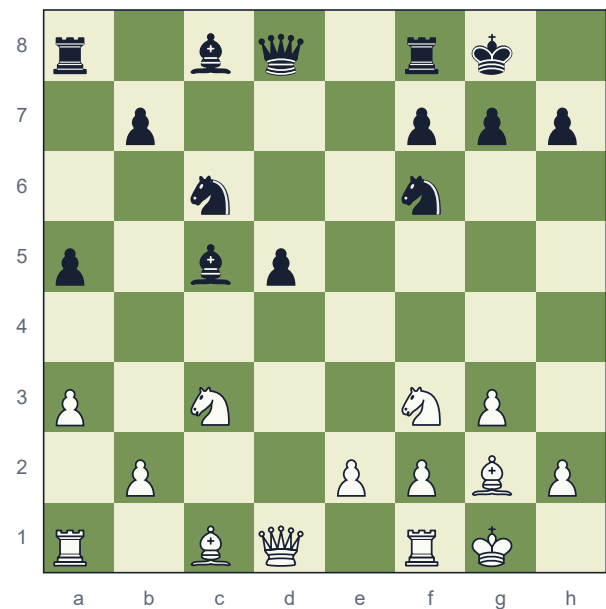
STUDY LINE 07-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. g3 Nc6 6. Bg2 Nf6 7. O-O Be7 8. Nc3 O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. a3 a5

Selected anchor ends with 8... O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White can also maintain the central tension. Black's choice between ...cxd4, ...c4 and waiting changes where your counterplay belongs.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

If ...c4 closes the queenside, a timely b3 can challenge the chain. If the center opens, the g2 bishop becomes stronger.

WATCH FOR

Do not use b3 before checking ...Bb4 and pressure on c3. A strategic break still needs tactical support.

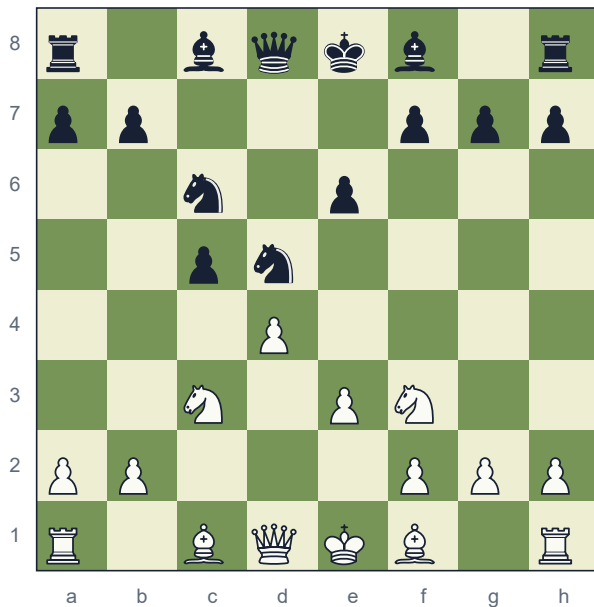
REMEMBER A locked pawn chain needs an attack on its base.

03 Semi-Tarrasch with an isolated white pawn

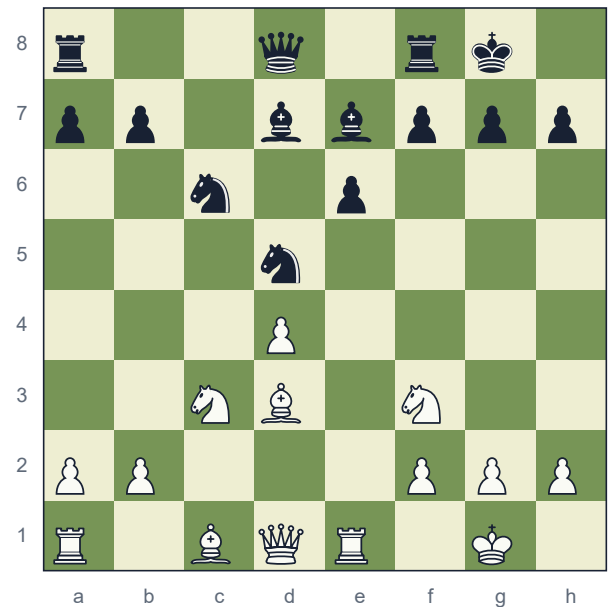
STUDY LINE 07-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e3 Nc6 7. Bd3 cxd4 8. exd4 Be7 9. O-O O-O 10. Re1 Bd7

Selected anchor ends with 10. Re1. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The e-pawn recapture keeps active central space but leaves d4 isolated. Re1 supports active piece play and a possible d5 break.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bf4 or Bg5 when useful, bring the queen toward the center, and look for d5 when Black's pieces are uncoordinated.

WATCH FOR

Trading every minor piece can leave you defending a weak pawn in an endgame. Judge trades by activity, not by quantity.

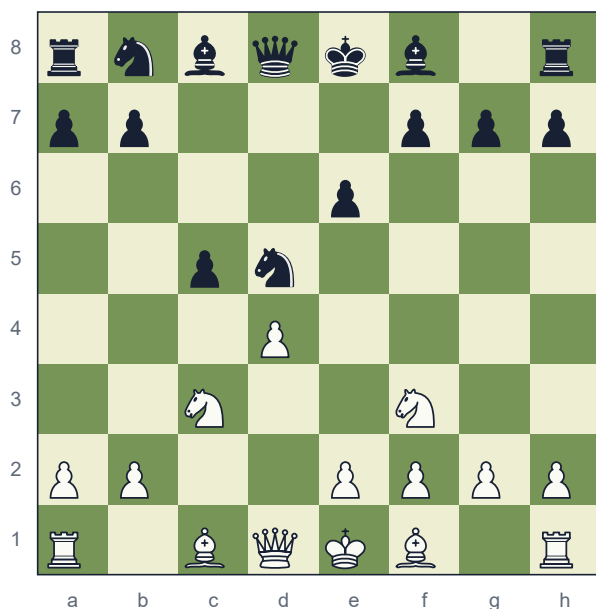
REMEMBER With the isolated pawn, play actively.

04 An early ...Nf6-c5 move order

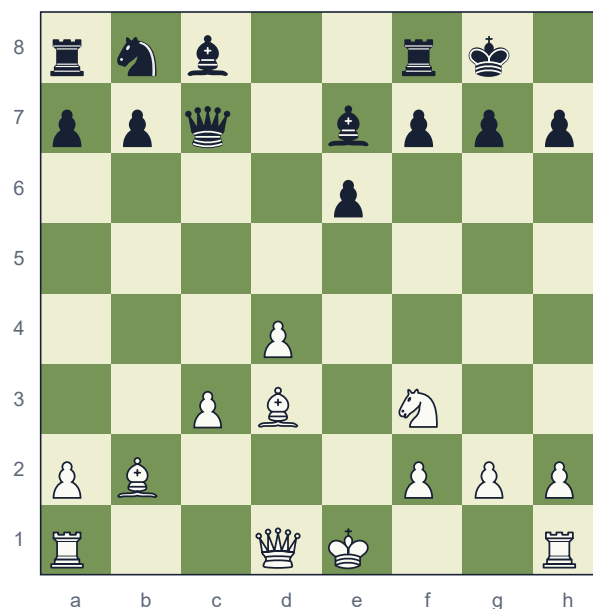
STUDY LINE 07-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e3 cxd4 7. exd4 Nxc3 8. bxc3 Qc7 9. Bb2 Be7 10. Bd3 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 6. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This is the same Semi-Tarrasch through an Indian move order. The choice of 3.Nf3 did not remove ...c5 from Black's options.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

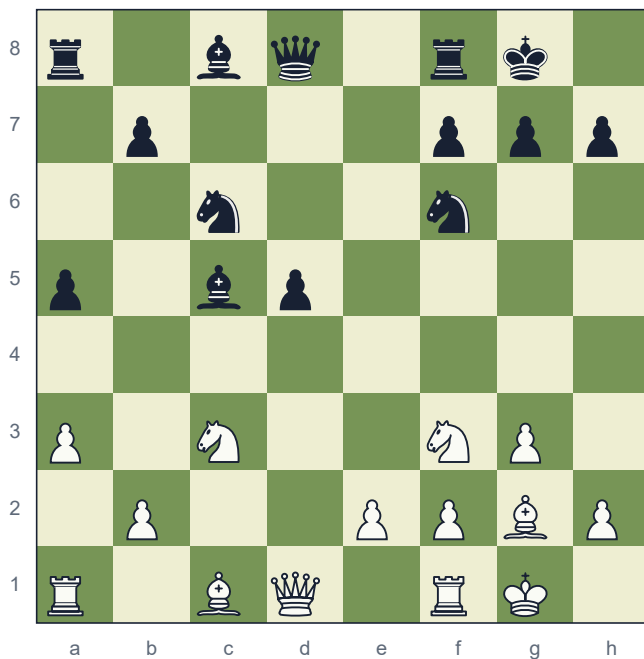
Follow the development scheme when the position matches. If Black changes the recapture, inspect the pawn structure again.

WATCH FOR

A name on a database screen is less important than the actual recapture on d5.

REMEMBER Recognize the route and verify the recapture.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

In the Tarrasch, Black often has the isolated d-pawn. In the Semi-Tarrasch, exchanges can leave White with one instead. The identity of the isolated pawn matters.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black seeks rapid development and active central pieces. ...d4 or ...d5 can liquidate a weakness if the timing is right.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Use a knight to restrain d4 and place rooks on the central files. Do not hurry to win the pawn at the expense of piece coordination.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

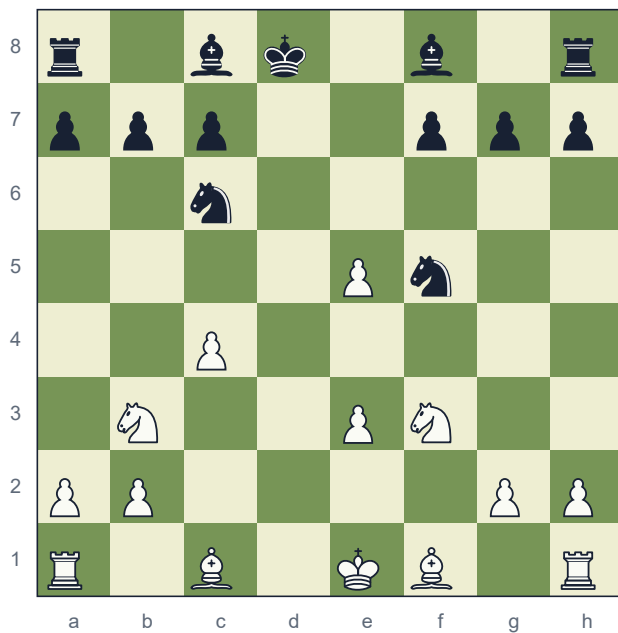
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Albin Countergambit: a complete practical answer

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 d4 4.Nf3 Nc6 5.Nbd2

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Accept the e5 pawn, develop Nf3, and use Nbd2 with the idea Nb3 against d4. You are not obliged to keep every extra pawn: king safety and neutralizing d4 come first.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

White has an extra pawn on e5; Black has a space-gaining wedge on d4. The d-file, the diagonal to e1, and the f3 knight are the tactical features to track.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black wants ...Bg4 or ...Be6, quick development, and sometimes queenside castling. The wedge can advance or capture on e3; it must never disappear from your threat scan.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. 5.Nbd2 is a repertoire choice, not a forced refutation of the Albin.
2. Do not play 4.e3 on autopilot: ...Bb4+ and ...dxe3 create the Lasker trap.
3. The plan Nb3 targets d4, but first account for pins and queen pressure against e5.
4. After Black castles long, queenside pawn play can become an attack rather than a slow positional plan.

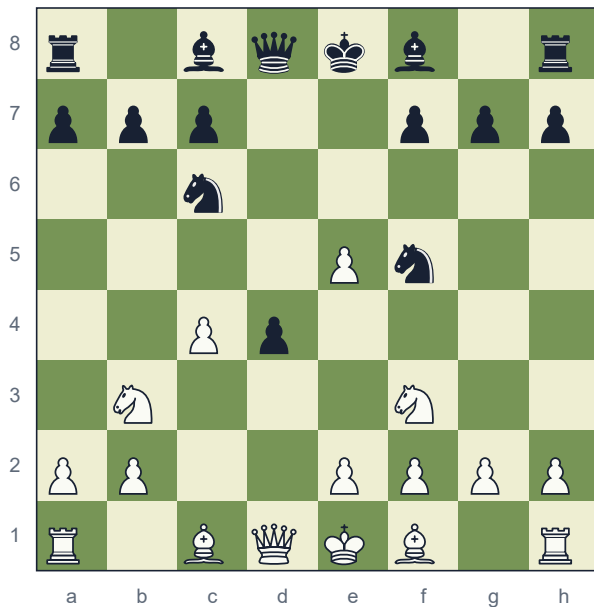
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Main choice: ...Nge7 and the queen trade

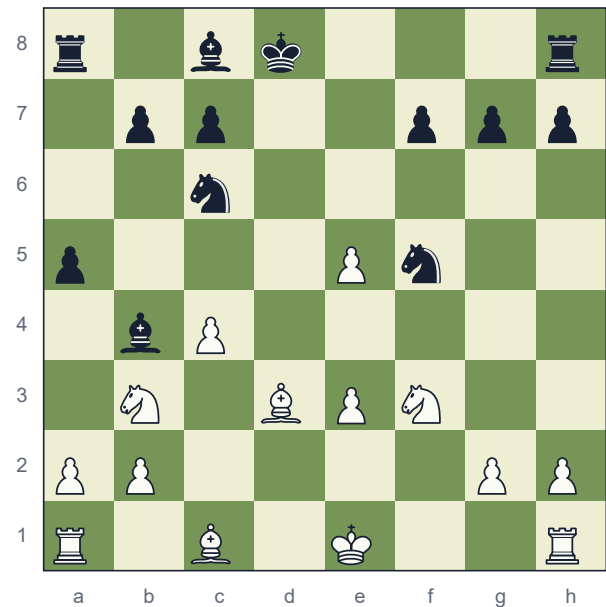
STUDY LINE 08-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Nge7 6. Nb3 Nf5 7. e4 dxe3 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. fxe3 a5 10. Bd3 Bb4+

Selected anchor ends with 9. fxe3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move - in check

WHY THESE MOVES

Nbd2-b3 attacks d4. e4 challenges the knight and allows an en-passant capture; Qxd8+ first is essential to understand the resulting queenless position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

First answer the check shown in the final diagram. Develop the bishops, bring the king to a safe useful square, and use the extra material without rushing. Your e-pawns are doubled, so assess activity as well as pawn count.

WATCH FOR

After e2-e4, ...dxe3 is en passant. Do not draw the pawn on e4 as if it survived that capture.

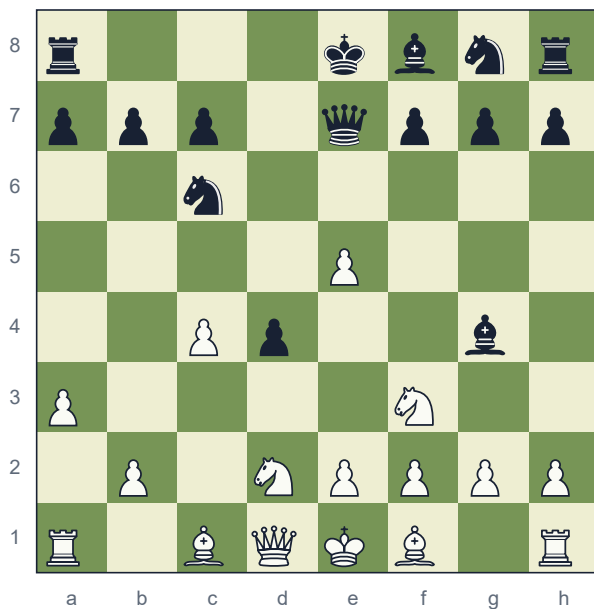
REMEMBER Nb3, e4, and understand the queen trade.

02 The pin: ...Bg4 and ...Qe7

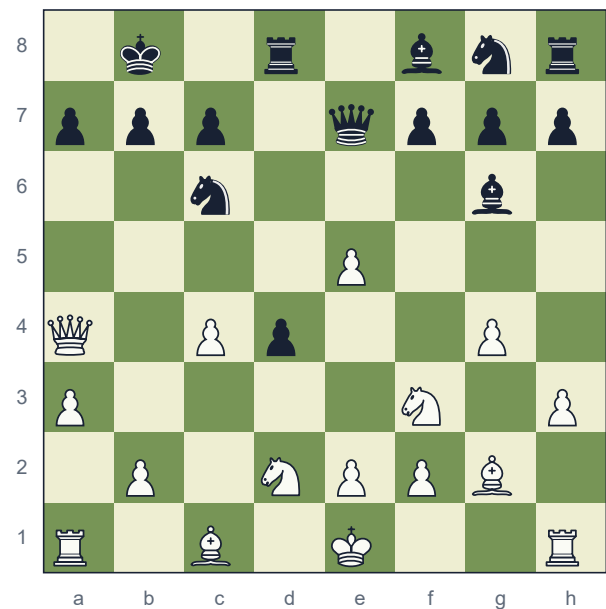
STUDY LINE 08-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Bg4 6. a3 Qe7 7. h3 Bh5 8. Qa4 O-O-O 9. g4 Bg6 10. Bg2 Kb8

Selected anchor ends with 8. Qa4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a3 prevents ...Bb4+; h3 asks the bishop to choose. Qa4 creates queenside pressure while Black spends time placing the queen on e7.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Meet castling long with useful queenside development and possibly b4. If Black regains e5, exchange accurately and complete development.

WATCH FOR

The f3 knight is pinned to the queen while the bishop stays on g4 or h5. Capturing with it can expose a queen capture.

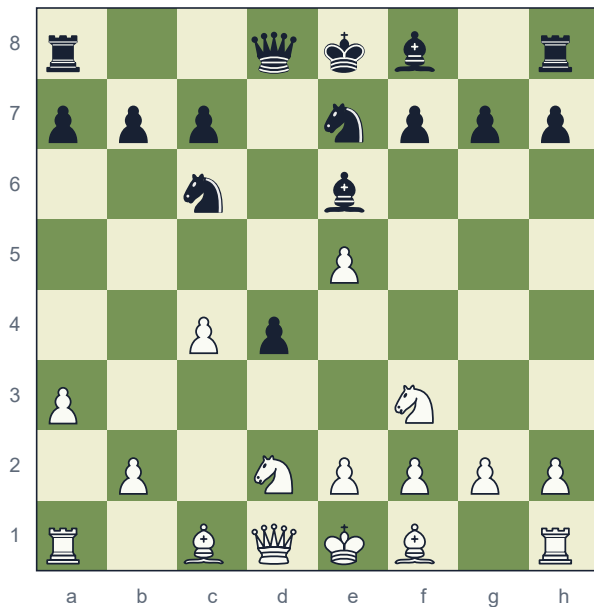
REMEMBER Deal with the pin before collecting another pawn.

03 ...Be6 and the d4 blockade

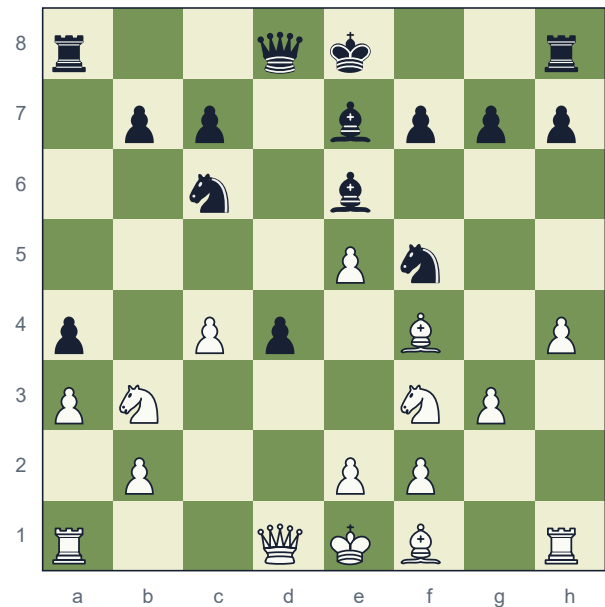
STUDY LINE 08-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Be6 6. a3 Nge7 7. Nb3 Nf5 8. g3 Be7 9. h4 a5 10. Bf4 a4

Selected anchor ends with 8. g3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The bishop on e6 supports active development. The fianchetto provides a safe king scheme while the b3 knight questions d4.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bg2 and castling are sensible aims. Check whether an exchange on d4 opens lines against your king or improves your center.

WATCH FOR

Do not grab d4 if Black can exploit a pin, a check, or the loose e5 pawn with tempo.

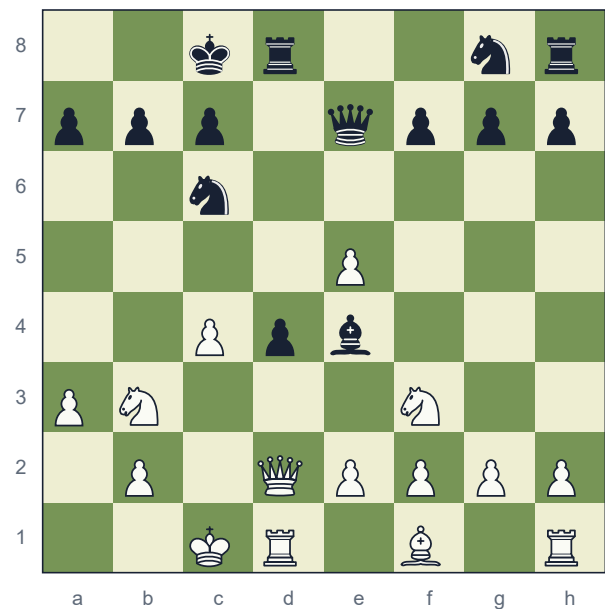
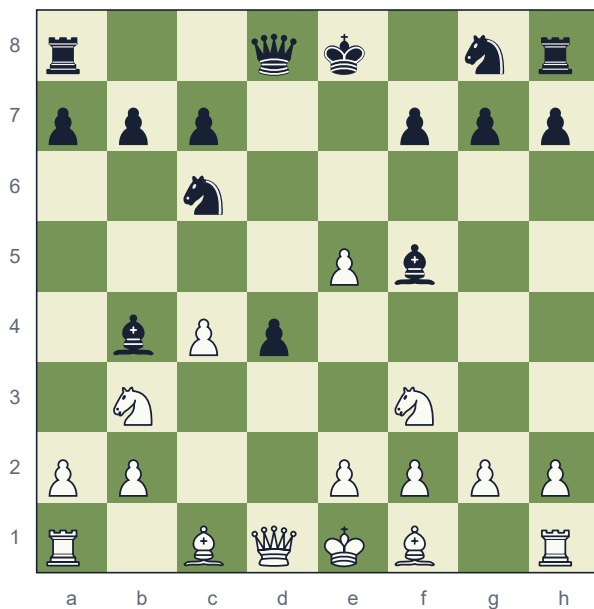
REMEMBER Attack the wedge while building king safety.

04 ...Bf5 allows Nb3 with tempo ideas

STUDY LINE 08-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Bf5 6. Nb3 Bb4+ 7. Bd2 Qe7 8. a3 Bxd2+ 9. Qxd2 Be4 10. O-O-O O-O-O

Selected anchor ends with 9. Qxd2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



WHY THESE MOVES

Nb3 prepares a capture on d4 that would hit Bf5. Meet the check by developing Bd2 and recapture on d2 with the queen.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Finish development; do not assume that castling on either side is automatically safe. The queen on d2 helps you organize the position.

WATCH FOR

A line with the bishop on f5 is not identical to the ...Bg4 pin. Tactical defenses differ.

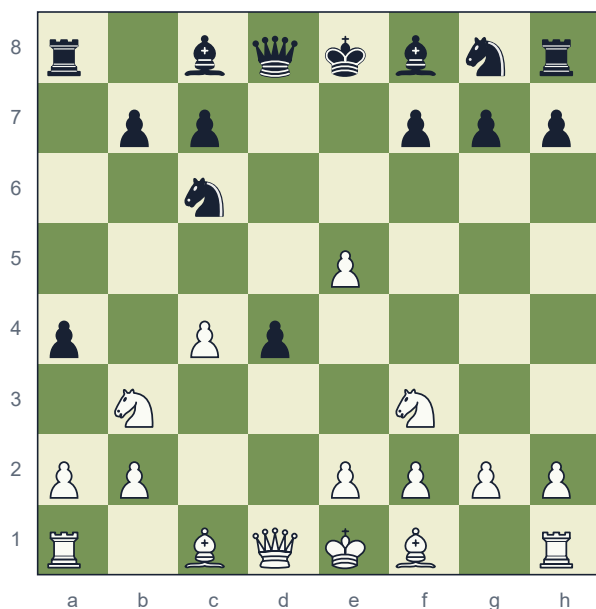
REMEMBER Use the exposed bishop to gain time on d4.

05 An early ...a5 restrains b4

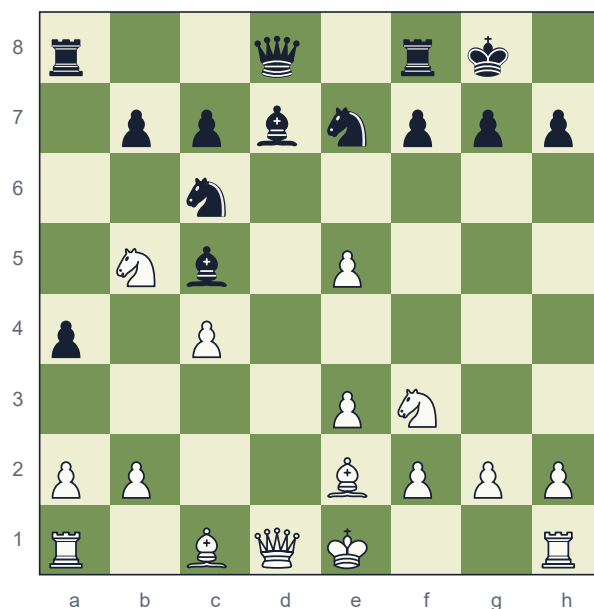
STUDY LINE 08-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 a5 6. Nb3 a4 7. Nbx d4 Bc5 8. e3 Nge7 9. Be2 O-O 10. Nb5 Bd7

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nbx d4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The knight takes the central wedge instead of retreating passively from the a-pawn. The point of Nb3 was to make d4 a target.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the remaining pieces and castle if safe. Black has spent time on the a-pawn and may seek compensation through open lines.

WATCH FOR

Check which knight can capture d4; write Nbx d4 when both knights could reach that square.

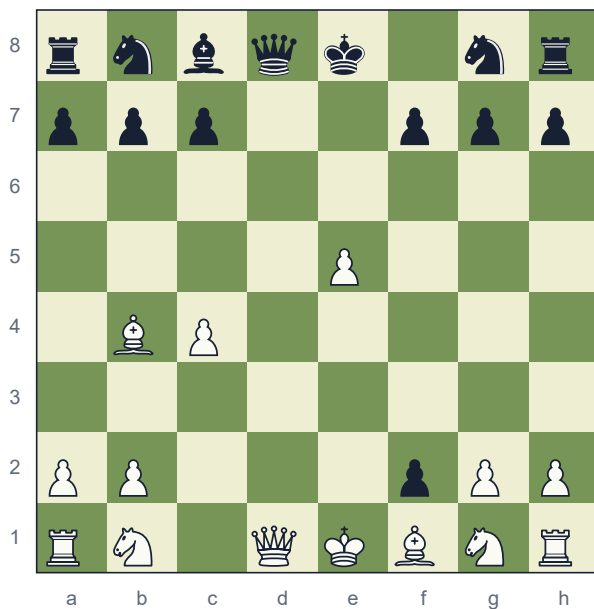
REMEMBER Answer flank threats with a concrete central resource.

06 Warning only: the Lasker underpromotion trap

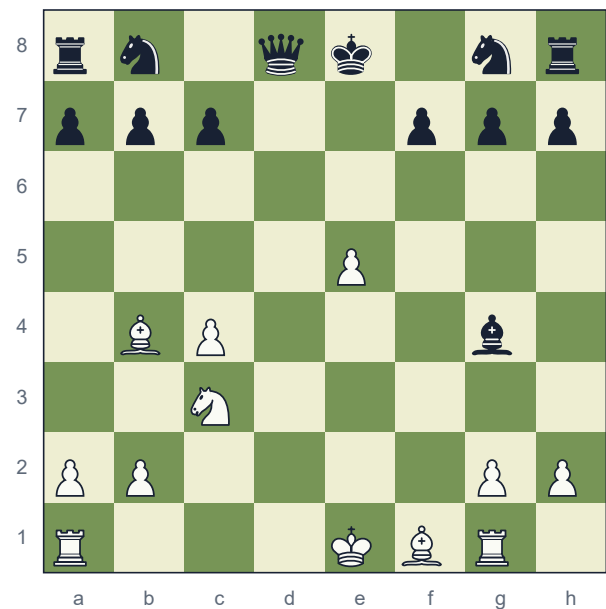
WARNING EXAMPLE - DO NOT PLAY THIS AS WHITE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. e3 Bb4+ 5. Bd2 dxe3 6. Bxb4 exf2+ 7. Ke2 fxg1=N+ 8. Rxb1 Bg4+ 9. Ke1 Bxd1 10. Nc3 Bg4

Selected anchor ends with 9... Bxd1. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This is a demonstration of what not to play. 4.e3 allows ...Bb4+; 6.Bxb4 ignores the passed pawn, and promotion to a knight comes with check.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

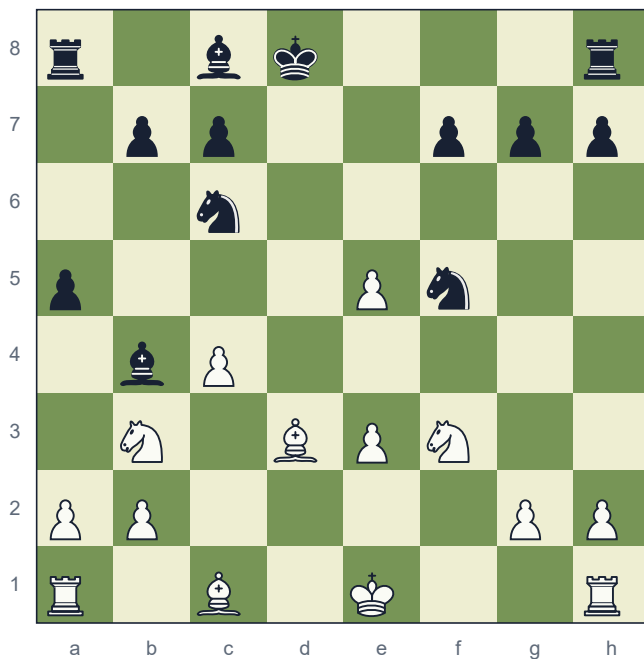
Avoid this entire mess with the recommended 4.Nf3. If you have already played e3, stop before capturing the bishop and examine checks and passed-pawn threats.

WATCH FOR

After ...fxg1=N+, the promoted knight attacks e2. Promotion to a queen would not create that same knight check.

REMEMBER Checks and promotion threats outrank a free-looking bishop.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move - in check

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

White has an extra pawn on e5; Black has a space-gaining wedge on d4. The d-file, the diagonal to e1, and the f3 knight are the tactical features to track.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black wants ...Bg4 or ...Be6, quick development, and sometimes queenside castling. The wedge can advance or capture on e3; it must never disappear from your threat scan.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the bishops, bring the king to a safe useful square, and use the extra material without rushing. Your e-pawns are doubled, so assess activity as well as pawn count.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

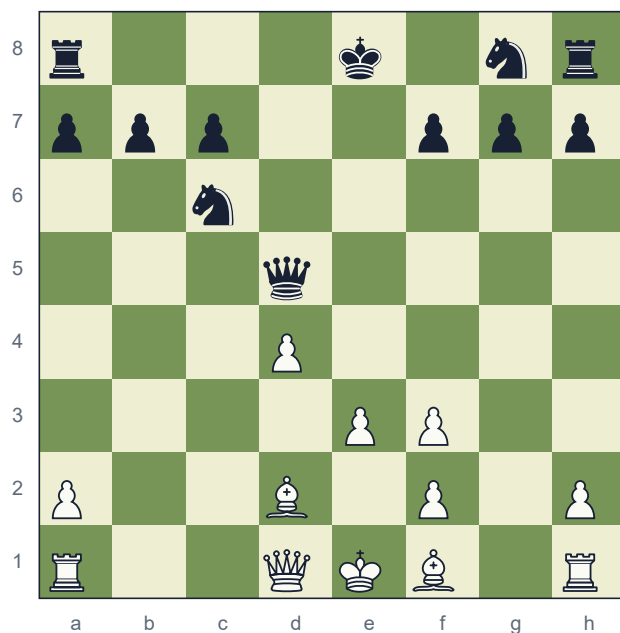
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

The Chigorin Defense

1.d4 d5 2.c4 Nc6 3.Nf3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Use central exchanges to question the early c6 knight. The main choice accepts doubled pawns after ...Bxf3 in return for the bishop pair and central control; this requires concrete attention to king safety.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The knight on c6 blocks Black's c-pawn. Black compensates with ...e5 and piece activity. White may obtain the bishop pair or a strong center, but cannot ignore tactical pins.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black uses ...Bg4, ...e5 and sometimes ...dxc4. A bishop capture on f3 can alter your pawn structure before you castle.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The absence of ...c5 does not mean Black lacks a central break: watch ...e5.
2. A doubled pawn can be acceptable if it supports a strong center and the king stays safe.
3. Do not attempt to win the d5 pawn without checking the e1 king and queen checks.

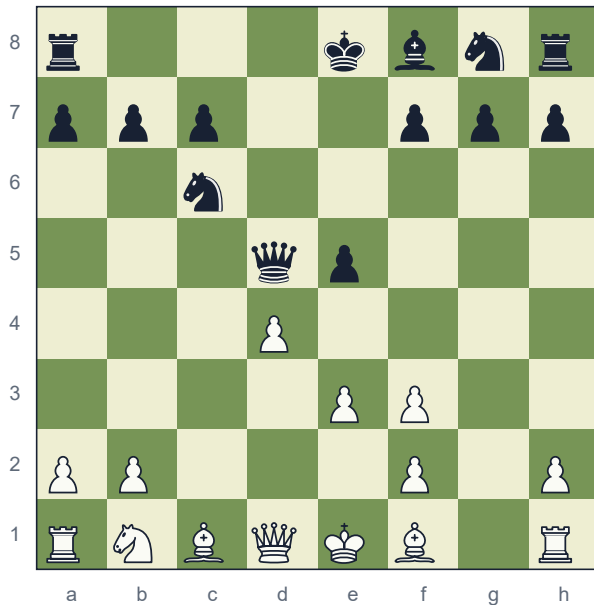
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Main reply: exchange and accept the structural trade

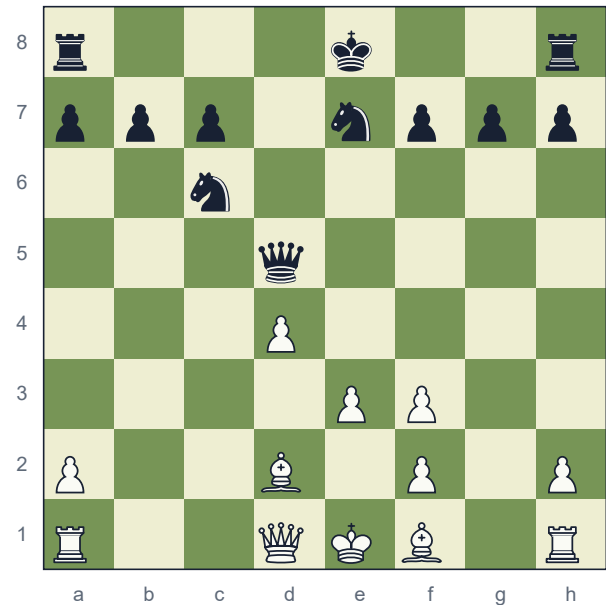
STUDY LINE 09-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. gxf3 Qxd5 6. e3 e5 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd2 Bxc3 9. bxc3 exd4 10. cxd4 Nge7

Selected anchor ends with 10. cxd4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black gives up bishops to damage your pawns. White accepts a broad center and the bishop pair; e3 supports development and the d4 square.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the f1 bishop and secure the king according to the open lines. The central pawns can restrict the knights, but must remain supported.

WATCH FOR

This structure is not a normal QGD. The g-file is open and the f-pawns are doubled; reassess king safety rather than castling by reflex.

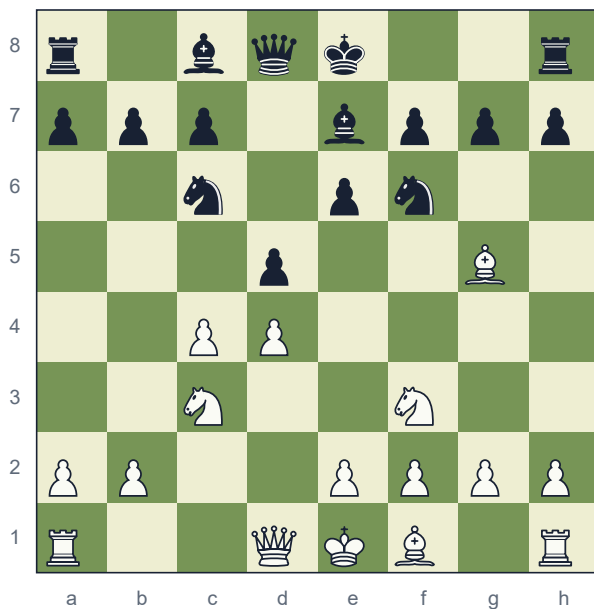
REMEMBER The bishop pair and center can justify doubled pawns.

02 Black develops ...Nf6

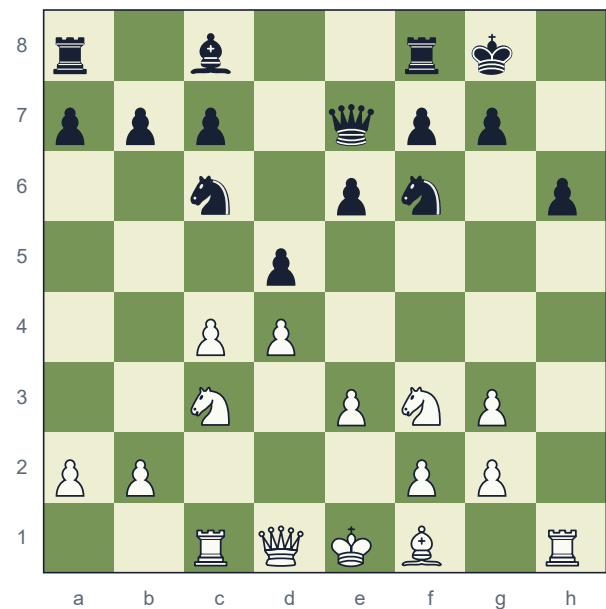
STUDY LINE 09-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Rc1 h6 8. Bf4 Bd6 9. Bg3 Bxg3 10. hxg3 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 6... O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black has chosen a solid setup with the c-pawn blocked. Ordinary development gives you a comfortable central position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bd3 and castling come first. A later cxd5 may lead to a structure where Black needs ...e5 to free the position.

WATCH FOR

Do not exchange automatically if keeping the tension restricts Black more effectively.

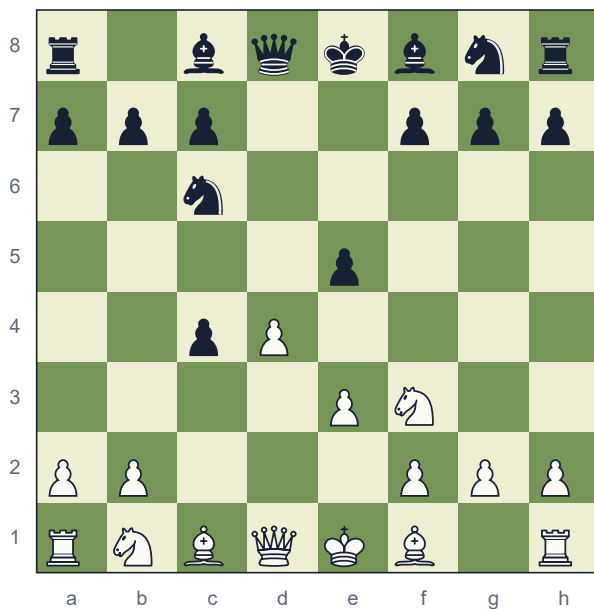
REMEMBER Keep the useful tension until an exchange improves your pieces.

03 Black captures the c-pawn

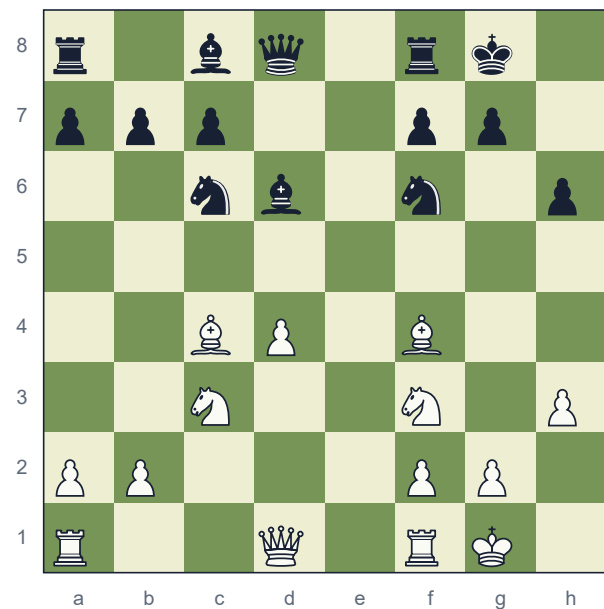
STUDY LINE 09-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 e5 5. Bxc4 Bb4+ 6. Nc3 exd4 7. exd4 Nf6 8. O-O O-O 9. h3 h6 10. Bf4 Bd6

Selected anchor ends with 5. Bxc4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Recover with the bishop while accepting that Black can build an e5 center. You should compare central control, not just the opening label.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Castle and use Nc3 to increase pressure on the center. Calculate d5 only when it gains something concrete.

WATCH FOR

A premature d5 may surrender key squares and help Black's knights.

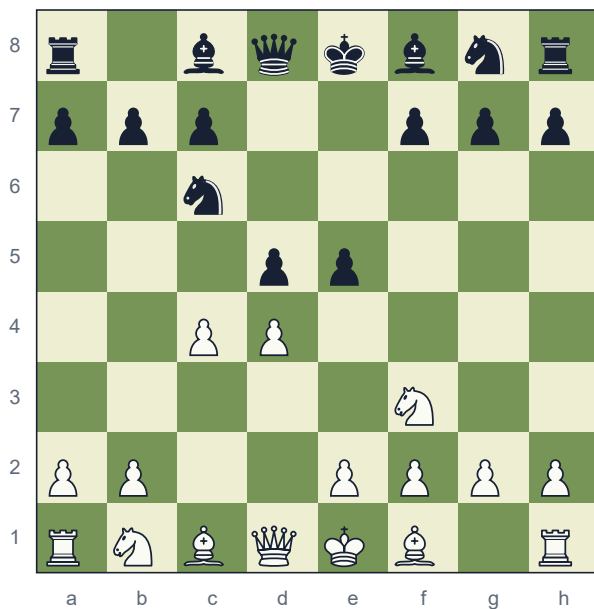
REMEMBER Get the pieces out before driving the center forward.

04 Early ...e5 in the center

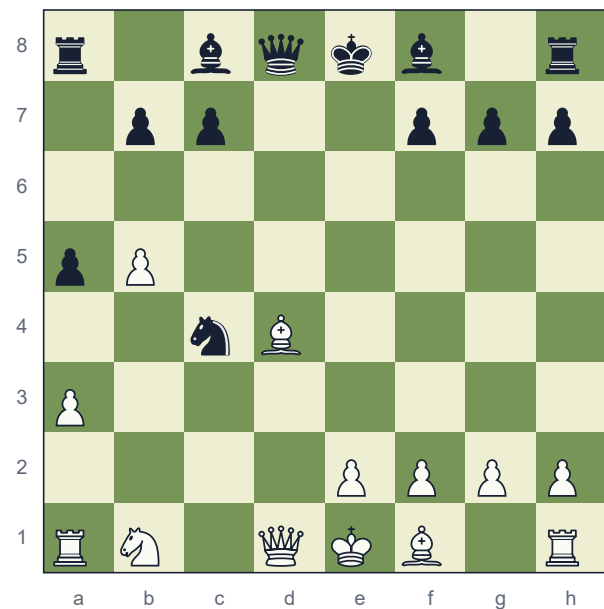
STUDY LINE 09-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 e5 4. dxe5 d4 5. a3 Nge7 6. b4 Ng6 7. Bb2 a5 8. b5 Ncxe5 9. Nxe5 Nxe5 10. Bxd4 Nxc4

Selected anchor ends with 4... d4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 3 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This resembles the Albin but has a different move order. The pawn wedge still deserves attention, and Nbd2 is a useful developing idea.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

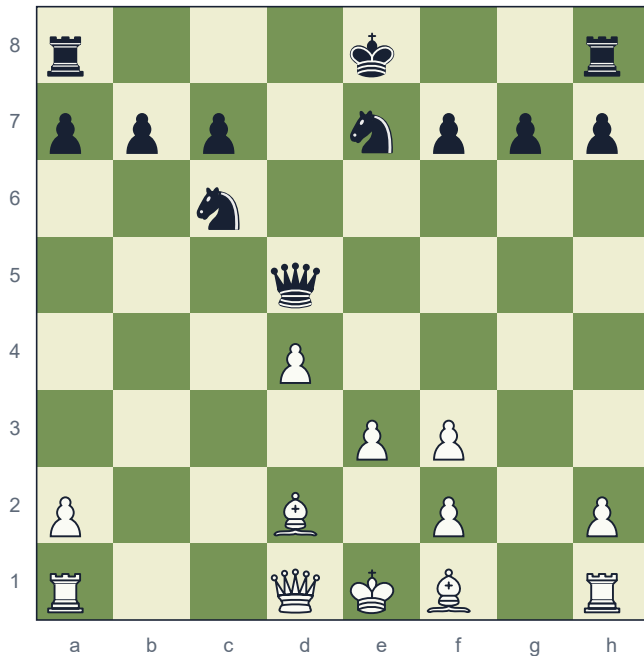
Use the Albin booklet as a structural guide, while checking the exact position and whether every transposition really matches.

WATCH FOR

The same pawn structure can occur with a different side to move. Never add a free tempo when memorizing a transposition.

REMEMBER Recognize the wedge; verify the tempo.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The knight on c6 blocks Black's c-pawn. Black compensates with ...e5 and piece activity. White may obtain the bishop pair or a strong center, but cannot ignore tactical pins.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black uses ...Bg4, ...e5 and sometimes ...dxc4. A bishop capture on f3 can alter your pawn structure before you castle.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the f1 bishop and secure the king according to the open lines. The central pawns can restrict the knights, but must remain supported.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

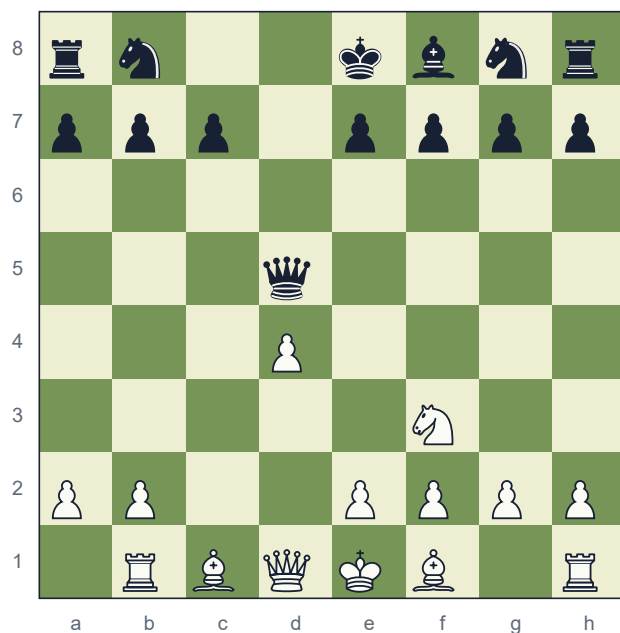
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Other Queen's Gambit counters

1.d4 d5 2.c4: alternatives to ...e6, ...c6 and ...dxc4

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Take the center and develop while responding to the actual threat. Several unusual defenses are playable; your task is a sound advantage or comfortable game, not an instant trap.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Early bishops outside the pawn chain leave b7 or d5 less protected. Early ...c5 can create an open center where development counts more than pawn counting.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

The Baltic plays ...Bf5; the Marshall plays ...Nf6 before securing d5; ...c5 challenges the center immediately; ...e5 is the Albin covered separately.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Look for a tactical reason before repeating the standard QGD setup.
2. A queen exchange can be a practical response to an active-looking gambit.
3. Do not overextend merely because an opening is uncommon.

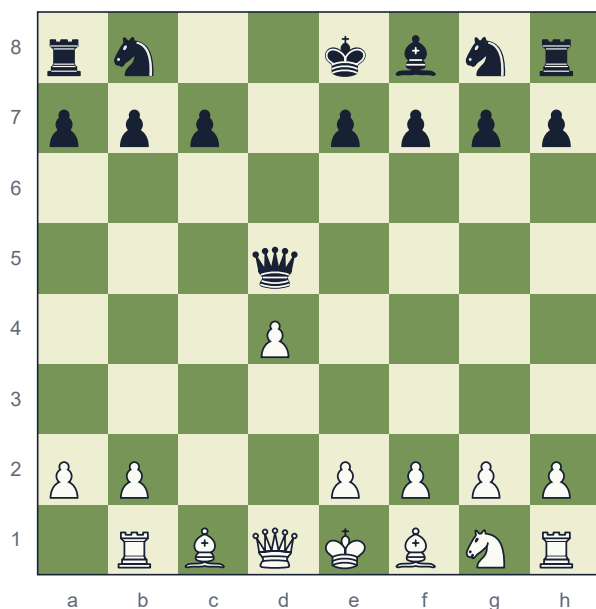
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Baltic: answer ...Bf5 concretely

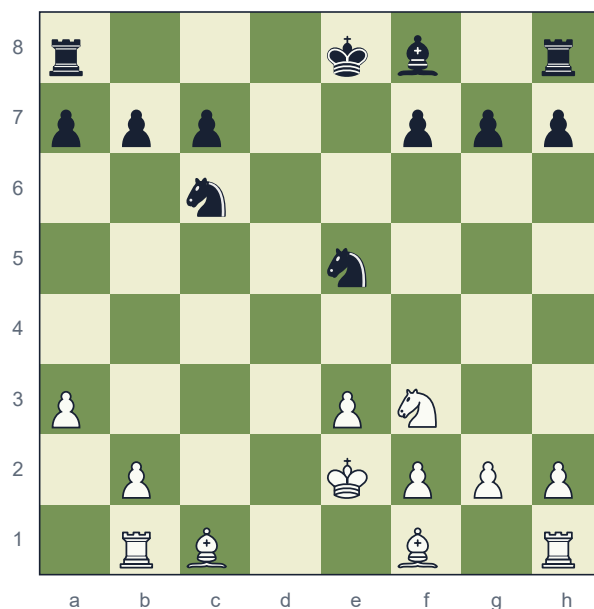
STUDY LINE 10-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Rxb1 Qxd5 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. a3 Nc6 7. e3 e5 8. dxe5 Qxd1+ 9. Kxd1 Ng4 10. Ke2 Ngxe5

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The rook recapture keeps your king and queen safe. Black recovers d5 but has exchanged an active bishop for your knight.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop e3 and Bd3 and bring the king to safety. The b-file rook may later pressure b7.

WATCH FOR

The rook on b1 does not mean you must start a queenside attack immediately. Finish development.

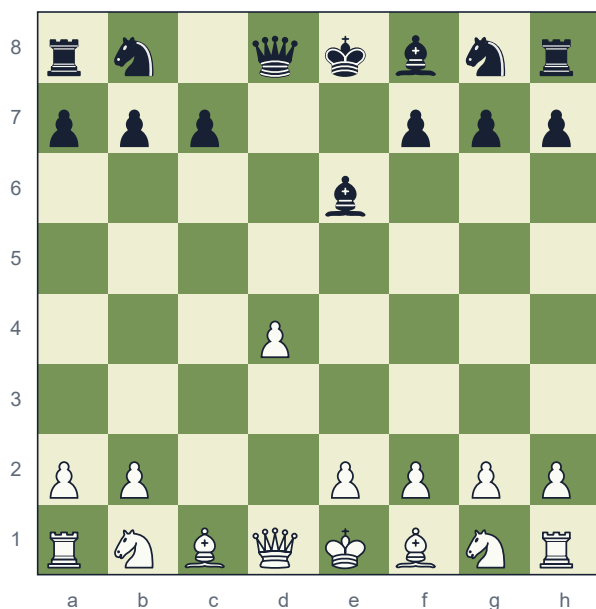
REMEMBER Accept the bishop pair and develop.

02 Baltic: Black recaptures with ...e6

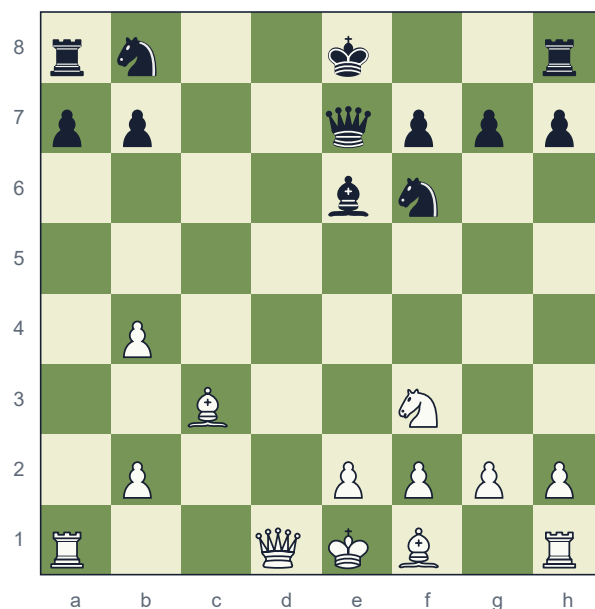
STUDY LINE 10-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 e6 4. dxe6 Bxe6 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd2 c5 8. a3 cxd4 9. axb4 dxc3 10. Bxc3 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White accepts another central pawn while letting Black develop. The extra pawn must be balanced against the time spent capturing.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e3 or g3 as appropriate, develop the b1 knight, and castle. Be willing to return material if that eliminates a serious initiative.

WATCH FOR

Clinging to a pawn while leaving the king in the center can reverse the evaluation quickly.

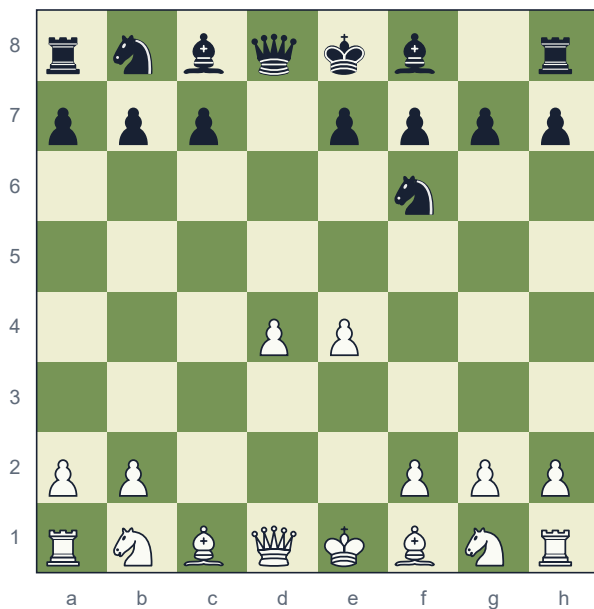
REMEMBER Material is useful only if your position survives.

03 Marshall Defense: ...Nf6

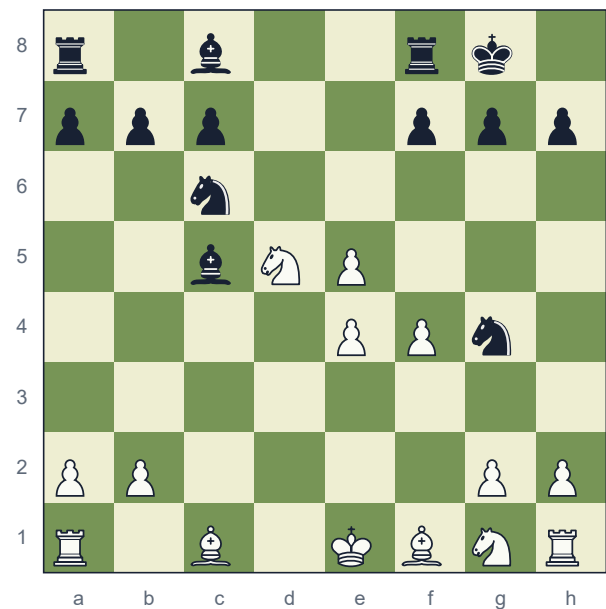
STUDY LINE 10-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. e4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. dxe5 Qxd1+ 7. Kxd1 Ng4 8. Ke1 Bc5 9. f4 Nc6 10. Nd5 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nc3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e4 builds a broad center with tempo against the knight. You gain space without chasing a queen around the board.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Nf3, bring out the bishops, and castle. Be ready for ...e5 or ...c5 to question the center.

WATCH FOR

Do not push e5 unless it improves your position; the existing center is already an asset.

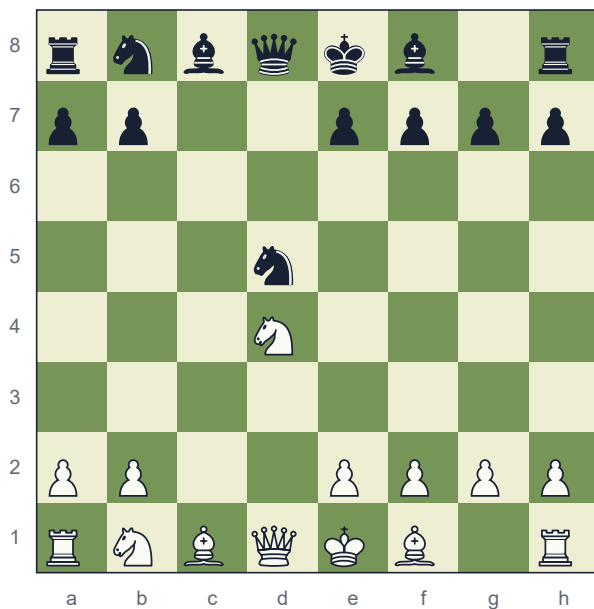
REMEMBER Build the center with tempo, then support it.

04 Symmetrical counter: ...c5

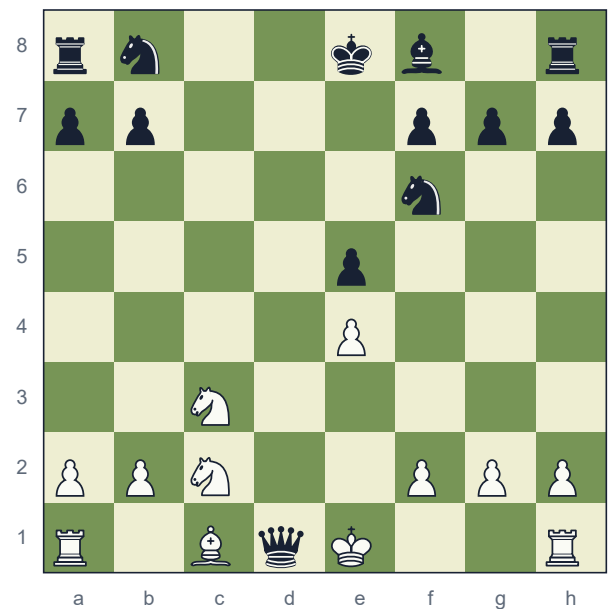
STUDY LINE 10-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c5 3. cxd5 Nf6 4. Nf3 cxd4 5. Nxd4 Nxd5 6. e4 Nf6 7. Bb5+ Bd7 8. Bxd7+ Qxd7 9. Nc3 e5 10. Nc2 Qxd1+

Selected anchor ends with 6. e4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move - in check

WHY THESE MOVES

Central exchanges produce an open position. e4 can gain space while attacking the knight on d5.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

First answer the check shown in the final diagram. Develop quickly and calculate queen checks before chasing knights further. Open files reward a castled king and connected rooks.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume all pawn captures are forced. An intermediate developing move can be stronger.

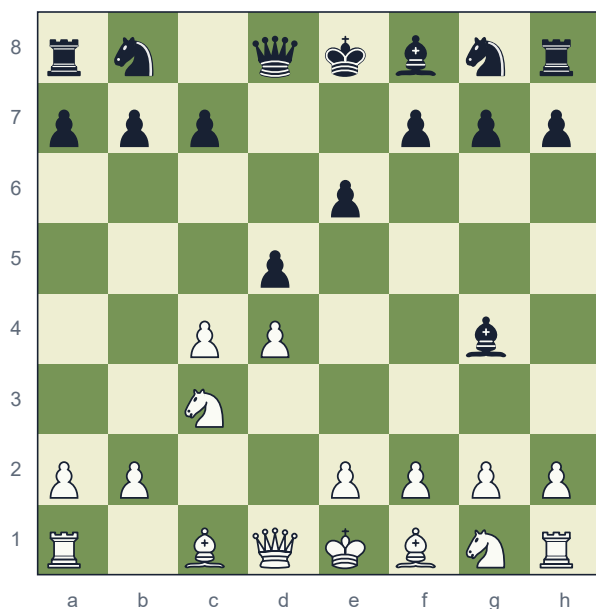
REMEMBER In an open center, count tempi as well as pawns.

05 An early ...Bg4

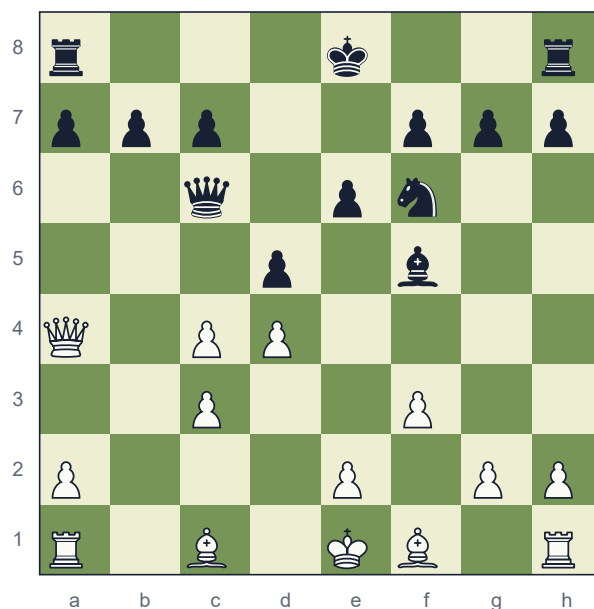
STUDY LINE 10-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bg4 3. Nc3 e6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Ne5 Bf5 6. Qb3 Nc6 7. Qa4 Bb4 8. Nxc6 Bxc3+ 9. bxc3 Qd7 10. f3 Qxc6

Selected anchor ends with 4... Nf6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 3 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Nc3 and Nf3 are useful developing moves. Black's bishop is active, but the center and b7 can become targets.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

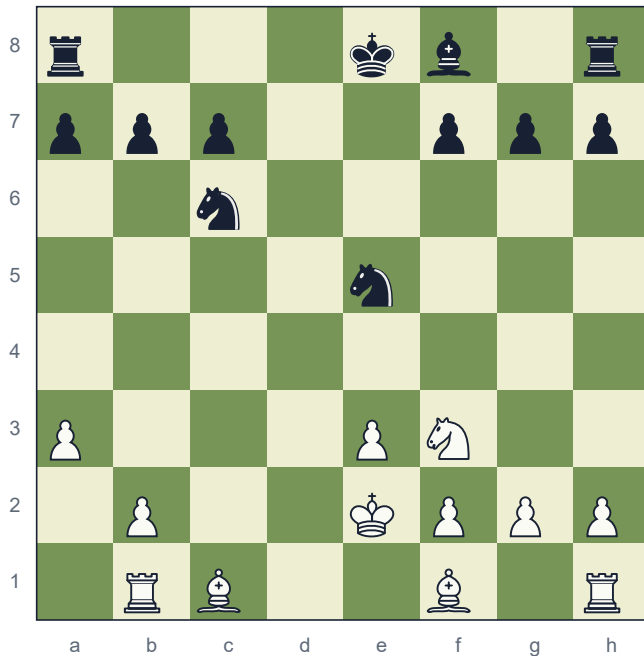
Choose e3 and a safe king setup, or question the bishop if there is a concrete gain. Use the actual central structure to select a plan.

WATCH FOR

Do not play f3 casually: it takes the natural f3 square from the knight and weakens the king.

REMEMBER Develop first; chase the bishop only with a reason.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Early bishops outside the pawn chain leave b7 or d5 less protected. Early ...c5 can create an open center where development counts more than pawn counting.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

The Baltic plays ...Bf5; the Marshall plays ...Nf6 before securing d5; ...c5 challenges the center immediately; ...e5 is the Albin covered separately.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop e3 and Bd3 and bring the king to safety. The b-file rook may later pressure b7.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

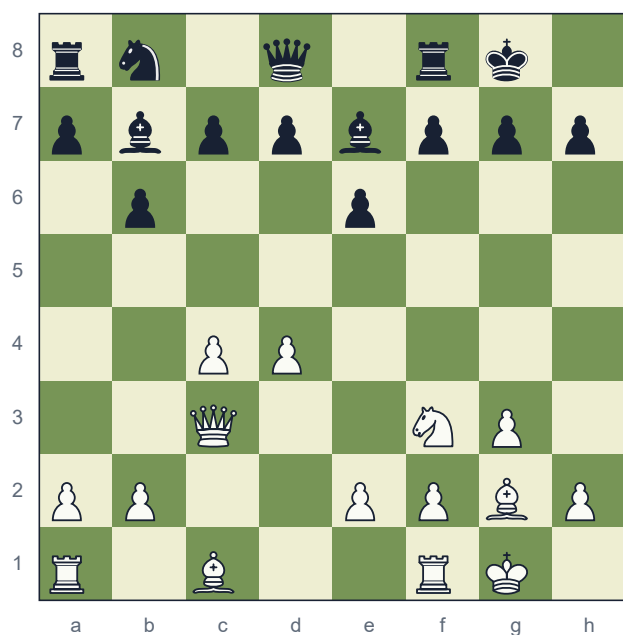
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Queen's Indian: the g3 repertoire

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Fianchetto the king bishop and support the center with pieces. Learn distinct answers to ...Bb7 and ...Ba6 rather than treating them as interchangeable.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Black controls e4 with Nf6 and a queenside bishop. White seeks stable d4-c4 space and a timely e4 or d5 break without weakening the long diagonals.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

...Ba6 attacks c4; ...Bb7 pressures e4. Black may choose ...d5, ...c5 or a hedgehog-like setup with ...d6.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Against ...Ba6, defend c4 before carrying on with a routine fianchetto.
2. Do not push e4 until it is adequately supported against both the knight and the bishop.
3. The move b3 can defend c4 but also invites checks on b4; learn the complete response.

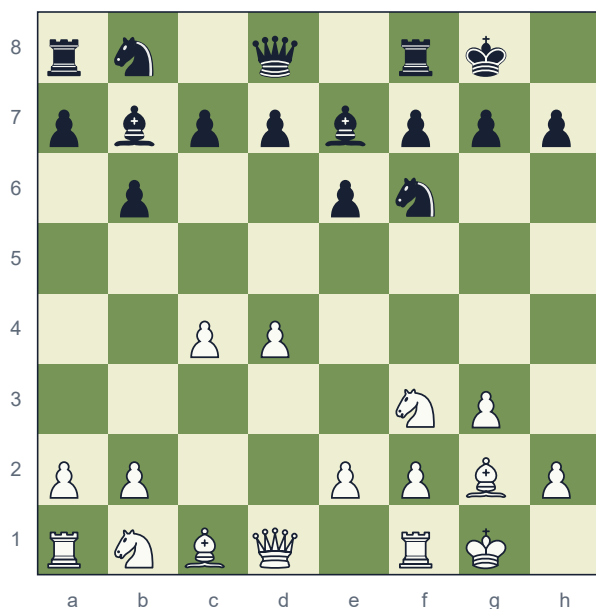
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Classical ...Bb7 setup

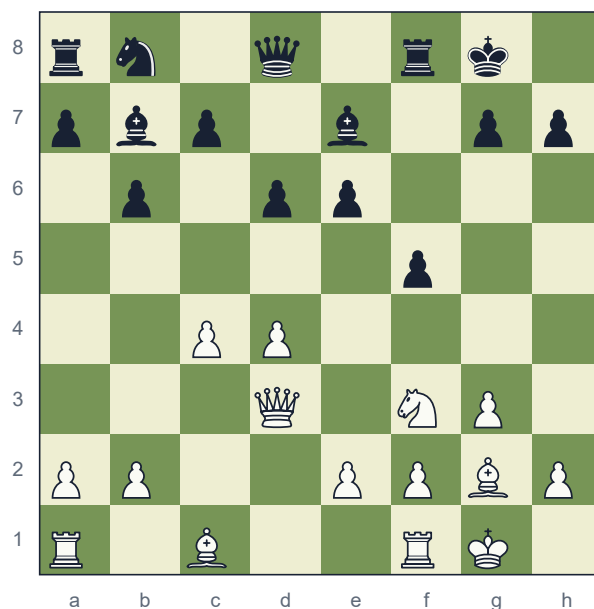
STUDY LINE 11-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 b6 4. g3 Bb7 5. Bg2 Be7 6. O-O O-O 7. Nc3 Ne4 8. Qc2 Nxc3 9. Qxc3 d6 10. Qd3 f5

Selected anchor ends with 9. Qxc3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Qc2 supports central play and the queen recapture preserves your pawns. Black exchanges a useful knight but reduces White's control of e4.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the c1 bishop to f4 or g5 when appropriate. Prepare e4 or d5 only after checking the long diagonal.

WATCH FOR

The b7 bishop can suddenly attack g2 after central exchanges.

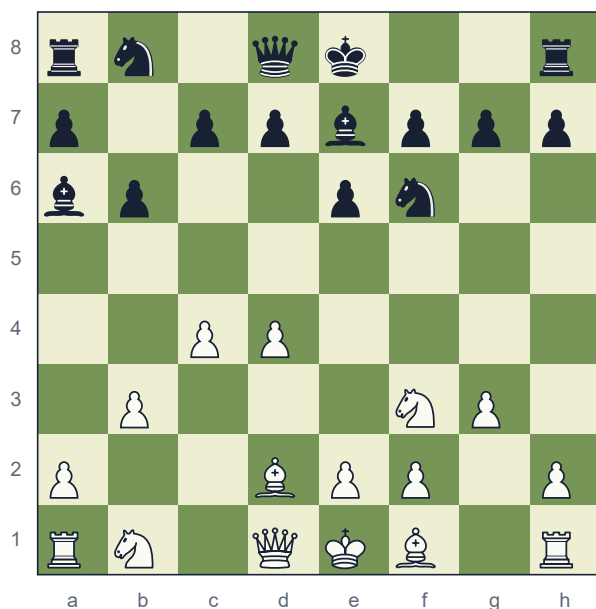
REMEMBER Coordinate the center before opening the long diagonal.

02 ...Ba6 and the standard b3 defense

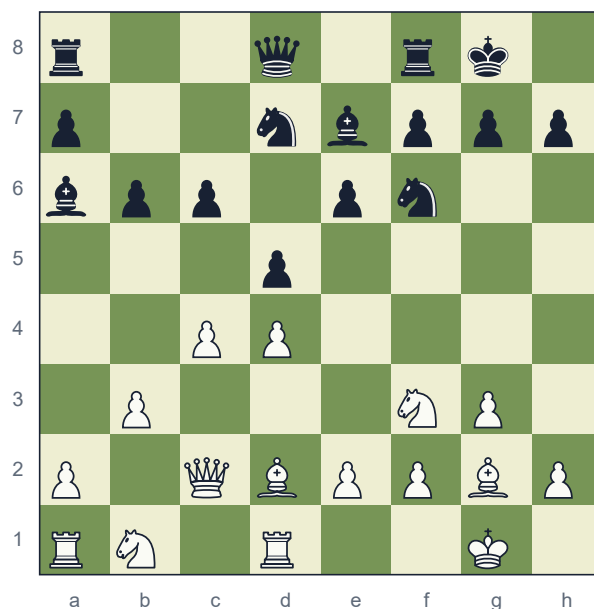
STUDY LINE 11-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 b6 4. g3 Ba6 5. b3 Bb4+ 6. Bd2 Be7 7. Bg2 c6 8. O-O d5 9. Qc2 O-O 10. Rd1 Nbd7

Selected anchor ends with 8... d5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

b3 defends c4. Bd2 interposes against the check and makes ...Bb4+ a manageable part of the move order.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Qc2 and development of the b1 knight complete the setup. Compare cxd5 with maintaining tension when Black plays ...d5.

WATCH FOR

The queen bishop's placement on d2 may affect whether Nc3 is tactically safe.

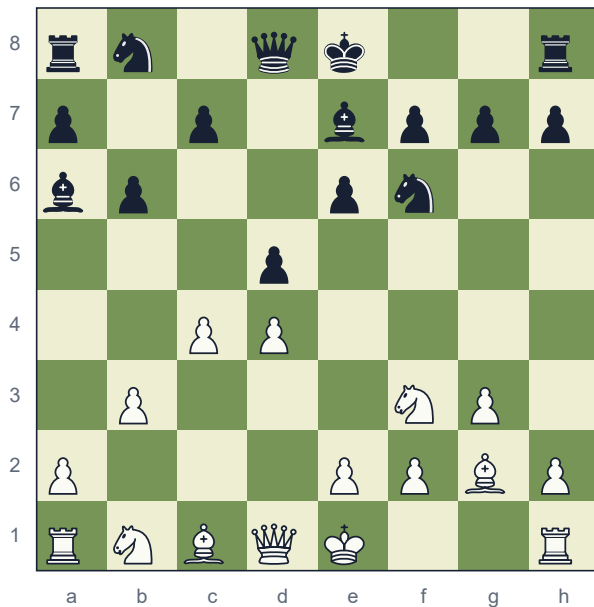
REMEMBER Defend c4, answer the check, then finish the fianchetto.

03 ...Ba6 without the check

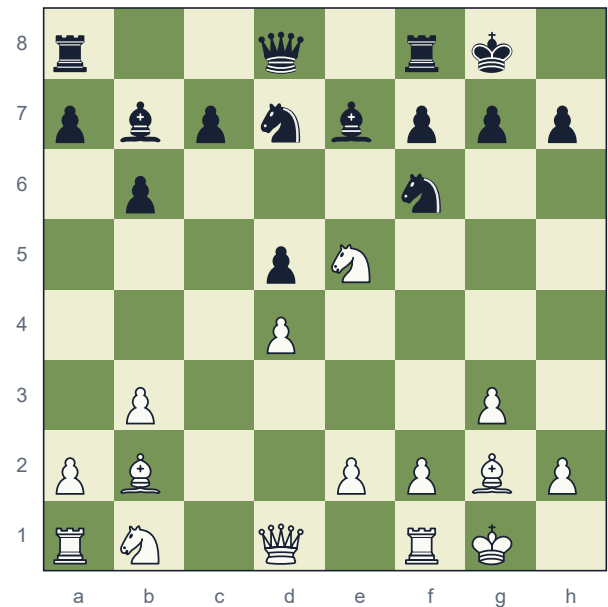
STUDY LINE 11-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 b6 4. g3 Ba6 5. b3 d5 6. Bg2 Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Ne5 Bb7 10. Bb2 Nbd7

Selected anchor ends with 7... O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

With no check, White can complete normal kingside development. The a6 bishop still influences decisions about c4 and the f1-a6 diagonal.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bb2 or a knight as the position allows. Do not release the central tension without identifying the better recapture.

WATCH FOR

A capture on d5 may activate Black's pieces and surrender the space advantage.

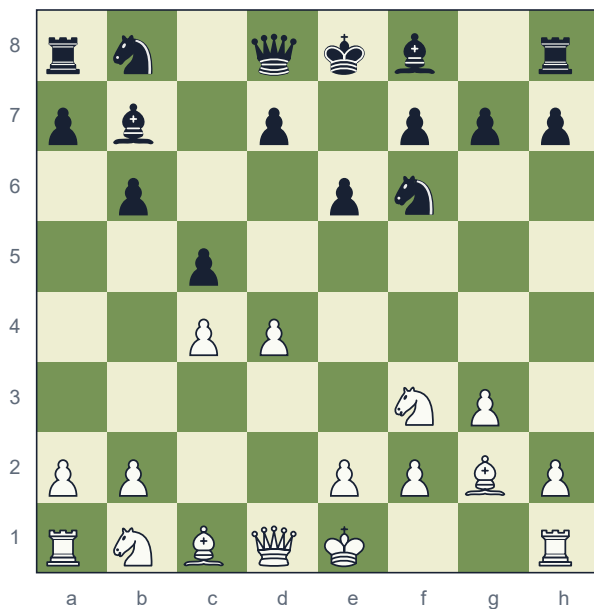
REMEMBER Keep c4 defended while coordinating both wings.

04 The early ...c5 structure

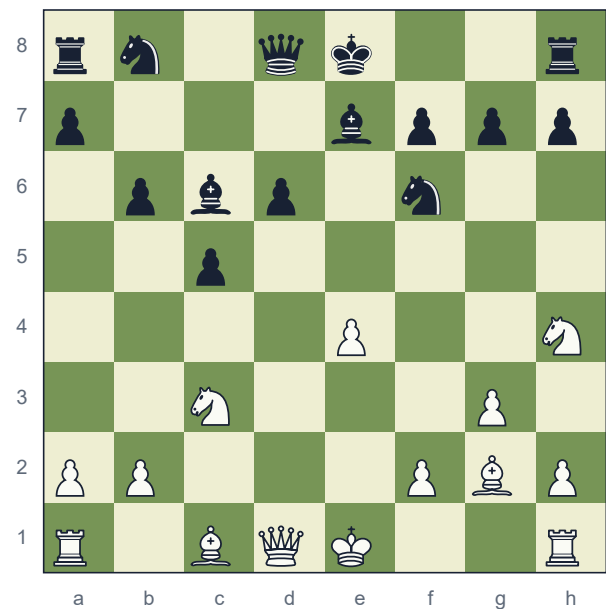
STUDY LINE 11-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 b6 4. g3 Bb7 5. Bg2 c5 6. d5 exd5 7. cxd5 Bxd5 8. Nc3 Bc6 9. e4 d6 10. Nh4 Be7

Selected anchor ends with 6. d5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

d5 gains space while Black's bishop has committed to b7. Exchanges can produce a Benoni-like structure.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

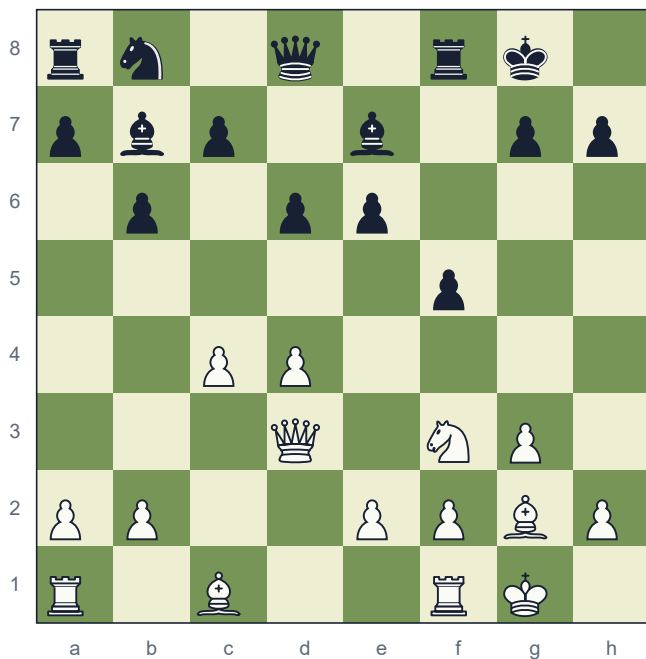
If ...exd5, recapture with the c-pawn and compare the resulting center with the Benoni booklet. Develop before attacking the queenside.

WATCH FOR

Do not recapture with a piece by reflex; the choice determines whether you keep a space-gaining pawn on d5.

REMEMBER The center decides which opening family you now have.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Black controls e4 with Nf6 and a queenside bishop. White seeks stable d4-c4 space and a timely e4 or d5 break without weakening the long diagonals.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

...Ba6 attacks c4; ...Bb7 pressures e4. Black may choose ...d5, ...c5 or a hedgehog-like setup with ...d6.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the c1 bishop to f4 or g5 when appropriate. Prepare e4 or d5 only after checking the long diagonal.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

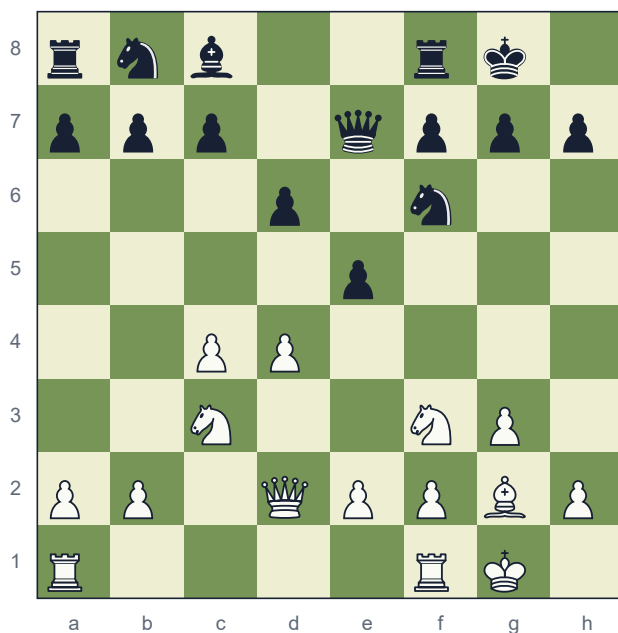
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Bogo-Indian: meet the check with Bd2

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Bb4+ 4.Bd2

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Use Bd2 to answer the check without committing the b1 knight. A kingside fianchetto often gives easy development and useful control of the center.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Black may exchange the bishop, retreat it, or preserve it with ...a5. The unresolved c- and d-pawn tension matters more than the check itself.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

...Bxd2+ removes White's bishop; ...Qe7 prepares development without choosing the center; ...a5 keeps the bishop on b4 longer.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The Bogo is available because you played Nf3 rather than Nc3.
2. A check is not necessarily a threat that requires a passive defense.
3. Recapture choices on d2 change your coordination and central plans.

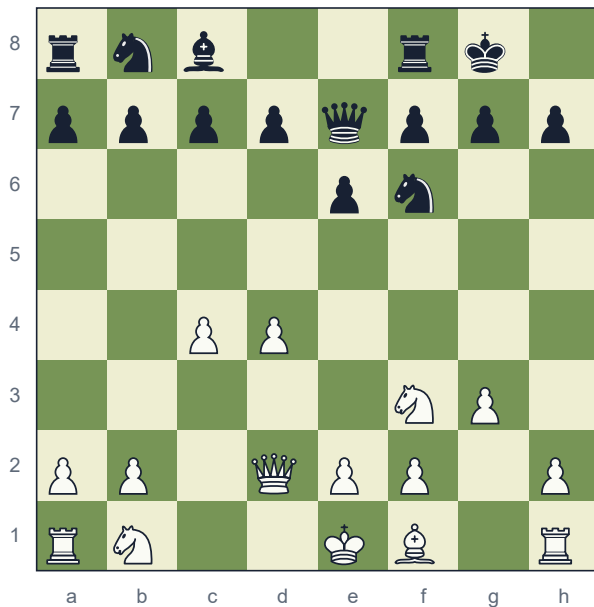
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Main ...Qe7 setup

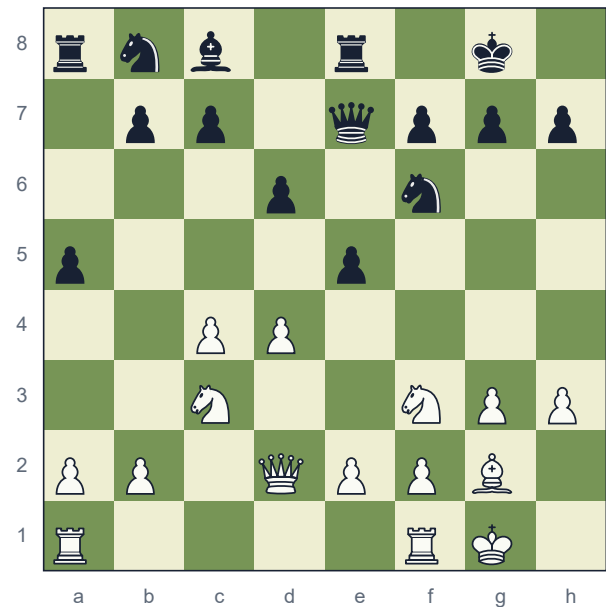
STUDY LINE 12-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Bb4+ 4. Bd2 Qe7 5. g3 Bxd2+ 6. Qxd2 O-O 7. Bg2 d6 8. Nc3 e5 9. O-O Re8 10. h3 a5

Selected anchor ends with 9. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The queen recapture preserves the b1 knight's choice of square. g3 and Bg2 provide a compact developing scheme.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

If ...e5 closes the center after d5, improve pieces around the space advantage. If the tension remains, prepare a central exchange on favorable terms.

WATCH FOR

An early d5 may help Black maneuver knights if your pieces are not ready to use the extra space.

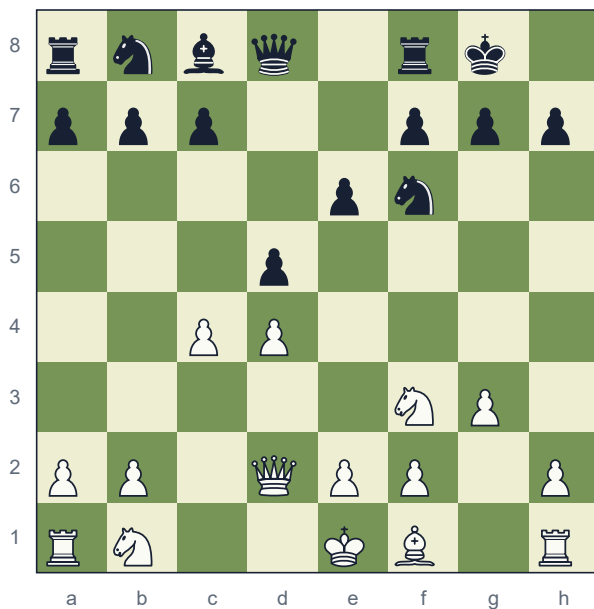
REMEMBER Answer the check and keep your development flexible.

02 Black exchanges immediately

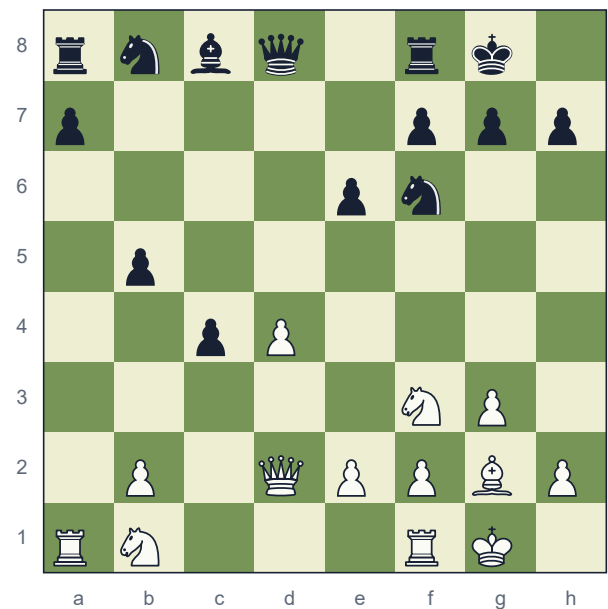
STUDY LINE 12-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Bb4+ 4. Bd2 Bxd2+ 5. Qxd2 d5 6. g3 O-O 7. Bg2 c6 8. O-O dxc4 9. a4 b5 10. axb5 cxb5

Selected anchor ends with 7. Bg2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The check has led to an early bishop exchange. You can still use the fianchetto while keeping d4 and c4 in the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Castle and develop Nc3. Pressure on the long diagonal can become relevant after central pawn exchanges.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume that the missing light-squared bishops make the entire position harmless; ...dxc4 and ...c5 remain important.

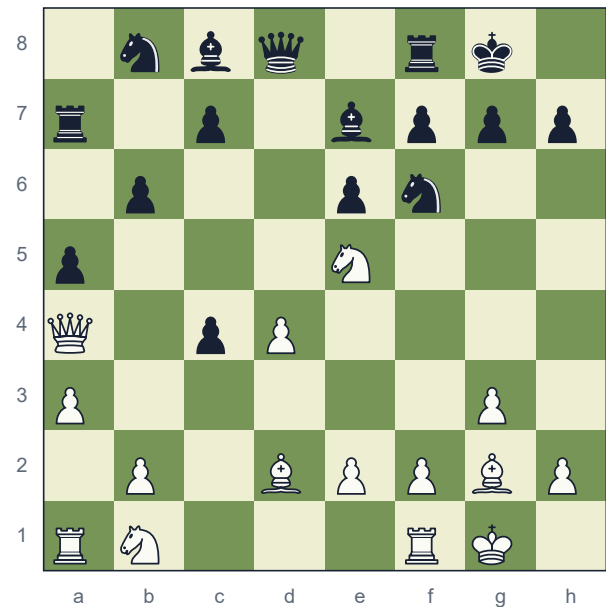
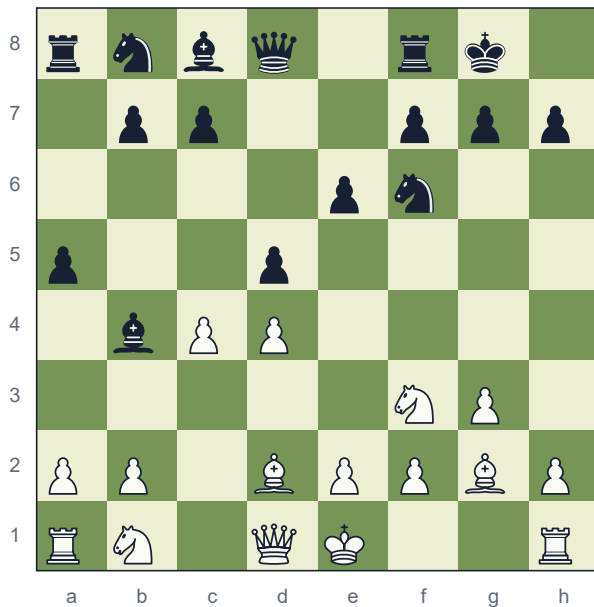
REMEMBER The center still needs attention after a simple exchange.

03 The ...a5 bishop retreat square

STUDY LINE 12-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Bb4+ 4. Bd2 a5 5. g3 d5 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O dxc4 8. a3 Be7 9. Qa4 b6 10. Ne5 Ra7

Selected anchor ends with 7. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



WHY THESE MOVES

Black spends a tempo preserving the b4 bishop. White uses that time to finish kingside development.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Challenge the bishop with Nc3 or a3 only when the exchange or retreat benefits you. Inspect c4 and d4 before each pawn move.

WATCH FOR

a3 may merely induce a favorable exchange for Black if you are unprepared for the recapture.

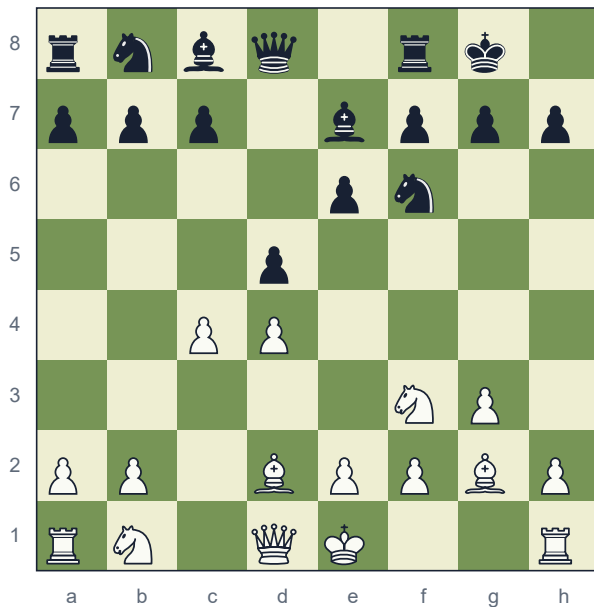
REMEMBER Develop while Black invests in bishop placement.

04 The bishop retreats to e7

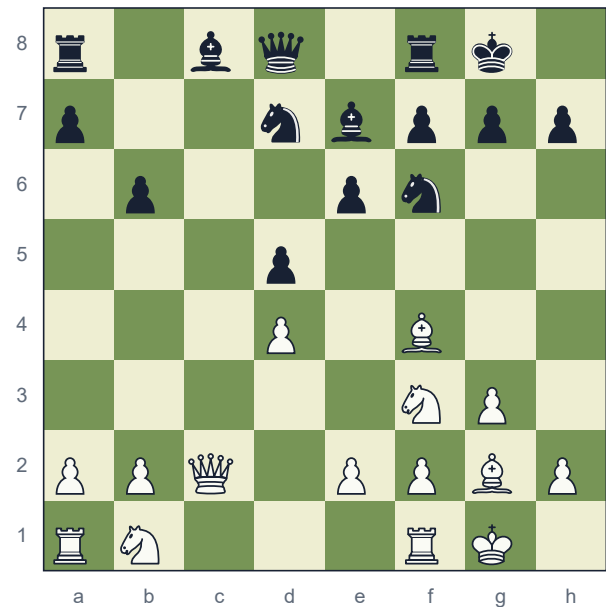
STUDY LINE 12-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Bb4+ 4. Bd2 Be7 5. g3 d5 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O Nbd7 8. Qc2 c6 9. Bf4 b6 10. cxd5 cxd5

Selected anchor ends with 7. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black has spent a tempo on the bishop excursion. A calm developing plan is enough to use the extra freedom.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

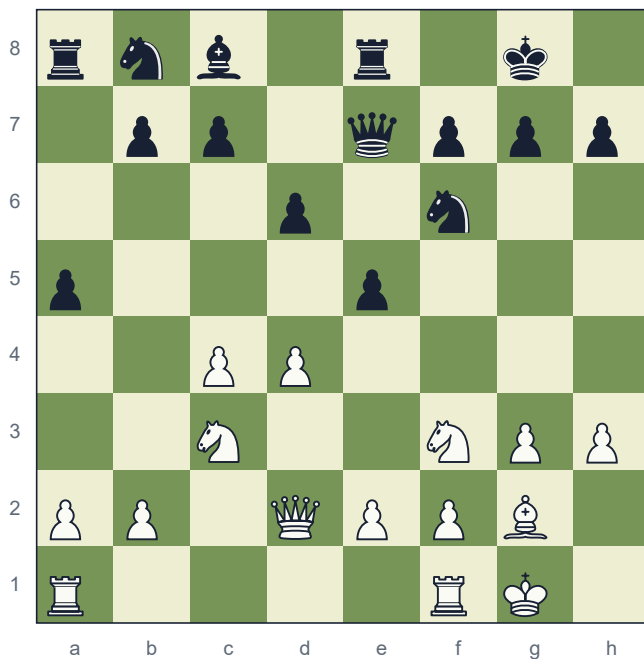
Prepare Nc3 and central pressure. Transpose to related fianchetto structures only when the bishop and queen placements match.

WATCH FOR

Do not invent a forced attack solely because Black lost a tempo.

REMEMBER Use time to improve coordination.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Black may exchange the bishop, retreat it, or preserve it with ...a5. The unresolved c- and d-pawn tension matters more than the check itself.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

...Bxd2+ removes White's bishop; ...Qe7 prepares development without choosing the center; ...a5 keeps the bishop on b4 longer.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

If ...e5 closes the center after d5, improve pieces around the space advantage. If the tension remains, prepare a central exchange on favorable terms.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

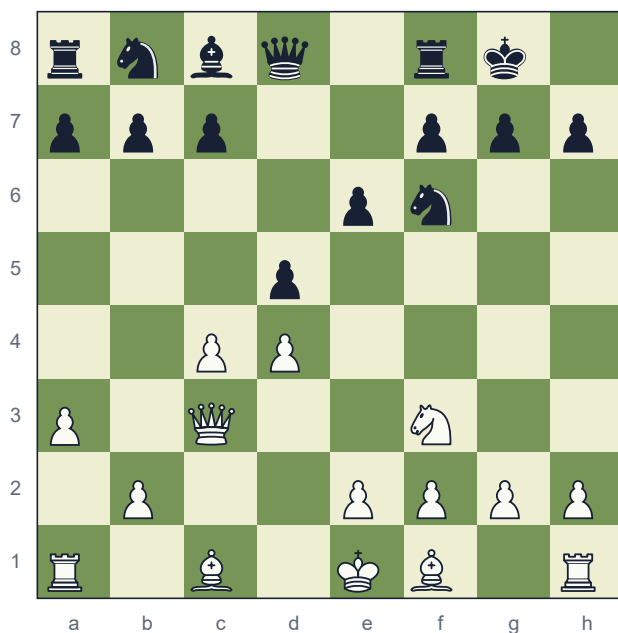
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Optional expansion: the Nimzo-Indian

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

This booklet is optional. The main course uses 3.Nf3 to avoid the Nimzo. If you later choose 3.Nc3, 4.Qc2 aims to preserve the bishop pair without doubling the c-pawns.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The pin on Nc3 restrains e4. Qc2 supports the knight and lets the queen recapture after ...Bxc3, but the queen move costs a developing tempo.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black attacks the center with ...d5 or ...c5, castles quickly, and may try ...b6. White must avoid collecting positional assets while neglecting the king.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Do not add this whole booklet to your first study cycle unless you want to play 3.Nc3.
2. Qc2 and a3 are not free moves: account for the time they take.
3. The bishop pair is valuable in an open position, not a guarantee of an opening advantage.

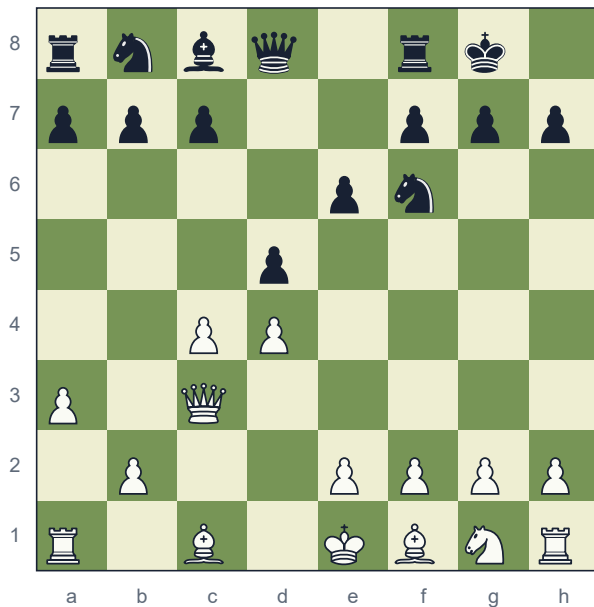
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Classical Qc2 against castling

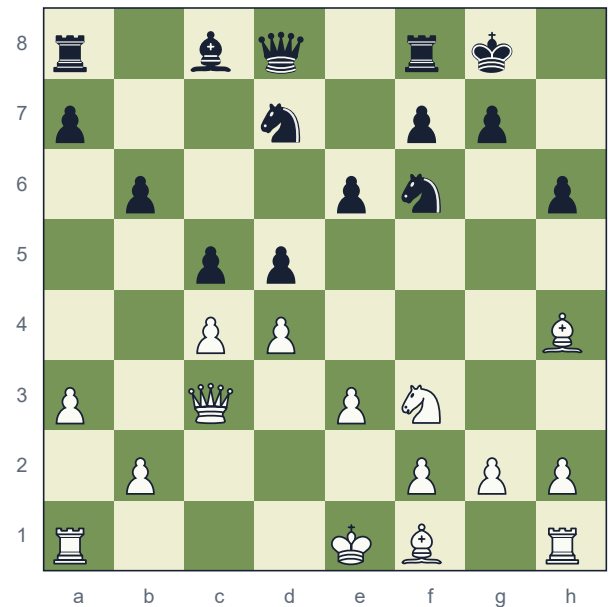
STUDY LINE 13-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 O-O 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. Qxc3 d5 7. Nf3 Nbd7 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 c5 10. e3 b6

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a3 asks the bishop to decide; Qxc3 preserves the pawn structure. Nf3 brings another piece into the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the bishops, castle, and use the bishop pair once the center opens. e3 is often the practical next step.

WATCH FOR

The queen on c3 can be attacked with tempo by ...Ne4.

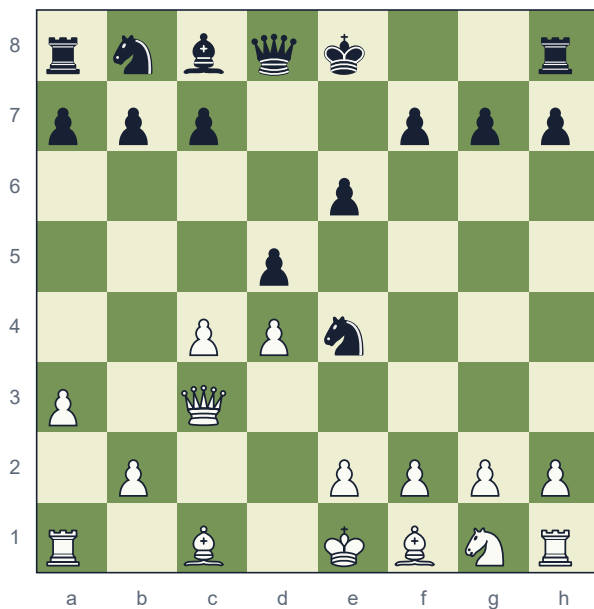
REMEMBER Keep the bishop pair without forgetting development.

02 The direct ...d5 challenge

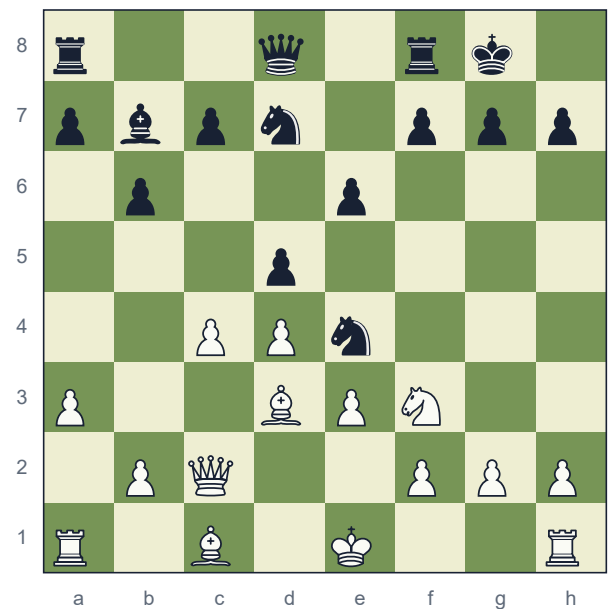
STUDY LINE 13-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 d5 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. Qxc3 Ne4 7. Qc2 O-O 8. Nf3 Nd7 9. e3 b6 10. Bd3 Bb7

Selected anchor ends with 7. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The queen retreats after the knight gains time. You have preserved the structure, but Black has obtained active central play.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Nf3 and e3 are sensible development goals. Challenge the e4 knight only when the resulting exchanges help you.

WATCH FOR

Do not count the bishop pair as compensation for unlimited queen moves.

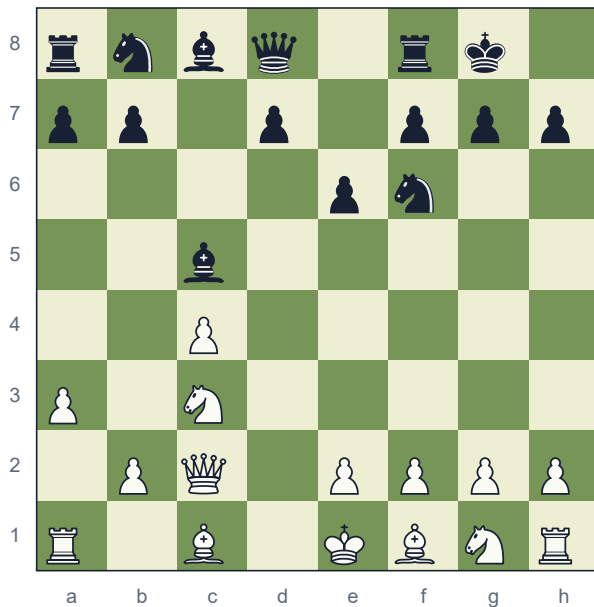
REMEMBER Positional gains must be balanced against tempi.

03 The ...c5 counterstrike

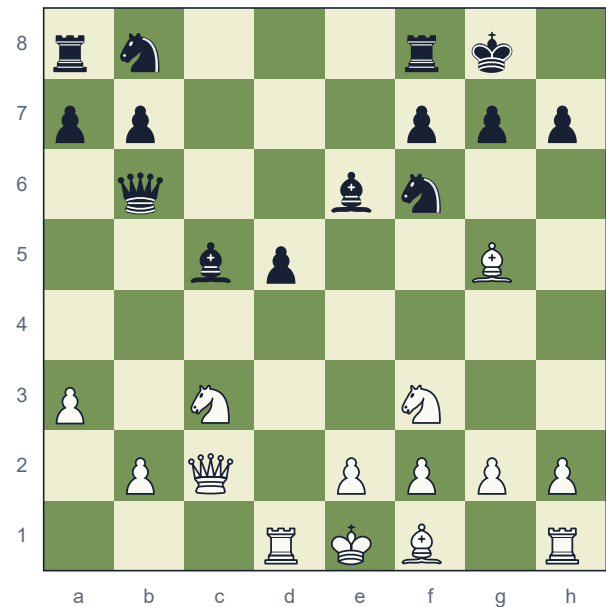
STUDY LINE 13-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 c5 5. dxc5 O-O 6. a3 Bxc5 7. Nf3 d5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bg5 Be6 10. Rd1 Qb6

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Exchanging on c5 changes the center and lets Black develop a bishop. Your queen on c2 still helps with central control.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bf4 or Bg5 when useful, then e3 and castling. Keep an eye on ...d5 as Black's freeing move.

WATCH FOR

Do not cling to c5 if Black can recover it with a developing move anyway.

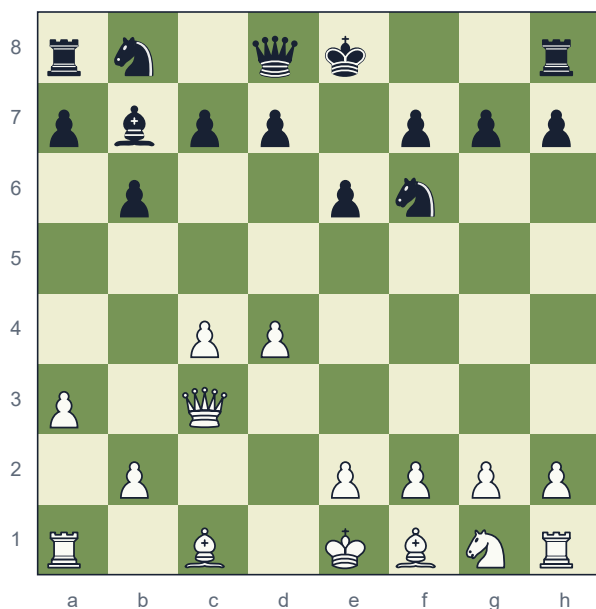
REMEMBER Use central exchanges to develop a playable position.

04 The ...b6 fianchetto

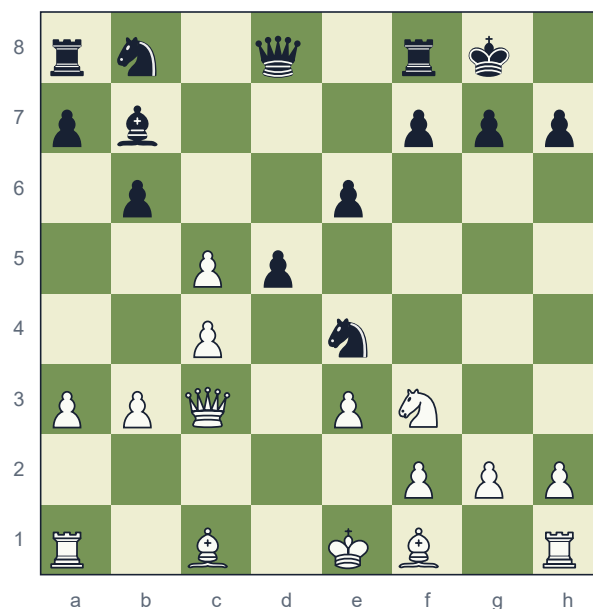
STUDY LINE 13-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 b6 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. Qxc3 Bb7 7. Nf3 O-O 8. e3 d5 9. b3 c5 10. dxc5 Ne4

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black exchanges the pinning bishop and activates the other one. White gains two bishops but still needs to organize the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

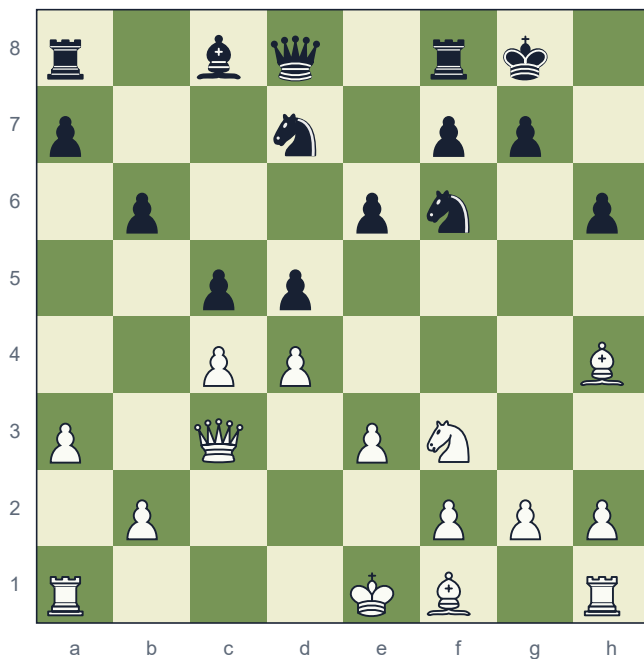
g3 or e3 can be chosen according to the central pawn structure. Complete development before opening both long diagonals.

WATCH FOR

A premature e4 may be challenged by both the f6 knight and the b7 bishop.

REMEMBER Count e4 defenders before claiming the center.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The pin on Nc3 restrains e4. Qc2 supports the knight and lets the queen recapture after ...Bxc3, but the queen move costs a developing tempo.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black attacks the center with ...d5 or ...c5, castles quickly, and may try ...b6. White must avoid collecting positional assets while neglecting the king.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the bishops, castle, and use the bishop pair once the center opens. e3 is often the practical next step.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

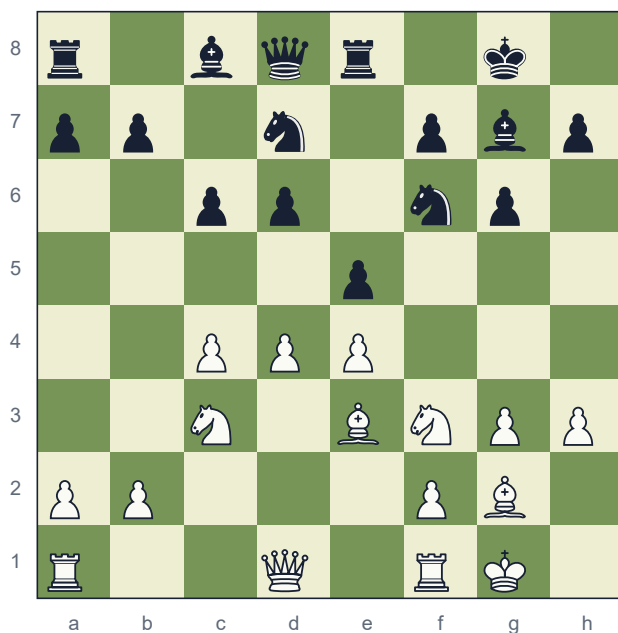
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

King's Indian: a fianchetto repertoire

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nf3 Bg7 4.g3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Use Bg2 and castling to build a resilient king position. Develop Nc3 and take e4 when the center is ready; then learn whether to close with d5 or keep the tension.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Black concedes central space and strikes with ...e5 or ...c5. The g2 bishop helps defend your king and adds central pressure, but its diagonal can be blocked by your own pawns.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black seeks ...e5, ...c5, and sometimes a queenside ...a6/...b5 expansion. ...f5 becomes relevant only when the knight and pawn structure permit it.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. This is not the Mar del Plata race with an automatic white queenside attack and black kingside attack.
2. Keep the g2 bishop unless a concrete exchange is favorable.
3. Always inspect ...c5 before assuming you can close the center with d5.

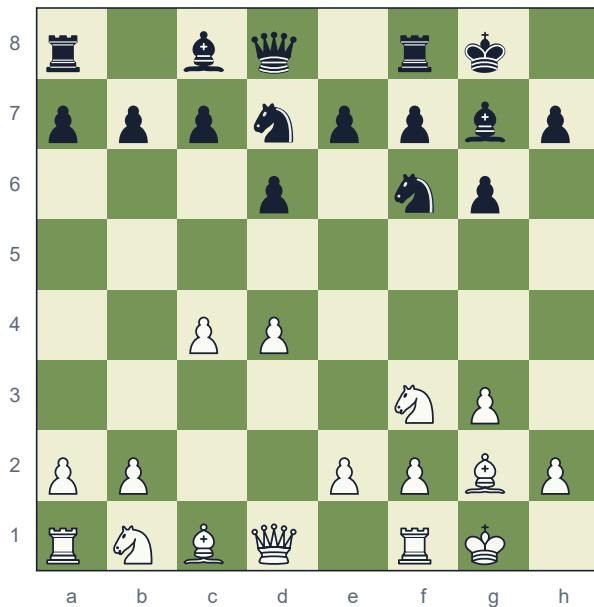
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Classical fianchetto development

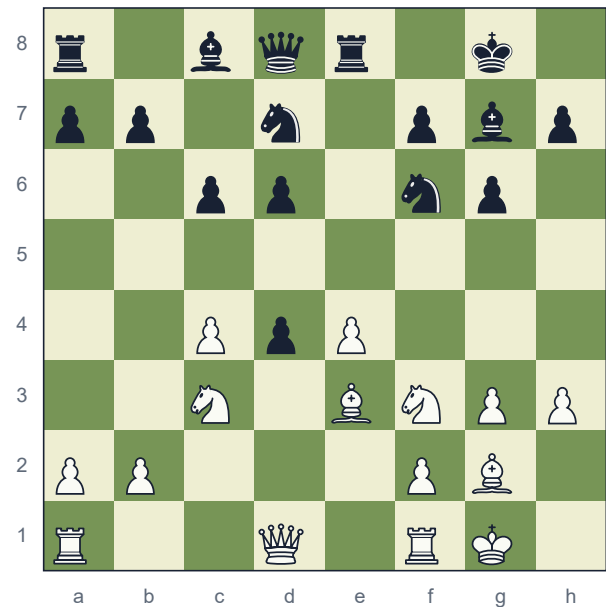
STUDY LINE 14-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 Bg7 4. g3 O-O 5. Bg2 d6 6. O-O Nbd7 7. Nc3 e5 8. e4 c6 9. h3 Re8 10. Be3 exd4

Selected anchor ends with 10. Be3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The center is supported by pieces before e4. h3 restricts ...Bg4 and gives the king position a little flexibility.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Choose Qc2, Re1 or d5 according to Black's regrouping. If the center closes, identify useful knight routes rather than launching pawns immediately.

WATCH FOR

A kingside pawn move can weaken the very squares your fianchetto is meant to protect.

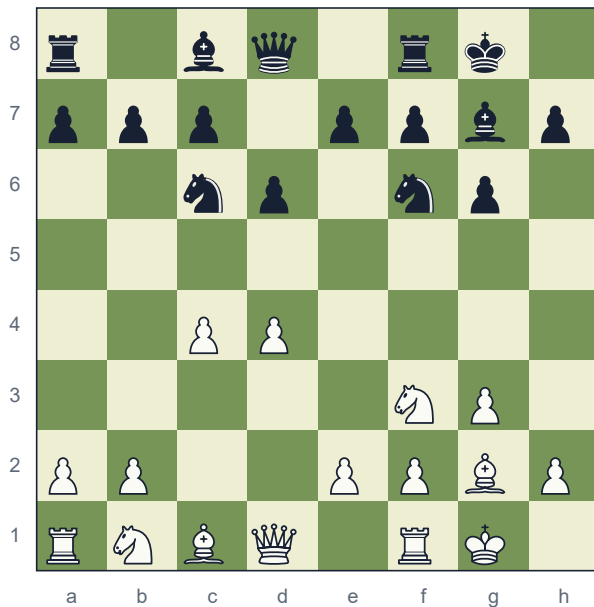
REMEMBER Build the center behind a secure king.

02 Panno: ...Nc6 and ...a6

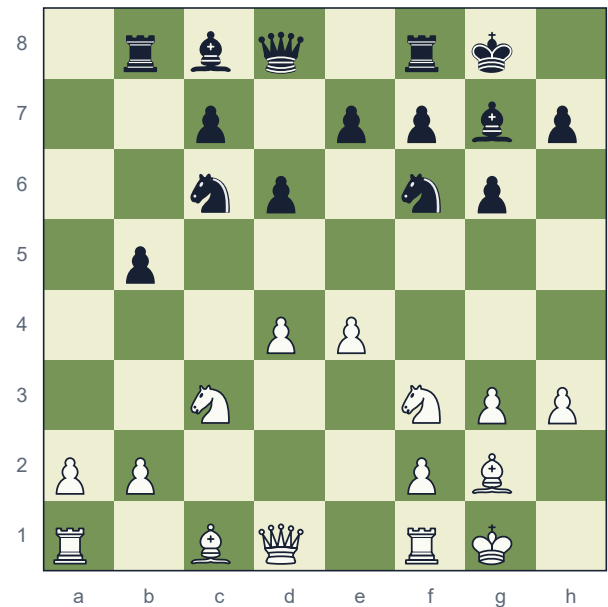
STUDY LINE 14-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 Bg7 4. g3 O-O 5. Bg2 d6 6. O-O Nc6 7. Nc3 a6 8. h3 Rb8 9. e4 b5 10. cxb5 axb5

Selected anchor ends with 8... Rb8. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black prepares queenside expansion. h3 is a useful waiting move but does not by itself stop ...b5.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Consider a4 to restrain ...b5, or prepare e4 if the center is ready. Decide which plan fits Black's rook and knight placement.

WATCH FOR

Do not push a4 and assume all queenside threats have vanished; ...Na5 and ...c5 can create new play.

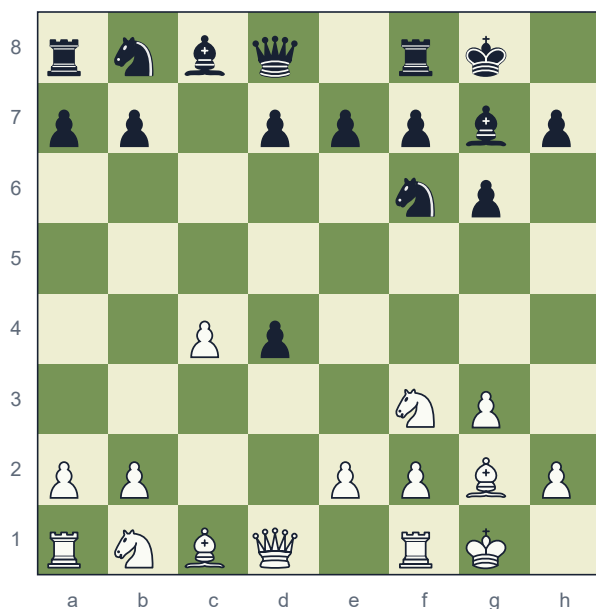
REMEMBER Read the purpose of ...Rb8 before choosing your plan.

03 The ...c5 structure

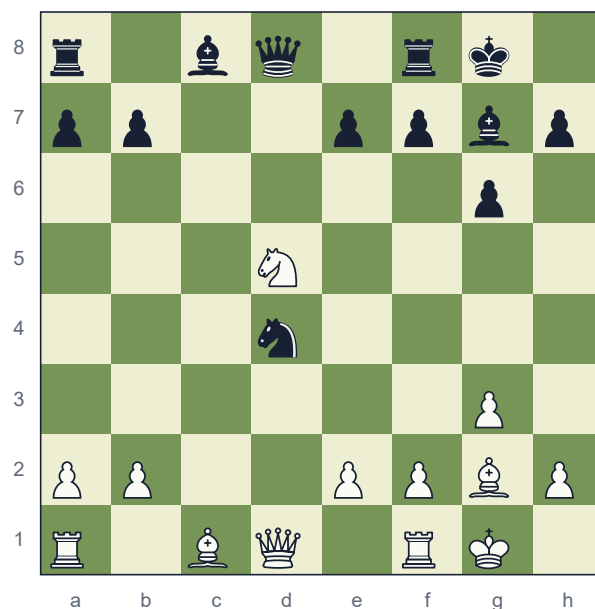
STUDY LINE 14-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 Bg7 4. g3 O-O 5. Bg2 c5 6. O-O cxd4 7. Nxd4 Nc6 8. Nc3 d5 9. cxd5 Nxd5 10. Nxd5 Nxd4

Selected anchor ends with 7... Nc6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The knight recapture keeps a healthy pawn structure and moves the game away from a locked center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Nc3 and a useful bishop development complete your setup. Watch ...d5 as a freeing central break.

WATCH FOR

Do not play e4 without checking whether ...Nxe4 or ...d5 changes the tactical balance.

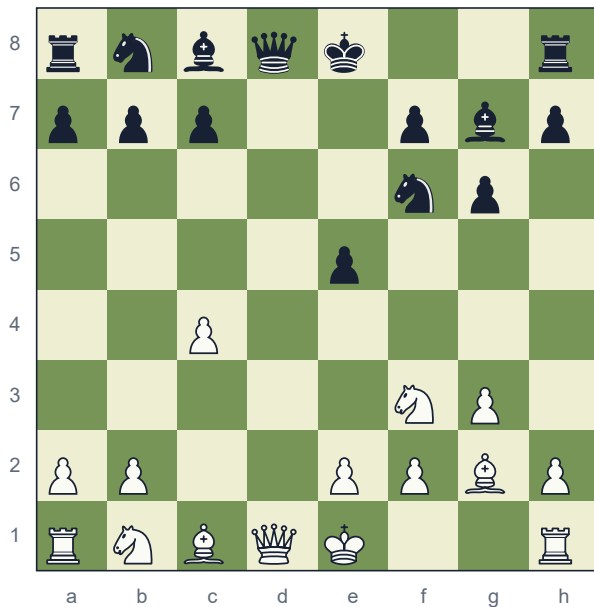
REMEMBER An open center rewards piece activity.

04 Black attacks the center before castling

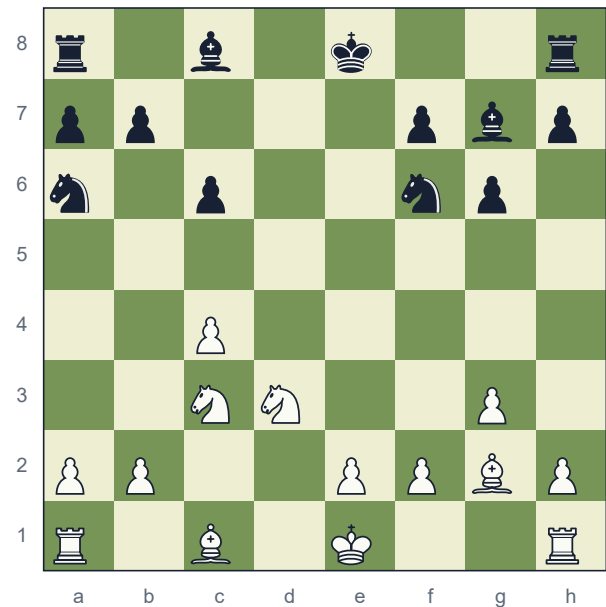
STUDY LINE 14-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 Bg7 4. g3 d6 5. Bg2 e5 6. dxe5 dxe5 7. Qxd8+ Kxd8 8. Nxe5 Ke8 9. Nc3 c6 10. Nd3 Na6

Selected anchor ends with 7... Kxd8. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

A queen trade is available when the d-file opens. It reduces king-attack risk but does not make Black's king permanently weak in an endgame.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

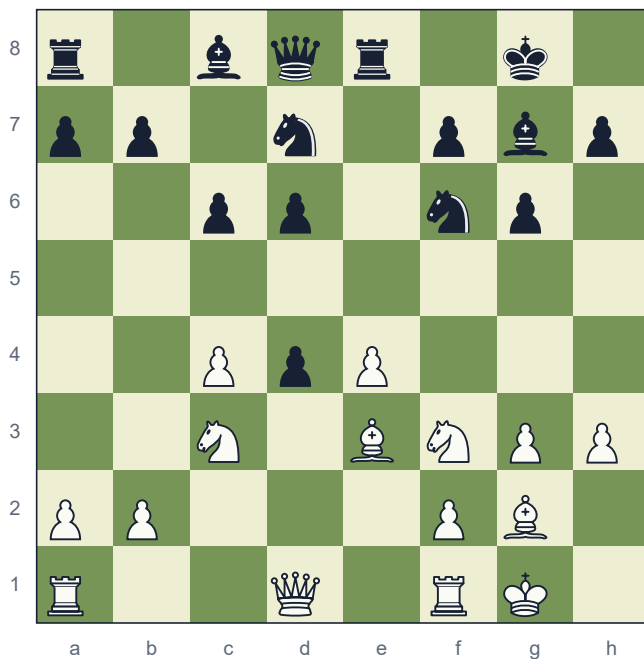
Develop the b1 knight, castle if useful, and use central squares. Aim for activity rather than spending tempi chasing the king.

WATCH FOR

Do not overvalue the loss of castling when queens are off; an active central king may become an asset.

REMEMBER Simplification changes what king safety means.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Black concedes central space and strikes with ...e5 or ...c5. The g2 bishop helps defend your king and adds central pressure, but its diagonal can be blocked by your own pawns.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black seeks ...e5, ...c5, and sometimes a queenside ...a6/...b5 expansion. ...f5 becomes relevant only when the knight and pawn structure permit it.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Choose Qc2, Re1 or d5 according to Black's regrouping. If the center closes, identify useful knight routes rather than launching pawns immediately.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

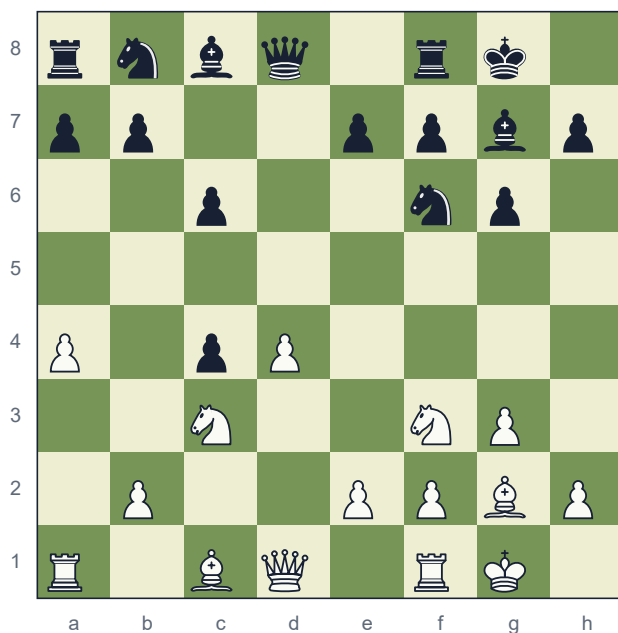
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Grunfeld: keep the fianchetto

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nf3 d5 4.g3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Meet the early ...d5 with the same fianchetto family used against the King's Indian. Do not mix this system with the sharp Exchange Grunfeld unless you deliberately choose that extra theory.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Black challenges d4 immediately and often exchanges on c4 or d4. The long diagonals and the c- and d-files become important.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black wants active pieces, ...c5, and pressure against a central pawn that White advances too far. Capturing c4 can buy time for development.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The difference between ...d6 and ...d5 is fundamental.
2. Do not play e4 by habit while d4 is under pressure.
3. Recover c4 with a plan that accounts for ...a6 and ...b5.

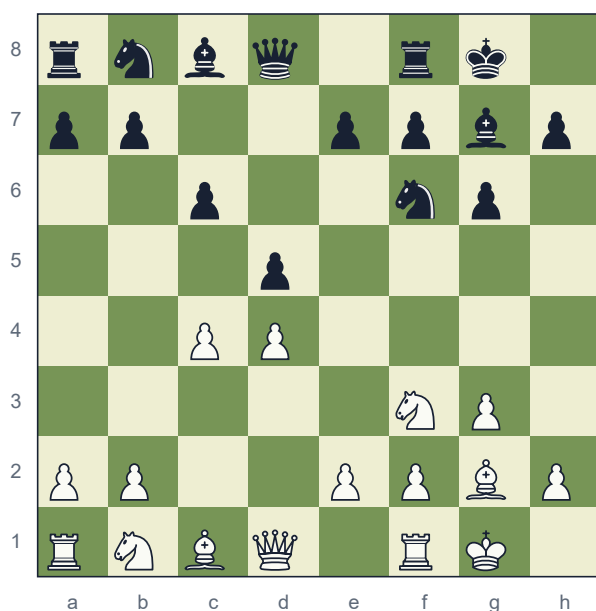
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Closed fianchetto structure

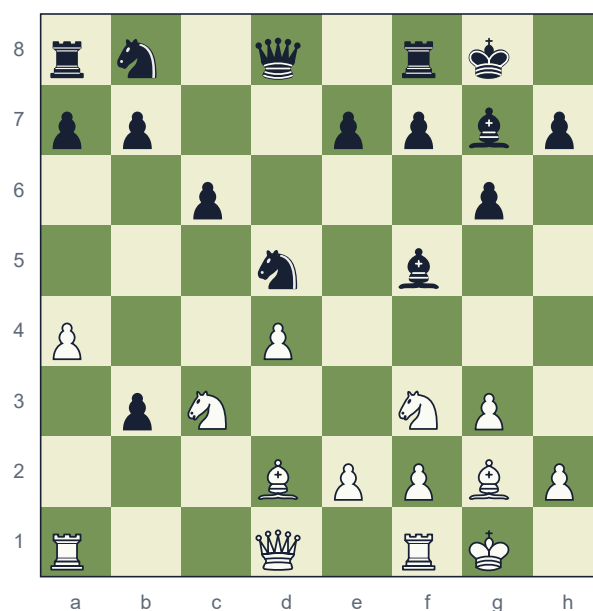
STUDY LINE 15-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Bg7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O c6 7. Nc3 dxc4 8. a4 Nd5 9. Bd2 Bf5 10. b3 cxb3

Selected anchor ends with 8. a4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 restrains ...b5 and prepares to recover the pawn without allowing a lasting queenside chain.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop e3 or a queen move to recover c4 as appropriate. Keep your pieces coordinated against ...c5 or ...Na6-b4.

WATCH FOR

The bishop on g7 can attack d4 once the diagonal opens; do not remove central defenders casually.

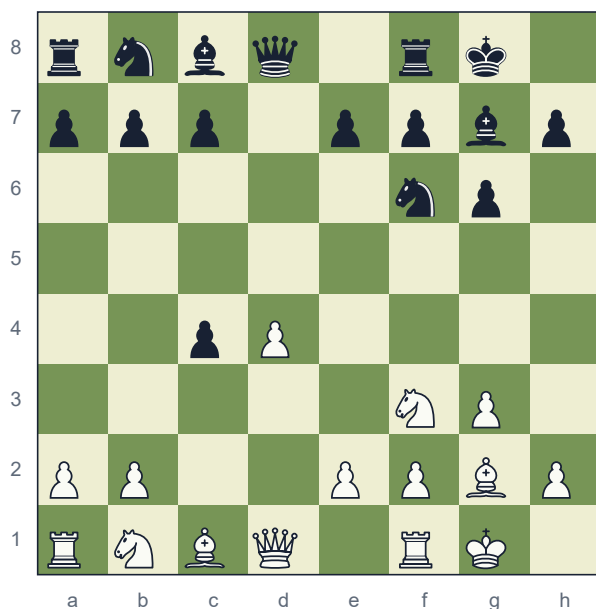
REMEMBER Secure the center while recovering the pawn.

02 Open fianchetto: ...dxc4

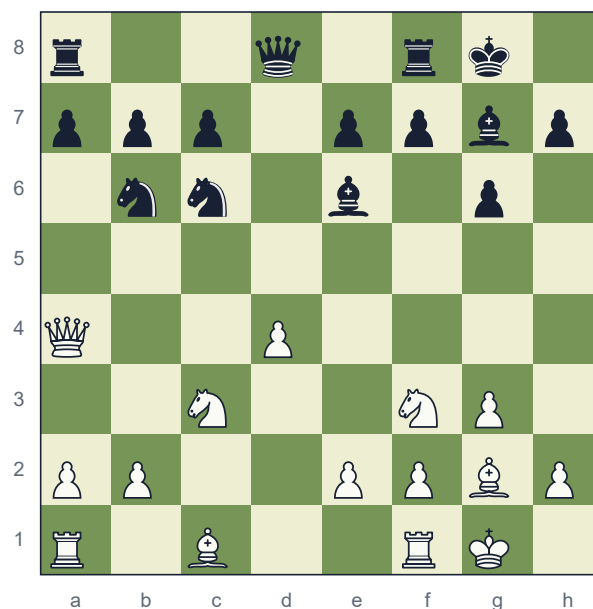
STUDY LINE 15-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Bg7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O dxc4 7. Qc2 Nc6 8. Qxc4 Be6 9. Qa4 Nd5 10. Nc3 Nb6

Selected anchor ends with 7. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Qc2 eyes c4 and keeps the center supported. Black must decide how much effort to spend holding the extra pawn.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Recover with the queen when safe, develop the b1 knight, and meet ...c5 through central exchanges or support.

WATCH FOR

A queen capture on c4 can be met with ...b5 or ...Be6, so count the tempi before taking.

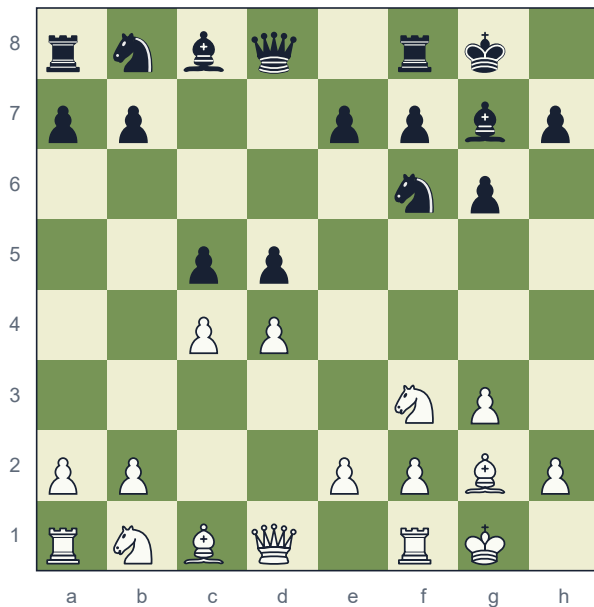
REMEMBER Recover c4 without letting the queen become a target.

03 Black plays ...c5 quickly

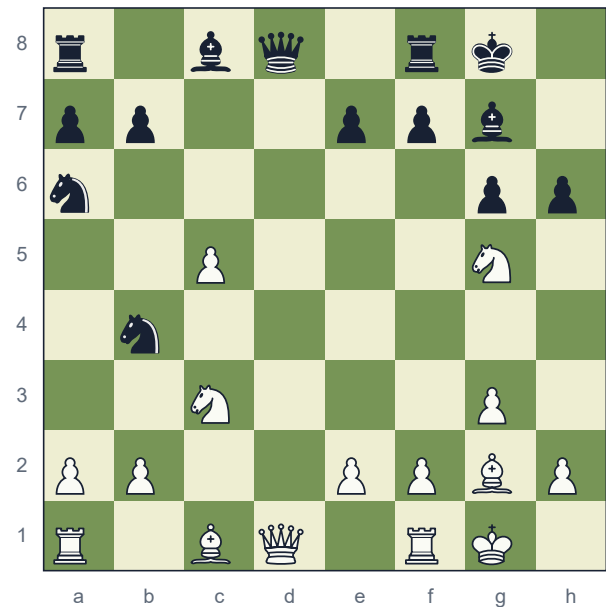
STUDY LINE 15-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Bg7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O c5 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. dxc5 Na6 9. Ng5 Ndb4 10. Nc3 h6

Selected anchor ends with 8. dxc5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Both central pawn pairs can be exchanged. The result emphasizes development and active files rather than a permanent space advantage.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bring the b1 knight into play and develop the c1 bishop. Use the open center instead of trying to recreate a pawn chain that no longer exists.

WATCH FOR

A central knight may be tactically vulnerable to a queen or bishop move; check before defending a pawn with another pawn.

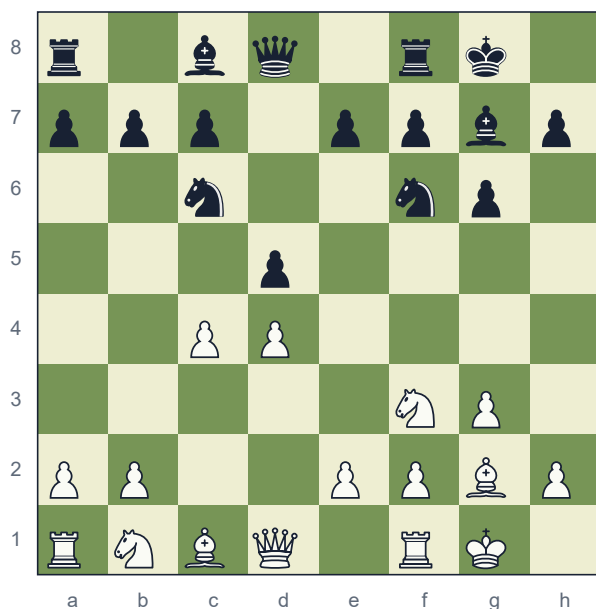
REMEMBER When the center clears, activate pieces.

04 Black develops ...Nc6

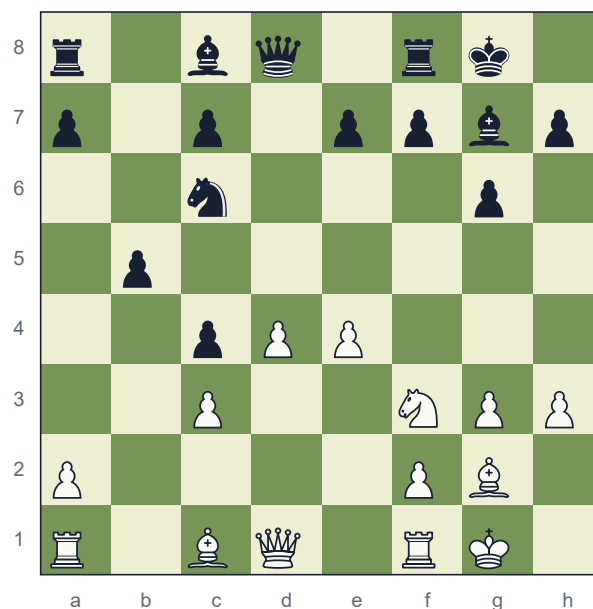
STUDY LINE 15-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Bg7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O Nc6 7. Nc3 dxc4 8. h3 Nd5 9. e4 Nxc3 10. bxc3 b5

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nc3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

You can develop naturally, but the pressure against d4 and the possibility of ...dxc4 still govern the position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

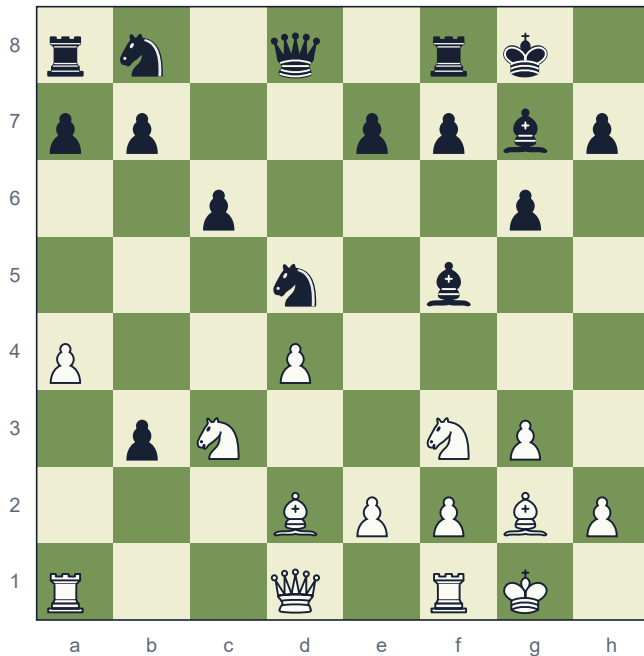
Consider cxd5 if the recapture gives you a useful target. Otherwise keep the center and improve the queen bishop.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume the c6 knight is misplaced simply because it blocks ...c5; it may support an immediate ...e5.

REMEMBER Identify Black's actual central break.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Black challenges d4 immediately and often exchanges on c4 or d4. The long diagonals and the c- and d-files become important.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black wants active pieces, ...c5, and pressure against a central pawn that White advances too far. Capturing c4 can buy time for development.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop e3 or a queen move to recover c4 as appropriate. Keep your pieces coordinated against ...c5 or ...Na6-b4.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

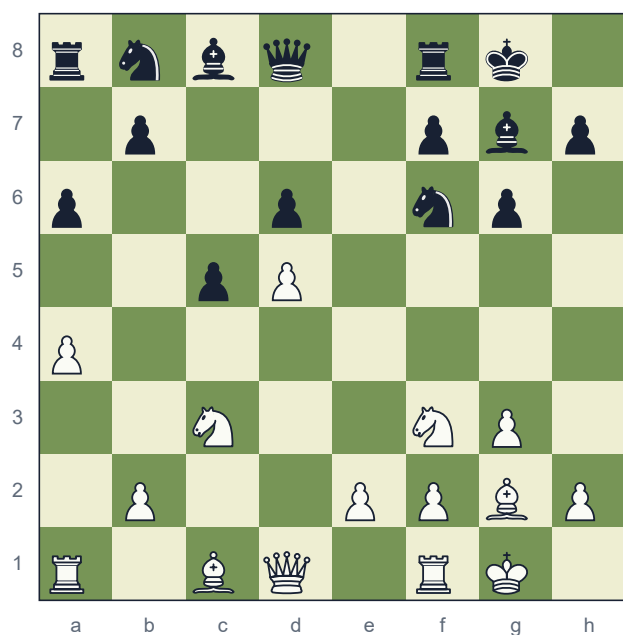
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Modern Benoni: space and the fianchetto

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Keep a pawn on d5 and use a kingside fianchetto to build a coherent setup. The center gives you space; Black's queenside majority and active pieces create counterplay.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

After ...exd5 and cxd5, White has a central space advantage while Black has a queenside pawn majority. The d6 pawn is a potential target, but ...b5 can be a powerful freeing move.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black seeks ...b5, pressure down the e-file, and piece activity against e4 or d5. A rook on e8 and bishop on g7 can cooperate tactically.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Restrain ...b5 when useful, but do not make every move a defensive pawn move.
2. The d6 pawn may be weak, yet Black's active pieces can make capturing it impossible.
3. The key white breakthrough is often e4-e5, prepared by development and central support.

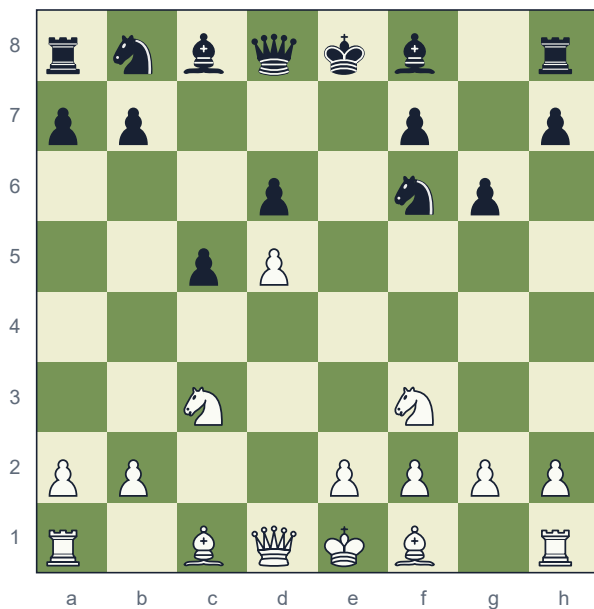
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 The fianchetto main setup

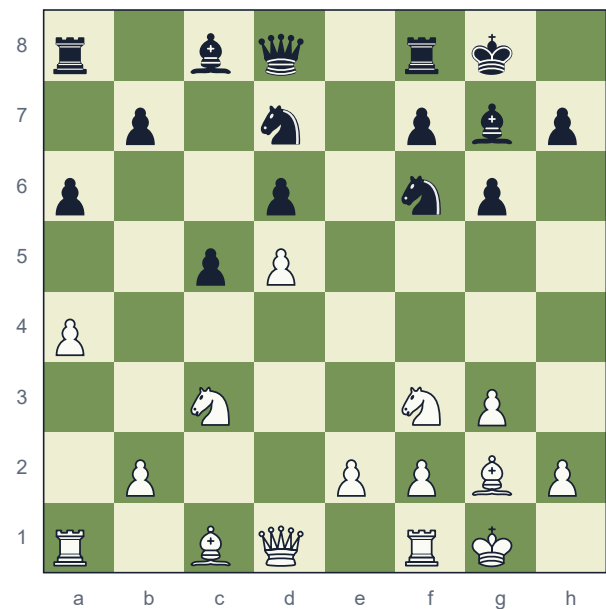
STUDY LINE 16-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. g3 Bg7 8. Bg2 O-O 9. O-O a6 10. a4 Nbd7

Selected anchor ends with 10. a4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a4 makes ...b5 harder to achieve. The g2 bishop supports the center while the king reaches safety.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the c1 bishop and prepare e4. Use rooks on central files and watch for an e5 breakthrough when it opens lines favorably.

WATCH FOR

After a4, the b4 square may become available to a black knight. Preventing one break can concede a square.

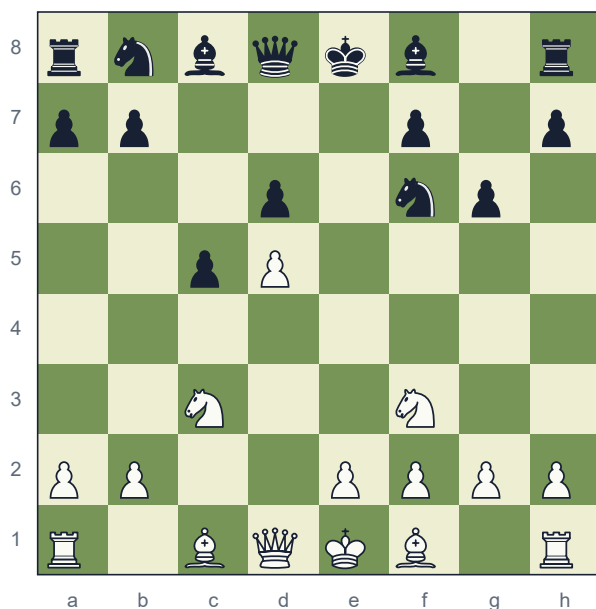
REMEMBER Keep d5, complete development, prepare e4-e5.

02 Black delays castling

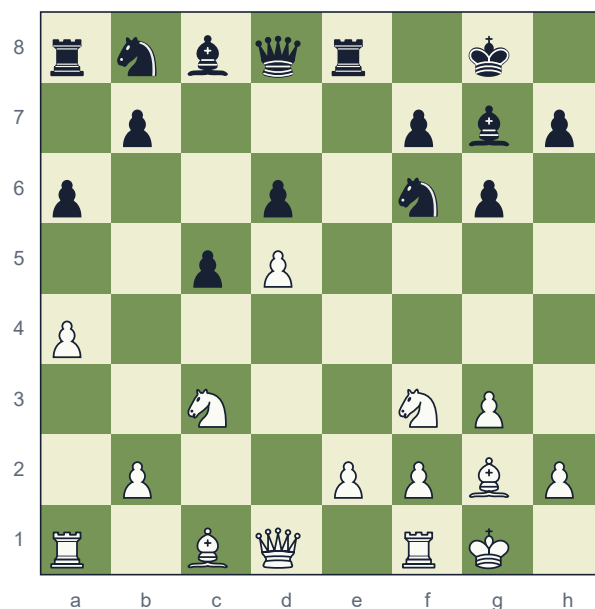
STUDY LINE 16-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. g3 Bg7 8. Bg2 a6 9. O-O O-O 10. a4 Re8

Selected anchor ends with 9. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White need not delay king safety just because Black does. The center and ...b5 remain the strategic questions.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

a4 may restrain ...b5; e4 builds the full center if supported. Compare these moves rather than choosing by habit.

WATCH FOR

A premature e5 may release Black's cramped position with favorable exchanges.

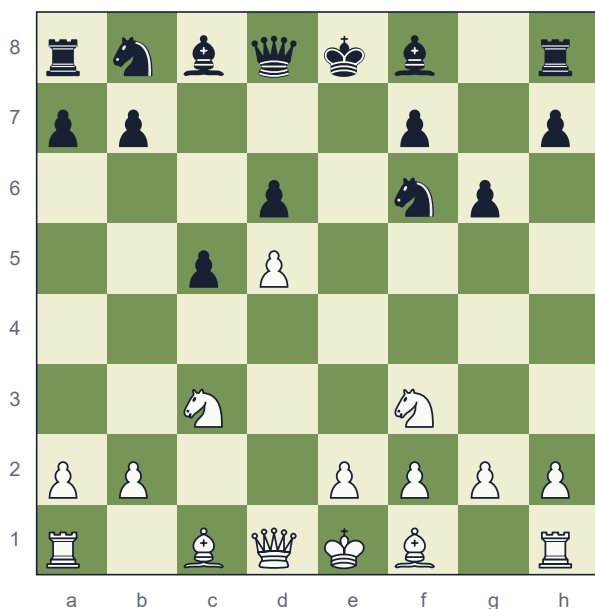
REMEMBER Prepare the central break rather than forcing it.

03 The ...e6 move order after 3.Nf3

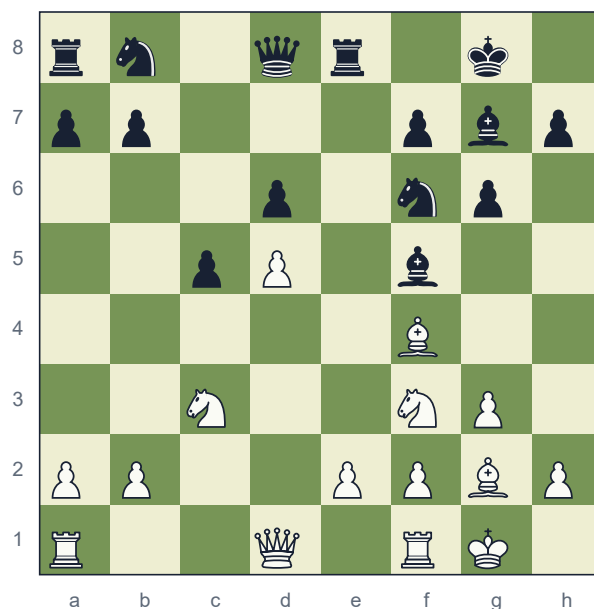
STUDY LINE 16-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. d5 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nc3 g6 7. g3 Bg7 8. Bf4 O-O 9. Bg2 Re8 10. O-O Bf5

Selected anchor ends with 7. g3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This transposes to the same fianchetto Benoni with the f3 knight developed earlier. Your repertoire remains coherent across both move orders.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bg2, O-O and restraint of ...b5 are familiar goals. Check whether Black inserted a useful move before calling the position identical.

WATCH FOR

If Black plays ...b5 instead of ...exd5, consult the Blumenfeld section; do not recapture a pawn that has not been exchanged.

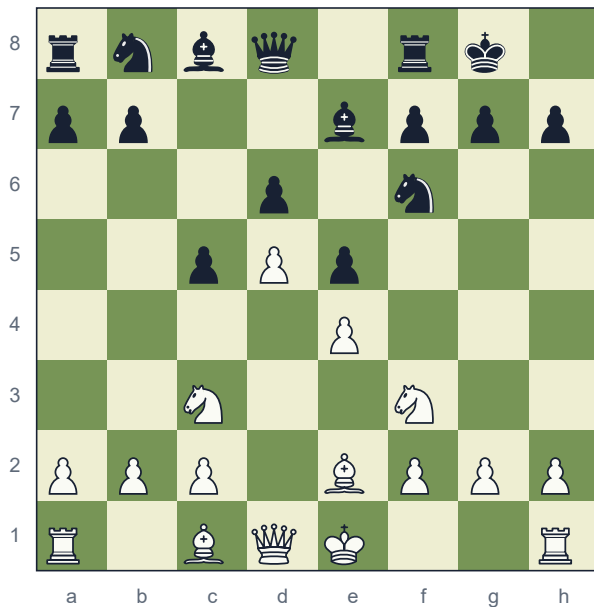
REMEMBER Recognize the transposition and the alternative gambit.

04 Old Benoni: the locked center

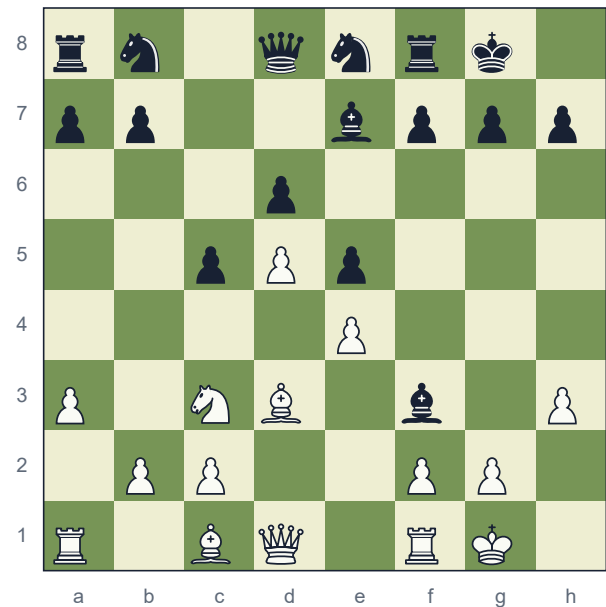
STUDY LINE 16-04

1. d4 c5 2. d5 e5 3. e4 d6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Nc3 Be7 6. Be2 O-O 7. O-O Ne8 8. Bd3 Bd7 9. a3 Bg4 10. h3 Bxf3

Selected anchor ends with 7. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Here White deferred c4 and took e4. The center is locked, so the right wing for play depends on piece placement and possible pawn breaks.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

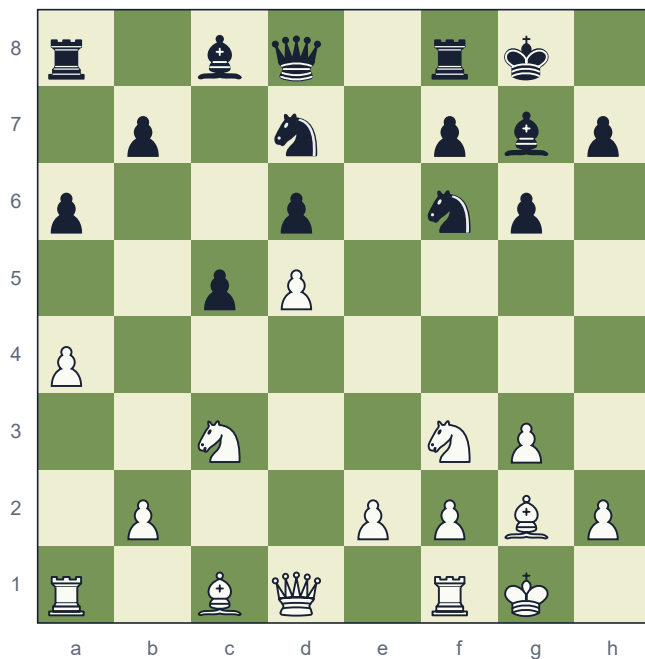
Prepare a queenside expansion or central undermining move. c4 is optional later; it should improve control rather than merely imitate another opening.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume a locked center makes kingside pawn advances safe forever. A break can open files suddenly.

REMEMBER This is a different pawn skeleton from the Modern Benoni.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

After ...exd5 and cxd5, White has a central space advantage while Black has a queenside pawn majority. The d6 pawn is a potential target, but ...b5 can be a powerful freeing move.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black seeks ...b5, pressure down the e-file, and piece activity against e4 or d5. A rook on e8 and bishop on g7 can cooperate tactically.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the c1 bishop and prepare e4. Use rooks on central files and watch for an e5 breakthrough when it opens lines favorably.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

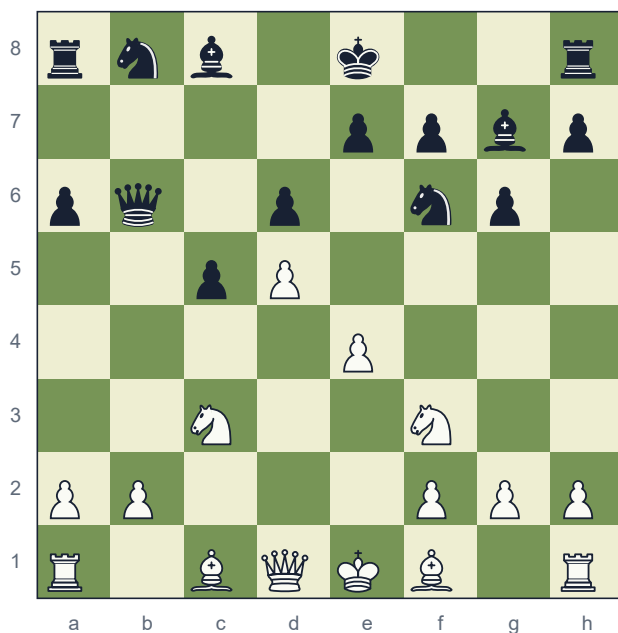
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Benko Gambit: the 5.b6 practical decline

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 b5 4.cxb5 a6 5.b6

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Return the b-pawn on terms that reduce Black's familiar open-file compensation. 5.b6 is a practical repertoire choice; it does not refute the Benko.



Main-line anchor - White to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

By advancing the captured pawn to b6, White avoids the standard accepted structure with open a- and b-files against the queenside. Black still has active pieces and a central minority.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black can capture with the queen or knight, or delay the recapture. ...g6, ...Bg7 and ...d6 remain natural development.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Do not mix 5.b6 with accepted-Benko advice about defending an extra pawn on a6.
2. The d5 pawn is your useful space advantage; support it and develop.
3. A returned pawn can buy easier development and reduce the opponent's prepared initiative.

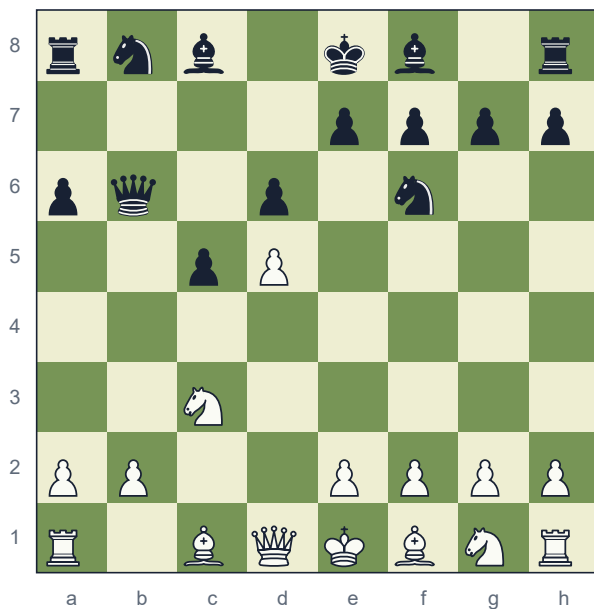
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Black recaptures with the queen

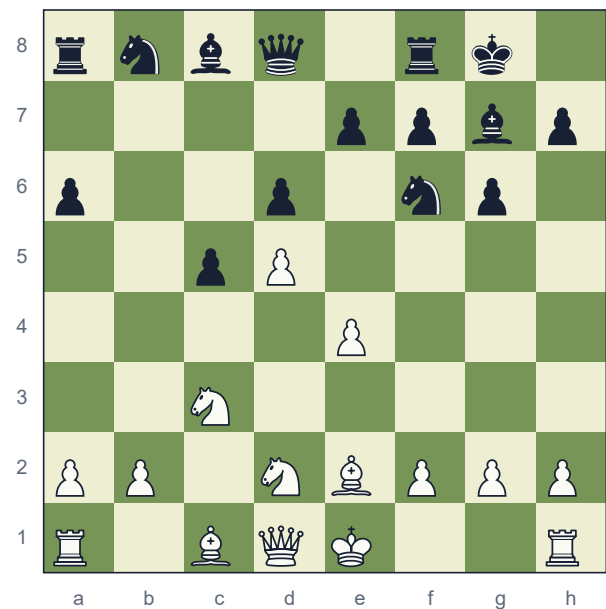
STUDY LINE 17-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. b6 Qxb6 6. Nc3 d6 7. e4 g6 8. Nf3 Bg7 9. Be2 O-O 10. Nd2 Qd8

Selected anchor ends with 8... Bg7. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White has returned material but kept central space. The queen on b6 can become a target for useful developing moves.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the bishops and castle. A timely Nd2-c4 can question the queen, but verify the central tactics first.

WATCH FOR

Do not chase the queen while abandoning d5 or e4.

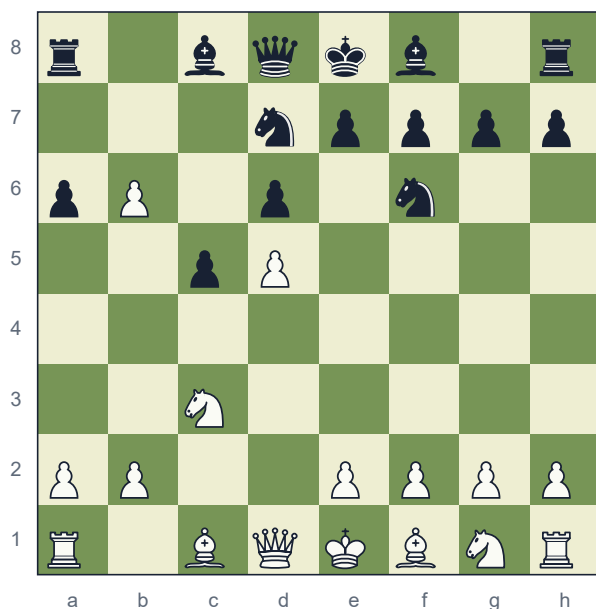
REMEMBER Return the pawn and build a healthy center.

02 Black recaptures with the knight

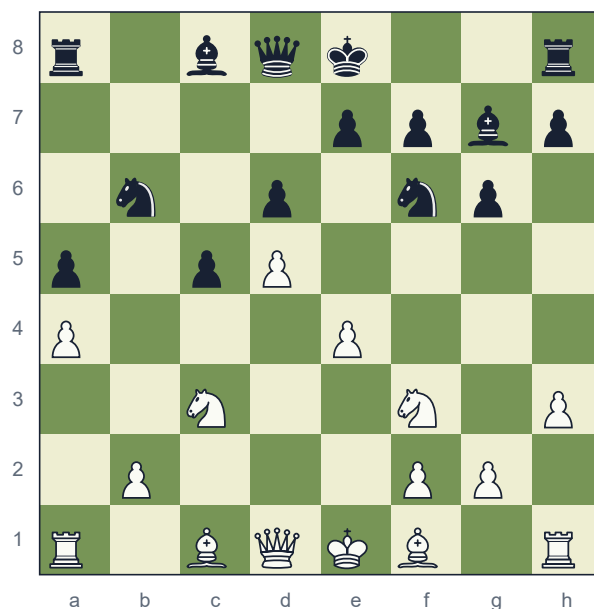
STUDY LINE 17-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. b6 d6 6. Nc3 Nbd7 7. e4 Nxb6 8. Nf3 g6 9. h3 Bg7 10. a4 a5

Selected anchor ends with 8. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The knight route costs time but develops a useful piece. White uses the time to occupy the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Complete development and compare the value of a4 with improving a bishop. Watch ...e6 against d5.

WATCH FOR

The b6 knight can return to c4 or a4. A queenside pawn move may give it a target.

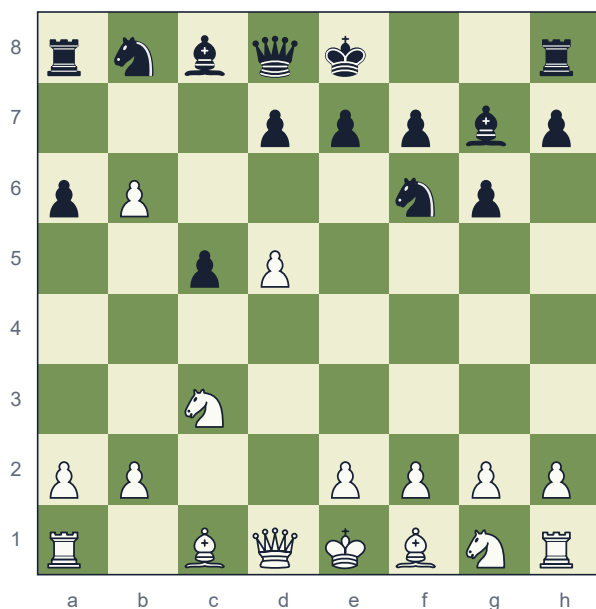
REMEMBER Use Black's recapture tempi for development.

03 Black develops before recovering b6

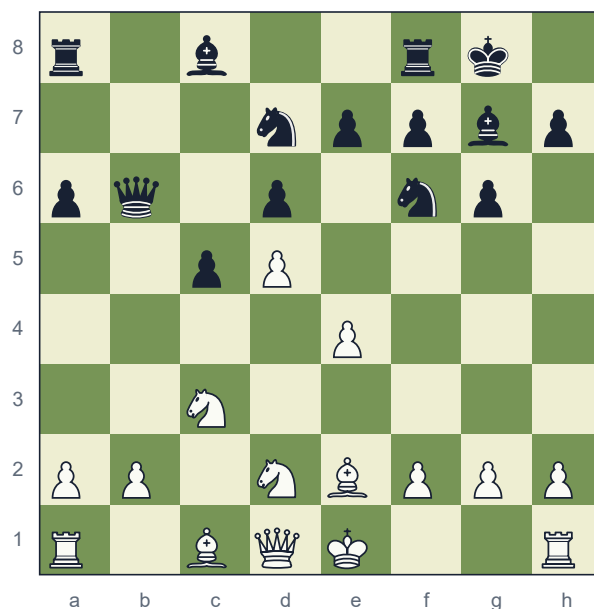
STUDY LINE 17-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. b6 g6 6. Nc3 Bg7 7. e4 O-O 8. Nf3 Qxb6 9. Nd2 d6 10. Be2 Nbd7

Selected anchor ends with 8. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White continues normal development instead of trying to defend b6 at any cost. The advanced pawn can be surrendered if protecting it slows the army.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bring out the bishops and castle. Make Black prove compensation in the center, not in a familiar accepted-gambit structure.

WATCH FOR

A pawn far from home is often a distraction. Do not move the queen repeatedly to defend it.

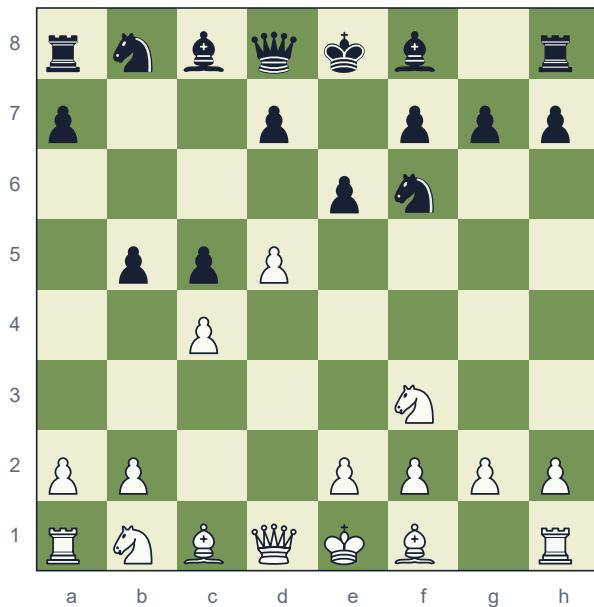
REMEMBER Your center matters more than the temporary b6 pawn.

04 The ...e6 move is a different gambit

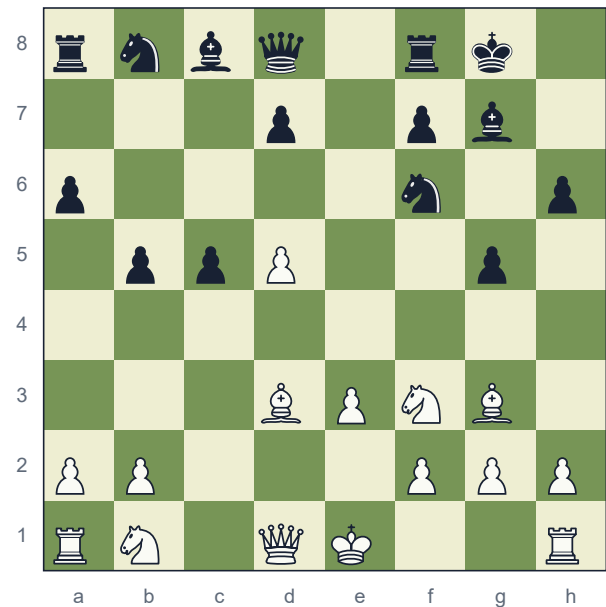
STUDY LINE 17-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bg5 exd5 6. cxd5 h6 7. Bh4 g5 8. Bg3 Bg7 9. e3 a6 10. Bd3 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. Bg5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This move order is related to the Blumenfeld family. Bg5 develops while retaining central tension instead of treating every ...b5 as a Benko.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

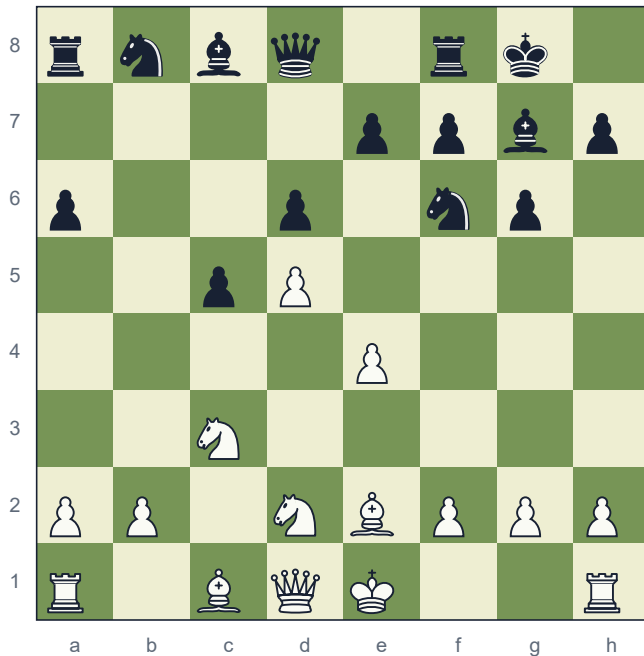
Use the Blumenfeld lesson in Booklet 18. Central exchanges and the f6 pin determine the correct continuation.

WATCH FOR

Do not apply the 5.b6 recipe when you have not captured on b5.

REMEMBER Name the center before choosing the gambit response.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

By advancing the captured pawn to b6, White avoids the standard accepted structure with open a- and b-files against the queenside. Black still has active pieces and a central minority.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black can capture with the queen or knight, or delay the recapture. ...g6, ...Bg7 and ...d6 remain natural development.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the bishops and castle. A timely Nd2-c4 can question the queen, but verify the central tactics first.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

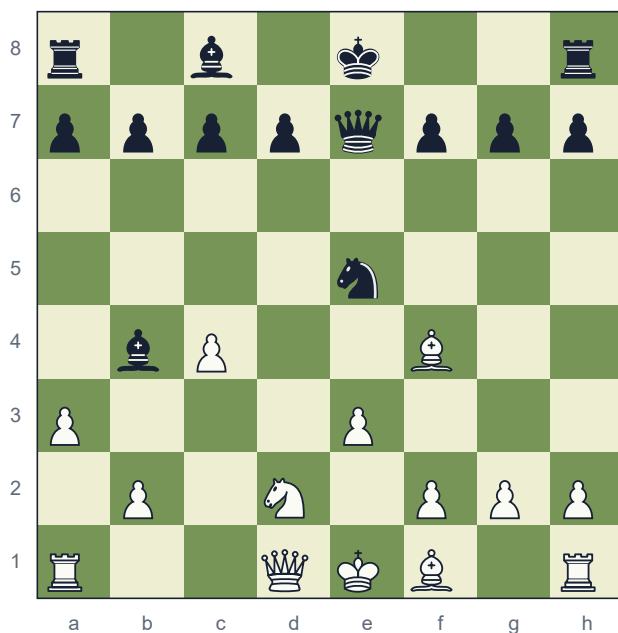
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Budapest, Fajarowicz and Blumenfeld

Early ...e5 or ...b5 after 1...Nf6

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Accept the Budapest pawn with development in mind. Against the Blumenfeld, prefer Bg5 and a healthy center to defending a dangerous extra flank pawn.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The Budapest uses piece activity to recover e5; the Blumenfeld offers a flank pawn to build a large central mass. These require different practical responses.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Budapest: ...Ng4, ...Nc6 and ...Bb4+. Fajarowicz: ...Ne4 and tactical queen/bishop activity. Blumenfeld: ...exd5 and central expansion if White spends time taking b5.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Meet checks with useful development.
2. Do not defend e5 with too many pawn moves if Black can recover it safely anyway.
3. A pin on f6 can be more valuable than an extra b-pawn.

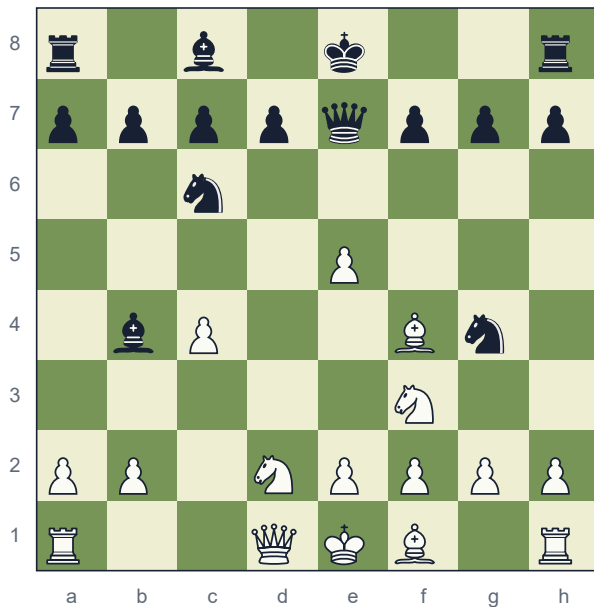
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Budapest: the Bf4 and Nbd2 system

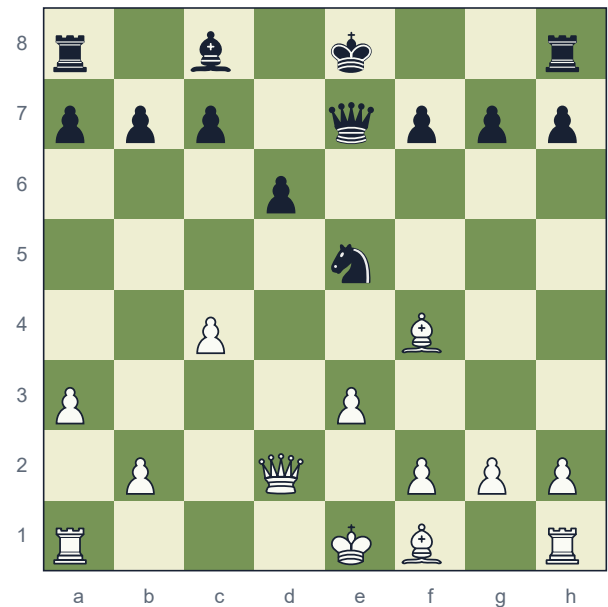
STUDY LINE 18-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 Ng4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Bf4 Bb4+ 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. a3 Ngxe5 8. Nxe5 Nxe5 9. e3 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 d6

Selected anchor ends with 9. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Nbd2 answers the check and supports development. After the central exchanges, e3 opens the f1 bishop without weakening the king.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Be2 or Bd3 and castle. The bishop pair or central space may offer lasting chances once the tactical phase ends.

WATCH FOR

Do not take on e5 with the wrong piece before checking pins and ...Nd3+ ideas.

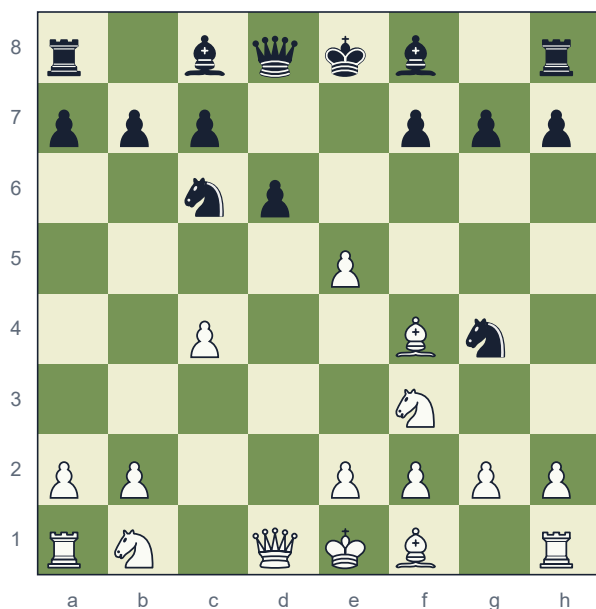
REMEMBER Develop against the gambit; do not worship the extra pawn.

02 Budapest without the bishop check

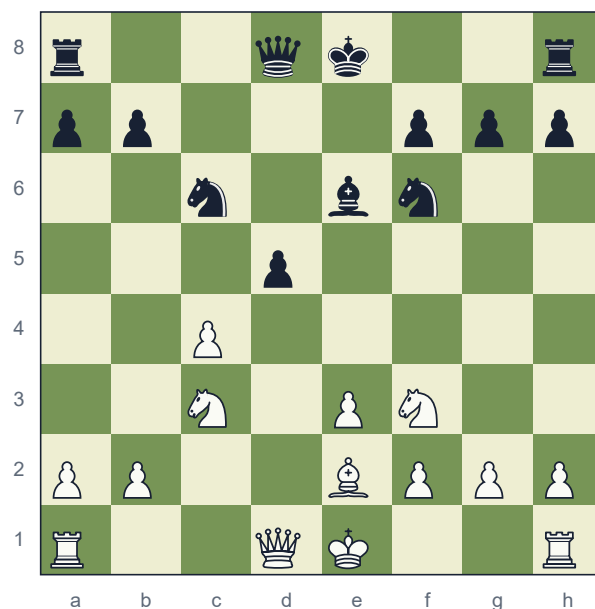
STUDY LINE 18-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 Ng4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Bf4 d6 6. exd6 Bxd6 7. Bxd6 cxd6 8. e3 Be6 9. Nc3 Nf6 10. Be2 d5

Selected anchor ends with 6... Bxd6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black returns to straightforward development. The e5 pawn disappears, but White can maintain a healthy position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

e3, Be2 and castling are priorities. Keep central squares controlled and challenge active black pieces.

WATCH FOR

Do not use a sequence from the ...Bb4+ line when the bishop is on d6; the pins differ.

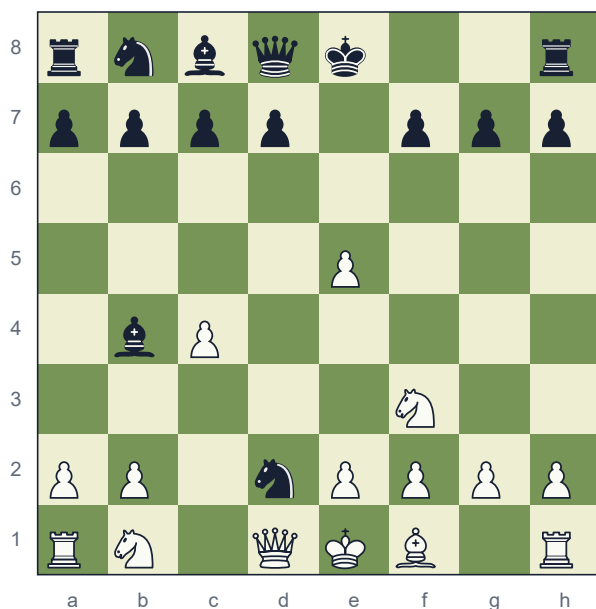
REMEMBER A returned pawn can finish the opening problem.

03 Fajarowicz: the immediate ...Ne4

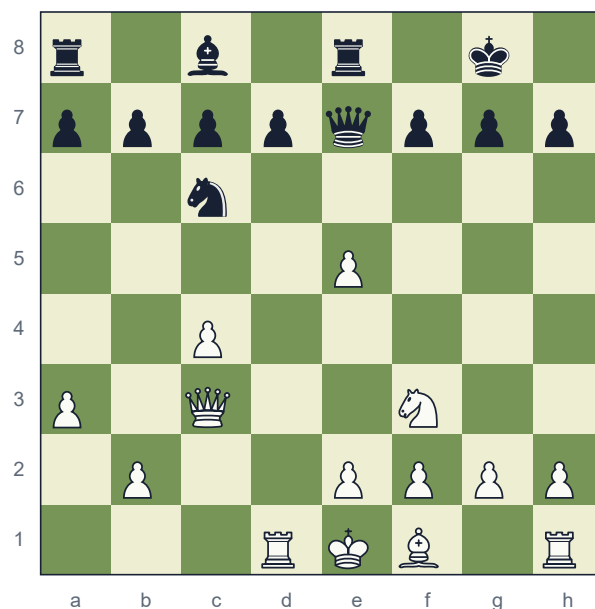
STUDY LINE 18-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 Ne4 4. Nf3 Bb4+ 5. Bd2 Nxd2 6. Nbx d2 Qe7 7. a3 Bxd2+ 8. Qxd2 Nc6 9. Qc3 O-O 10. Rd1 Re8

Selected anchor ends with 6. Nbx d2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Develop while answering the check. The knight recapture on d2 helps cover central squares and avoids needless queen exposure.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bring out the f1 bishop, castle, and keep the e5 pawn only when it is convenient. Black's knight adventure has cost time.

WATCH FOR

Queen checks on h4 or a5 can combine with a loose piece. Always inspect checks before grabbing a second pawn.

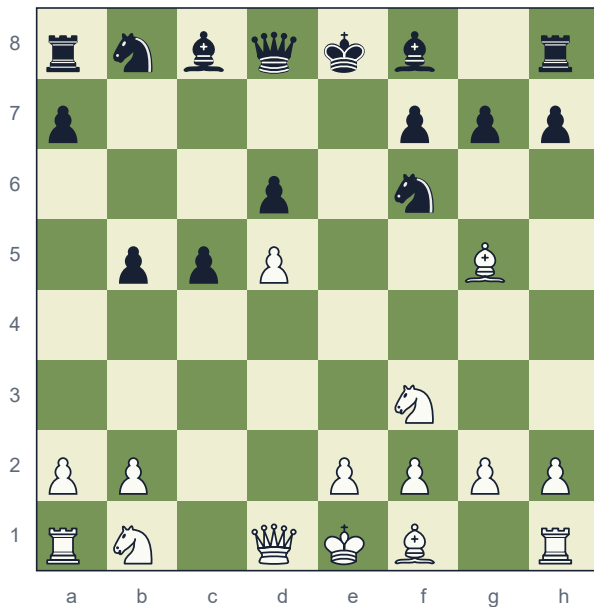
REMEMBER Trade away the active knight and develop.

04 Blumenfeld declined with Bg5

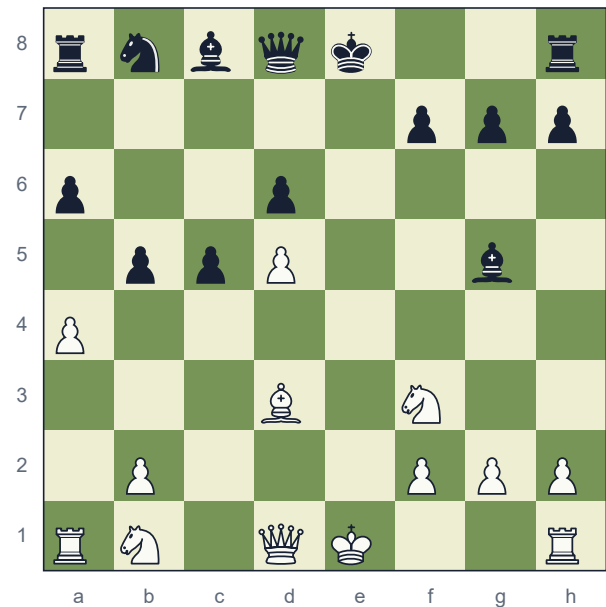
STUDY LINE 18-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. d5 b5 5. Bg5 exd5 6. cxd5 d6 7. e4 a6 8. a4 Be7 9. Bd3 Nxd5 10. exd5 Bxg5

Selected anchor ends with 7. e4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bg5 pins the f6 knight and declines to help Black build the ideal accepted-gambit center. e4 supports a useful space advantage.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the b1 knight, choose a safe bishop square, and castle. Be alert to ...Be7 breaking the pin before Black strikes centrally.

WATCH FOR

The f6 knight may become unpinned after ...Be7. Recalculate captures that relied on the pin.

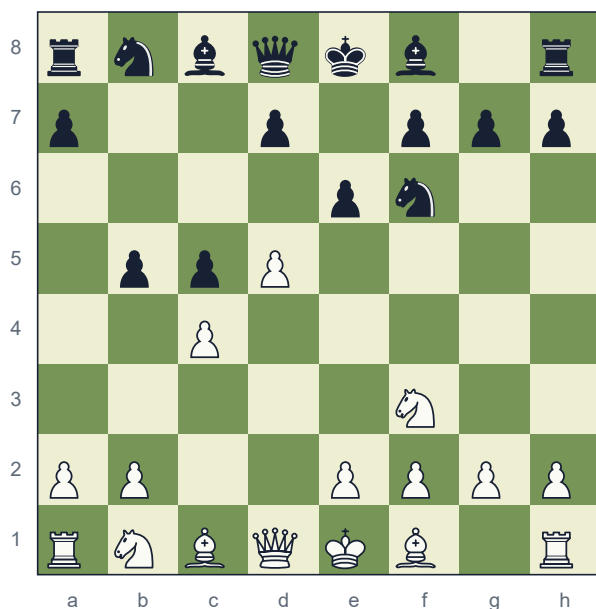
REMEMBER Prefer central control to a risky flank pawn.

05 Blumenfeld: Black develops ...Be7

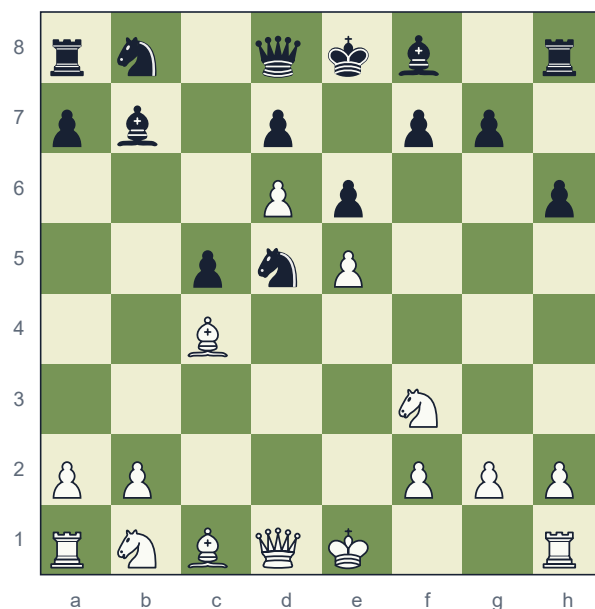
STUDY LINE 18-05

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. d5 b5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. d6 Bf8 7. e4 bxc4 8. e5 h6 9. Bc1 Nd5 10. Bxc4 Bb7

Selected anchor ends with 5... Be7. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black addresses the pin without fixing the central pawn structure. White must now choose how to complete development and handle the tension.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

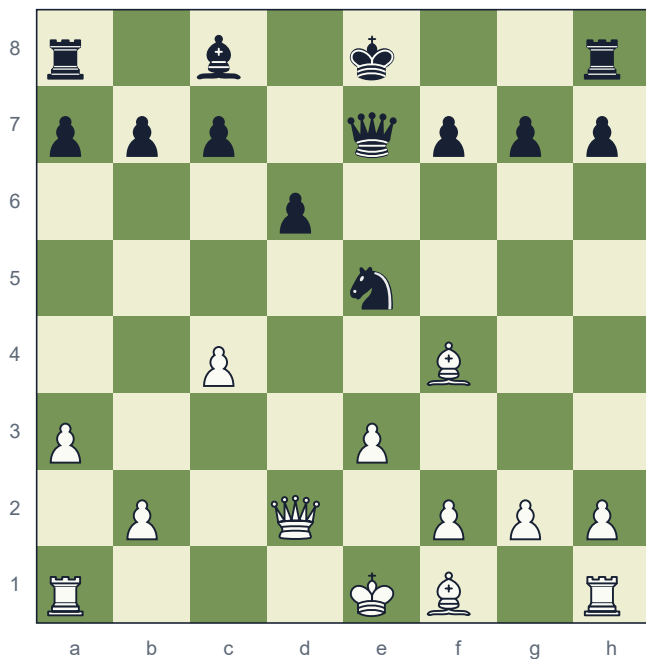
e3 or a central exchange may be appropriate. Check ...exd5 and ...bxc4 before making a quiet move.

WATCH FOR

Do not pretend the pin still prevents ...Nxd5 after the bishop has moved to e7.

REMEMBER Recount defenders whenever a pin is broken.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The Budapest uses piece activity to recover e5; the Blumenfeld offers a flank pawn to build a large central mass. These require different practical responses.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Budapest: ...Ng4, ...Nc6 and ...Bb4+. Fajarowicz: ...Ne4 and tactical queen/bishop activity. Blumenfeld: ...exd5 and central expansion if White spends time taking b5.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop Be2 or Bd3 and castle. The bishop pair or central space may offer lasting chances once the tactical phase ends.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

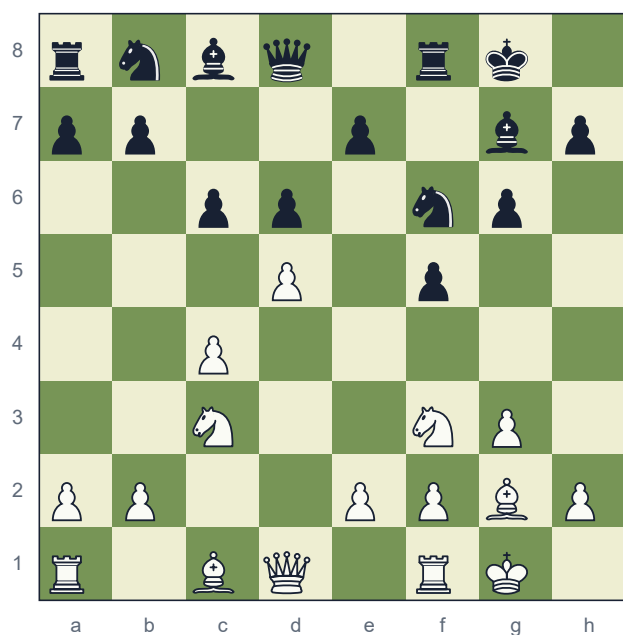
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Dutch Defense: defer c4 with 2.g3

1.d4 f5 2.g3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Choose a fianchetto against the Dutch and add c4 after your king is ready. This is a move-order preference; 2.c4 is also a sound move.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The f5 pawn controls e4 but weakens the king and e6/e5 complex. Black's choice of ...g6, ...e6/...d5, or ...e6/...d6 creates three different structures.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

The Leningrad uses a kingside fianchetto; the Stonewall locks d5-e6-f5; the Classical keeps ...d6 and seeks ...e5 or a kingside initiative.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Do not play the same middlegame plan against all Dutch structures.
2. e5 is a key square in the Stonewall; ...e5 is a key freeing break in other Dutch systems.
3. Trade or restrain attacking pieces before opening your king with pawn moves.

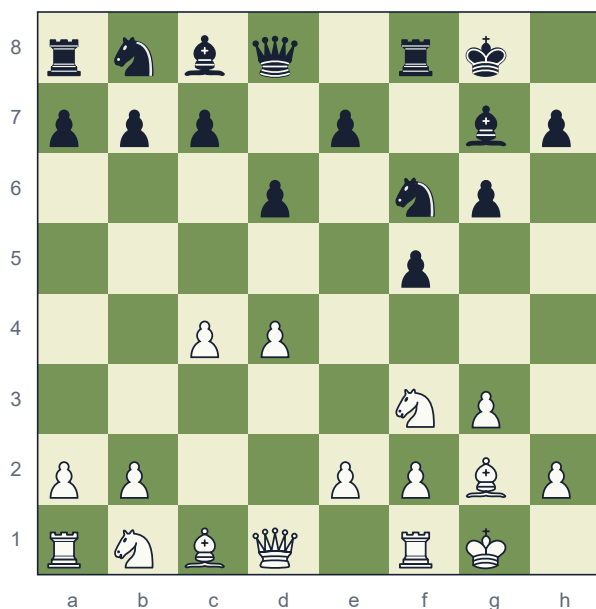
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Leningrad Dutch

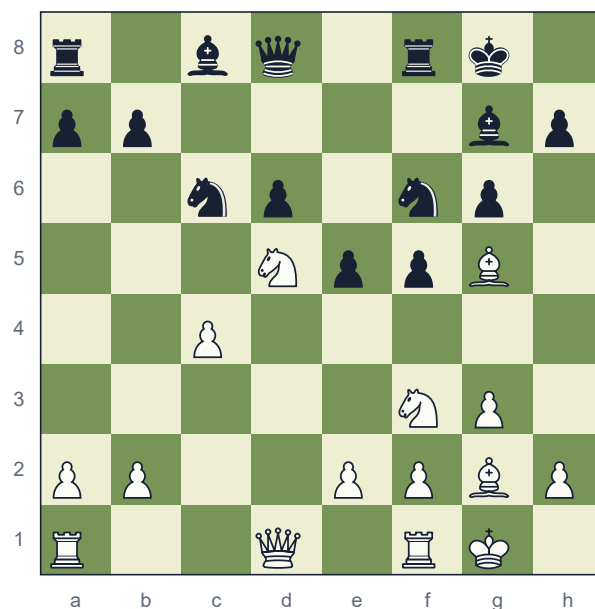
STUDY LINE 19-01

1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. O-O O-O 6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 c6 8. d5 cxd5 9. Nxd5 e5 10. Bg5 Nc6

Selected anchor ends with 8. d5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White castles before confronting the center. d5 gains space and asks how Black will organize ...e5.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Keep central control and watch ...Qe8 or ...Na6. A timely e4 can be strong, but its tactical support must be real.

WATCH FOR

The black f-pawn has already moved; opening the center may expose either king depending on development.

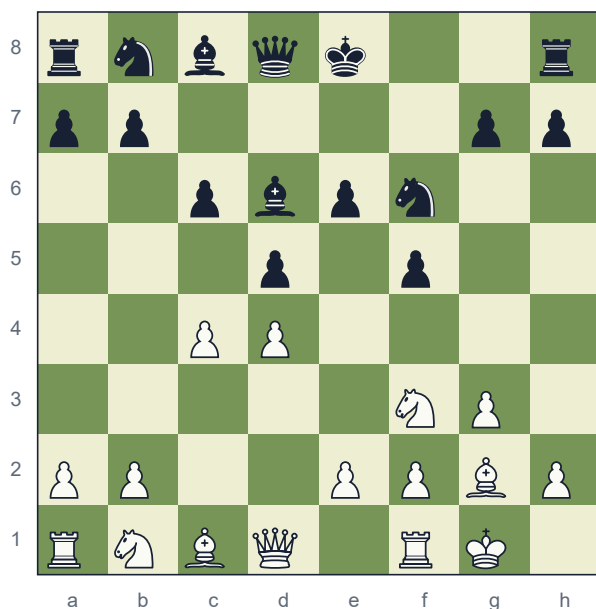
REMEMBER A secure king makes the central confrontation easier.

02 Stonewall and the Ba3 idea

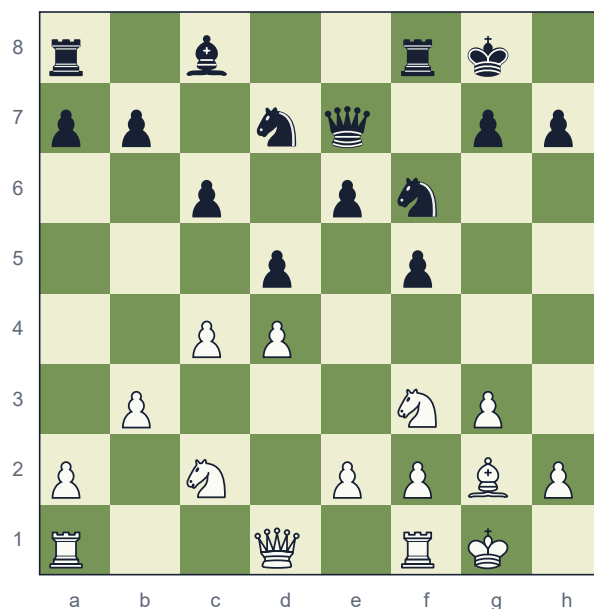
STUDY LINE 19-02

1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. Nf3 d5 5. O-O Bd6 6. c4 c6 7. b3 O-O 8. Ba3 Bxa3 9. Nxa3 Qe7 10. Nc2 Nbd7

Selected anchor ends with 9. Nxa3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Ba3 challenges the good d6 bishop. The knight recapture develops a piece that may head toward c2 and e5.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e5 as an outpost and improve the remaining bishop. Keep ...Ne4 and ...g5 under observation.

WATCH FOR

Do not put a knight on e5 if exchanging it would strengthen Black's attack or create a protected passed pawn.

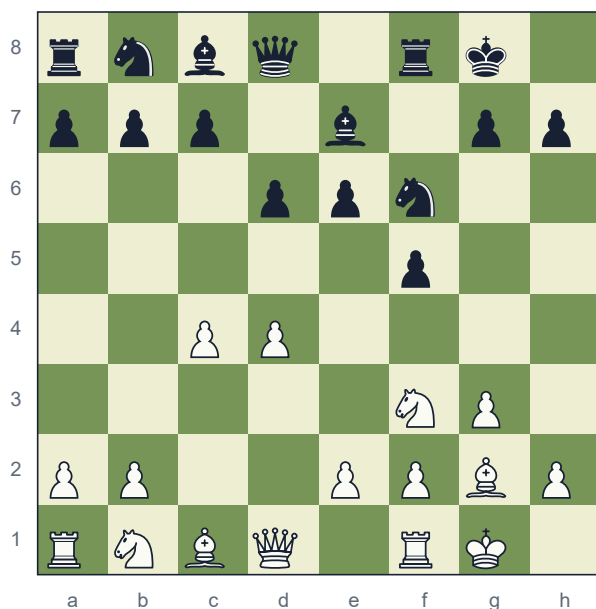
REMEMBER Exchange the good bishop and contest e5.

03 Classical Dutch

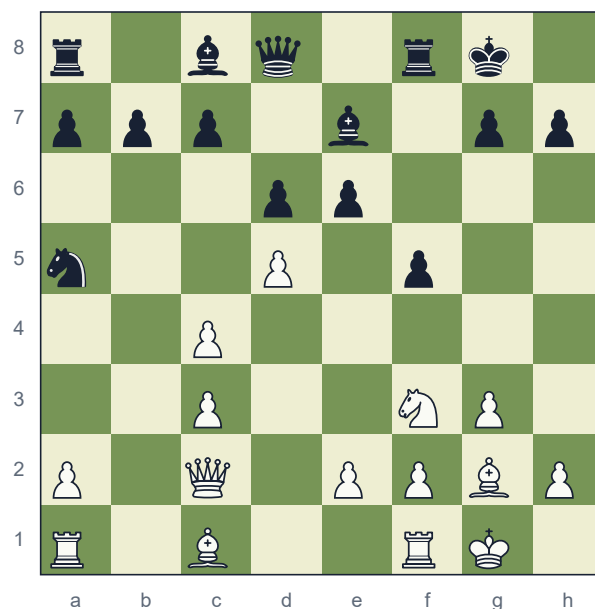
STUDY LINE 19-03

1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. O-O O-O 6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 Ne4 8. Qc2 Nxc3 9. bxc3 Nc6 10. d5 Na5

Selected anchor ends with 8. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Qc2 supports central play and questions the advanced knight. Black has a flexible center rather than a Stonewall.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Prepare e4 or improve the queen bishop. Meet kingside activity by acting in the center when it is sound.

WATCH FOR

Do not allow ...Nxc3 to damage your structure without considering the recapture and long diagonal.

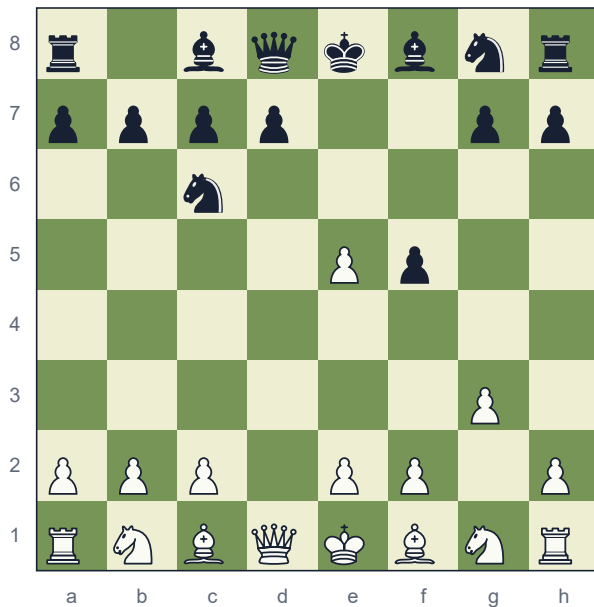
REMEMBER Use central play against a flank initiative.

04 Black tries an early ...e5

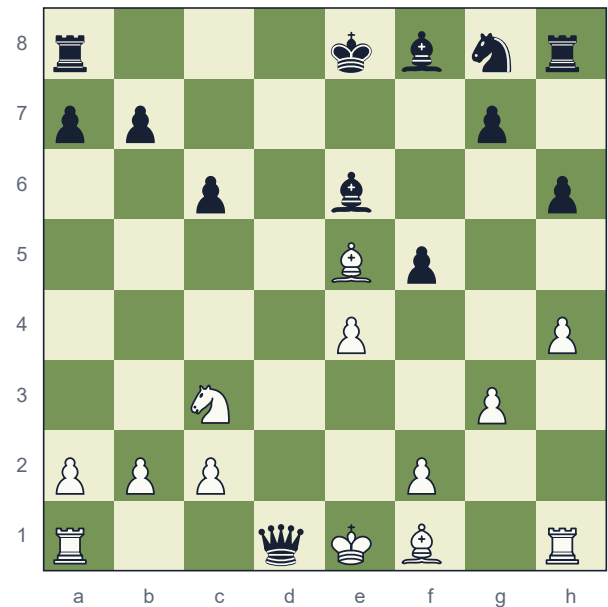
STUDY LINE 19-04

1. d4 f5 2. g3 e5 3. dxe5 Nc6 4. Nf3 d6 5. Bf4 h6 6. h4 Be6 7. Nc3 dxe5 8. Nxe5 Nxe5 9. Bxe5 c6 10. e4 Qxd1+

Selected anchor ends with 4. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 3 - White to move



End of study line - White to move - in check

WHY THESE MOVES

Accept the pawn and develop. Black's f-pawn move changes the central and king-safety calculation from an Englund Gambit.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

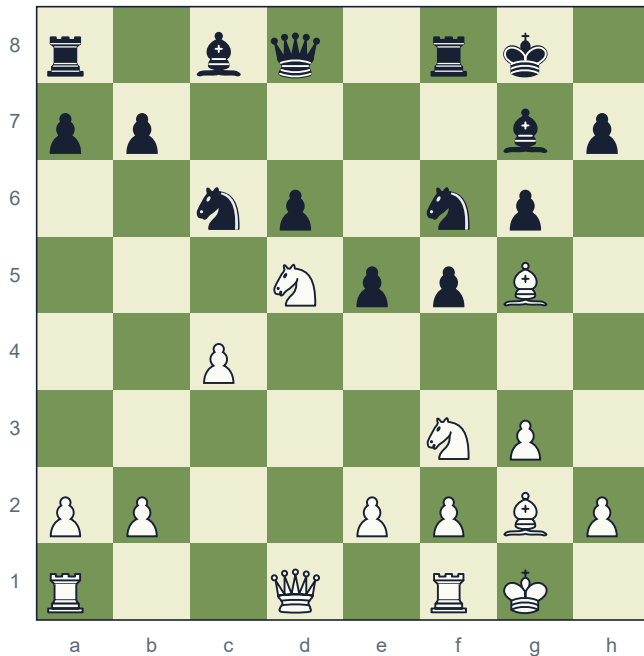
First answer the check shown in the final diagram. Bg2 and castling are the aims. Return a pawn if necessary to finish development and neutralize threats.

WATCH FOR

Do not spend tempi defending e5 with a chain of pawn moves while Black mobilizes.

REMEMBER Against an early gambit, development is your insurance.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The f5 pawn controls e4 but weakens the king and e6/e5 complex. Black's choice of ...g6, ...e6/...d5, or ...e6/...d6 creates three different structures.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

The Leningrad uses a kingside fianchetto; the Stonewall locks d5-e6-f5; the Classical keeps ...d6 and seeks ...e5 or a kingside initiative.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Keep central control and watch ...Qe8 or ...Na6. A timely e4 can be strong, but its tactical support must be real.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

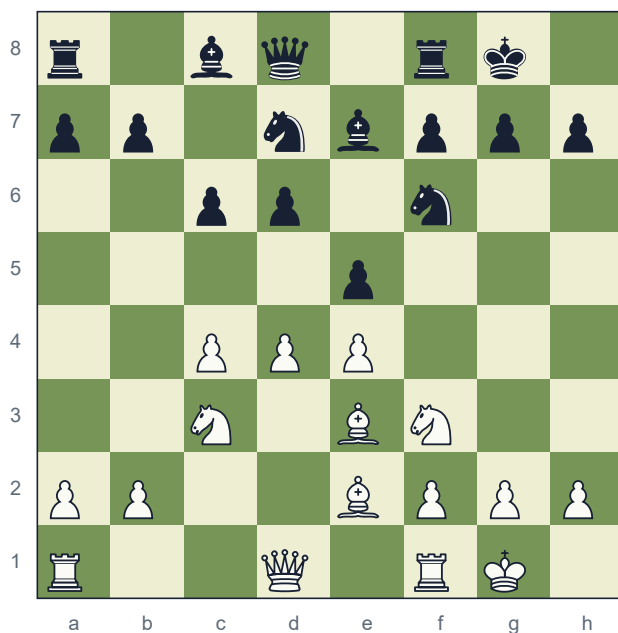
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Old Indian and Modern move orders

...d6, ...g6 and early ...Bg4

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Keep 2.c4 against ...d6 or ...g6 when you want to remain in this repertoire. Take central space, develop naturally, and identify whether Black finally chooses ...e5 or ...d5.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Black can postpone the knight development and choose among Indian structures. White should avoid committing to an inflexible setup too early.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

The Old Indian uses ...d6, ...Nf6 and ...e5 without a king-bishop fianchetto. The Modern may delay ...Nf6 and challenge the center in several ways.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. 2.c4 is sound against 1...d6 and 1...g6; these are not mandatory exceptions.
2. After a delayed ...d5, revisit the Grunfeld or QGD central tension rather than pushing e4 automatically.
3. If the c8 bishop reaches g4, account for exchanges on f3 before choosing your pawn structure.

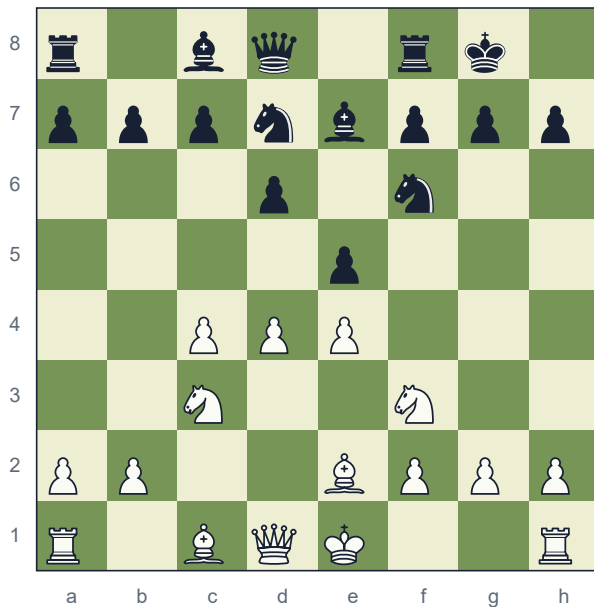
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Old Indian classical center

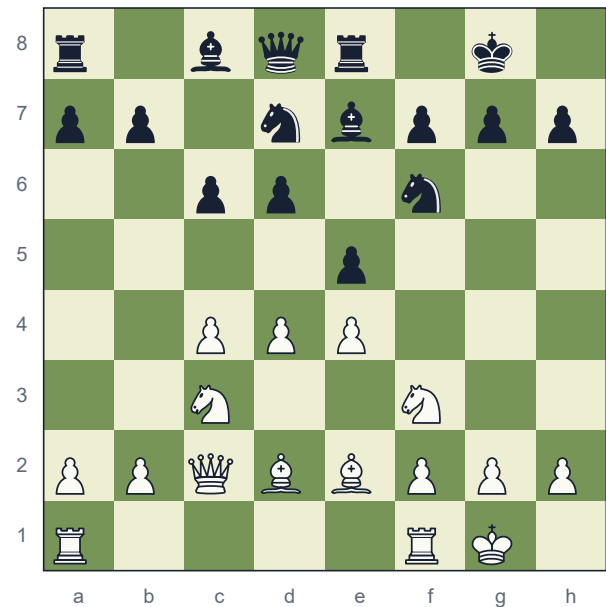
STUDY LINE 20-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 d6 3. Nc3 e5 4. Nf3 Nbd7 5. e4 Be7 6. Be2 O-O 7. O-O c6 8. Be3 Ng4 9. Bd2 Ngf6 10. Qc2 Re8

Selected anchor ends with 8. Be3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The broad center is supported by development. Black is compact and will seek a freeing pawn break.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use Qc2 and central rooks, or close with d5 if the timing is favorable. Watch ...exd4 and ...Re8 before pushing e5.

WATCH FOR

A space advantage can become overextension if your pieces cannot defend the advanced pawns.

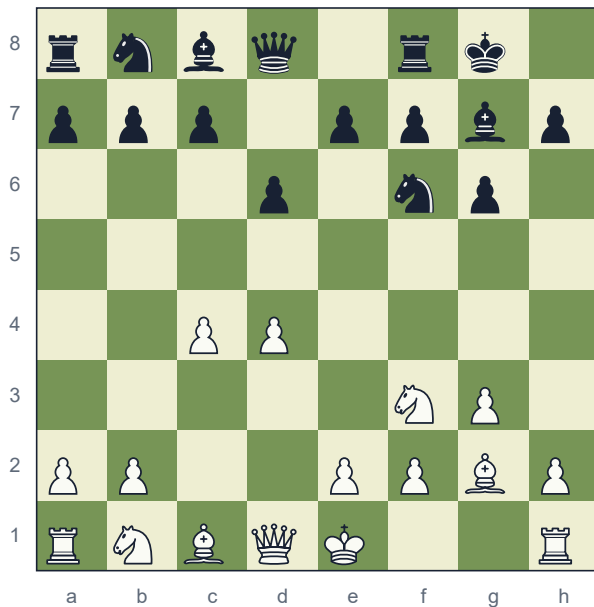
REMEMBER Occupy the center and keep it supported.

02 Modern: keep the c4 center

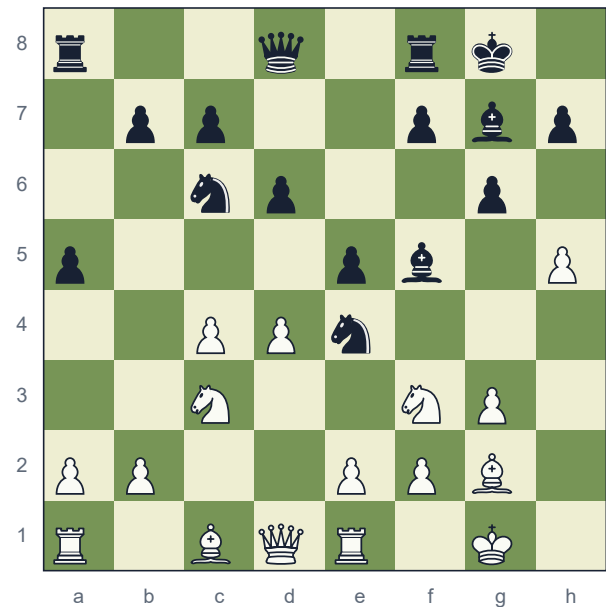
STUDY LINE 20-02

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nf3 d6 4. g3 Nf6 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O Bf5 7. Re1 a5 8. Nc3 Ne4 9. h4 Nc6 10. h5 e5

Selected anchor ends with 6. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The delayed knight move transposes to the fianchetto King's Indian. You have avoided introducing an unrelated e4-opening repertoire.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Nc3 and e4 are familiar goals. If Black instead chooses ...c5 or ...d5, consult the relevant central structure.

WATCH FOR

Do not assign an opening name before Black has committed the central pawns.

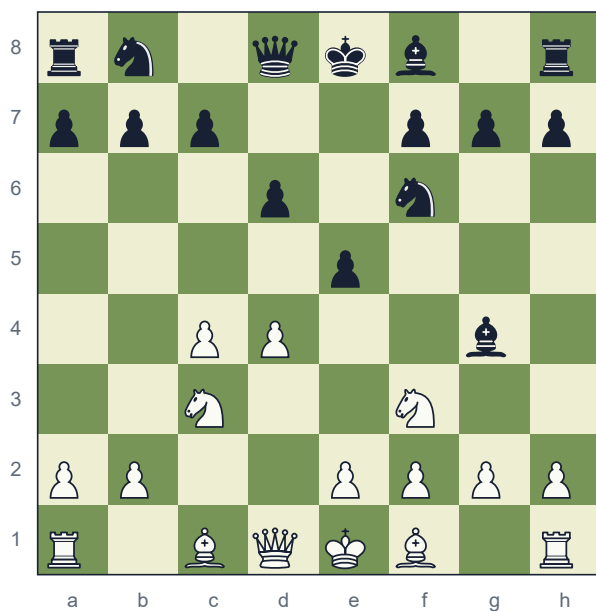
REMEMBER Wait for the central commitment before choosing the plan.

03 ...d6 and ...Bg4

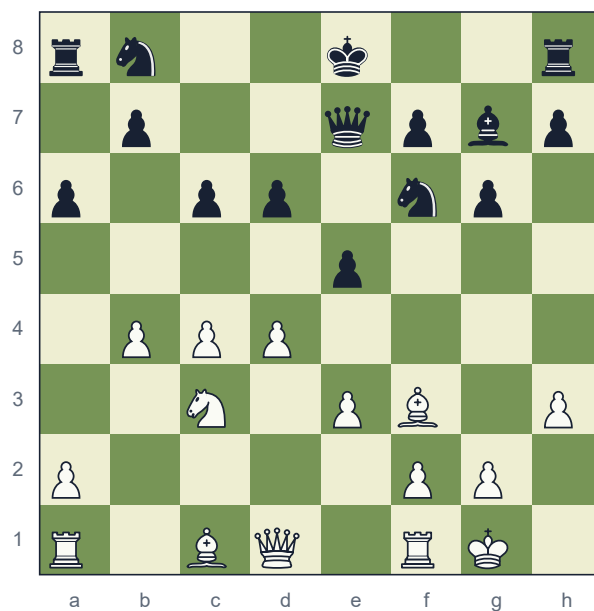
STUDY LINE 20-03

1. d4 d6 2. c4 Nf6 3. Nc3 e5 4. Nf3 Bg4 5. e3 Qe7 6. Be2 g6 7. h3 Bxf3 8. Bxf3 c6 9. O-O Bg7 10. b4 a6

Selected anchor ends with 5. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e3 maintains a flexible center and opens the f1 bishop. The pin deserves attention, but it does not require an immediate pawn chase.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Be2 or Bd3 and castle. Challenge the center or bishop only after counting tactical captures.

WATCH FOR

If ...Bxf3 doubles your pawns, assess king safety before accepting the structural damage.

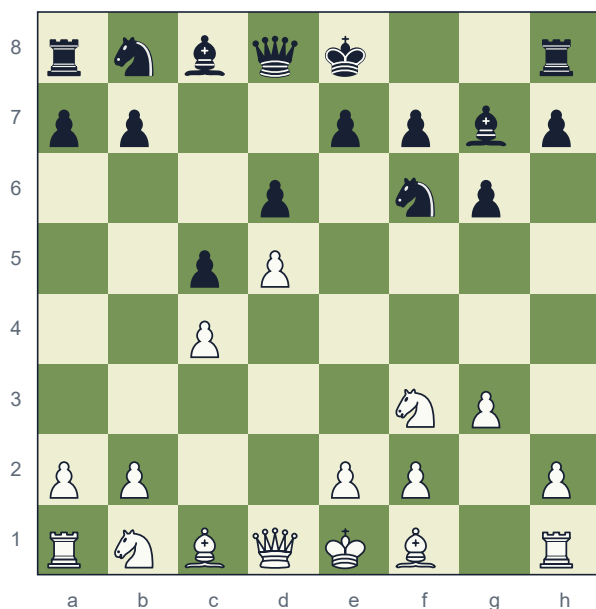
REMEMBER Develop through the pin and preserve options.

04 Modern with ...c5 before ...Nf6

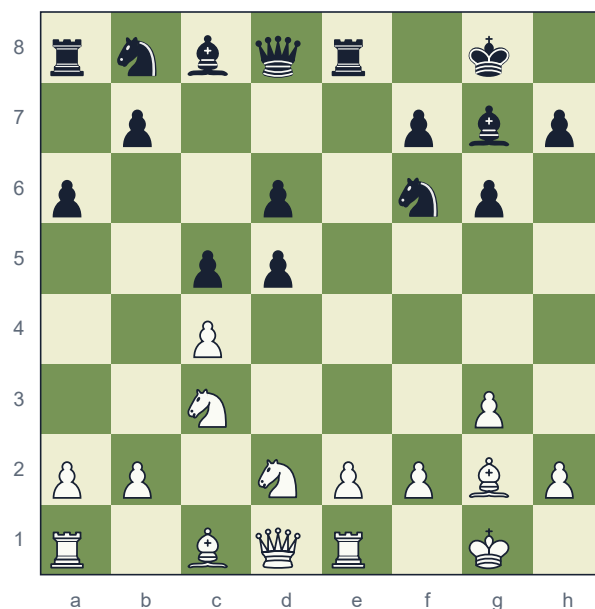
STUDY LINE 20-04

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nf3 c5 4. d5 d6 5. g3 Nf6 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O Re8 8. Re1 a6 9. Nc3 e6 10. Nd2 exd5

Selected anchor ends with 6... O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

d5 gains space and leads to a Benoni-like structure without requiring the standard ...e6 exchange immediately.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

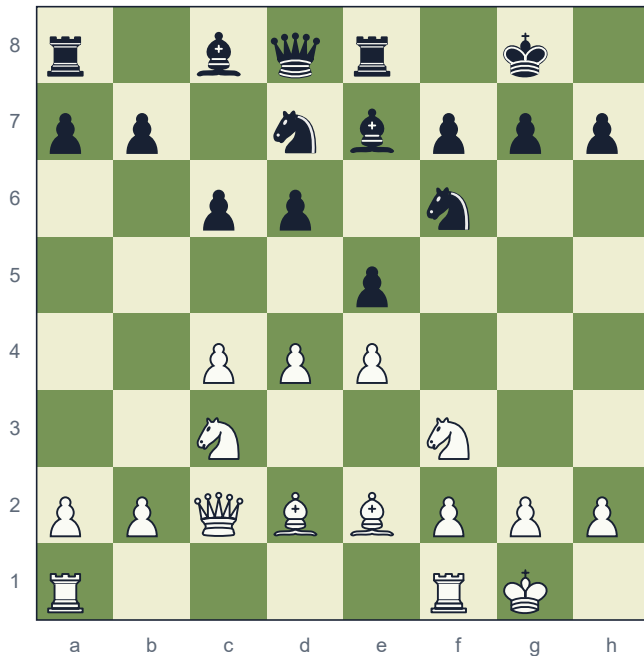
Castle, develop Nc3 and consider e4. Black's ...e6 and ...b5 breaks must be monitored.

WATCH FOR

Without an exchange on d5, the pawn structure differs from the Modern Benoni main line. Reassess before using a memorized plan.

REMEMBER Similar piece placement does not guarantee the same structure.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Black can postpone the knight development and choose among Indian structures. White should avoid committing to an inflexible setup too early.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

The Old Indian uses ...d6, ...Nf6 and ...e5 without a king-bishop fianchetto. The Modern may delay ...Nf6 and challenge the center in several ways.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Use Qc2 and central rooks, or close with d5 if the timing is favorable. Watch ...exd4 and ...Re8 before pushing e5.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

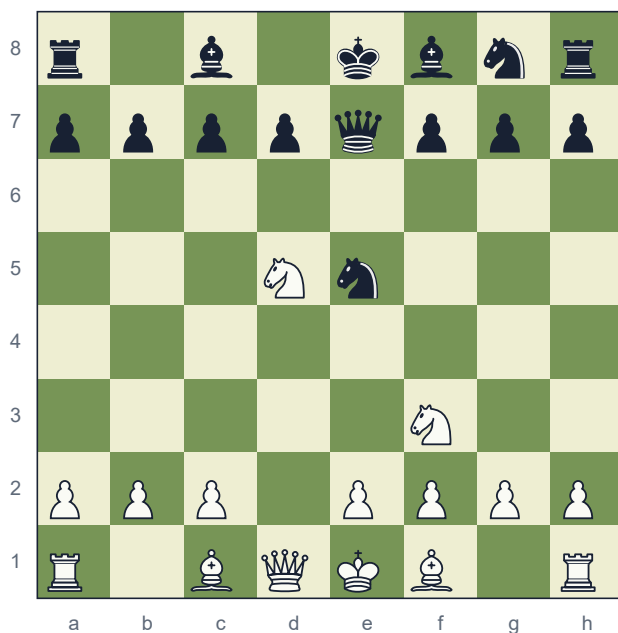
Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

When c4 waits: Englund and unusual first moves

1.d4 e5, 1...c5, 1...Nc6, 1...b6 and 1...b5

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Respond to what Black has actually offered. Against a direct attack on d4 or a free central pawn, a central capture or advance can be more useful than automatic c4.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

These first moves may produce an open center, a closed Benoni, or a broad d4-e4 center. c4 remains a tool you can add later when it improves the position.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Unusual openings often rely on traps, an unfamiliar pawn structure, or a developing move gained by attacking an exposed queen.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. After 1...e5, choose 2.dxe5 rather than drifting into a needless pawn sacrifice with 2.c4.
2. After 1...c5, 2.d5 is the practical course choice; 2.c4 is not inherently losing.
3. Against ...b6 or ...b5, e4 takes offered central space; against ...e6 or ...c6, c4 remains a normal sound choice.

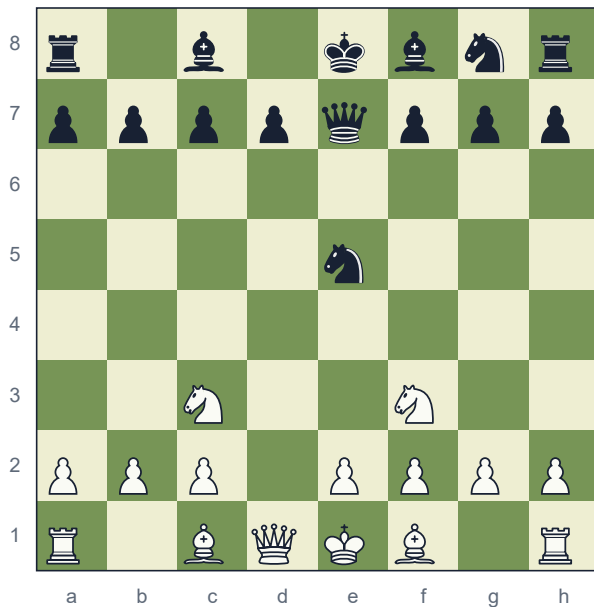
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Englund: develop against ...Qe7

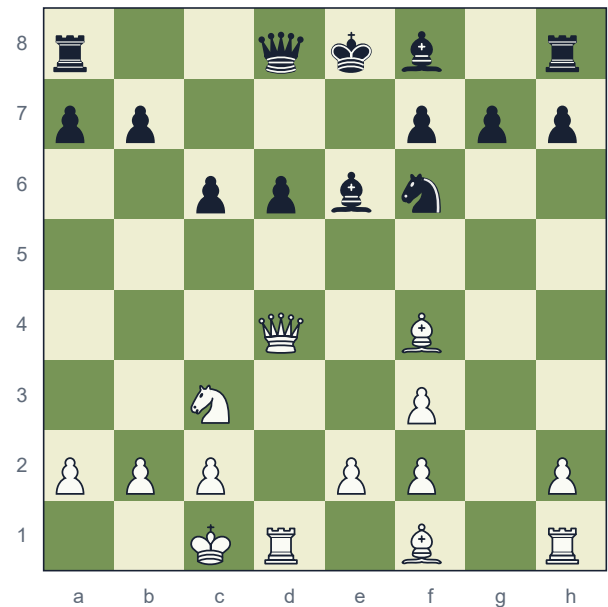
STUDY LINE 21-01

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 Qe7 4. Nc3 Nxe5 5. Nd5 Nxf3+ 6. gxf3 Qd8 7. Bf4 d6 8. Qd4 c6 9. Nc3 Be6 10. O-O-O Nf6

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nd5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Nc3 develops while defending the center. After ...Nxe5, Nd5 attacks the queen with tempo and disrupts Black's intended setup.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Continue with useful developing moves and keep the king safe. If Black exchanges on f3 with check, recapture accurately and reevaluate the structure.

WATCH FOR

Do not play Bf4 and Qd2 mechanically against queen checks on b4. The queen's path and the b2 pawn matter.

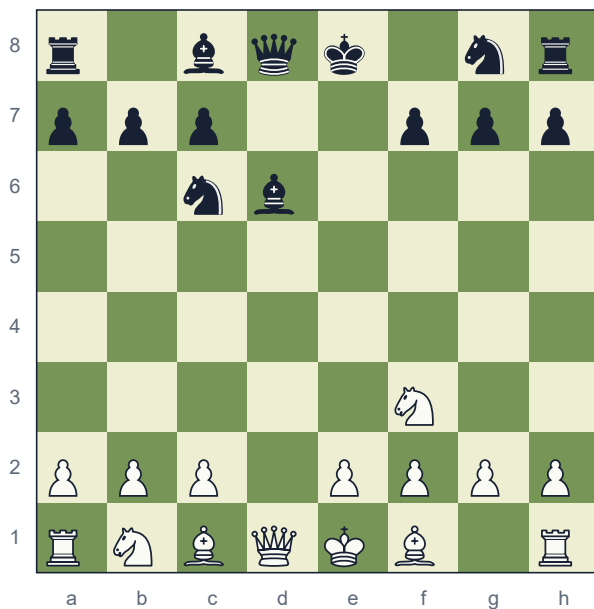
REMEMBER Meet the queen sortie with development and tempo.

02 Englund: the ...d6 gambit

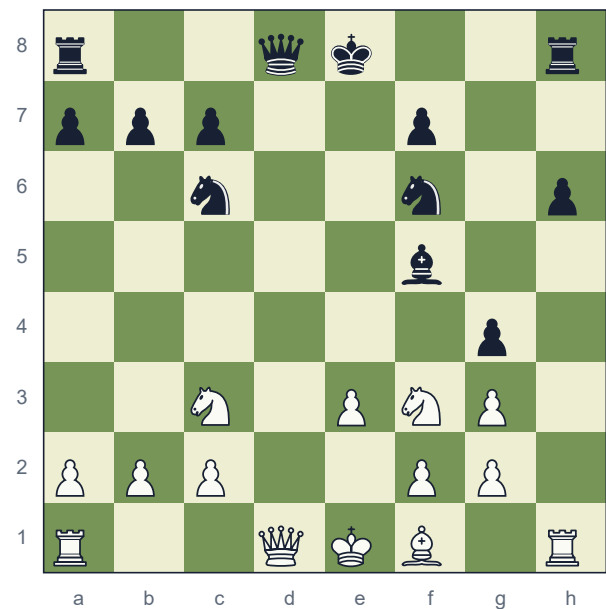
STUDY LINE 21-02

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 d6 4. exd6 Bxd6 5. Nc3 Nf6 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 Bf5 8. e3 g5 9. Bg3 Bxg3 10. hxg3 g4

Selected anchor ends with 5... Nf6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White accepts material but helps Black develop a bishop. Your response must be efficient development, not further pawn collecting.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bg5, e3 and king safety are natural aims. Return a pawn if it removes an initiative or opens a useful line for your pieces.

WATCH FOR

A knight move to e4 can come with threats against both bishops and central squares.

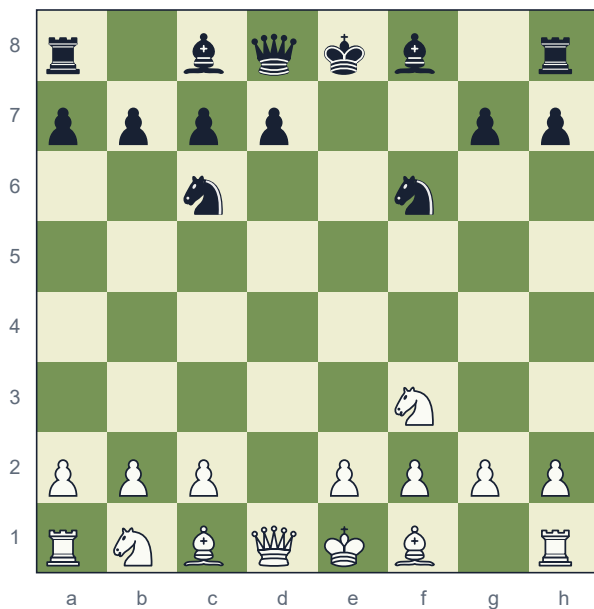
REMEMBER A gambit is answered with coordination as well as material.

03 Englund: the ...f6 gambit

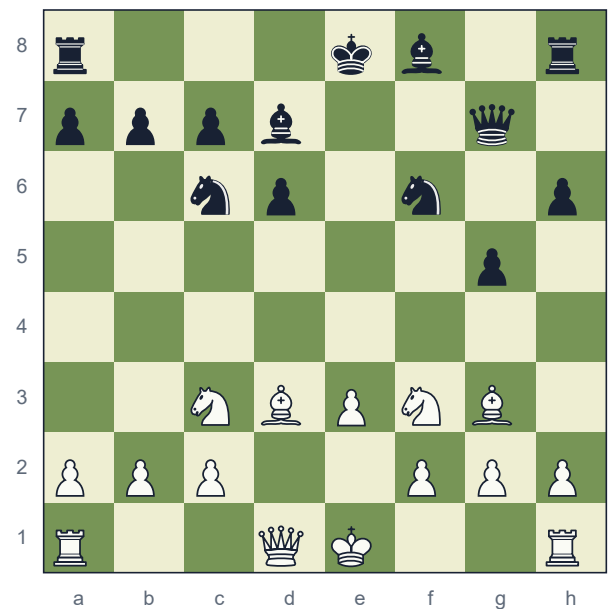
STUDY LINE 21-03

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 f6 4. exf6 Nxf6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 g5 7. Bg3 Qe7 8. e3 d6 9. Bd3 Qg7 10. Nc3 Bd7

Selected anchor ends with 5. Bg5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The f-pawn exchange leaves Black with an exposed king structure. Bg5 develops and increases pressure against f6.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e3, develop the bishops and castle. Look for central opening moves only when your pieces can use them.

WATCH FOR

Do not launch a queen raid before bringing out the rest of your pieces.

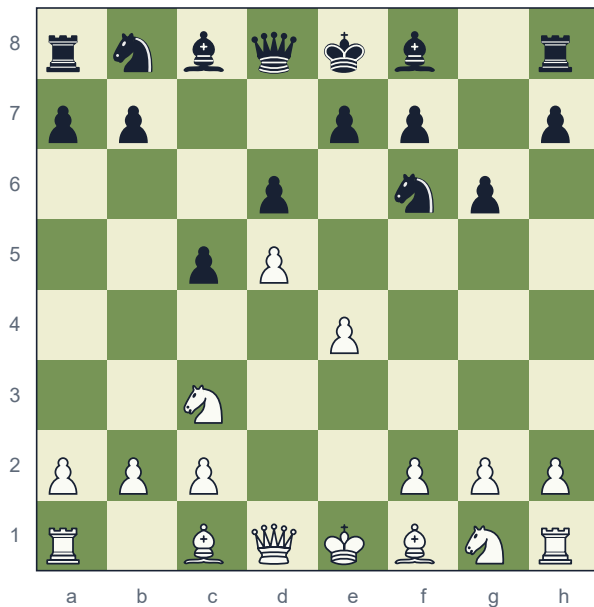
REMEMBER Use the weakened king structure through development.

04 1...c5: advance before playing c4

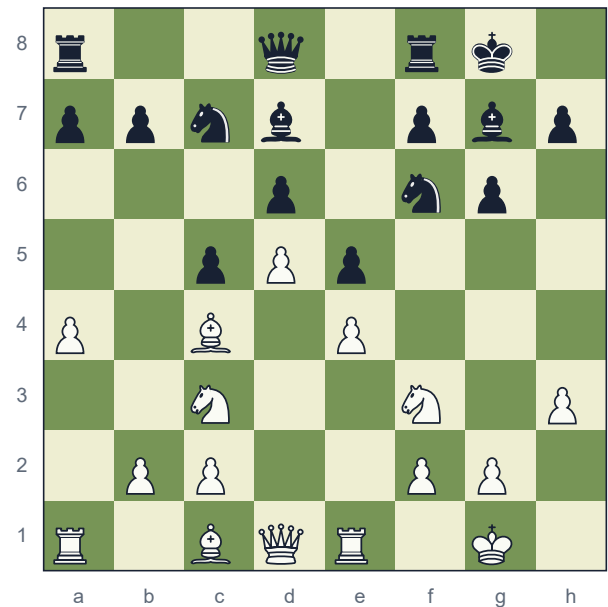
STUDY LINE 21-04

1. d4 c5 2. d5 Nf6 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 g6 5. Nf3 Bg7 6. Bc4 O-O 7. O-O Na6 8. h3 Nc7 9. Re1 Bd7 10. a4 e5

Selected anchor ends with 5... Bg7. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

d5 claims space immediately. Nc3 and e4 build the center; you are not required to add c4 to justify playing 1.d4.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Be2 and castle, or use another coherent king setup. If you later play c4, check whether it restricts useful knight routes.

WATCH FOR

Do not confuse a recommended practical move order with a statement that 2.c4 is a mistake.

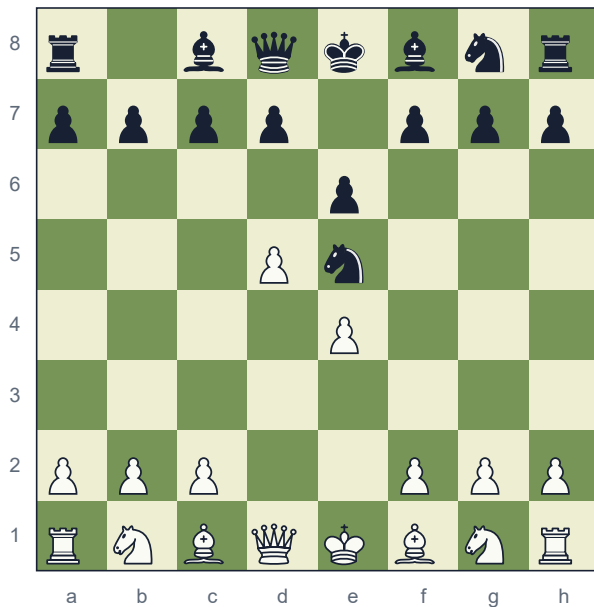
REMEMBER Take the offered space and build behind it.

05 1...Nc6: gain space with d5

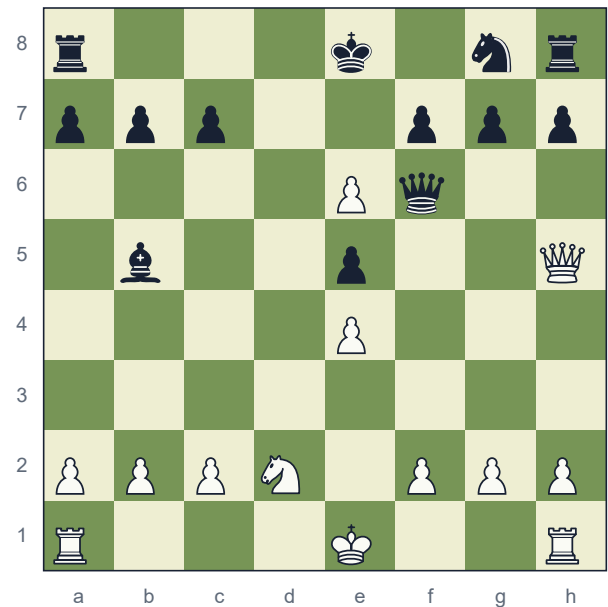
STUDY LINE 21-05

1. d4 Nc6 2. d5 Ne5 3. e4 e6 4. Nf3 d6 5. Nxe5 dxe5 6. Bb5+ Bd7 7. dxe6 Bxb5 8. Qh5 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Nxd2 Qf6

Selected anchor ends with 4. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 3 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

d5 gains time against the knight and e4 supports a broad center. Nf3 develops rather than using too many pawn moves to chase the knight.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the bishops and castle. Exchange centrally if that improves activity or reduces the chance of overextension.

WATCH FOR

A sequence of f-pawn and g-pawn pushes can expose the king while Black catches up in development.

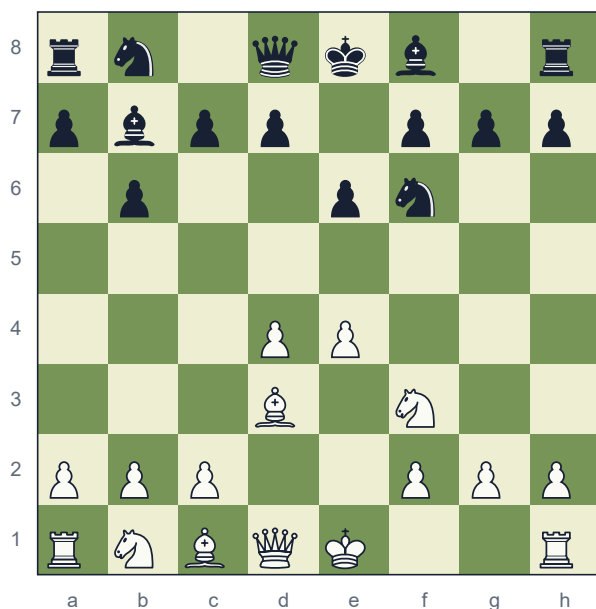
REMEMBER Gain space once, then develop.

06 1...b6: take e4

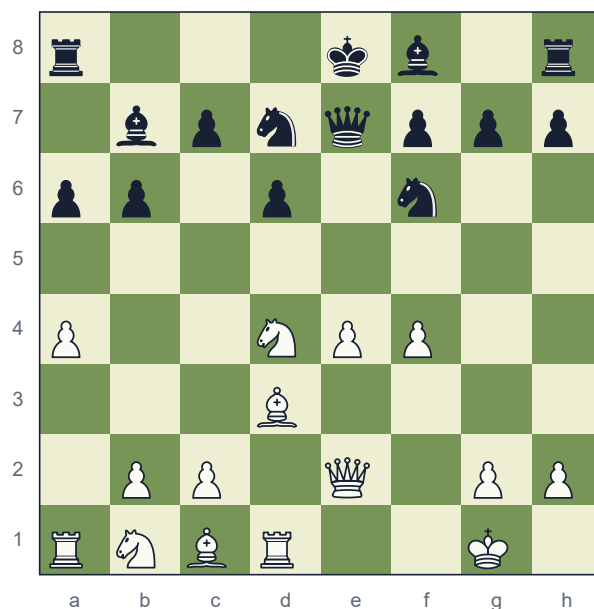
STUDY LINE 21-06

1. d4 b6 2. e4 Bb7 3. Bd3 e6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Qe2 d6 6. O-O Nbd7 7. Rd1 e5 8. a4 exd4 9. Nxd4 a6 10. f4 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 5. Qe2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e4 uses the central space Black offered; Bd3 and Qe2 support it against the b7 bishop and f6 knight.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Castle and develop the b1 knight without blocking the pieces you need. Be ready for ...c5 or ...d5.

WATCH FOR

The bishop on b7 is already aimed at e4. Support the pawn before spending tempi on the flanks.

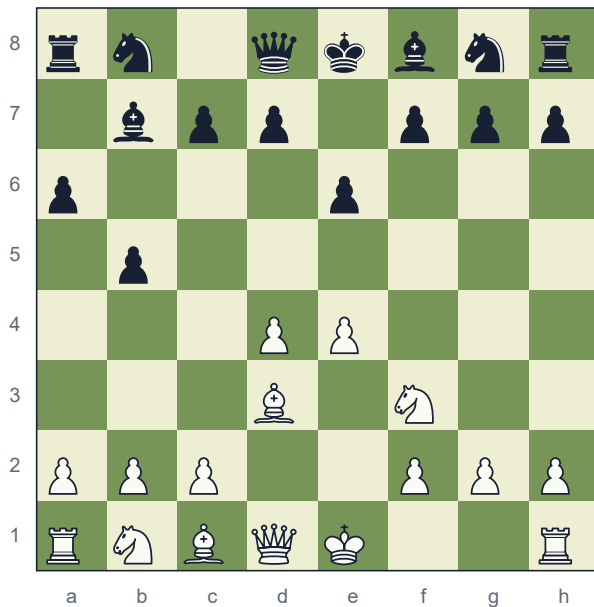
REMEMBER Take the center, then defend it with pieces.

07 1...b5: center before flank action

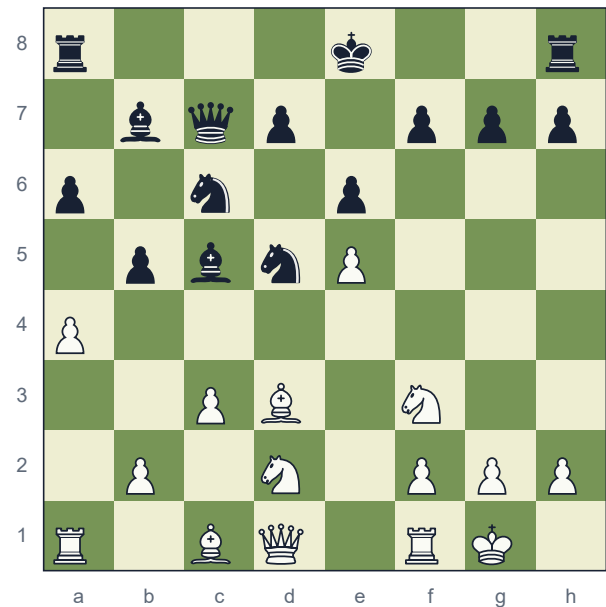
STUDY LINE 21-07

1. d4 b5 2. e4 Bb7 3. Bd3 a6 4. Nf3 e6 5. O-O c5 6. c3 Nf6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. e5 Nd5 9. Nbd2 Nc6 10. a4 Qc7

Selected anchor ends with 5. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White occupies the center while Black expands on the flank. The b5 pawn does not have to be attacked immediately.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

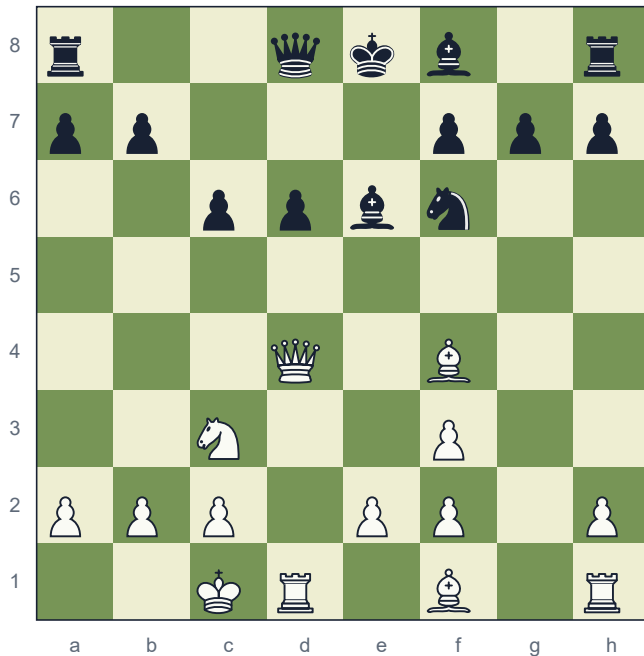
Develop Nc3 or Nbd2 as appropriate, then use a4 or central action if it improves your position.

WATCH FOR

Do not trade useful central pawns simply to win a flank pawn that cannot be held.

REMEMBER A flank opening is often answered in the center.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

These first moves may produce an open center, a closed Benoni, or a broad d4-e4 center. c4 remains a tool you can add later when it improves the position.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Unusual openings often rely on traps, an unfamiliar pawn structure, or a developing move gained by attacking an exposed queen.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Continue with useful developing moves and keep the king safe. If Black exchanges on f3 with check, recapture accurately and reevaluate the structure.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.

Read the pawns before choosing a plan

START WITH THE CENTRAL PAWN SKELETON

Name which pawns can challenge each other. Identify half-open files, outposts and likely breaks. Then check whether piece placement makes the strategic plan tactically possible.

A STRUCTURAL TARGET IS NOT AUTOMATICALLY WEAK

A pawn can be isolated but active, backward but tactically defended, or doubled while supporting important central squares. Evaluate the pieces and king safety alongside the pawn labels.

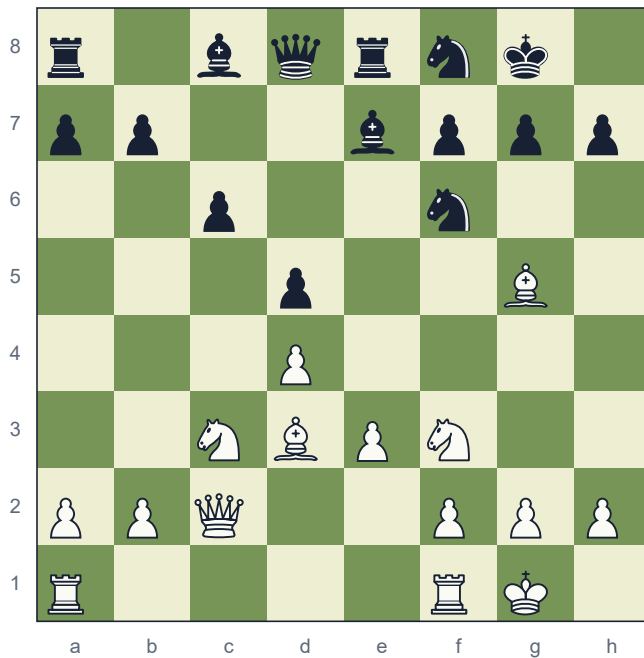
QUESTIONS FOR EVERY POSITION

What is my least active piece? What does Black want next? Which pawn break improves my position? Which trade helps the opponent? What forcing move could invalidate my plan?

USE THIS BOOKLET IN BOTH COLORS

Practicing the Black side of your chosen White structures teaches you the counterplay. A repertoire becomes more reliable when you understand the opponent's best idea.

Carlsbad and the minority attack



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The c-file is half-open for White and the black c6 pawn can become a target after b4-b5. Your queenside minority tries to create a weakness, not a passed pawn immediately.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Coordinate a rook on b1 or c1, prepare b4, and assess b5. If ...cxb5, examine the isolated d-pawn or weak c-file squares; if ...c5, recalculate the central structure.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks ...Ne4, kingside activity and the freeing ...c5. If those threats are urgent, a slow pawn plan may be too slow.

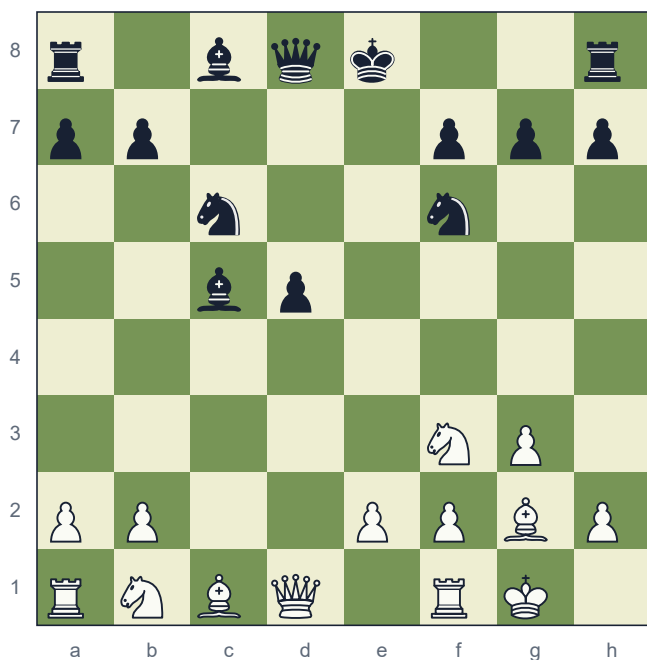
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which piece needs improvement before b4? What exact pawn weakness would b5 create?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Playing against an isolated queen pawn



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

Black's d-pawn has no friendly c- or e-pawn to support it. It controls central squares, so it is not simply a free target.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Restrain its advance, blockade with a suitable piece, and exchange active attacking pieces when favorable. Attack the pawn only after your king and pieces are coordinated.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black wants ...d4 or an initiative before the position simplifies. A poorly timed pawn capture can release all of Black's pieces.

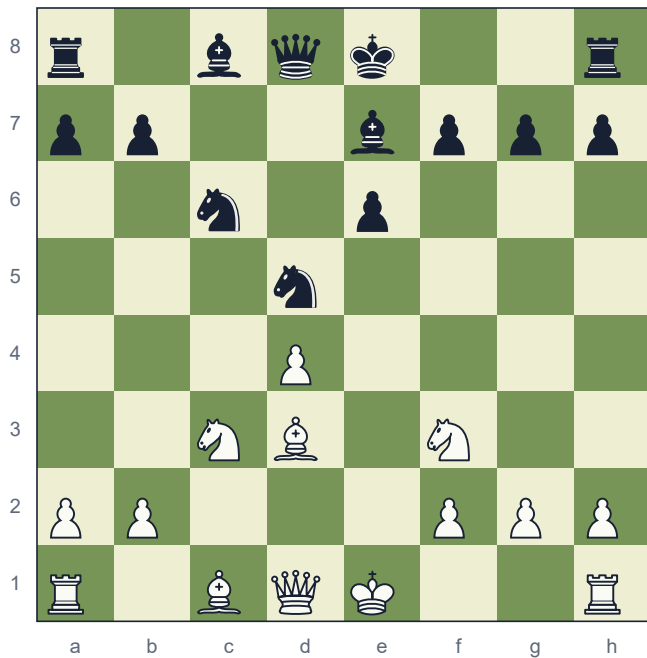
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which square is directly in front of the isolated pawn? Can you occupy it safely?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Playing with an isolated queen pawn



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

White has an isolated d4 pawn and open central lines. The pawn offers space and activity but can become an endgame burden.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Use active bishops and rooks, keep useful attacking pieces, and prepare d5 if it opens the position favorably. Make the opponent defend threats before they can blockade.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black wants a stable blockade and favorable piece exchanges. Avoid trading into a passive ending simply because it reduces the material.

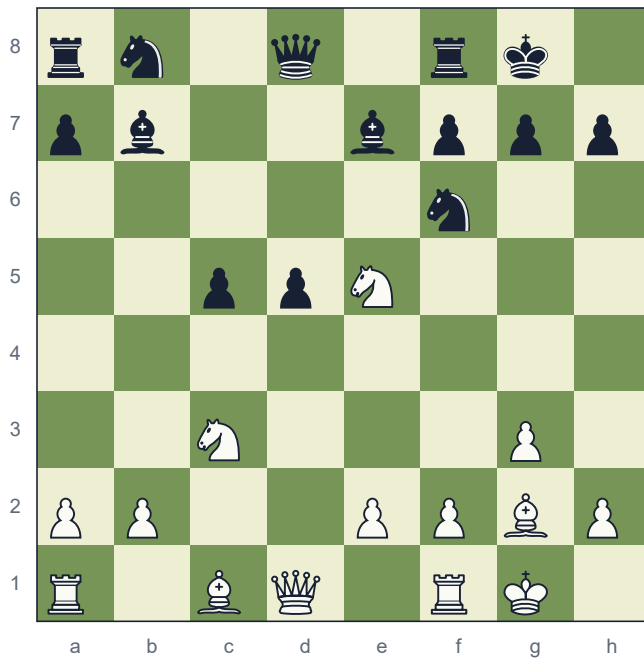
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which trade favors the blockader? What would have to change for d5 to work?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Hanging pawns: c5 and d5



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The adjacent black c5 and d5 pawns lack friendly pawns on the neighboring outer files. Together they control useful central squares; after one advances, the other may become weak.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

For the side facing them, pressure both pawns and provoke a concession without allowing a strong advance. For the side owning them, keep activity and choose the right moment to push.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

One careless exchange can turn the pair into a strong passed pawn rather than a weakness. Calculate recaptures before celebrating a structural target.

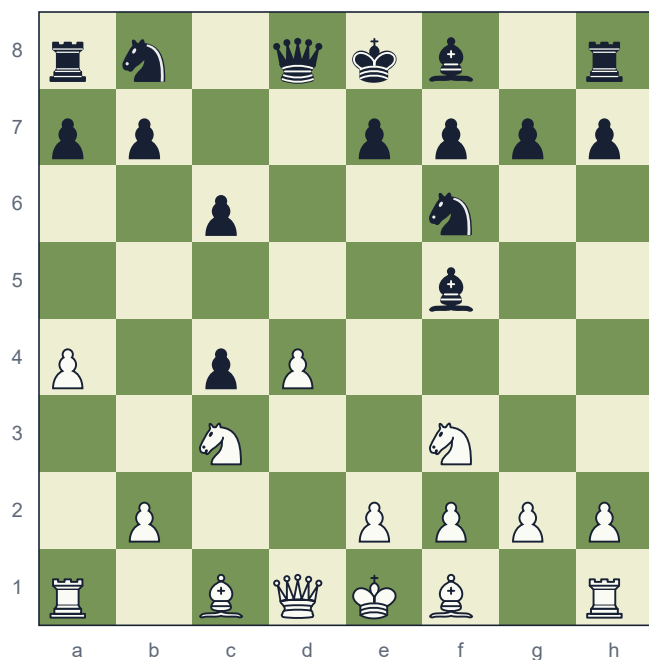
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

If ...d4 is played, which square and pawn become vulnerable?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Slav: the captured c4 pawn



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

Black has captured on c4 and White has played a4. The immediate structural battle concerns whether ...b5 can hold the extra pawn.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Develop e3 and Bxc4 when safe. Do not replace useful development with queen moves just to regain the pawn one move sooner.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black can counter in the center while you recover c4. The later e4 break must be supported against pins and exchanges.

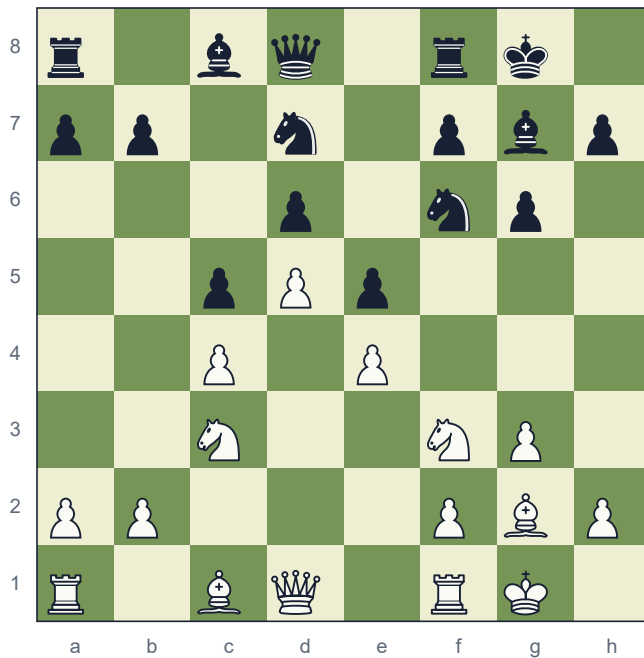
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Why does a4 matter here? Which move opens the bishop that can recover c4?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

The locked Indian center



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

White's d5 and e4 pawns face Black's d6 and e5 pawns. The center is closed, but pawn breaks can reopen it.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Improve the least active minor piece and identify a useful break. Queenside space is valuable only if it creates entry squares or targets. Keep the fianchetto bishop's defensive role in mind.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black can prepare kingside activity or queenside breaks. The exact knight placements decide whether ...f5 or ...b5 is feasible.

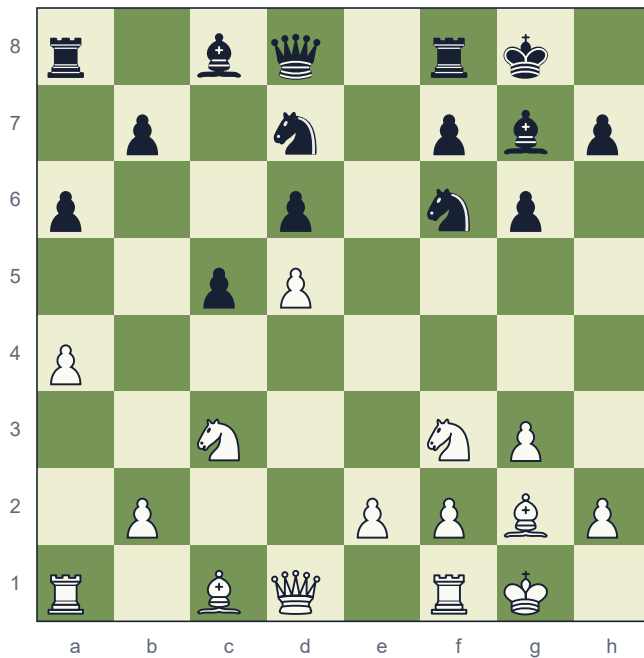
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which pawn break is realistic for each side? Which knight has the clearest route to a better square?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Modern Benoni: central space versus ...b5



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

White's d5 pawn cramps Black. Black has a queenside majority and a potentially weak d6 pawn, compensated by active diagonals and files.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Restrain ...b5 when useful, develop, and prepare e4-e5. Watch whether exchanging a key bishop would weaken your control of central squares.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks ...b5, ...Re8 and pressure against the center. The d6 pawn is rarely won by a single unsupported attack.

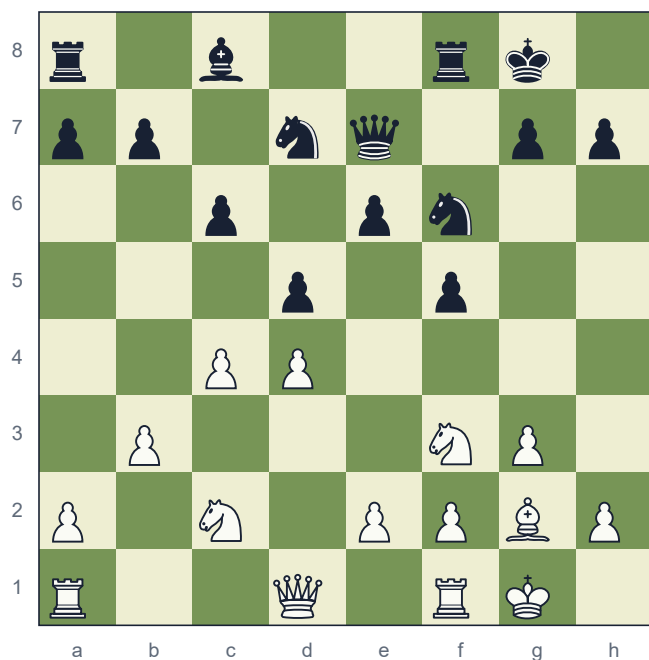
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Does a4 stop ...b5 permanently or only make it harder? What supports an eventual e5 break?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Dutch Stonewall: the e5 square



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The d5-e6-f5 chain gives Black space and restrains e4, but it leaves e5 as a potential white outpost and limits the c8 bishop.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Challenge the good dark-squared bishop where possible. Maneuver a knight toward e5 only when the exchange consequences are favorable. Use patient piece improvement.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks ...Ne4 and attacking chances near your king. Do not create targets with unnecessary kingside pawn moves.

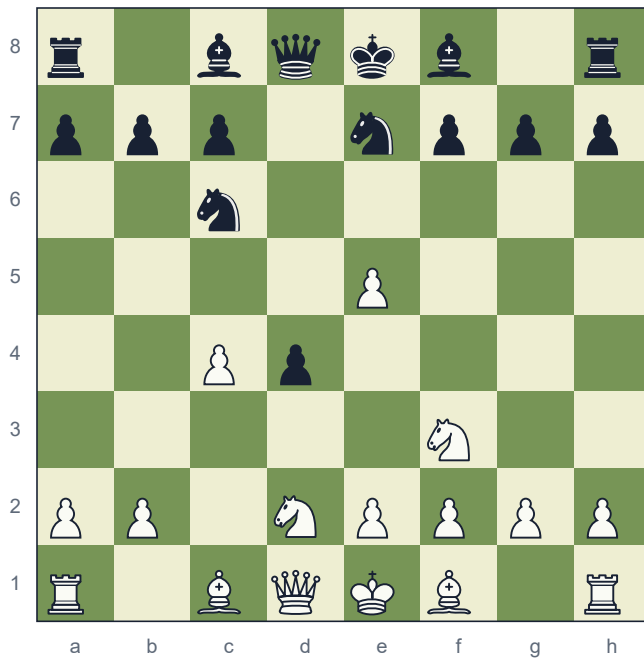
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which bishop would Black most like to improve? Which trade reduces the attack?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Albin: the advanced d4 wedge



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

The d4 pawn limits your pieces and creates tactics on e3 and along the d-file. White's extra e5 pawn does not remove those threats.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Nbd2-b3 targets d4. Address pins first, and return material if needed to simplify safely. Know the en-passant detail in the e4 line.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black seeks fast development, ...Bg4, and attacks while your king is central. Greedy bishop captures can allow a dangerous passed pawn.

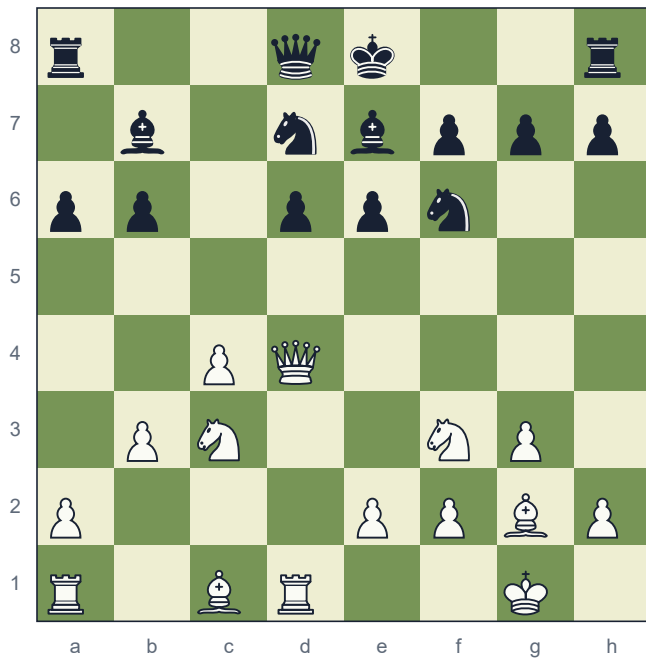
WRITE YOUR ANSWER

What does Nb3 attack? Why is e3 tactically different from a quiet QGD e3 move?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

Hedgehog: respect the freeing break



Training position - White to move

READ THE POSITION

Black keeps pawns on a6, b6, d6 and e6 behind compact pieces. White has more space, but that space can become vulnerable if overextended.

WHITE'S USEFUL PLAN

Improve pieces and watch ...b5 and ...d5. Do not attack a compact position by creating more weak pawns than targets.

COUNTERPLAY TO RESPECT

Black waits for a central or queenside break that activates several pieces at once. A quiet move may be a tactical preparation.

WRITE YOUR ANSWER

Which break would free Black's position? Can it be prevented usefully, or should you prepare to meet it?

PRACTICE METHOD

Choose two plausible moves. Calculate one forcing reply to each, then explain which move improves your least active piece or prepares the relevant pawn break. Compare your answer with the plan above, not just with a numerical evaluation.

From a memorized line to a played position

THESE ARE TRAINING CONTINUATIONS

The eight continuations begin at selected course study positions. Stockfish 18 supplies legal, checked sample play through roughly move twenty. They are not historical games, forced variations or a promise of how your opponents will respond.

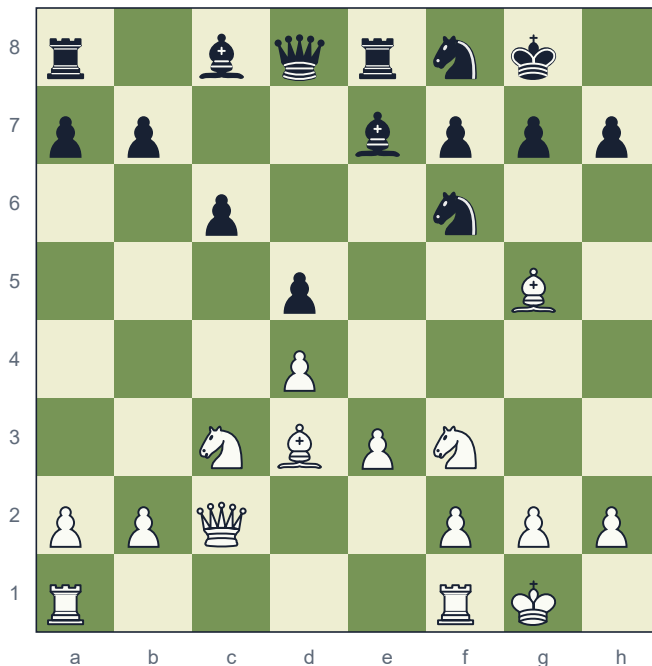
YOUR TASK BEFORE READING

Set up the move-ten position. Write the pawn structure, Black's intended break, your least active piece and two candidate moves. Spend at least five minutes before revealing the sample continuation.

DO NOT MEMORIZE THE LABORATORY

Compare the sample play with the strategic questions. If the engine chooses a move you cannot explain, inspect its concrete reply before adding it to your repertoire. Use the accompanying PGN to move through the line slowly.

Queen's Gambit Declined: the Exchange / start



After the opening study line - White to move

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Complete development with a rook on b1 or c1 according to Black's setup. Prepare b4-b5, and meet a kingside initiative with exchanges or a central break.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

Black wants ...Ne4, piece exchanges that reduce pressure, or ...c5 before you organize a minority attack. Development can matter more than a permanent pawn weakness.

BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

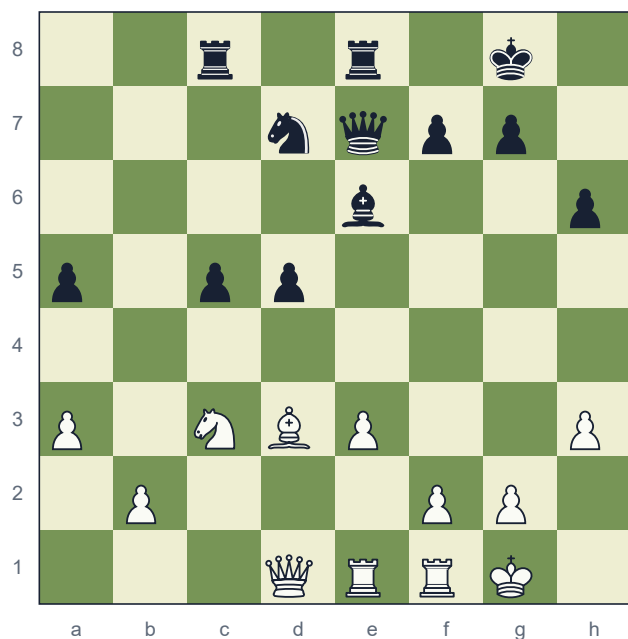
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

Exchange, develop, castle, then choose the pawn break. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

Queen's Gambit Declined: the Exchange / sample play

11. h3 Be6 12. a3 a5 13. Rab1 N8d7 14. Rbe1 Rc8 15. Ne5 h6 16. Bh4 c5 17. Nxd7 Nxd7 18. Bxe7 Qxe7 19. Qd1 b6 20. dxc5 bxc5



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses h3. Another searched candidate was Rae1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses Rab1. Another searched candidate was Nh2. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses Ne5. Another searched candidate was Rc1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

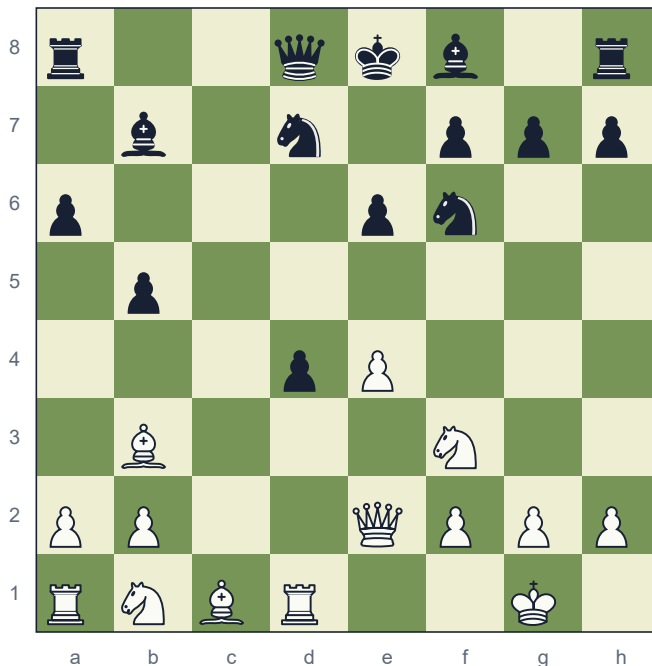
EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

Queen's Gambit Accepted / start



After the opening study line - White to move

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Develop the b1 knight to c3 or d2 according to tactics. Watch ...cxd4 and decide which piece or pawn should recapture.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

Black returns the pawn to develop freely, or tries ...b5 to hold it. The latter often gives you targets for a4 and undermining moves.

BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

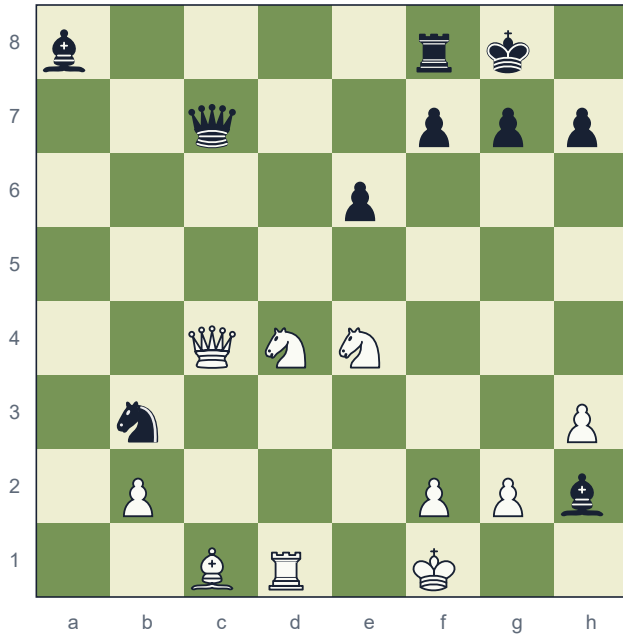
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

Recover with the bishop and bring a rook to the center. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

Queen's Gambit Accepted / sample play

11. Nxd4 Qb8 12. a4 Bd6 13. h3 O-O 14. axb5 axb5 15. Rxa8 Bxa8 16. Qxb5 Qc7 17. Qc4 Nc5 18. Nc3 Nfxe4 19. Nxe4 Bh2+ 20. Kf1 Nxb3



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses Nxd4. Another searched candidate was a4. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses h3. Another searched candidate was g3. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses Rxa8. Another searched candidate was Ra2. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

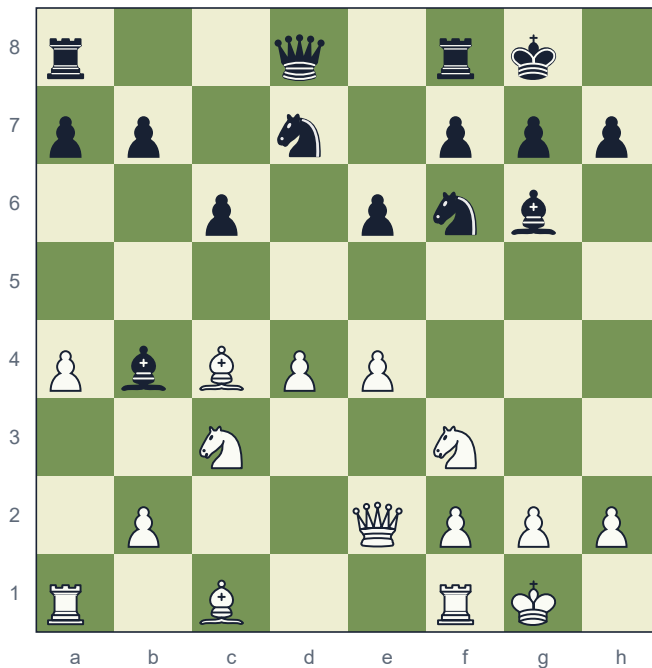
EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

The Slav Defense / start



After the opening study line - White to move

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Support e4, develop the c1 bishop, and watch ...Bg6 or ...Bxc3. The d4-e4 center can advance only if the pieces behind it cooperate.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

Black can capture c4, develop ...Bf5 or ...Bg4, play a waiting ...a6, or transpose to the Semi-Slav with ...e6.

BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

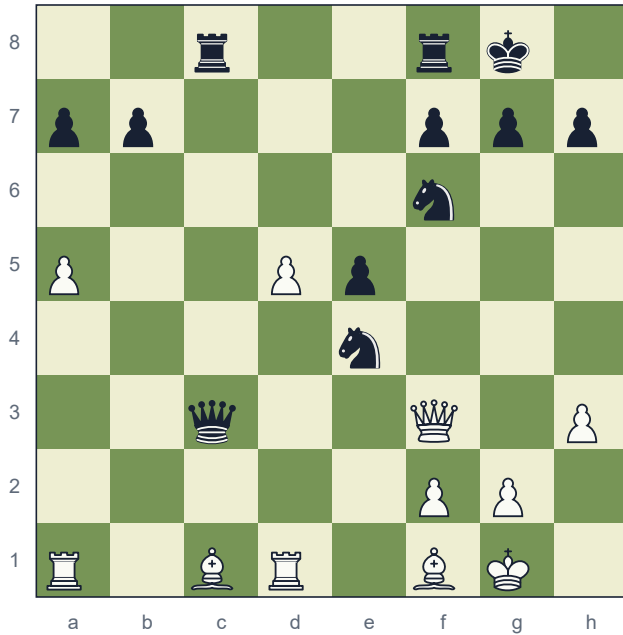
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

a4, recover c4, develop, then consider e4. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

The Slav Defense / sample play

11. Bd3 Bh5 12. h3 Bxf3 13. Qxf3 e5 14. d5 Bxc3 15. bxc3 cxd5 16. exd5 Nc5 17. Bc4 Qc7 18. a5 Rac8 19. Rd1 Nce4 20. Bf1 Qxc3



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses Bd3. Another searched candidate was e5. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses Qxf3. Another searched candidate was gxf3. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses bxc3. Another searched candidate was dxc6. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

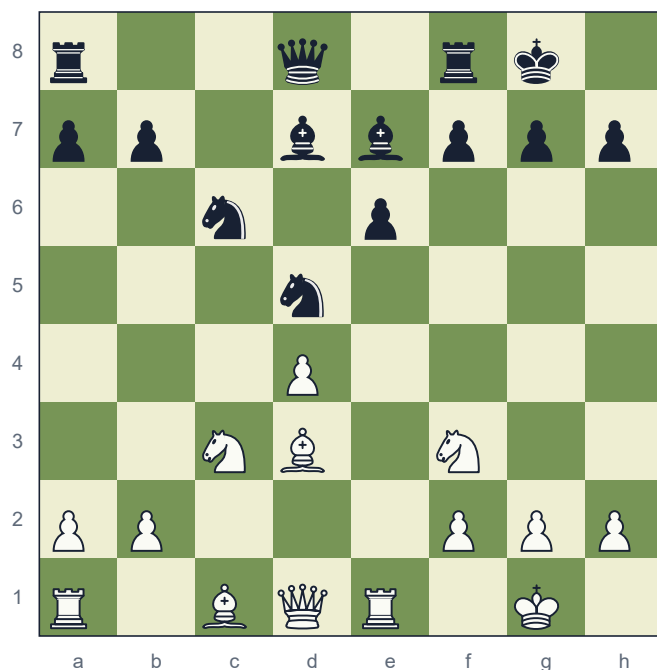
EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

Tarrasch and Semi-Tarrasch / start



After the opening study line - White to move

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Develop Bf4 or Bg5 when useful, bring the queen toward the center, and look for d5 when Black's pieces are uncoordinated.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

Black seeks rapid development and active central pieces. ...d4 or ...d5 can liquidate a weakness if the timing is right.

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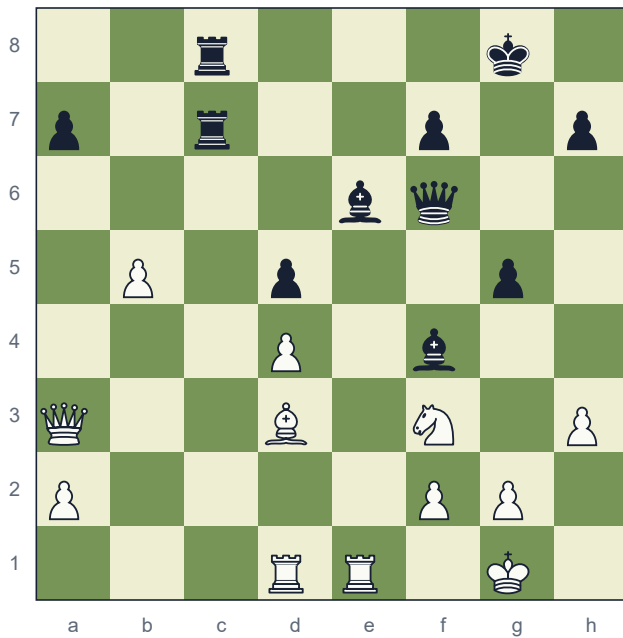
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

With the isolated pawn, play actively. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

Tarrasch and Semi-Tarrasch / sample play

11. h3 Rc8 12. Nxd5 exd5 13. Qb3 Be6 14. Qxb7 Nb4 15. Bg5 Bxg5 16. Qxb4 Bf4 17. Qa3 Rc7 18. b4 Qf6 19. b5 Rfc8 20. Rad1 g5



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses h3. Another searched candidate was Nxd5. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses Qb3. Another searched candidate was Bd2. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses Bg5. Another searched candidate was Bb1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

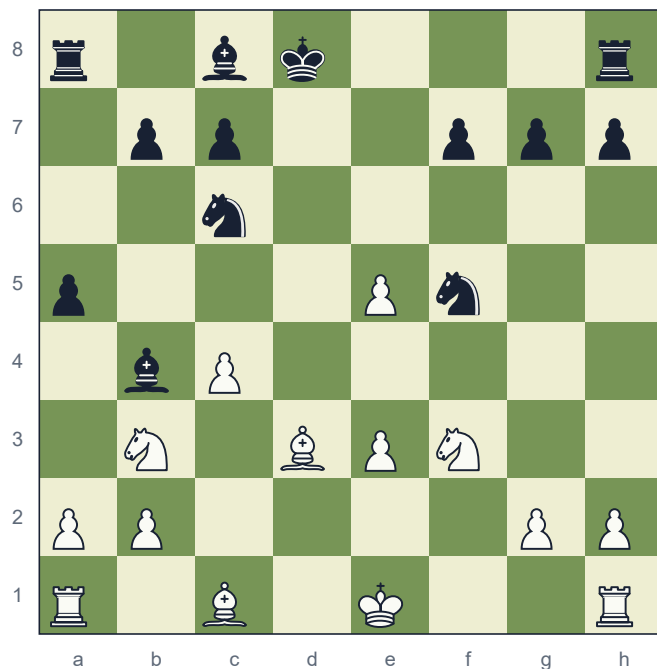
EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

Albin Countergambit: a complete practical answer / start



After the opening study line - White to move - in check

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Develop the bishops, bring the king to a safe useful square, and use the extra material without rushing. Your e-pawns are doubled, so assess activity as well as pawn count.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

Black wants ...Bg4 or ...Be6, quick development, and sometimes queenside castling. The wedge can advance or capture on e3; it must never disappear from your threat scan.

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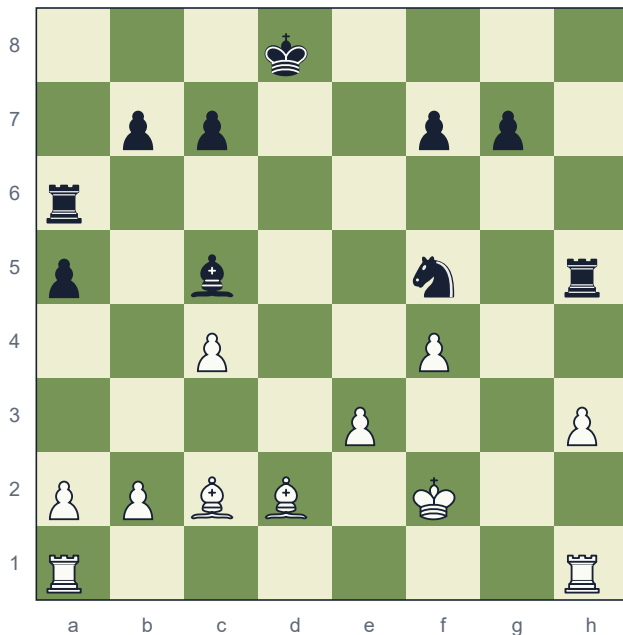
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

Nb3, e4, and understand the queen trade. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

Albin Countergambit: a complete practical answer / sample play

11. Kf2 Nh6 12. h3 Re8 13. Be4 Bd7 14. Nbd4 Ra6 15. Nxc6+ Bxc6 16. Bxh7 Bc5 17. Bc2 Bxf3 18. gxf3 Rxe5 19. f4 Rh5 20. Bd2 Nf5



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses Kf2. Another searched candidate was Ke2. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses Be4. Another searched candidate was Rd1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses Nxc6+. Another searched candidate was Rd1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

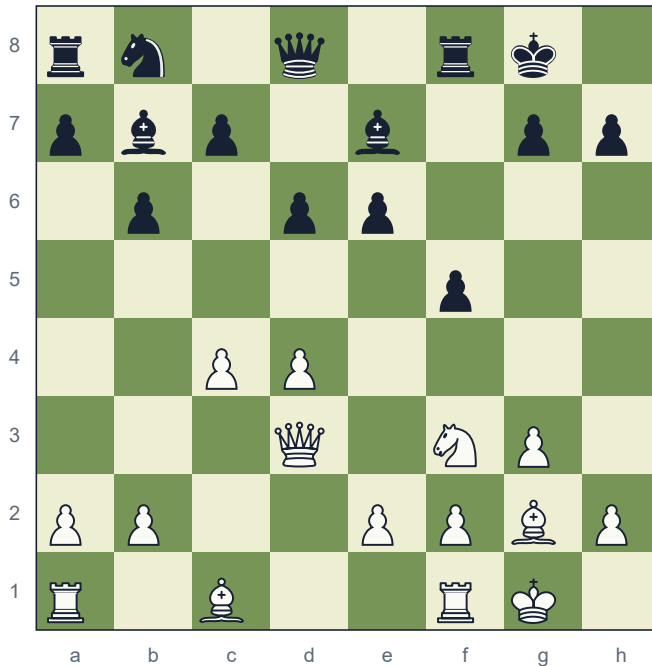
EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

Queen's Indian: the g3 repertoire / start



After the opening study line - White to move

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Develop the c1 bishop to f4 or g5 when appropriate. Prepare e4 or d5 only after checking the long diagonal.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

...Ba6 attacks c4; ...Bb7 pressures e4. Black may choose ...d5, ...c5 or a hedgehog-like setup with ...d6.

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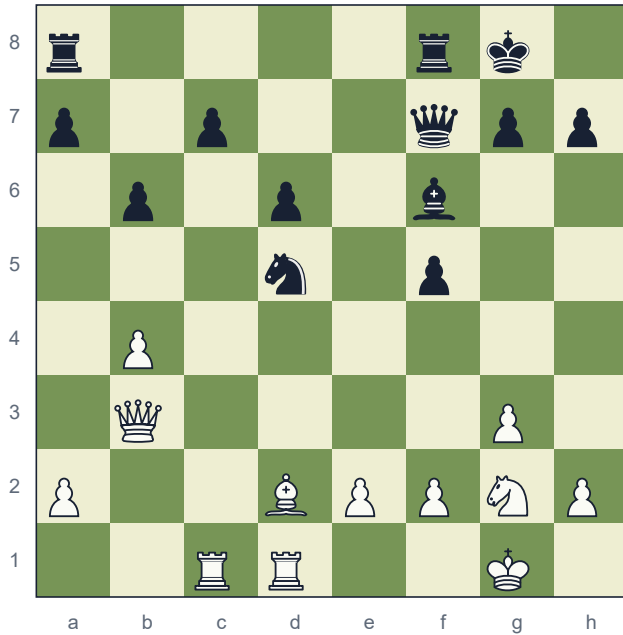
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

Coordinate the center before opening the long diagonal. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

Queen's Indian: the g3 repertoire / sample play

11. Qe3 Qc8 12. Bd2 Bf6 13. b4 Be4 14. Rfd1 Qe8 15. Rac1 Nc6 16. d5 exd5 17. cxd5 Ne7 18. Ne1 Nxd5 19. Qb3 Bxg2 20. Nxg2 Qf7



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses Qe3. Another searched candidate was Ne1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses b4. Another searched candidate was Rac1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses Rac1. Another searched candidate was a4. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

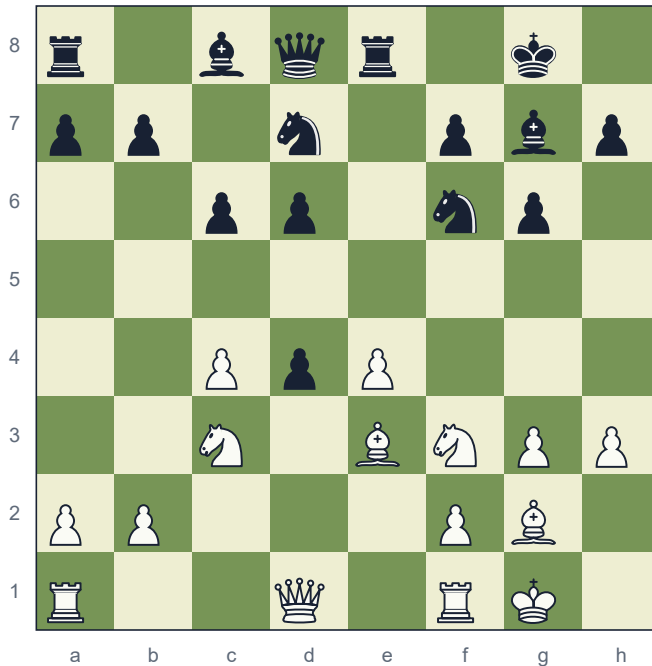
EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

King's Indian: a fianchetto repertoire / start



After the opening study line - White to move

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Choose Qc2, Re1 or d5 according to Black's regrouping. If the center closes, identify useful knight routes rather than launching pawns immediately.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

Black seeks ...e5, ...c5, and sometimes a queenside ...a6/...b5 expansion. ...f5 becomes relevant only when the knight and pawn structure permit it.

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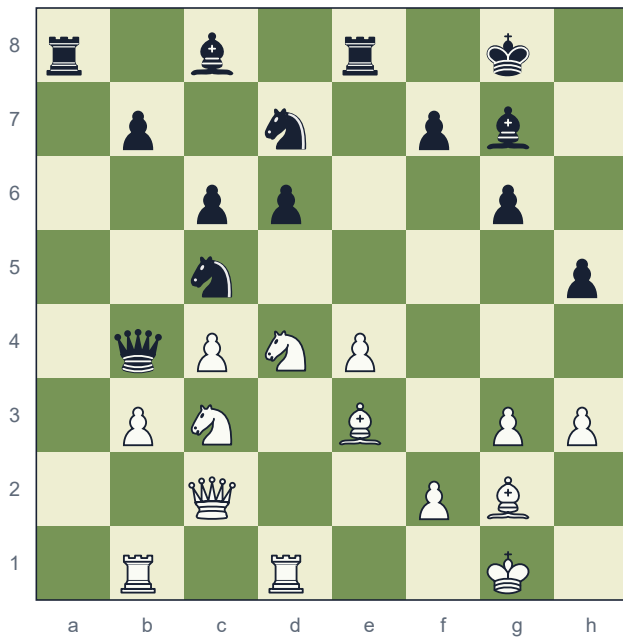
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

Build the center behind a secure king. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

King's Indian: a fianchetto repertoire / sample play

11. Nxd4 a5 12. Qc2 a4 13. Rad1 Qa5 14. b3 Nc5 15. Rd2 Qb4 16. Rb1 Nfd7 17. Rdd1 h5 18. Bd2 Qb6 19. Be3 axb3 20. axb3 Qb4



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses Nxd4. Another searched candidate was Bxd4. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses Rad1. Another searched candidate was Rfe1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses Rd2. Another searched candidate was Rb1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

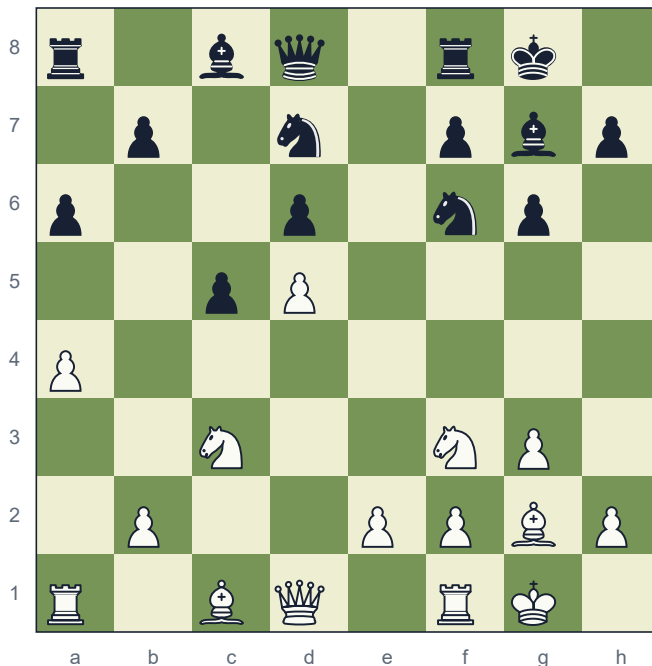
EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

Modern Benoni: space and the fianchetto / start



After the opening study line - White to move

YOUR OPENING PLAN

Develop the c1 bishop and prepare e4. Use rooks on central files and watch for an e5 breakthrough when it opens lines favorably.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCES

Black seeks ...b5, pressure down the e-file, and piece activity against e4 or d5. A rook on e8 and bishop on g7 can cooperate tactically.

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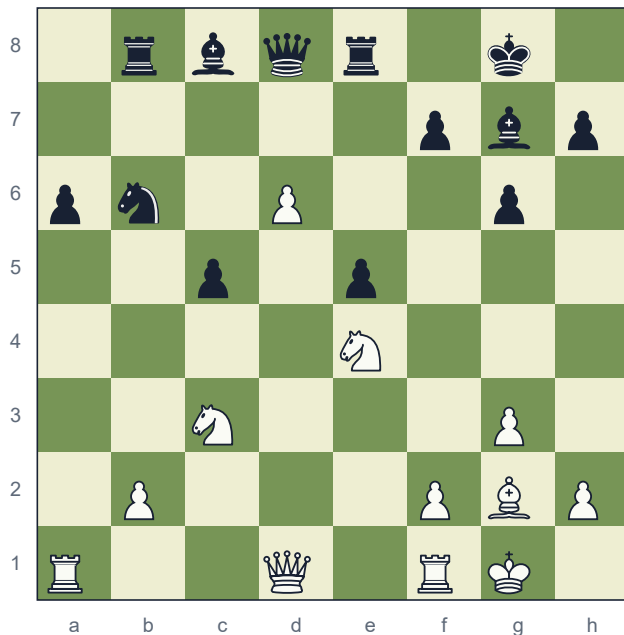
Write two candidate moves. For each, calculate Black's most forcing reply. Then write what would make you change plans: a central break, a piece exchange, or a threat against the king.

STUDY PROMPT

Keep d5, complete development, prepare e4-e5. Explain how that principle affects the current position. A move that follows the plan can still fail tactically; check it before choosing.

Modern Benoni: space and the fianchetto / sample play

11. Bf4 Qb6 12. a5 Qc7 13. e4 Re8 14. Nd2 b5 15. axb6 Nxb6 16. e5 dxe5 17. Bg5 Rb8 18. Bxf6 Bxf6 19. Nde4 Qd8 20. d6 Bg7



After sample continuation - White to move

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 11

The sample chooses Bf4. Another searched candidate was Re1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 13

The sample chooses e4. Another searched candidate was Re1. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

CANDIDATE CHECK AT MOVE 15

The sample chooses axb6. Another searched candidate was Be3. Compare their concrete replies and ask which better serves the current pawn structure.

EXPLAIN THE CHANGES

Which pawns or pieces were exchanged? Did the original plan survive, or did a central break create a new structure? Identify one position where a routine developing move would miss a concrete opportunity.

REPLAY DRILL

Play the position from move ten against a partner or engine, then switch colors. Annotate the first decision where your plan and the sample diverge. A different sound move is not automatically a mistake.

Test understanding, not just memory

HOW TO USE THE TEST

There are 40 repertoire-recall positions, ten structure questions and ten concrete tactical or opening decisions. Write the move, a reason and the opponent's best idea. The answer section follows all questions so you can print them separately.

SCORING

For each problem award one point for the selected move or a sound plan, one point for the explanation, and one point for identifying the opponent's threat or resource. Maximum: 180. Recall exercises can have other sound moves; the key gives the course choice.

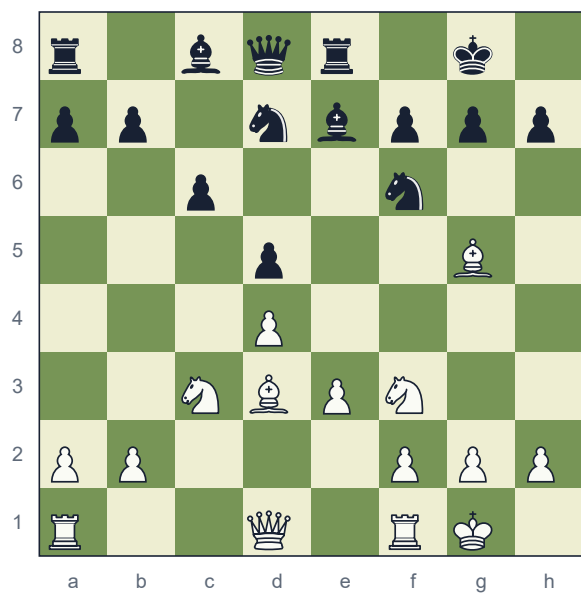
HONEST EVALUATION

This score is a study diagnostic, not an Elo estimate. Below 60 percent, revisit the core plans. Between 60 and 80 percent, repair missed branches. Above 80 percent, test retention through real games and delayed review.

TACTICAL PROBLEMS

For forcing problems, calculate to a clear result. In the Albin warning positions the side to move is Black. Do not answer with a plausible White developing move simply because this is a White repertoire course.

Exercises 01-02



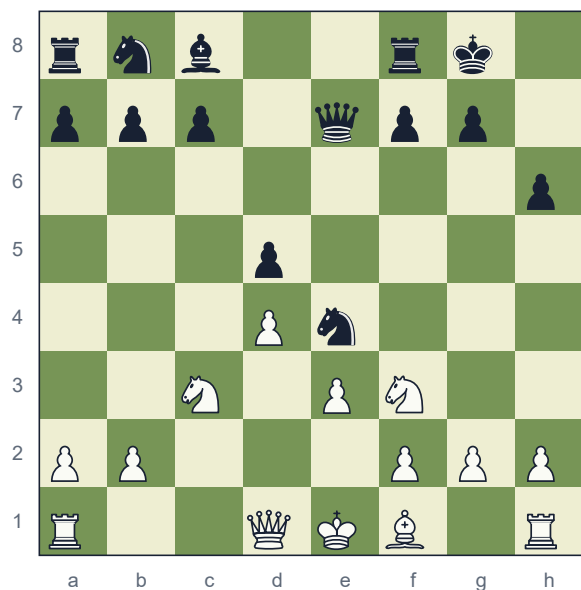
01. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



02. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 03-04

8

a

b

c

d

e

f

g

h

White to move

03. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

8

a

b

c

d

e

f

g

h

White to move

04. Repertoire recall

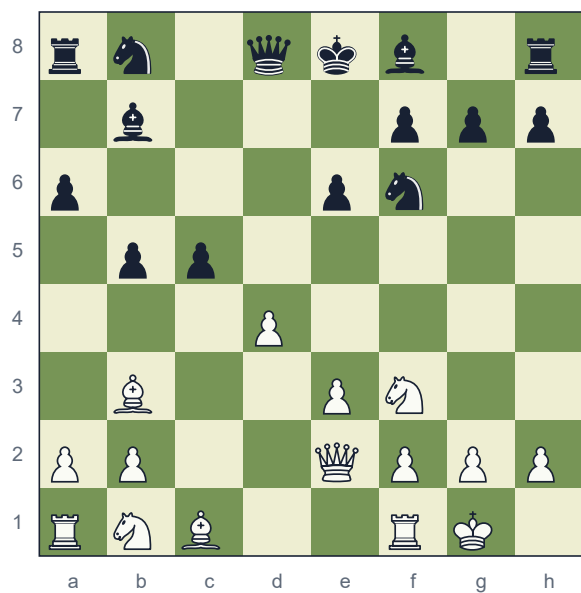
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 05-06



White to move

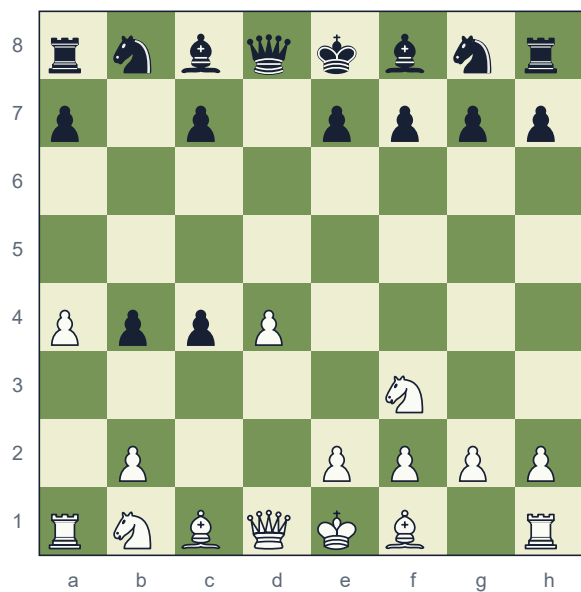
05. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

06. Repertoire recall

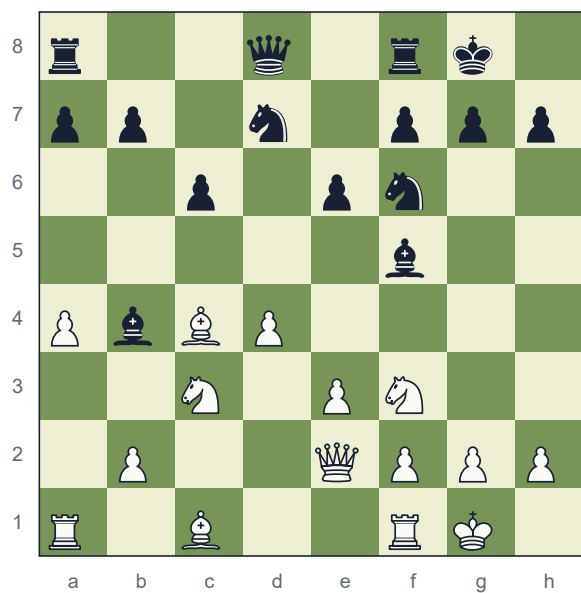
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 07-08



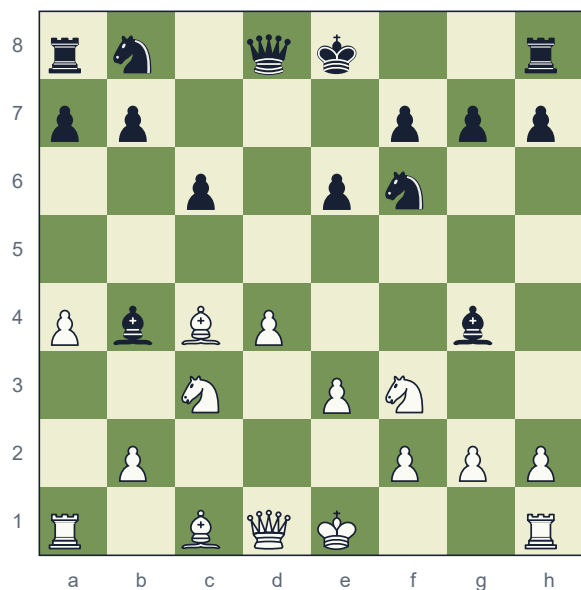
07. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



08. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 09-10

8

a

b

c

d

e

f

g

h

White to move

09. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

8

a

b

c

d

e

f

g

h

White to move

10. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

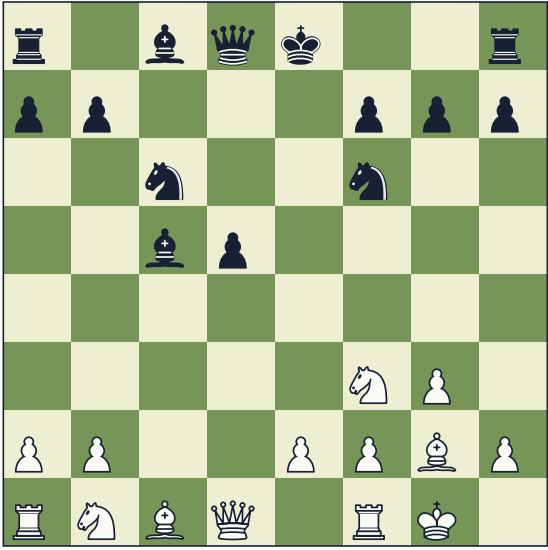
My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 11-12

8



a b c d e f g h

White to move

11. Repertoire recall

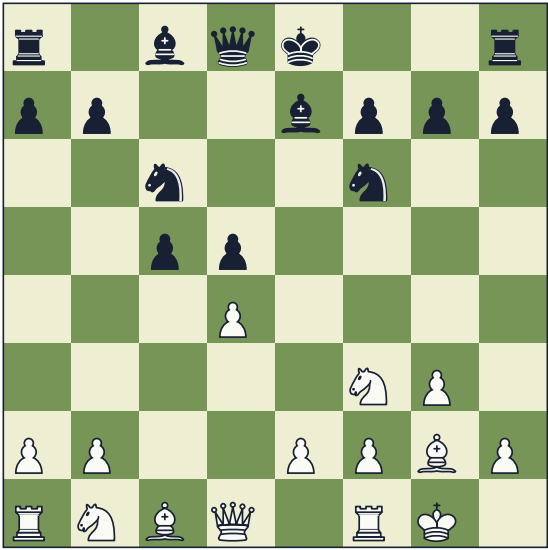
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

8



a b c d e f g h

White to move

12. Repertoire recall

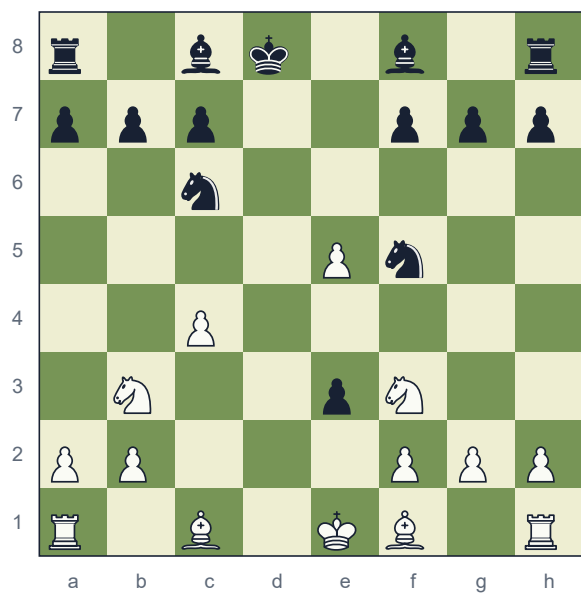
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 13-14



White to move

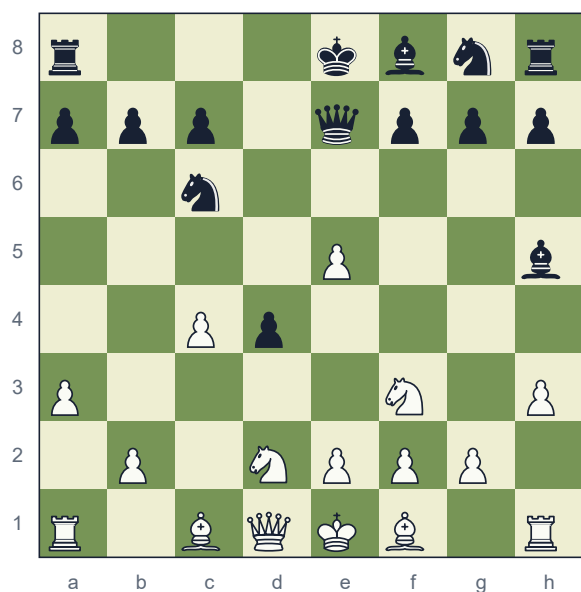
13. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

14. Repertoire recall

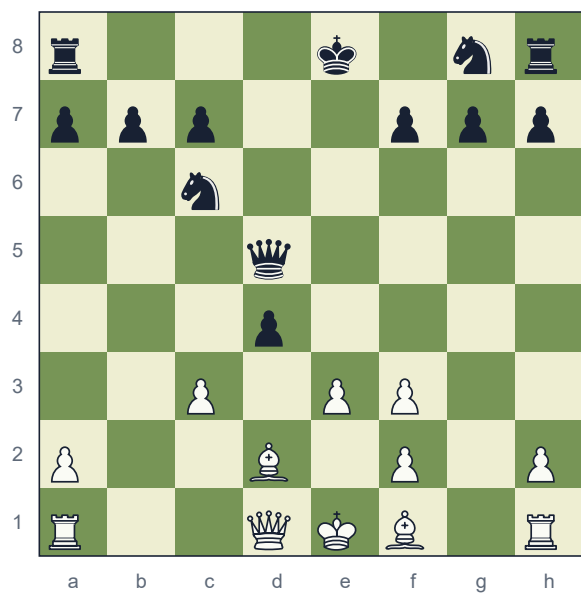
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 15-16



White to move

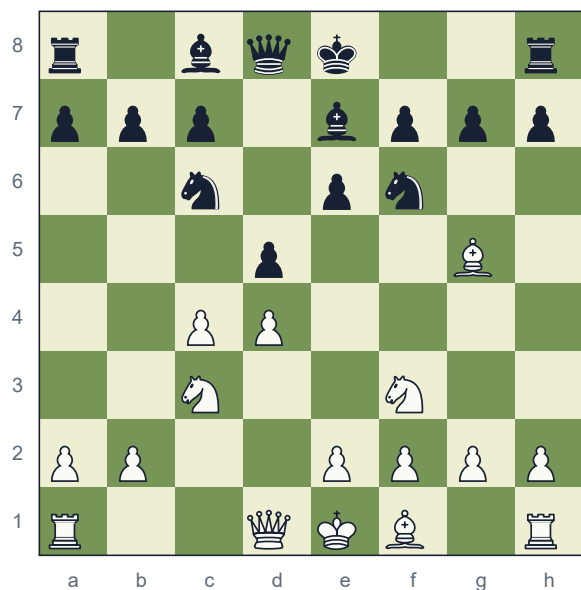
15. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

16. Repertoire recall

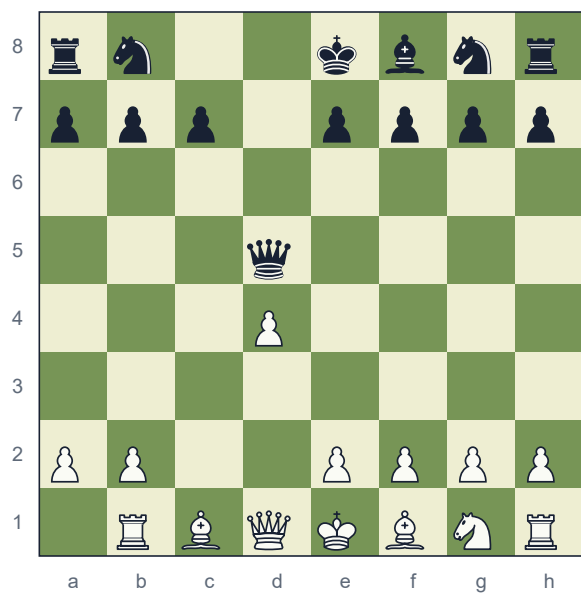
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 17-18



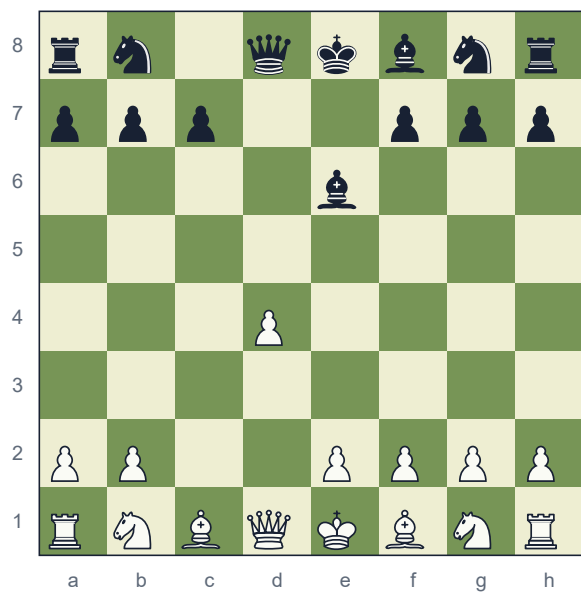
17. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



18. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

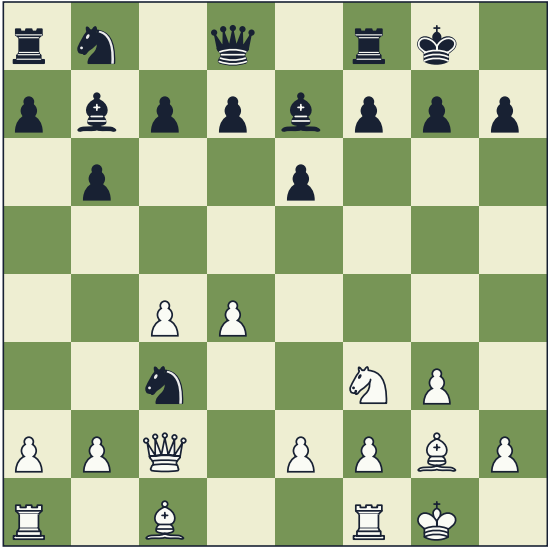
My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 19-20

8



a b c d e f g h

White to move

19. Repertoire recall

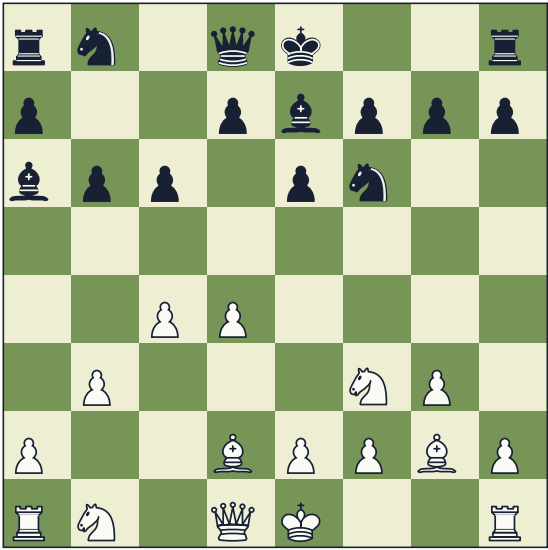
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

8



a b c d e f g h

White to move

20. Repertoire recall

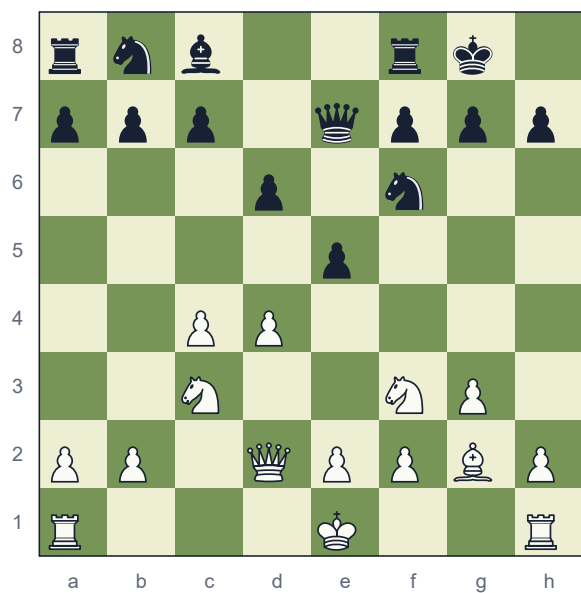
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 21-22



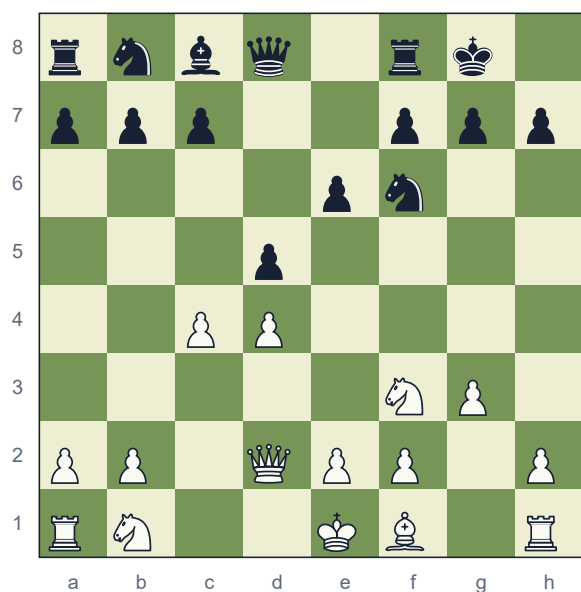
21. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



22. Repertoire recall

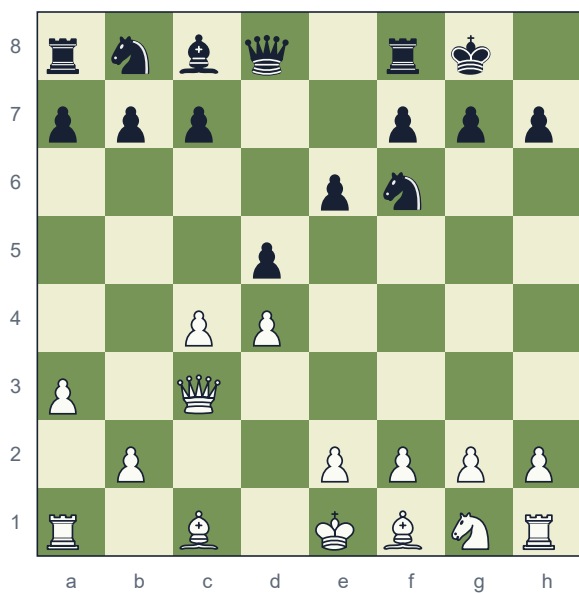
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 23-24



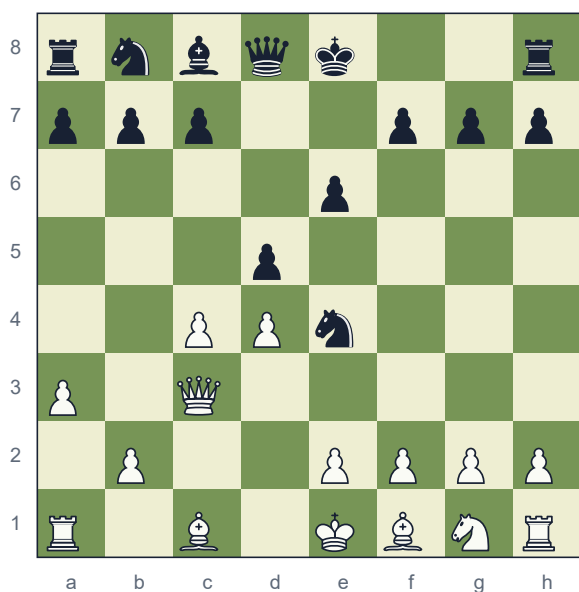
23. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



24. Repertoire recall

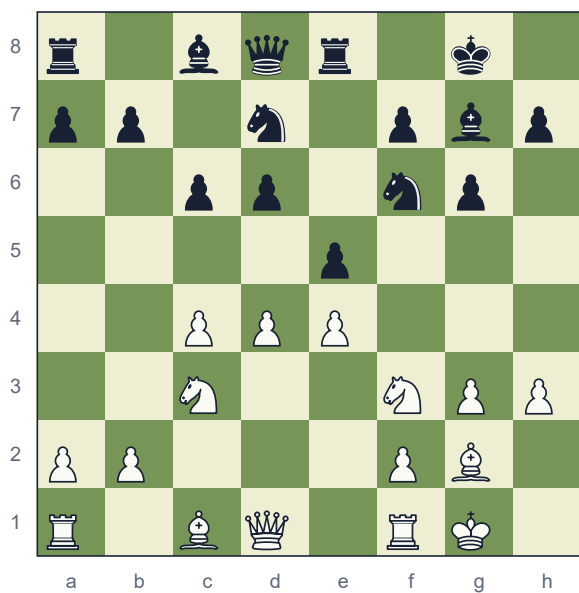
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 25-26



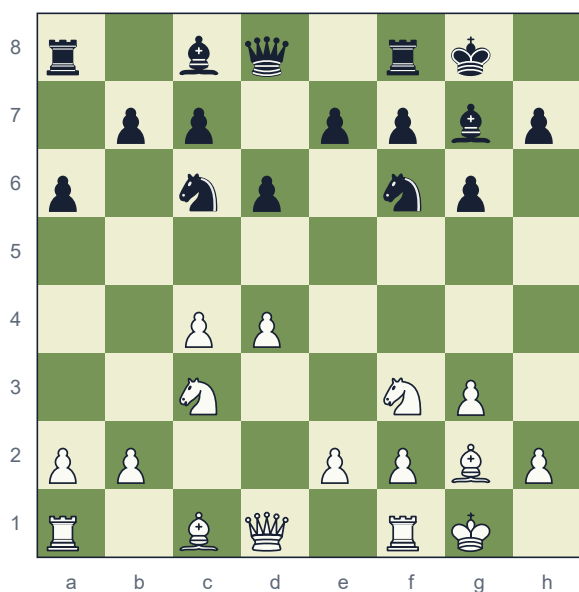
25. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



26. Repertoire recall

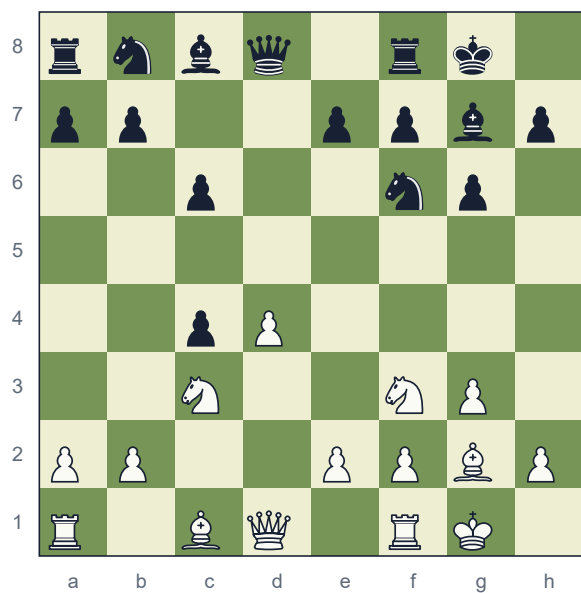
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 27-28



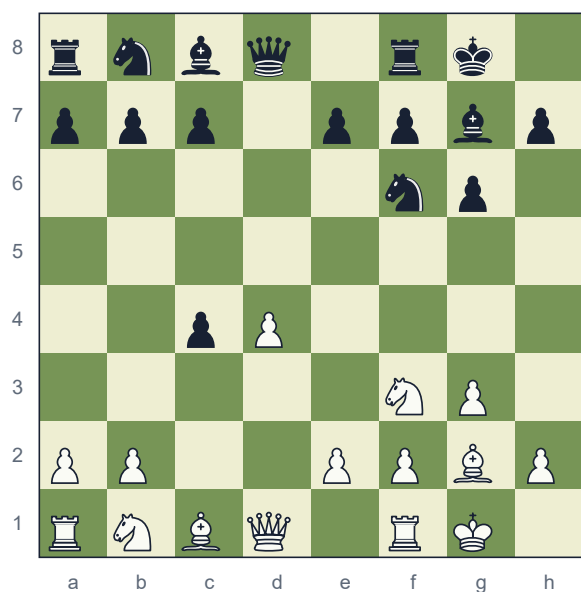
27. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



28. Repertoire recall

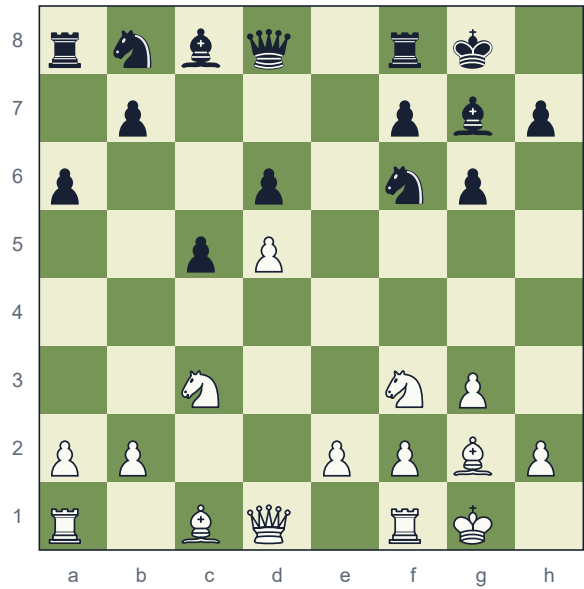
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 29-30



White to move

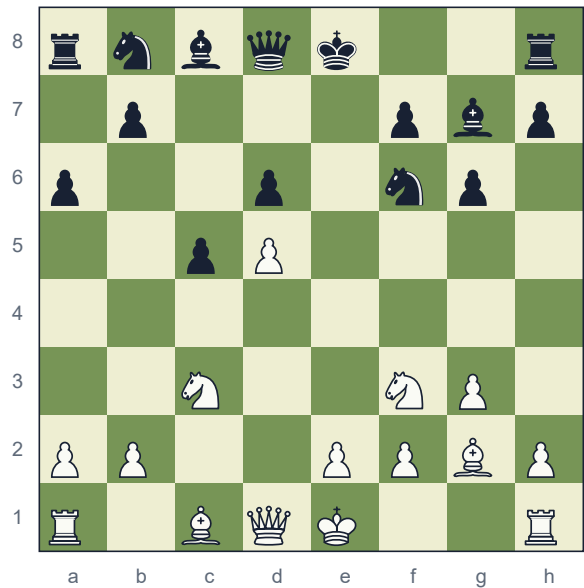
29. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

30. Repertoire recall

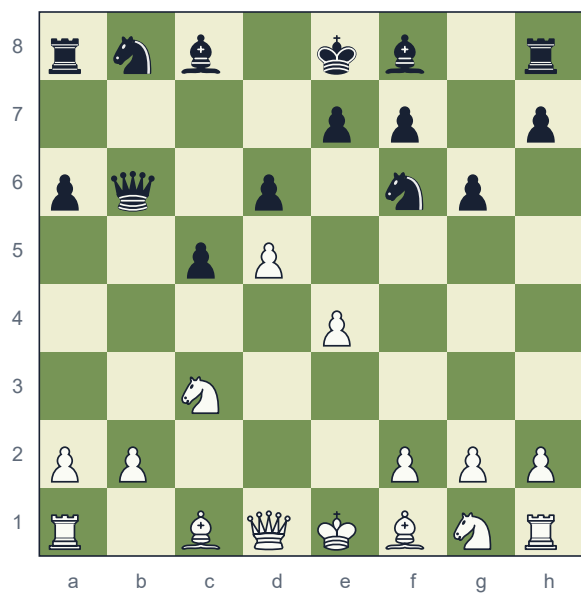
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 31-32



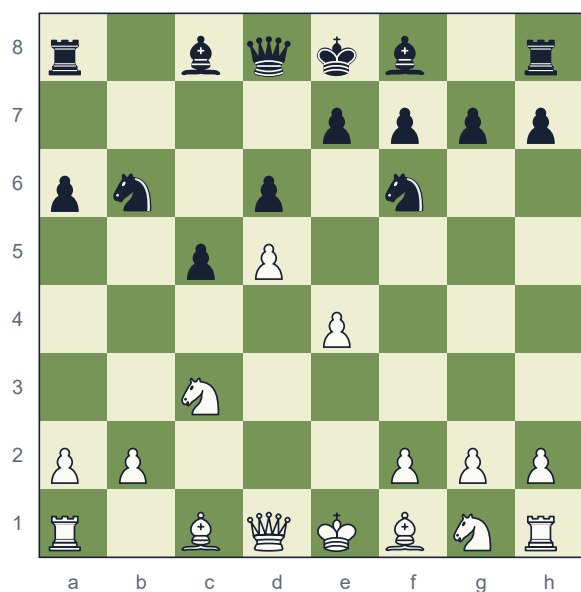
31. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



32. Repertoire recall

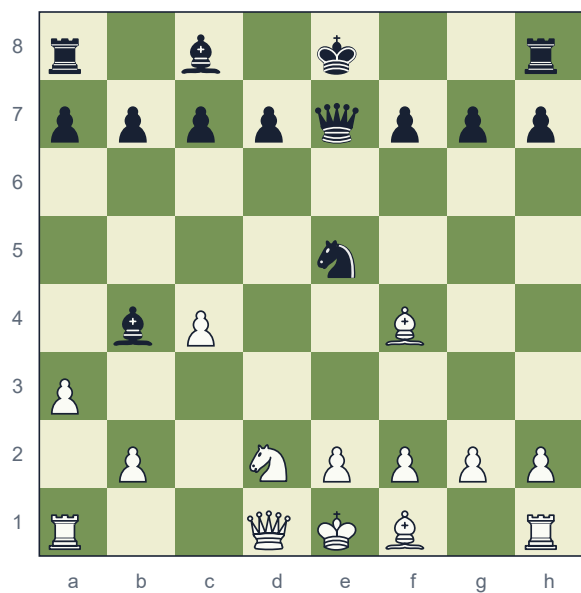
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 33-34



White to move

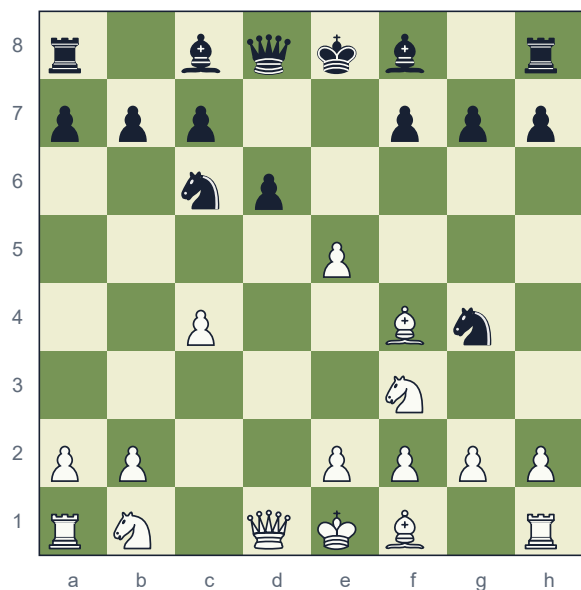
33. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

34. Repertoire recall

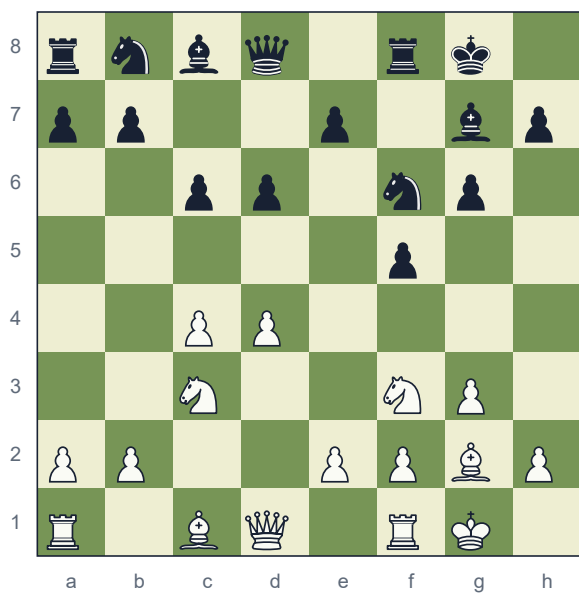
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 35-36



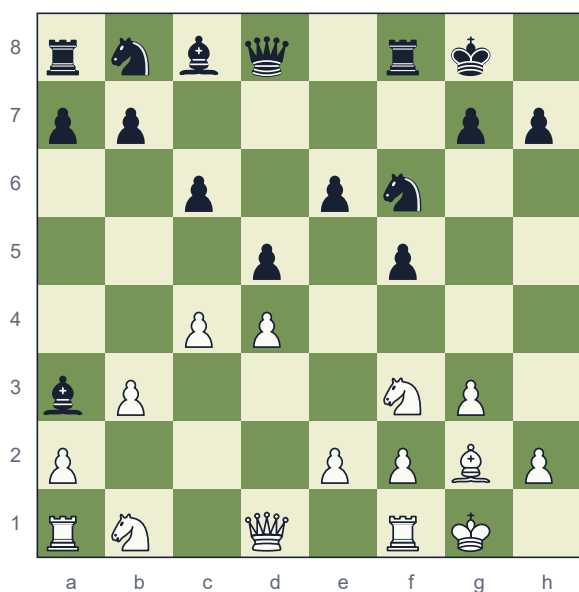
35. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



36. Repertoire recall

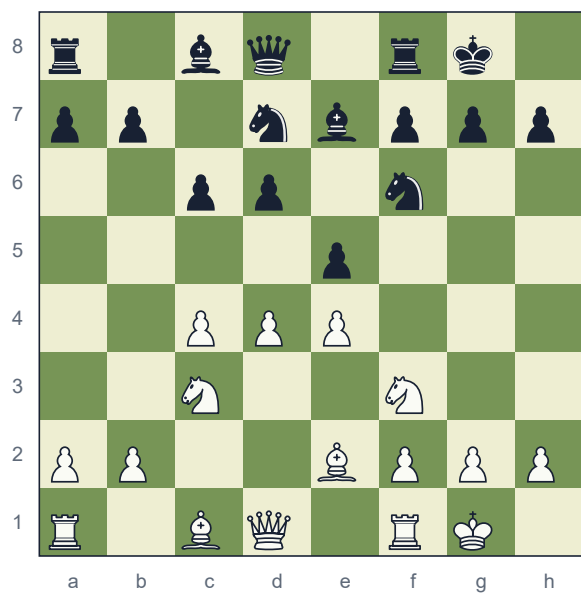
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 37-38



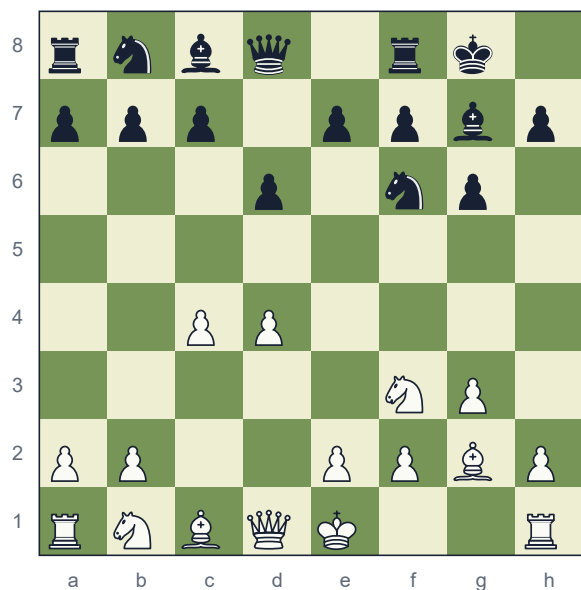
37. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



38. Repertoire recall

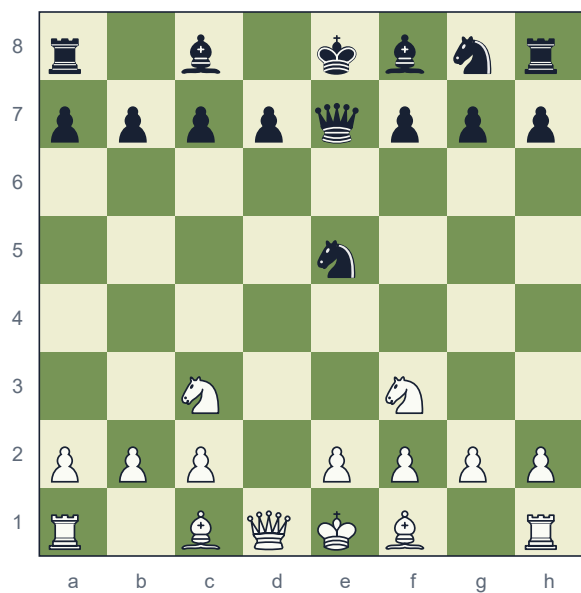
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 39-40



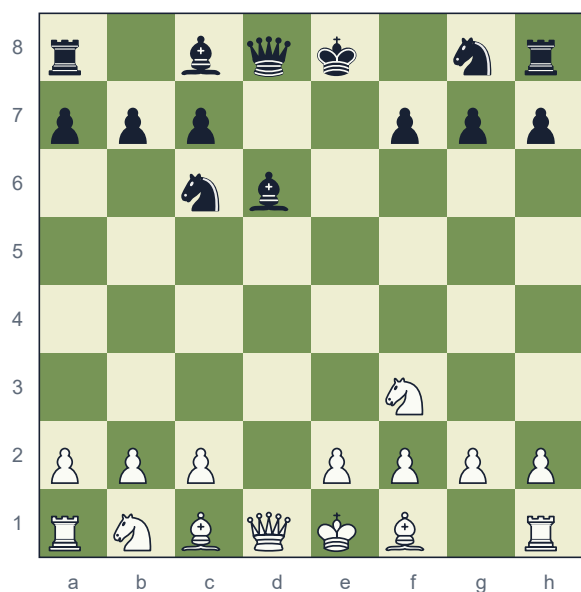
39. Repertoire recall

Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



40. Repertoire recall

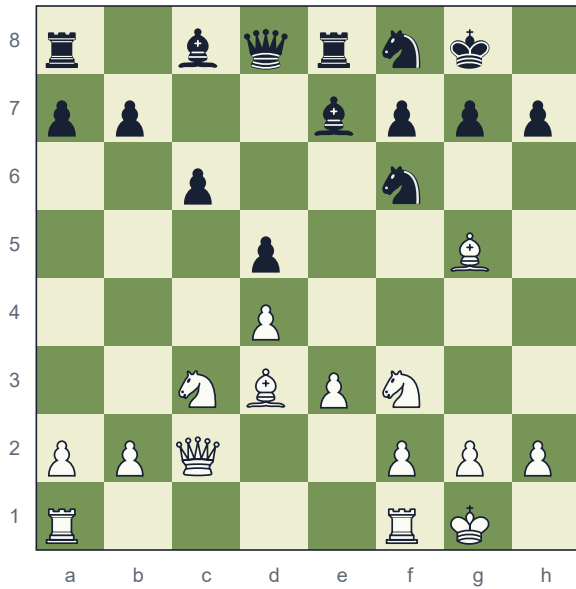
Choose the course move and explain its purpose.
Other moves may also be sound.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 41-42



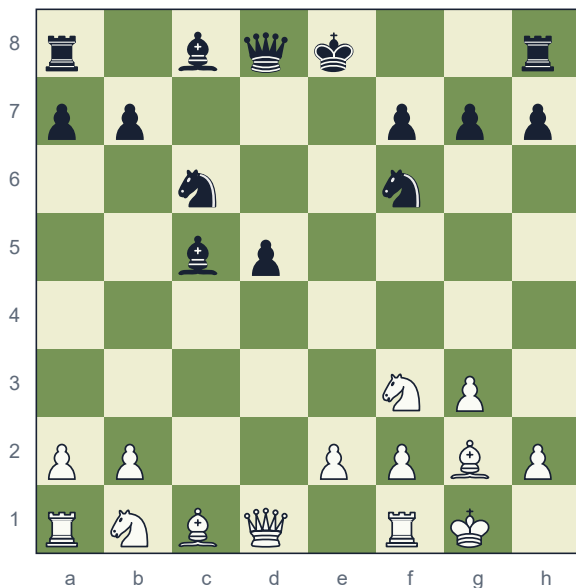
41. Plan and structure

Which piece needs improvement before b4? What exact pawn weakness would b5 create? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



42. Plan and structure

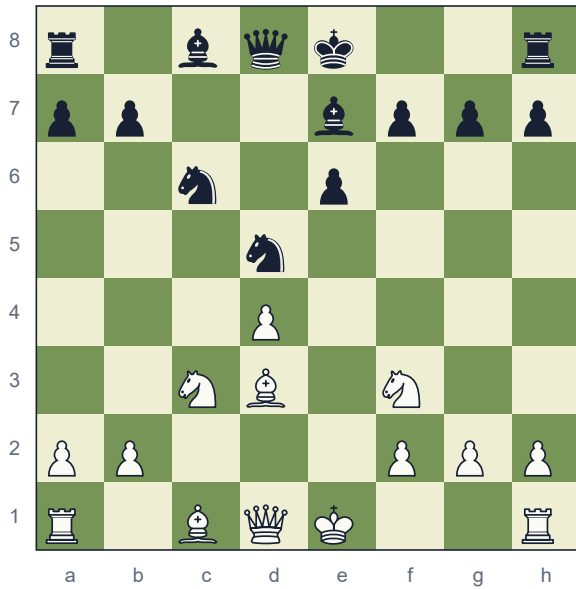
Which square is directly in front of the isolated pawn? Can you occupy it safely? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 43-44



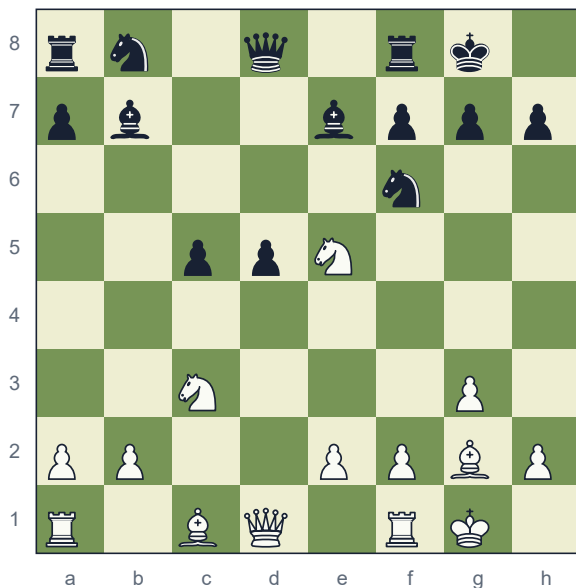
43. Plan and structure

Which trade favors the blockader? What would have to change for d5 to work? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



44. Plan and structure

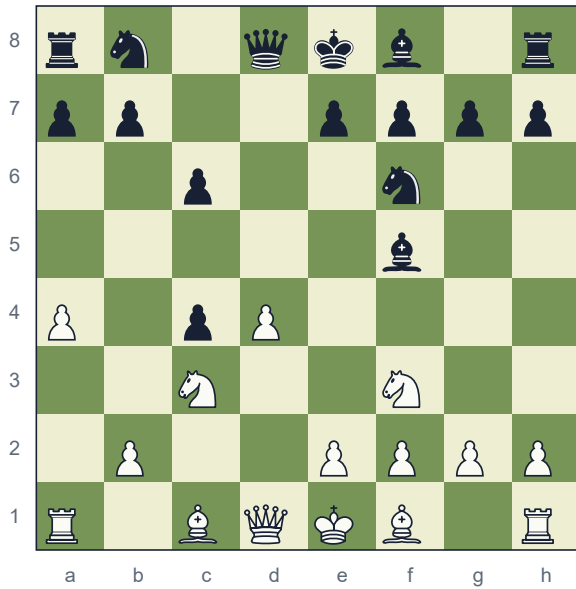
If ...d4 is played, which square and pawn become vulnerable? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 45-46



White to move

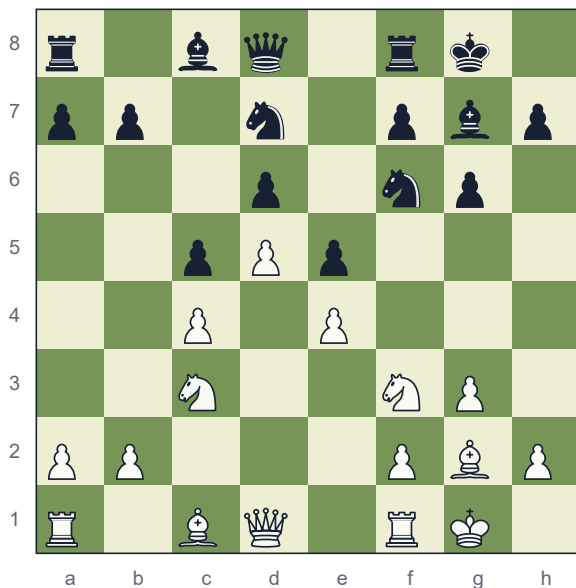
45. Plan and structure

Why does a4 matter here? Which move opens the bishop that can recover c4? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

46. Plan and structure

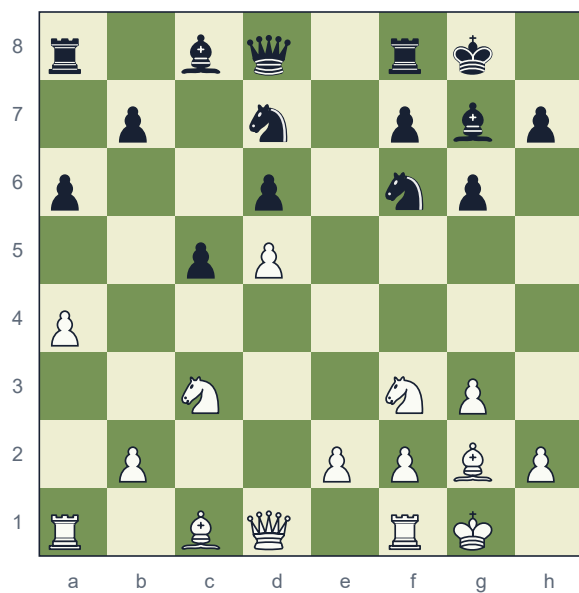
Which pawn break is realistic for each side? Which knight has the clearest route to a better square? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 47-48



White to move

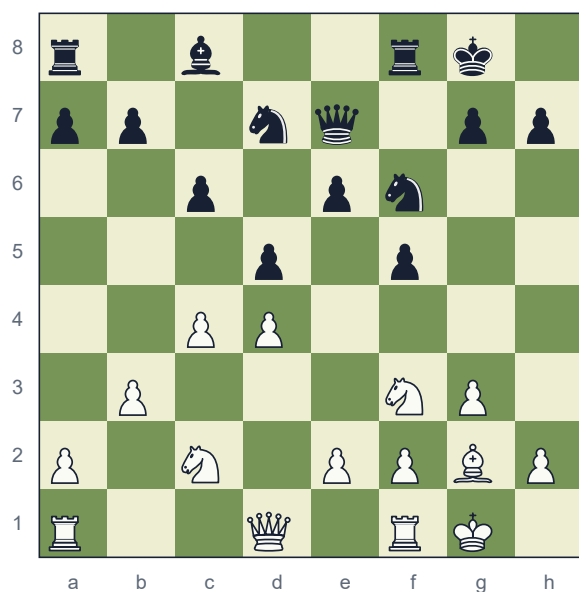
47. Plan and structure

Does a4 stop ...b5 permanently or only make it harder?
What supports an eventual e5 break? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

48. Plan and structure

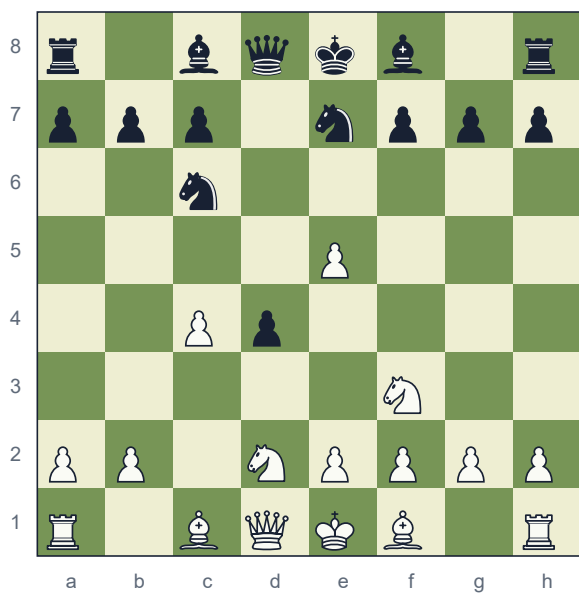
Which bishop would Black most like to improve? Which trade reduces the attack? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 49-50



White to move

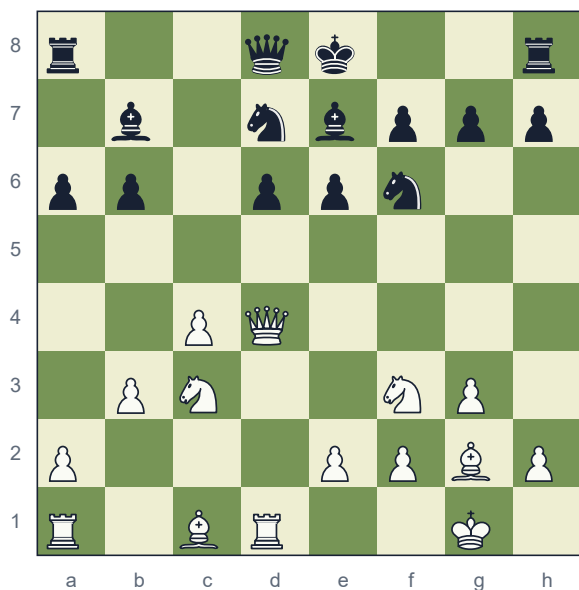
49. Plan and structure

What does Nb3 attack? Why is e3 tactically different from a quiet QGD e3 move? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

50. Plan and structure

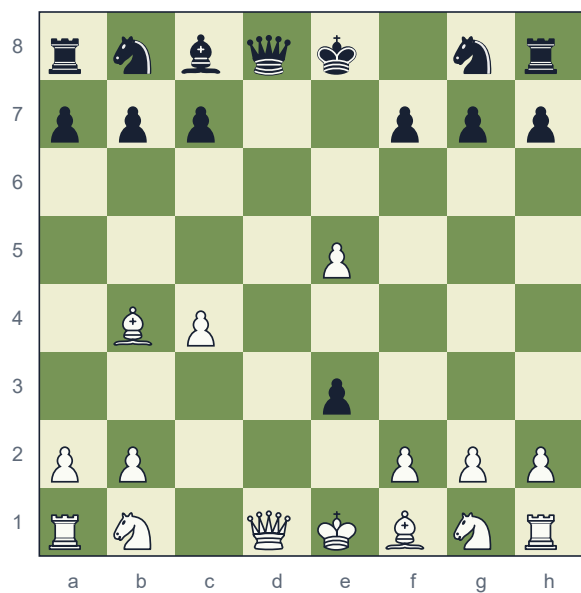
Which break would free Black's position? Can it be prevented usefully, or should you prepare to meet it? Name the structure and one resource for the other side.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 51-52



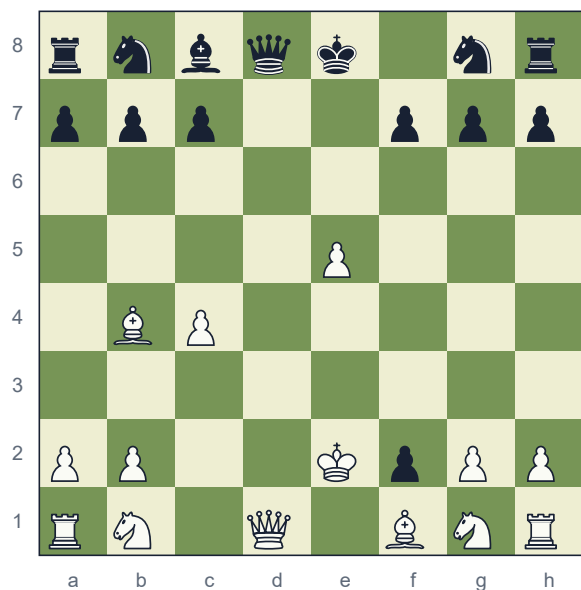
51. Tactical warning: Black to move

Find the forcing move. Why is capturing a bishop or promoting to a queen not the whole calculation?

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



52. Tactical warning: Black to move

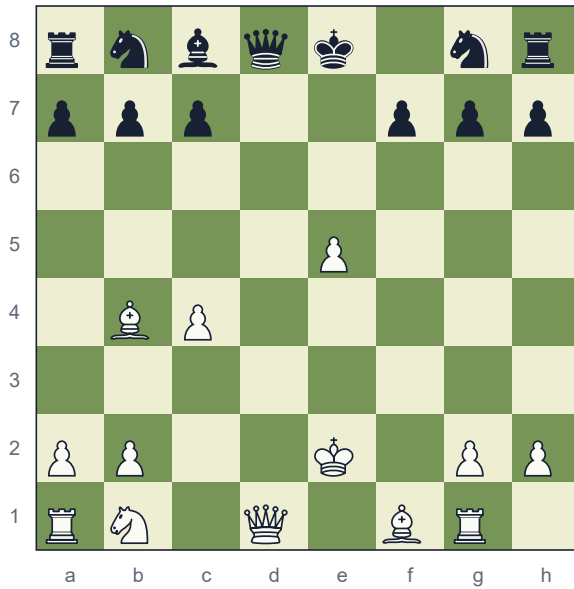
Find the forcing move. Why is capturing a bishop or promoting to a queen not the whole calculation?

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 53-54



Black to move

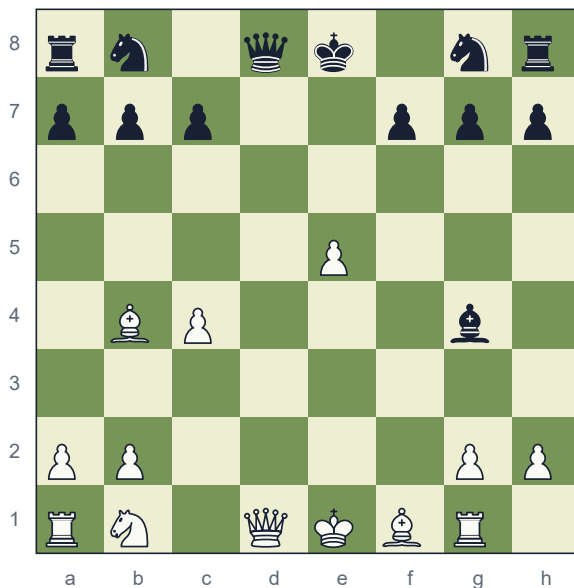
53. Tactical warning: Black to move

Find the forcing move. Why is capturing a bishop or promoting to a queen not the whole calculation?

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



Black to move

54. Tactical warning: Black to move

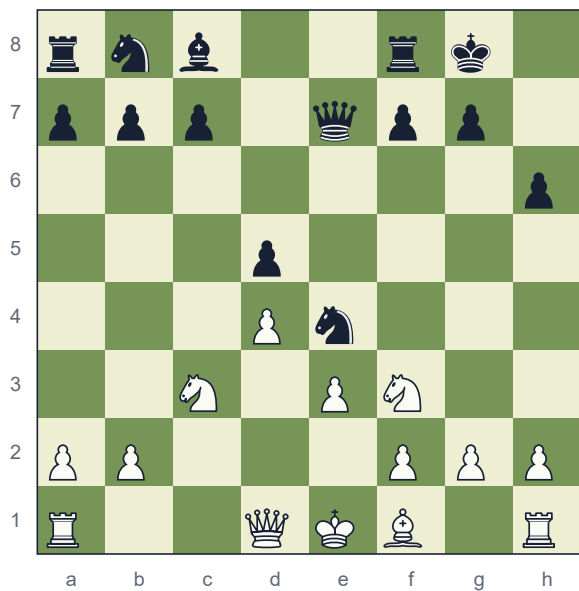
Find the forcing move. Why is capturing a bishop or promoting to a queen not the whole calculation?

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 55-56



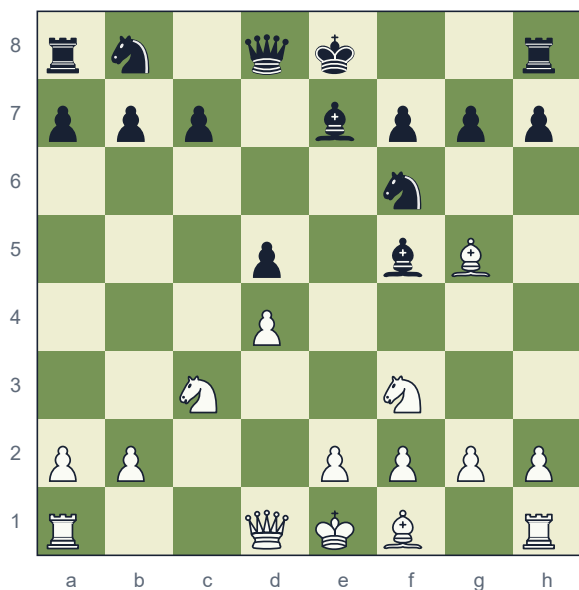
55. Concrete opening decision

A central pawn has lost a defender. Find the concrete opportunity.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



56. Concrete opening decision

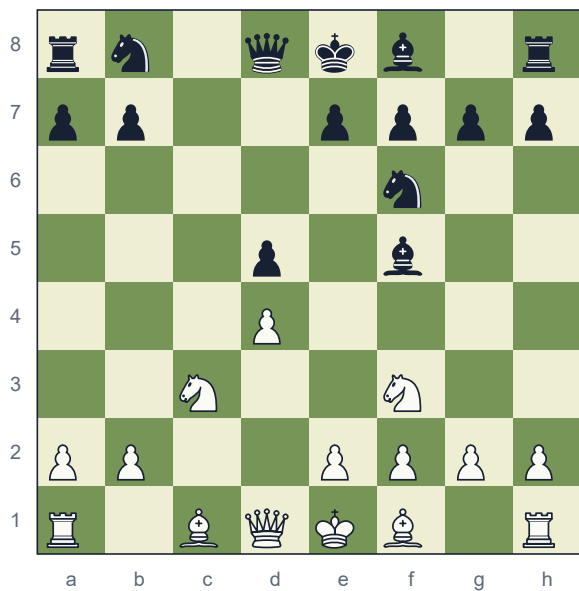
Which defender can White exchange to create pressure on d5?

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 57-58



White to move

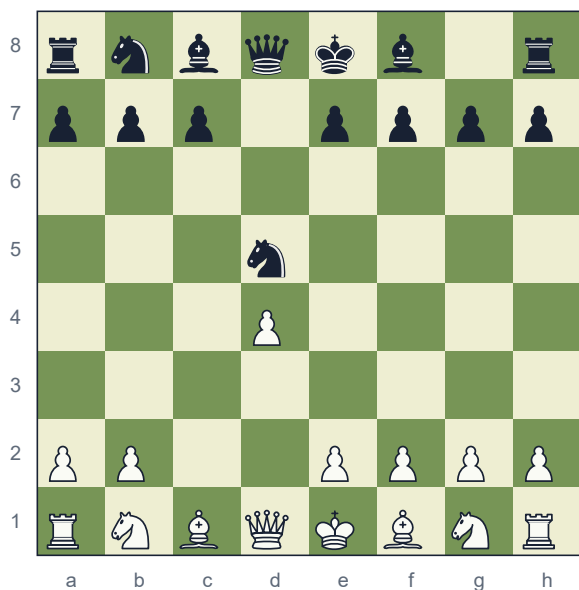
57. Concrete opening decision

Black developed the c8 bishop early. How can White create queenside pressure?

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



White to move

58. Concrete opening decision

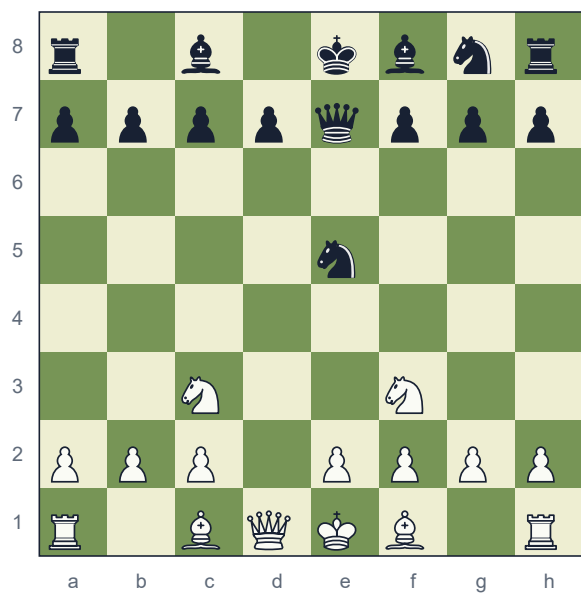
Gain central space with tempo against the knight.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Exercises 59-60



White to move

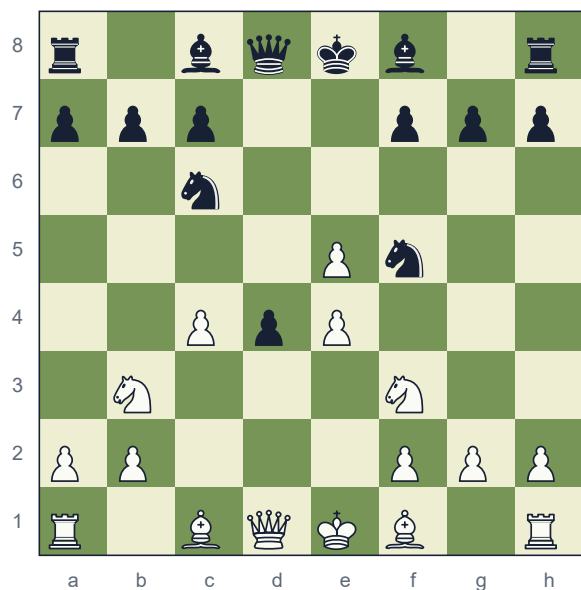
59. Concrete opening decision

The black queen is exposed. Find a developing attack on it.

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:



Black to move

60. Concrete opening decision

Black can capture en passant. What is the move, and why is it legal?

My move / plan:

Why it works:

Opponent's reply:

Answers 01-03

01. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 02-01

Qc2. Coordinates the queen with central play while clearing d1 for a rook. cxd5 fixes a structure you can study repeatedly. Bg5 develops outside the e3 pawn chain; Bd3 points at h7 while supporting later central play.

Replay: 10. Qc2 Nf8

02. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 02-02

Nxd5. The knight captures on d5. Check the resulting recapture, pawn structure and open lines before applying the longer-term plan. Bh4 keeps the pin available; when the knight reaches e4, exchanging on e7 simplifies the pressure on your bishop without abandoning development.

Replay: 10. Nxd5 Qd8

03. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 03-01

e3. Supports d4 and opens a diagonal for the f1 bishop. The exchange removes the tension before the pin generates more complications. Bg5 counter-pins the f6 knight and e3 prepares Bd3.

Replay: 8. e3 Bf5 9. Be2 Nbd7 10. Qb3 c5

Answers 04-06

04. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 03-02

Bg5. Develops the bishop and increases pressure along the diagonal toward f6 and d8. e4 uses the tempo Black spent capturing c4. The center gives space but becomes the target of ...c5 and ...Nxe4 ideas.

Replay: 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bxf6 Qxf6 8. Bxc4 c5 9. O-O cxd4 10. e5 Qd8

05. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 04-01

Rd1. Places the rook on d1. Use the line explanation below to connect that placement to the center and opponent's threats. e3 opens the bishop and Bxc4 recovers the pawn with development. Qe2 and Rd1 build pressure on the central file.

Replay: 9. Rd1 Nbd7 10. e4 cxd4

06. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 04-02

e3. Supports d4 and opens a diagonal for the f1 bishop. a4 attacks the base of Black's chain. After ...b4, e3 opens lines and prepares to recover c4.

Replay: 5. e3 Nf6 6. Bxc4 e6 7. a5 a6 8. O-O Bb7 9. Nbd2 Be7 10. Re1 O-O

Answers 07-09

07. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 05-01

e4. Gains central space and controls d5 and f5; check the concrete attacks on the new pawn. a4 restrains ...b5, e3 releases the bishop, and e4 later uses your central majority after development.

Replay: 10. e4 Bg6

08. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 05-02

O-O. Castling moves the king out of the center and brings a rook closer to the central files. The bishop pins f3 instead of controlling e4 from f5. You can still use the main development scheme.

Replay: 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qb3 Qb6 10. Nd2 a5

09. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 06-01

e5. Places the pawn on e5. Use the line explanation below to connect that placement to the center and opponent's threats. White gains time against the f6 knight while Black attacks the center. This is a concrete line: e5 is a central reaction to ...c5, not a generic attacking move.

Replay: 10. e5 cxd4

Answers 10-12

10. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 06-02

Qc2. Coordinates the queen with central play while clearing d1 for a rook. Qc2 reinforces e4 while castling removes your king from the center. Both players retain choices about the central tension.

Replay: 8. Qc2 e5 9. cxd5 cxd5 10. e4 exd4

11. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 07-01

Nc3. Develops the queen knight and adds control of d5 and e4. The bishop on g2 attacks central dark squares. Exchanging d4xc5 can leave Black with an isolated d5 pawn.

Replay: 9. Nc3 O-O 10. a3 a5

12. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 07-02

Nc3. Develops the queen knight and adds control of d5 and e4. White can also maintain the central tension. Black's choice between ...cxd4, ...c4 and waiting changes where your counterplay belongs.

Replay: 8. Nc3 O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. a3 a5

Answers 13-15

13. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 08-01

fxe3. The pawn captures on e3. Check the resulting recapture, pawn structure and open lines before applying the longer-term plan. Nbd2-b3 attacks d4. e4 challenges the knight and allows an en-passant capture; Qxd8+ first is essential to understand the resulting queenless position.

Replay: 9. fxe3 a5 10. Bd3 Bb4+

14. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 08-02

Qa4. Places the queen on a4. Use the line explanation below to connect that placement to the center and opponent's threats. a3 prevents ...Bb4+; h3 asks the bishop to choose. Qa4 creates queenside pressure while Black spends time placing the queen on e7.

Replay: 8. Qa4 O-O-O 9. g4 Bg6 10. Bg2 Kb8

15. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 09-01

cxd4. The pawn captures on d4. Check the resulting recapture, pawn structure and open lines before applying the longer-term plan. Black gives up bishops to damage your pawns. White accepts a broad center and the bishop pair; e3 supports development and the d4 square.

Replay: 10. cxd4 Nge7

Answers 16-18

16. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 09-02

e3. Supports d4 and opens a diagonal for the f1 bishop. Black has chosen a solid setup with the c-pawn blocked. Ordinary development gives you a comfortable central position.

Replay: 6. e3 O-O 7. Rc1 h6 8. Bf4 Bd6 9. Bg3 Bxg3 10. hxg3 Qe7

17. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 10-01

Nf3. Develops the king knight and influences the central d4 and e5 squares. The rook recapture keeps your king and queen safe. Black recovers d5 but has exchanged an active bishop for your knight.

Replay: 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. a3 Nc6 7. e3 e5 8. dxe5 Qxd1+ 9. Kxd1 Ng4 10. Ke2 Ngxe5

18. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 10-02

Nf3. Develops the king knight and influences the central d4 and e5 squares. White accepts another central pawn while letting Black develop. The extra pawn must be balanced against the time spent capturing.

Replay: 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd2 c5 8. a3 cxd4 9. axb4 dxc3 10. Bxc3 Qe7

Answers 19-21

19. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 11-01

Qxc3. The queen captures on c3. Check the resulting recapture, pawn structure and open lines before applying the longer-term plan. Qc2 supports central play and the queen recapture preserves your pawns. Black exchanges a useful knight but reduces White's control of e4.

Replay: 9. Qxc3 d6 10. Qd3 f5

20. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 11-02

O-O. Castling moves the king out of the center and brings a rook closer to the central files. b3 defends c4. Bd2 interposes against the check and makes ...Bb4+ a manageable part of the move order.

Replay: 8. O-O d5 9. Qc2 O-O 10. Rd1 Nbd7

21. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 12-01

O-O. Castling moves the king out of the center and brings a rook closer to the central files. The queen recapture preserves the b1 knight's choice of square. g3 and Bg2 provide a compact developing scheme.

Replay: 9. O-O Re8 10. h3 a5

Answers 22-24

22. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 12-02

Bg2. Completes the kingside fianchetto and prepares or supports a castled king setup. The check has led to an early bishop exchange. You can still use the fianchetto while keeping d4 and c4 in the center.

Replay: 7. Bg2 c6 8. O-O dxc4 9. a4 b5 10. axb5 cxb5

23. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 13-01

Nf3. Develops the king knight and influences the central d4 and e5 squares. a3 asks the bishop to decide; Qxc3 preserves the pawn structure. Nf3 brings another piece into the center.

Replay: 7. Nf3 Nbd7 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 c5 10. e3 b6

24. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 13-02

Qc2. Coordinates the queen with central play while clearing d1 for a rook. The queen retreats after the knight gains time. You have preserved the structure, but Black has obtained active central play.

Replay: 7. Qc2 O-O 8. Nf3 Nd7 9. e3 b6 10. Bd3 Bb7

Answers 25-27

25. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 14-01

Be3. Places the bishop on e3. Use the line explanation below to connect that placement to the center and opponent's threats. The center is supported by pieces before e4. h3 restricts ...Bg4 and gives the king position a little flexibility.

Replay: 10. Be3 exd4

26. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 14-02

h3. Controls g4 and can restrict or question a black minor piece on that square. Black prepares queenside expansion. h3 is a useful waiting move but does not by itself stop ...b5.

Replay: 8. h3 Rb8 9. e4 b5 10. cxb5 axb5

27. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 15-01

a4. Controls b5 and challenges Black's queenside pawn expansion. a4 restrains ...b5 and prepares to recover the pawn without allowing a lasting queenside chain.

Replay: 8. a4 Nd5 9. Bd2 Bf5 10. b3 cxb3

Answers 28-30

28. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 15-02

Qc2. Coordinates the queen with central play while clearing d1 for a rook. Qc2 eyes c4 and keeps the center supported. Black must decide how much effort to spend holding the extra pawn.

Replay: 7. Qc2 Nc6 8. Qxc4 Be6 9. Qa4 Nd5 10. Nc3 Nb6

29. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 16-01

a4. Controls b5 and challenges Black's queenside pawn expansion. a4 makes ...b5 harder to achieve. The g2 bishop supports the center while the king reaches safety.

Replay: 10. a4 Nbd7

30. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 16-02

O-O. Castling moves the king out of the center and brings a rook closer to the central files. White need not delay king safety just because Black does. The center and ...b5 remain the strategic questions.

Replay: 9. O-O O-O 10. a4 Re8

Answers 31-33

31. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 17-01

Nf3. Develops the king knight and influences the central d4 and e5 squares. White has returned material but kept central space. The queen on b6 can become a target for useful developing moves.

Replay: 8. Nf3 Bg7 9. Be2 O-O 10. Nd2 Qd8

32. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 17-02

Nf3. Develops the king knight and influences the central d4 and e5 squares. The knight route costs time but develops a useful piece. White uses the time to occupy the center.

Replay: 8. Nf3 g6 9. h3 Bg7 10. a4 a5

33. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 18-01

e3. Supports d4 and opens a diagonal for the f1 bishop. Nbd2 answers the check and supports development. After the central exchanges, e3 opens the f1 bishop without weakening the king.

Replay: 9. e3 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 d6

Answers 34-36

34. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 18-02

exd6. The pawn captures on d6. Check the resulting recapture, pawn structure and open lines before applying the longer-term plan. Black returns to straightforward development. The e5 pawn disappears, but White can maintain a healthy position.

Replay: 6. exd6 Bxd6 7. Bxd6 cxd6 8. e3 Be6 9. Nc3 Nf6 10. Be2 d5

35. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 19-01

d5. Gains space and controls c6 and e6; the resulting central pawn structure determines the next plan. White castles before confronting the center. d5 gains space and asks how Black will organize ...e5.

Replay: 8. d5 cxd5 9. Nxd5 e5 10. Bg5 Nc6

36. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 19-02

Nxa3. The knight captures on a3. Check the resulting recapture, pawn structure and open lines before applying the longer-term plan. Ba3 challenges the good d6 bishop. The knight recapture develops a piece that may head toward c2 and e5.

Replay: 9. Nxa3 Qe7 10. Nc2 Nbd7

Answers 37-39

37. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 20-01

Be3. Places the bishop on e3. Use the line explanation below to connect that placement to the center and opponent's threats. The broad center is supported by development. Black is compact and will seek a freeing pawn break.

Replay: 8. Be3 Ng4 9. Bd2 Ngf6 10. Qc2 Re8

38. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 20-02

O-O. Castling moves the king out of the center and brings a rook closer to the central files. The delayed knight move transposes to the fianchetto King's Indian. You have avoided introducing an unrelated e4-opening repertoire.

Replay: 6. O-O Bf5 7. Re1 a5 8. Nc3 Ne4 9. h4 Nc6 10. h5 e5

39. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 21-01

Nd5. Places the knight actively on d5 with an attack on the opposing queen. Nc3 develops while defending the center. After ...Nxe5, Nd5 attacks the queen with tempo and disrupts Black's intended setup.

Replay: 5. Nd5 Nxf3+ 6. gxf3 Qd8 7. Bf4 d6 8. Qd4 c6 9. Nc3 Be6 10. O-O-O Nf6

Answers 40-42

40. REPERTOIRE RECALL | SEE 21-02

Nc3. Develops the queen knight and adds control of d5 and e4. White accepts material but helps Black develop a bishop. Your response must be efficient development, not further pawn collecting.

Replay: 5. Nc3 Nf6 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 Bf5 8. e3 g5 9. Bg3 Bxg3 10. hxg3 g4

41. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / CARLSBAD AND THE MINORITY ATTACK

The c-file is half-open for White and the black c6 pawn can become a target after b4-b5. Your queenside minority tries to create a weakness, not a passed pawn immediately. Coordinate a rook on b1 or c1, prepare b4, and assess b5. If ...cxb5, examine the isolated d-pawn or weak c-file squares; if ...c5, recalculate the central structure. Black: Black seeks ...Ne4, kingside activity and the freeing ...c5. If those threats are urgent, a slow pawn plan may be too slow.

42. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / PLAYING AGAINST AN ISOLATED QUEEN PAWN

Black's d-pawn has no friendly c- or e-pawn to support it. It controls central squares, so it is not simply a free target. Restrain its advance, blockade with a suitable piece, and exchange active attacking pieces when favorable. Attack the pawn only after your king and pieces are coordinated. Black: Black wants ...d4 or an initiative before the position simplifies. A poorly timed pawn capture can release all of Black's pieces.

Answers 43-45

43. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / PLAYING WITH AN ISOLATED QUEEN PAWN

White has an isolated d4 pawn and open central lines. The pawn offers space and activity but can become an endgame burden. Use active bishops and rooks, keep useful attacking pieces, and prepare d5 if it opens the position favorably. Make the opponent defend threats before they can blockade. Black: Black wants a stable blockade and favorable piece exchanges. Avoid trading into a passive ending simply because it reduces the material.

44. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / HANGING PAWNS: C5 AND D5

The adjacent black c5 and d5 pawns lack friendly pawns on the neighboring outer files. Together they control useful central squares; after one advances, the other may become weak. For the side facing them, pressure both pawns and provoke a concession without allowing a strong advance. For the side owning them, keep activity and choose the right moment to push. Black: One careless exchange can turn the pair into a strong passed pawn rather than a weakness. Calculate recaptures before celebrating a structural target.

45. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / SLAV: THE CAPTURED C4 PAWN

Black has captured on c4 and White has played a4. The immediate structural battle concerns whether ...b5 can hold the extra pawn. Develop e3 and Bxc4 when safe. Do not replace useful development with queen moves just to regain the pawn one move sooner. Black: Black can counter in the center while you recover c4. The later e4 break must be supported against pins and exchanges.

Answers 46-48

46. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / THE LOCKED INDIAN CENTER

White's d5 and e4 pawns face Black's d6 and e5 pawns. The center is closed, but pawn breaks can reopen it. Improve the least active minor piece and identify a useful break. Queenside space is valuable only if it creates entry squares or targets. Keep the fianchetto bishop's defensive role in mind. Black: Black can prepare kingside activity or queenside breaks. The exact knight placements decide whether ...f5 or ...b5 is feasible.

47. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / MODERN BENONI: CENTRAL SPACE VERSUS ...B5

White's d5 pawn cramps Black. Black has a queenside majority and a potentially weak d6 pawn, compensated by active diagonals and files. Restrain ...b5 when useful, develop, and prepare e4-e5. Watch whether exchanging a key bishop would weaken your control of central squares. Black: Black seeks ...b5, ...Re8 and pressure against the center. The d6 pawn is rarely won by a single unsupported attack.

48. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / DUTCH STONEWALL: THE E5 SQUARE

The d5-e6-f5 chain gives Black space and restrains e4, but it leaves e5 as a potential white outpost and limits the c8 bishop. Challenge the good dark-squared bishop where possible. Maneuver a knight toward e5 only when the exchange consequences are favorable. Use patient piece improvement. Black: Black seeks ...Ne4 and attacking chances near your king. Do not create targets with unnecessary kingside pawn moves.

Answers 49-51

49. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / ALBIN: THE ADVANCED D4 WEDGE

The d4 pawn limits your pieces and creates tactics on e3 and along the d-file. White's extra e5 pawn does not remove those threats. Nbd2-b3 targets d4. Address pins first, and return material if needed to simplify safely. Know the en-passant detail in the e4 line. Black: Black seeks fast development, ...Bg4, and attacks while your king is central. Greedy bishop captures can allow a dangerous passed pawn.

50. PLAN AND STRUCTURE | SEE 22 / HEDGEHOG: RESPECT THE FREEING BREAK

Black keeps pawns on a6, b6, d6 and e6 behind compact pieces. White has more space, but that space can become vulnerable if overextended. Improve pieces and watch ...b5 and ...d5. Do not attack a compact position by creating more weak pawns than targets. Black: Black waits for a central or queenside break that activates several pieces at once. A quiet move may be a tactical preparation.

51. TACTICAL WARNING: BLACK TO MOVE | SEE 08-06

exf2+. The forcing sequence uses the passed pawn, knight underpromotion with check, and the exposed white king to win material. This is why the course avoids the early e3 trap.

Replay: 6... exf2+ 7. Ke2 fxg1=N+ 8. Rxg1 Bg4+ 9. Ke1 Bxd1 10. Nc3 Bg4

Answers 52-54

52. TACTICAL WARNING: BLACK TO MOVE | SEE 08-06

fxg1=N+. The forcing sequence uses the passed pawn, knight underpromotion with check, and the exposed white king to win material. This is why the course avoids the early e3 trap.

Replay: 7... fxg1=N+ 8. Rxg1 Bg4+ 9. Ke1 Bxd1 10. Nc3 Bg4

53. TACTICAL WARNING: BLACK TO MOVE | SEE 08-06

Bg4+. The forcing sequence uses the passed pawn, knight underpromotion with check, and the exposed white king to win material. This is why the course avoids the early e3 trap.

Replay: 8... Bg4+ 9. Ke1 Bxd1 10. Nc3 Bg4

54. TACTICAL WARNING: BLACK TO MOVE | SEE 08-06

Bxd1. The forcing sequence uses the passed pawn, knight underpromotion with check, and the exposed white king to win material. This is why the course avoids the early e3 trap.

Replay: 9... Bxd1 10. Nc3 Bg4

Answers 55-57

55. CONCRETE OPENING DECISION | SEE 02-02

Nxd5. Bh4 keeps the pin available; when the knight reaches e4, exchanging on e7 simplifies the pressure on your bishop without abandoning development.

Replay: 10. Nxd5 Qd8

56. CONCRETE OPENING DECISION | SEE 02-04

Bxf6. Exchanging the f6 knight removes a defender of d5. This concrete detail makes automatic e3 less ambitious in this exact position.

Replay: 7. Bxf6 Bxf6 8. Qb3 c6 9. Qxb7 Qb6 10. Qxb6 axb6

57. CONCRETE OPENING DECISION | SEE 05-04

Qb3. The queen eyes b7 after the bishop has left c8. This makes Black account for the queenside instead of completing a setup for free.

Replay: 6. Qb3 Bc8 7. e4 Nxe4 8. Bb5+ Bd7 9. Qxd5 Nxc3 10. bxc3 Bxb5

Answers 58-60

58. CONCRETE OPENING DECISION | SEE 10-03

e4. e4 builds a broad center with tempo against the knight. You gain space without chasing a queen around the board.

Replay: 4. e4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. dxe5 Qxd1+ 7. Kxd1 Ng4 8. Ke1 Bc5 9. f4 Nc6 10. Nd5 O-O

59. CONCRETE OPENING DECISION | SEE 21-01

Nd5. Nc3 develops while defending the center. After ...Nxe5, Nd5 attacks the queen with tempo and disrupts Black's intended setup.

Replay: 5. Nd5 Nxf3+ 6. gxf3 Qd8 7. Bf4 d6 8. Qd4 c6 9. Nc3 Be6 10. O-O-O Nf6

60. CONCRETE OPENING DECISION | SEE 08-01

dxe3. Nbd2-b3 attacks d4. e4 challenges the knight and allows an en-passant capture; Qxd8+ first is essential to understand the resulting queenless position.

Replay: 7... dxe3 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. fxe3 a5 10. Bd3 Bb4+

A sustainable training routine

FOUR SESSIONS EACH WEEK

Session A: 25 minutes of a new booklet and ten minutes of recall. Session B: 20 minutes of exercises and 15 minutes of diagram play. Session C: one slow game. Session D: 30-45 minutes reviewing that game and updating one weak branch.

CHOOSE USEFUL TIME CONTROLS

A slower rapid game such as 15+10 or longer gives you time to use a threat checklist. Blitz can test recall, but it should not be your only measure of whether the opening makes sense.

A SMALL REPERTOIRE NOTEBOOK

For each game record the opponent's defense, first unfamiliar move, your candidate moves, your decision and its reason. Add the corrected line only after you understand why the correction matters.

REVIEW INTERVALS

Revisit a new line the next day, three days later, one week later and one month later. If you miss it, shorten the next interval. If you explain it easily, spend the saved time playing the resulting position.

Weeks 1-4

WEEK 1: FOUNDATION AND THE DECISION TREE | BOOKLETS 00, 01, 21

Learn why c4 challenges d5. Rehearse the response to every common first move. Play three slow games and record the first unfamiliar position.

WEEK 2: QUEEN'S GAMBIT DECLINED | BOOKLETS 02, 03

Learn the main Carlsbad line and the triangle exception. Explain the minority attack without moving the pieces, then identify when ...c5 changes the plan.

WEEK 3: QUEEN'S GAMBIT ACCEPTED AND SLAV | BOOKLETS 04, 05

Practice recovering c4 by development. Drill the purpose of a4 against ...b5 and distinguish early from delayed captures on c4.

WEEK 4: SEMI-SLAV AND ISOLATED-PAWN STRUCTURES | BOOKLETS 06, 07, 22

Learn the Meran branching point. Play practice positions with the isolated d-pawn from both sides and annotate which trades help each player.

Weeks 5-8

WEEK 5: ALBIN AND CHIGORIN | BOOKLETS 08, 09

Reconstruct the Albin main line, including en passant. Recognize the Lasker trap. In the Chigorin, explain what you receive for doubled pawns.

WEEK 6: OTHER QUEEN-PAWN COUNTERS | BOOKLETS 10, 18

Practice Baltic, Marshall, Budapest and Blumenfeld recognition. Identify the exact check or capture that changes your normal developing scheme.

WEEK 7: QUEEN'S INDIAN AND BOGO | BOOKLETS 11, 12

Distinguish ...Ba6 from ...Bb7. Rehearse the Bogo check response. Explain the e4 battle and avoid unnecessary queen moves.

WEEK 8: KING'S INDIAN AND GRUNFELD | BOOKLETS 14, 15

Use the fianchetto consistently while distinguishing ...d6 from ...d5. Start practice games from the final main-line diagrams.

Weeks 9-12

WEEK 9: BENONI AND BENKO | BOOKLETS 16, 17

Learn the d5 space advantage and Black's ...b5 break. Practice the 5.b6 Benko route and the different Blumenfeld move order.

WEEK 10: DUTCH AND FLEXIBLE DEFENSES | BOOKLETS 19, 20

Name Leningrad, Stonewall and Classical structures from the pawns. Explain why 2.g3 is a choice, not a claim that 2.c4 loses.

WEEK 11: MIDDLEGAME HANDOFF | BOOKLETS 22, 23

For each training position, write two candidate moves and Black's plan before reading the continuation. Review your own recurring structural mistakes.

WEEK 12: ASSESSMENT AND CONSOLIDATION | BOOKLETS 24, 25

Take the mixed test without notes. Revisit only missed branches. Optional: begin Booklet 13 if you want to add the Nimzo-Indian to your repertoire.

Reference card: the first decisions

AGAINST 1...D5

2.c4. ...e6: QGD; ...c6: Slav; ...dxc4: Accepted; ...e5: Albin; ...Nc6: Chigorin. Develop according to the actual defense.

AGAINST 1...NF6

2.c4. ...e6: 3.Nf3 and identify QGD/Queen's Indian/Bogo/Benoni. ...g6: 3.Nf3 and the fianchetto family. ...c5: d5. ...e5: dxe5.

WHEN C4 WAITS

Against ...e5 play dxe5; against ...f5 choose g3; against ...c5 or ...Nc6 choose d5; against ...b6 or ...b5 choose e4. See Booklet 01 for the distinction between necessity and preference.

THE ALBIN CARD

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 d4 4.Nf3 Nc6 5.Nbd2. Think Nb3 against d4. Against ...Bg4 account for the pin; against ...Nge7 know the e4 and queen-trade idea. Do not enter the Lasker trap with automatic e3.

THE THREAT CARD

Before every move: checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, central break, worst piece. Before every recapture: is there an intermediate check or stronger capture?

Your post-game review form

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____

Time control: _____ Defense: _____

Result: _____ Booklet / line ID: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____

What did Black threaten? _____

My candidate moves: _____

What I played and why: _____

WHAT THE GAME TAUGHT ME

Opening decision to repair: _____

Structural plan I misunderstood: _____

Tactical pattern I missed: _____

One position to replay from both sides: _____

NEXT REVIEW

My corrected explanation in one sentence: _____

Review dates: tomorrow _____ three days _____ one week _____

What was checked and what was not

LEGALITY AND DIAGRAMS

Every opening anchor was parsed as legal SAN. Every printed continuation was replayed from the starting position, and every diagram was generated from the resulting board. Second-move choices, custom structure positions and exercise answers were also checked against legal moves.

ENGINE SCREENING

Stockfish 18 used two threads and a 128 MB hash. White anchor decisions after move two were screened with 60,000-node searches; differences above 0.85 pawns were rechecked at 450,000 nodes. Flagged draft choices were reviewed and corrected. Every final ordinary repertoire anchor has no unresolved flag under this test. The deliberately losing Lasker-trap line is excluded from White-recommendation screening.

SAMPLE CONTINUATIONS

Short anchors were extended toward ten full moves with 120,000-node searches, then their final positions checked at 300,000 nodes. Eight laboratory lines were extended toward twenty full moves using 300,000-node searches. These are finite checks, not exhaustive opening analysis or proof that a line is objectively best.

HUMAN PURPOSE

The course favors coherent, understandable positions and practical answers. An engine can prefer a different sound move. A good outcome is arriving at a position you understand, with no avoidable tactical concession - not claiming a forced win against every defense.

COVERAGE AND OMISSIONS

The main route covers common queen-pawn defenses and important gambits. The Nimzo is optional. Other good White systems, deep novelties and every rare Black move are not all separate repertoires here. Booklet 01 supplies a decision framework for unfamiliar moves.

HOW TO UPDATE THE COURSE

After a game, check the exact position in an opening database and analyze the opponent's concrete idea. Add a short branch with a reason. Do not replace an entire sound repertoire merely because one finite engine evaluation changes.

Sources and further study

OPENING NAMES AND MOVE-ORDER REFERENCE

Lichess chess-openings, public-domain/CC0 dataset. Local snapshots of a.tsv through e.tsv were downloaded for this project. Facts and names are reference material; the course is an original selection, not a reproduction of a published repertoire.

<https://github.com/lichess-org/chess-openings>

ENGINE VERIFICATION

Official Stockfish 18, Windows AVX2 build. Used locally to screen selected White decisions and generate explicitly labelled sample continuations.

<https://stockfishchess.org/download/>

ALBIN CROSS-CHECK

Ian Simpson's analysis of a3 and Nbd2 lines was consulted for the strategic distinction and the ...Nge7/e4 queen-trade idea. Commentary in this course is newly written.

<https://www.ianchessgambits.com/albin-counter-gambit-a3-and-nbd2.html>

Sources and further study

QUEEN'S INDIAN REFERENCE

Chess.com's opening overview was used to cross-check the distinction between ...Ba6 and ...Bb7.

<https://www.chess.com/openings/Queens-Indian-Defense>

ISOLATED PAWN TERMINOLOGY

Chess.com's isolated-pawn reference was consulted for terminology; the diagrams and exercises here use this course's own positions.

<https://www.chess.com/terms/isolated-pawn-chess>

PAWN MAJORITY AND MINORITY ATTACK TERMINOLOGY

Chess.com's pawn-majority reference was consulted for the definition of a minority attack.

<https://www.chess.com/terms/pawn-majority-chess>

Sources and further study

DIAGRAM IMPLEMENTATION AND ARTWORK

python-chess SVG documentation identifies the Colin M. L. Burnett / Cburnett pieces and their licensing. The supplied example.pdf was the visual reference for cream-and-green squares and clear dark-outlined pieces.

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/en/latest/svg.html>

Working chess vocabulary

SAN

Standard Algebraic Notation: Nf3, cxd5, Qxd8+, O-O. N is a knight; K is a king. The + sign means check and # means checkmate.

PLY

One move by one side. Ten full moves normally contain twenty plies: White's move and Black's reply each count once.

TABIYA

A useful starting position for studying an opening's middlegame plans after the initial developing moves.

TRANSPOSITION

Reaching the same position through a different move order. Side to move, castling rights and en-passant availability must also agree.

TEMPO

A unit of time measured by a move. Attacking a piece with a useful developing move can gain a tempo.

INITIATIVE

The ability to make threats that force the opponent to respond. It can compensate for a pawn, but may disappear if development stalls.

FIANCHETTO

Developing a bishop to g2, b2, g7 or b7 behind a moved knight pawn, to influence a long diagonal.

Working chess vocabulary

PAWN BREAK

A pawn advance or capture that challenges a pawn chain, opens a file, or changes the central structure.

MINORITY ATTACK

Using fewer pawns on a wing to provoke a lasting weakness in the opponent's larger pawn group.

ISOLATED PAWN

A pawn with no friendly pawn on either adjacent file. Its activity and vulnerability depend on the position.

HANGING PAWNS

Usually an adjacent c- and d-pawn pair without friendly pawns on the neighboring outer files. They can give space or become targets.

BACKWARD PAWN

A pawn that cannot safely advance and lacks adequate support from neighboring pawns; it may become a target on a half-open file.

OUTPOST

A square a piece can occupy securely, often because an enemy pawn cannot readily drive it away.

BLOCKADE

Placing a piece in front of an enemy pawn to restrain its advance. A blockade must be supported.

Working chess vocabulary

PROPHYLAXIS

Recognizing and restricting the opponent's useful plan while improving your own position.

RELATIVE PIN

A piece may legally move but doing so exposes a more valuable piece. A pin to the king instead makes exposing the king illegal.

EN PASSANT

Immediately after a pawn advances two squares, an adjacent enemy pawn may capture it as though it advanced only one. This right lasts for one reply.

UNDERPROMOTION

Promoting a pawn to rook, bishop or knight instead of queen. A knight promotion can give a check the queen would not give.

COMPENSATION

Positional or dynamic benefits offered in return for material: activity, king attack, space, or lasting structural targets.

ENGINE CENTIPAWN SCORE

A numerical search evaluation, conventionally measured in hundredths of a pawn. It is not a win probability or proof of the position's result.

File guide and credits

INDIVIDUAL PDFS

Booklets 00-26 can be studied or printed independently. The combined volume includes the same pages and PDF outline bookmarks for each booklet. START HERE explains the reading order; Booklet 25 provides the weekly plan.

PGN COMPANIONS

Repertoire_Lines.pgn contains the selected study branches. Warning lines are explicitly labelled. Middlegame_Laboratory.pgn contains the eight illustrative continuations. Exercises.pgn stores the exercise positions and answers for replay. These are analysis files, not records of played games.

REPRODUCIBILITY

Course_Manifest.json records page counts and file hashes. Verification_Summary.txt records the check counts and limitations. The folder also includes the Cburnett piece sources and license material used for the diagrams.

ARTWORK

Chess pieces: Colin M. L. Burnett / Cburnett, as supplied in python-chess SVG rendering. Credit and source links are retained in the course and in the accompanying artwork folder. The board colors and page design were matched to your provided example.pdf.

ORIGINAL CONTENT

Instructional prose, exercises and course structure were written for this project. Public opening facts and local engine analysis support the selected lines. No commercial course or annotated book was copied.